P2JW067000-8-A00100-16DDF61078D

ALEXANDER NEMENOV/PRESS POOL (2); AL DRAGO/PRESS POOL

WSJ

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL WEEKEND

The Worst Fouls in Men's Fashion

OFF DUTY

DOW JONES | News Corp ★★★★★★★★ SATURDAY/SUNDAY, MARCH 8 - 9, 2025 ~ VOL. CCLXXXV NO. 55 WSJ.com ★★★★ $6.00

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **The U.S. continued to** generate jobs at a steady pace in February, adding a seasonally adjusted 151,000 positions, but there were warning signs that the labor market could weaken. **A1**

◆ **U.S. stocks seesawed**, ending slightly higher on Friday, but down for the week. with the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow industrials having fallen 3.1%, 3.45% and 2.4%, respectively. **B11**

◆ **The Fed's Powell** signaled the central bank was comfortable maintaining its current stance on interest rates as it digests the effects of changes to trade policy. **A2**

◆ **About $900 million** in losses spread across two teams at Millennium Management contributed to its worst monthly performance in over six years in February. **B11**

◆ **Activist investor Mantle** Ridge has built a stake of more than $1 billion in Cognizant and believes shares of the technology-services firm are undervalued. **B10**

◆ **A French former** spymaster, Bernard Squarcini, was found guilty of illegally exploiting his networks to serve private interests, including those of LVMH and its chairman, Bernard Arnault. **B9**

World-Wide

◆ **A judge declined to** limit access to a Treasury Department payment system by Musk's Department of Government Efficiency, saying plaintiffs hadn't shown that improper disclosure of individuals' data was likely. **A4**

◆ **House Democratic leaders** said they would oppose a Republican measure to keep the government funded beyond March 14 and avoid a government shutdown. **A4**

◆ **The DHS said it would** no longer honor a bargaining agreement with the union representing airport security agents, a contract that covers more than 40,000 federal workers. **A2**

◆ **Gene Hackman died** of heart disease, officials in New Mexico said, and his wife, Betsy Arakawa, died of hantavirus pulmonary syndrome. **A6**

◆ **The Trump administration** canceled roughly $400 million in federal grants and contracts to Columbia University, citing the school's alleged failure to protect Jewish students from discrimination. **A3**

◆ **The number of people** sickened by measles in Texas and New Mexico surpassed 200, more than doubling over the past two weeks. **A3**

NOONAN
Snap out of it, Democrats **A13**

CLOCKS GO FORWARD
Daylight-saving time begins in most of the U.S. and Canada at 2 a.m. Sunday. Clocks move ahead by one hour. Standard time returns on Sunday, Nov. 2.

CONTENTS

10645>
0 78908 63144 2

U.S. Threatens Sanctions as Russia Slams Ukraine

SERGEY BOBOK/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

SMOLDERING: A car burned in Kharkiv after Russia bombarded Ukrainian cities with missiles and attack drones on Friday. President Trump said he was 'strongly considering' imposing sanctions and tariffs on Russia until a peace deal is reached. **A8**

Jobs Market Shows Steady Growth

U.S. economy added 151,000 jobs last month, somewhat below expectations

By Justin Lahart

The U.S. continued to generate jobs at a steady pace in February, offering reassurances that the labor market has remained relatively stable since President Trump took office. But there were warning signs that it could weaken.

The economy added a seasonally adjusted 151,000 jobs in February, the Labor Department reported Friday, slightly below the gain of 170,000 jobs economists polled by The Wall Street Journal expected to see. Still, that was better than the 125,000 jobs added in January.

The unemployment rate, which is based on a separate survey from the jobs figures, rose to 4.1% from 4%.

Economists believe that the cuts to federal government jobs under Trump came too late in the month to be captured in the February figures. But the report did show a loss of about 10,000 federal government jobs over the month, unusual both because it is a decline and because it is such a large one.

Of that, 3,500 lost jobs were at the postal service, where employment often swings higher and lower from month to month. The remaining 6,700 lost jobs represented

Please turn to page A2

◆ Tariff fights keep Fed in holding pattern A2
◆ The week when the dollar was battered B11

Trump Goes All In for Crypto After His $Trump Epiphany

By Rebecca Ballhaus, Josh Dawsey and Eliza Collins

President Trump regaled a group of high-rollers visiting Mar-a-Lago about all his administration was doing for the cryptocurrency industry. Then he turned to all the crypto money he is making as president.

Trump's personal meme coin, which he launched days before his inauguration, could bring in billions of dollars, the president said with an air of amazement. At one point, he turned to the audience—a group of donors who had each paid $1 million to his super PAC—and asked whether they knew what $Trump was worth. One did, according to people who were at the March 1 gathering. It had a market cap of around $13 billion.

The success of $Trump is one of the starkest examples of the president benefiting from an industry his administration regulates.

Trump, who promised to be the nation's "first crypto president," recounted to the group the Securities and Exchange Commission's recent dismissal of cases against crypto companies, nearly a dozen by Friday. Crypto executives see that as evidence of the industry's liberation from regulatory threats under the Biden administration that limited its growth in the U.S.

Other Mar-a-Lago guests that night included David Sacks, a longtime investor who now leads Trump's cryptocurrency policy. Sacks said this week he had sold his crypto holdings and his company had divested its stakes in certain crypto startups. A representative for Sacks didn't respond to a question about whether his firm retained investments in any crypto start-

Please turn to page A10

FTX Founder Makes Play For Pardon

By Ben Cohen, Alexander Osipovich and James Fanelli

After the spectacular collapse of his cryptocurrency exchange, Sam Bankman-Fried opened a Google Doc and started brainstorming a plan to resuscitate his public image.

"These are all random probably bad ideas," wrote the FTX founder.

The collection of 19 bullet points ranged from portraying himself as "extremely pro crypto, pro freedom" to sending out a poll on Twitter soliciting advice.

But it was No. 3 on the disgraced mogul's list of strategies that looked like the most improbable suggestion of them all: going on Tucker Carlson's show and coming out as a Republican.

Coming from one of the largest donors to the Democratic Party, it was a brazen thought—as if the crypto kingpin famous for his unruly frizz suddenly decided to get a buzzcut.

In the memo to himself, which federal prosecutors introduced ahead of his sentencing, Bankman-Fried plotted out exactly how he would pull it off. He would shine a light

Please turn to page A6

NATO's Baltic Target: Sea-Cable Saboteurs

By Bojan Pancevski and Daniel Michaels

Just after midnight on Dec. 26, Finnish commandos dropped from two helicopters onto the deck of a ramshackle Russian oil tanker in the Baltic Sea and ordered the ship's crew to sail into port.

They were acting on the orders of Finnish officials who suspected the Eagle S had hours earlier dragged its anchor along the seabed to slice through a vital power cable between Finland and Estonia. The Finnish action also potentially prevented the ship from cutting another cable, officials said.

It was the latest incident of suspected sabotage involving ships carrying Russian cargo in the region, and the first time authorities boarded a suspicious vessel while it was under way.

Then came the real work: Finding the evidence to prove sabotage.

Finnish law-enforcement officials questioned the crew

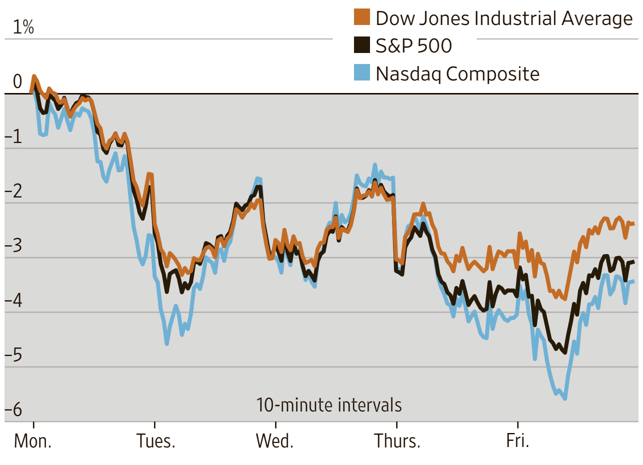
Please turn to page A8

◆ U.S. threatens more sanctions on Russia........ A8
◆ Germany considers nuclear options for defense........ A8

Stocks Rise to Cap Rough Week

Major indexes finished slightly higher Friday but were down for the week amid concern about unpredictable tariff policies. **B11**

Index performance this past week



Source: FactSet

Border Towns Question BFF Status

* * *

U.S.-Canada feud makes it weird; 'Just a little hurt'

By Joe Barrett

INTERNATIONAL FALLS, Minn.—This Northern Minnesota town is famous for its giant Smokey Bear statue, its cold weather and a cheeky nickname—"Icebox of the Nation."

Less well-known is that it has a twin, Fort Frances, On-

Please turn to page A10

EXCHANGE

DELIVERY WAR
Walmart's surprising challenge to Amazon's online supremacy. **B1**

It's Now Time to Debate Daylight-Saving Time

By Justin Lahart

Most people in the U.S. will be setting their clocks forward on Sunday, an annual ritual that allows them to start fighting about daylight-saving time an hour earlier.

The experience—interrupted sleep, tired children—is so distasteful that in recent years there have been growing calls to get rid of the clock change altogether.

President Trump has seized on the cause. "The Republican Party will use its best efforts to eliminate Daylight Saving Time, which has a small but strong constituency, but shouldn't!" he wrote in a post on Truth Social in December. (He had a different position a few years earlier, tweeting in 2019 that "Making Daylight Saving Time permanent is O.K. with me!")

Economists have jumped into the debate. Daylight-saving time's original selling point was to reduce energy use by making sunsets later in the day. New research questions that claim.

Preliminary findings from Yale economist Matthew Kotchen, with Arianna Salazar-Miranda, Erin Mansur and Steve Cicala, suggest that in

Please turn to page A6

P2JW067000-7-A00200-1--------XA

U.S. NEWS

Tariff Fights Keep Fed in Holding Pattern

Powell says central bank is positioned 'to wait for greater clarity' on outlook

By Nick Timiraos

Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell signaled the central bank was comfortable maintaining its current wait-and-see stance on interest rates as it digests the effects of changes to trade policy that have led to elevated uncertainty for economic activity.

"The economy is fine. It doesn't need us to do anything, really," Powell said during a moderated question-and-answer session at a conference Friday in New York.

Officials are focused on "separating the signal from the noise as the outlook evolves. We do not need to be in a hurry, and are well positioned to wait for greater clarity," he said.

Earlier Friday, the Labor Department reported that the U.S. added 151,000 jobs in February—more than the month before, but less than economists had expected.

The Fed cut interest rates by one percentage point last year after an aggressive effort to lift rates to a two-decade high in 2022 and 2023 to combat inflation. Inflation declined to around 2.5% in January, using the Fed's preferred gauge. The Fed targets 2% inflation over time.

Powell said the Fed could maintain its benchmark short-term rate, currently around 4.3%, if the economy remains on solid footing and inflation doesn't continue moving down to its goal. An unexpected weakening in the labor market or a decline in inflation would allow the Fed to resume lowering rates, he said.

YUKI IWAMURA/BLOOMBERG NEWS

'The economy is fine,' Fed Chair Jerome Powell said Friday.

"Despite elevated levels of uncertainty, the U.S. economy continues to be in a good place," Powell said.

Powell pointed to how the White House is in the process of revamping policies across multiple fronts: on trade, immigration, regulation, taxes and spending. "It is the net effect of these policy changes" that matter for the interest-rate outlook. "While there have been recent developments in some of these areas, especially trade policy, uncertainty around the changes and their likely effects remains high."

The Fed chief said labor markets look solid. He acknowledged recent data pointing to somewhat milder consumer spending and surveys showing how uncertainty over policy changes by the Trump administration might influence future spending and investment plans.

The Trump administration partially pulled back tariffs on some goods from Mexico and Canada on Thursday after markets sank and companies lobbied President Trump.

Trump gave America's neighbors and biggest trading partners a one-month reprieve from 25% tariffs on a range of goods, setting up another showdown for April 2. It was the second time in a month that Trump had retreated from tariffs on Mexico and Canada, highlighting the uncertainty of his trade policies.

The U.S. has raised duties on Chinese goods by 20%, hitting a range of goods that were exempted from tariffs in his first term. Officials have signaled plans to push bolder tariffs on a host of additional countries next month.

Tariff increases have led consumers and businesses to expect prices to rise in the coming months, Powell said, but he said measures of longer-term expectations remain stable and consistent with the Fed's target. Fed officials pay close attention to consumers' and businesses' expectations of future inflation because they believe those expectations can be self-fulfilling. Signs that long-run expectations were rising would likely make Fed officials very cautious about cutting interest rates.

Steady Growth for Job Market

Continued from Page One

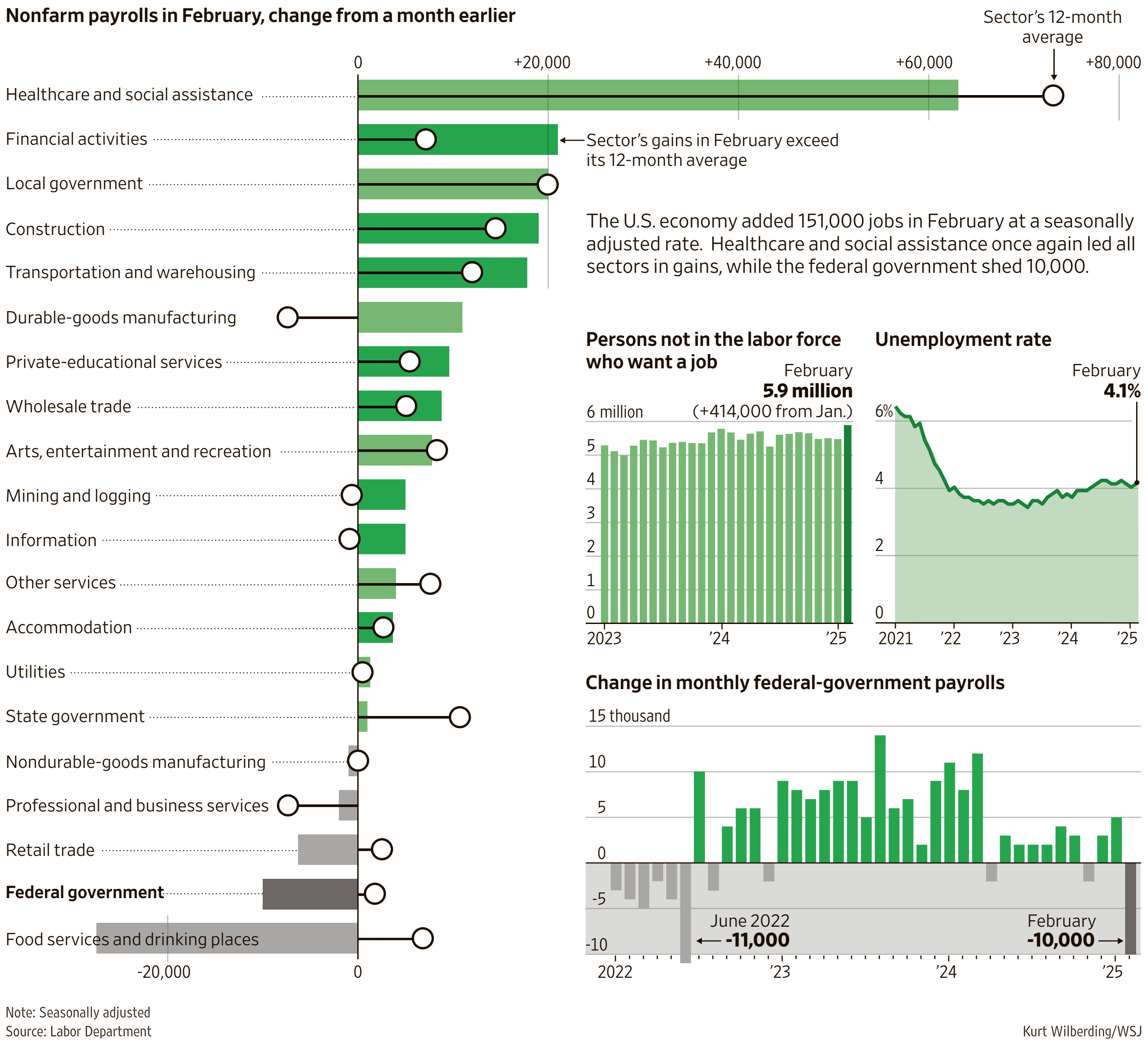
the biggest drop in more than two years.

Morgan Stanley economists wrote in a note Friday that they didn't believe the decline was a reflection of layoffs, "but was instead the front edge of the freeze on federal hiring." Trump put a hiring freeze in place on Jan. 20, the day he was inaugurated.

Local governments added 20,000 jobs, about half of them in education. State governments added 1,000 jobs.

Trump, a Republican, heralded the numbers as a success during remarks Friday from the Oval Office and pointed to a number of investments that companies have announced, including Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co. expansion plans for the U.S. He dismissed the effect of large-scale layoffs of government workers. "We had too many people in government," he said, defending a forthcoming plan to gut the Education Department.

Stocks finished the day higher, though they were still down for the week. Markets were battered during the week by Trump's back-and-forth on tariffs.



Healthcare accounted for a large portion of the February employment gain, adding 52,000 jobs. The transportation and warehousing industries added 18,000 jobs.

On the other side of the ledger, retailers shed 6,000 jobs. And the food services and drinking sector—largely restaurants and bars—lost 27,500 jobs. That could be an indication that immigration restrictions are beginning to affect the supply of workers at businesses that depend heavily on immigrant labor.

Economists expect that the combination of government job layoffs, reduced government funding, uncertainty over tariffs and immigration restrictions will at least temporarily weigh on employment growth in the months ahead. Still, some had worried more weakness would show up in the February report. Economists at High Frequency Economics, for example, had expected a gain of just 30,000 jobs.

"While we don't like being wrong, we are relieved that the February payrolls number did not print as low as we thought it might," they wrote in a note following the report's release.

Joe Brusuelas, chief economist at RSM US, said that the report showed that underlying demand for labor remained strong in February. But he cautioned that the administration's tariff moves could unsettle the labor market in the months to come.

"This might be the last of the job reports that will not be impacted by the significant changes in trade policy that are in train," he said.

The Federal Reserve is widely expected to hold interest rates steady at its meeting in two weeks. "Many indicators show that the labor market is solid and broadly in balance," Fed Chair Jerome Powell said at a conference in New York on Friday.

Average hourly earnings rose 0.3% from January, putting them 4% above their year-earlier level.

For its jobs figure, the Labor Department surveys employers on how many people they had on their payrolls during the pay period that includes the 12th of the month; anybody who worked at all during that period in February was counted as employed.

That includes federal workers still in their probationary period after getting hired or promoted that the White House began laying off around Feb. 13. It also includes the roughly 75,000 people who accepted the White House's "deferred resignation" offer, where the White House said they don't have to work but can still get paid through the end of September.

Those layoffs will begin showing up in the jobs count in the months ahead. Exactly how many federal government workers have lost their jobs so far as a result of the "Workforce Optimization Initiative" led by Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency is unclear. Some firings might not have been announced, while in other cases fired workers have been called back to the office. There are also layoffs at private-sector employers where government contracts and grants have been canceled.

Outplacement firm Challenger, Gray & Christmas on Thursday said that it counted 63,583 layoff announcements in February in the federal workforce and in government contractors. Labor Department data also show that there has been a pickup in initial claims for unemployment benefits filed by federal government employees.

Beyond layoffs, the government could also lose a number of jobs due to attrition as a result of the hiring freeze.

Strategists at Evercore ISI worry that uncertainty over contracts and grants is having "an additional paralyzing effect on hiring at employers exposed to these funding sources or in need of regulatory approvals from agencies that are themselves paralyzed by DOGE review."

Many businesses are enthusiastic about Trump's plans to cut taxes and scale back regulations, and that could lead them to increase hiring. The White House believes that tariffs will encourage manufacturers to bring more production, and jobs, to the U.S., and that cuts to government jobs and spending will ultimately make the economy more efficient.

Worries over tariffs could also weigh on the labor market. This is in part because uncertainty over what imports from what countries will be subject to higher tariffs, and at what rates, makes it hard for businesses to hire.

Immigration policy could also restrain the job market. The number of people coming into the U.S. began declining last summer, but since Inauguration Day appears to have dropped sharply.

CORRECTIONS & AMPLIFICATIONS

Readers can alert The Wall Street Journal to any errors in news articles by emailing **wsjcontact@wsj.com** or by calling 888-410-2667.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

(USPS 664-880) (Eastern Edition ISSN 0099-9660) (Central Edition ISSN 1092-0935) (Western Edition ISSN 0193-2241)

Editorial and publication headquarters: 1211 Avenue of the Americas,New York, N.Y. 10036

Published daily except Sundays and general legal holidays. Periodicals postage paid at New York, N.Y., and other mailing offices.

Postmaster: Send address changes to The Wall Street Journal, 200 Burnett Rd., Chicopee, MA 01020.

All Advertising published in The Wall Street Journal is subject to the applicable rate card, copies of which are available from the Advertising Services Department, Dow Jones & Co. Inc., 1211 Avenue of the Americas, New York, N.Y. 10036. The Journal reserves the right not to accept an advertiser's order. Only publication of an advertisement shall constitute final acceptance of the advertiser's order.

Letters to the Editor:
Fax: 212-416-2891; email: wsj.ltrs@wsj.com

Need assistance with your subscription?
By web: customercenter.wsj.com;
By email: support@wsj.com
By phone: 1-800-JOURNAL (1-800-568-7625)

Reprints & licensing:
By email: customreprints@dowjones.com;
By phone: 1-800-843-0008

WSJ back issues and framed pages: wsjshop.com

Our newspapers are 100% sourced from sustainably certified mills.

GOT A TIP FOR US? SUBMIT IT AT WSJ.COM/TIPS

Administration Says It Will Ignore TSA Labor Pact

By Allison Pohle

The Department of Homeland Security said it would no longer honor a bargaining agreement with the union representing airport security agents, the latest Trump administration move aiming to weaken labor unions representing federal workers.

The department said the move is meant to remove "bureaucratic hurdles that will strengthen workforce agility, enhance productivity and resiliency, while also jump-starting innovation." It will also push TSA employees who work full time on union matters to transition back to being security officers.

No workers will be fired as a result of the change, a DHS representative said.

"Transportation Security Officers will no longer lose their hard-earned dollars to a union that does not represent them," DHS said.

The move is a violation of the law, said Johnny Jones, secretary-treasurer for the American Federation of Government Employees TSA Council 100. The union represents more than 40,000 TSA workers. Union-represented transportation security officers and the agency signed a new labor contract last year that was set to run through 2031.

The department's move could add uncertainty within a labor force tasked with securing the nation's transportation system. "Nobody wants to work in a place where you have no rights or workplace protections," said Jones, a 22-year TSA employee.

Union and government officials have said TSA has experienced high employee turnover, in part, because of lower pay levels.

"If we didn't have this CBA, if we didn't have this pay package, I would submit to you, we probably wouldn't have a TSA in five or 10 years," former TSA Administrator David Pekoske said during the contract signing.

Private-sector contractors used to conduct most of airport-security screenings before the Sept. 11, 2001, terrorist attacks. Those responsibilities were largely brought under federal oversight after the TSA was established in 2001.

JOE RAEDLE/GETTY IMAGES

The TSA last year screened 904 million passengers.

TSA workers initially didn't have collective bargaining rights. In 2011, then-TSA Administrator John Pistole granted partial bargaining rights for workers.

The DHS announcement noted that nearly 200 TSA officers are paid by the government, but work full time on union matters. It goes on to say that 86% of airports have fewer than 200 TSA Officers to perform screening functions.

This is an inaccurate picture, said Jones. Out of the 45,000 employees represented by the union, 193, or less than 1%, are paid to work on union matters, he said. They are spread out across the country, not concentrated at one location, he adds.

TSA agents are responsible for securing more than 430 federalized airports, screening both travelers and bags. Employees aren't allowed to go on strike. Last year TSA screened 904 million passengers.

Project 2025, a government policy road map developed by the conservative think tank Heritage Foundation, recommended that the TSA be privatized. When asked, the DHS representative said the move to end collective bargaining isn't a response to the road map.

DOJ Opens Probe of Surge in Egg Prices

BY DAVE MICHAELS AND PATRICK THOMAS

The Justice Department has opened an investigation into the cause of soaring egg prices, including whether large producers have conspired to raise prices or hold back supply, according to people familiar with the matter.

The probe comes after prices have doubled over the past year and eggs are sometimes entirely absent from grocery store shelves. Grocers say eggs are one of the leading drivers of food inflation over the past few months. President Trump vowed to bring down inflation once he entered office.

The investigation is in its early stages. The department sent a letter to some egg companies that instructed them to preserve documents about their pricing conversations with customers and competitors, as well as communications with Urner Barry—which is now called Expana and tracks wholesale egg price information, some of the people familiar with the matter said.

It couldn't be learned whether the probe is under the direction of civil or criminal authorities.

A Justice Department spokeswoman declined to comment. The United Egg Producers, a trade group for the industry, said egg farmers are "doing everything they can to fight back against this deadly bird flu outbreak."

The egg industry, grocers and analysts have attributed high egg prices to the worst outbreak of avian flu in American history. It has resulted in the deaths of more than 150 million U.S. chickens, turkeys and egg-laying hens since 2022, according to the Agriculture Department.

Egg producers have had trouble repopulating their flocks because even young birds, known as pullets, have been killed by the flu, said Emily Metz, chief executive of the American Egg Board, an industry-funded marketing organization. That has extended the recovery time from an outbreak from six months to as much as a year, she said.

"Farmers know people are frustrated and they are frustrated too by the situation," Metz said. "They know they are not able to put on the volume of eggs that people want."

Steady demand despite rising costs and an influx of bird flu cases among egg-laying hens over the past few months has stressed the egg supply chain, leading to shortages and a run-up on wholesale egg prices.

On average shoppers are paying about $5 a dozen, according to the Labor Department. Grocers and food distributors are paying about $8 a dozen at wholesale, which makes selling them often a money-loser.

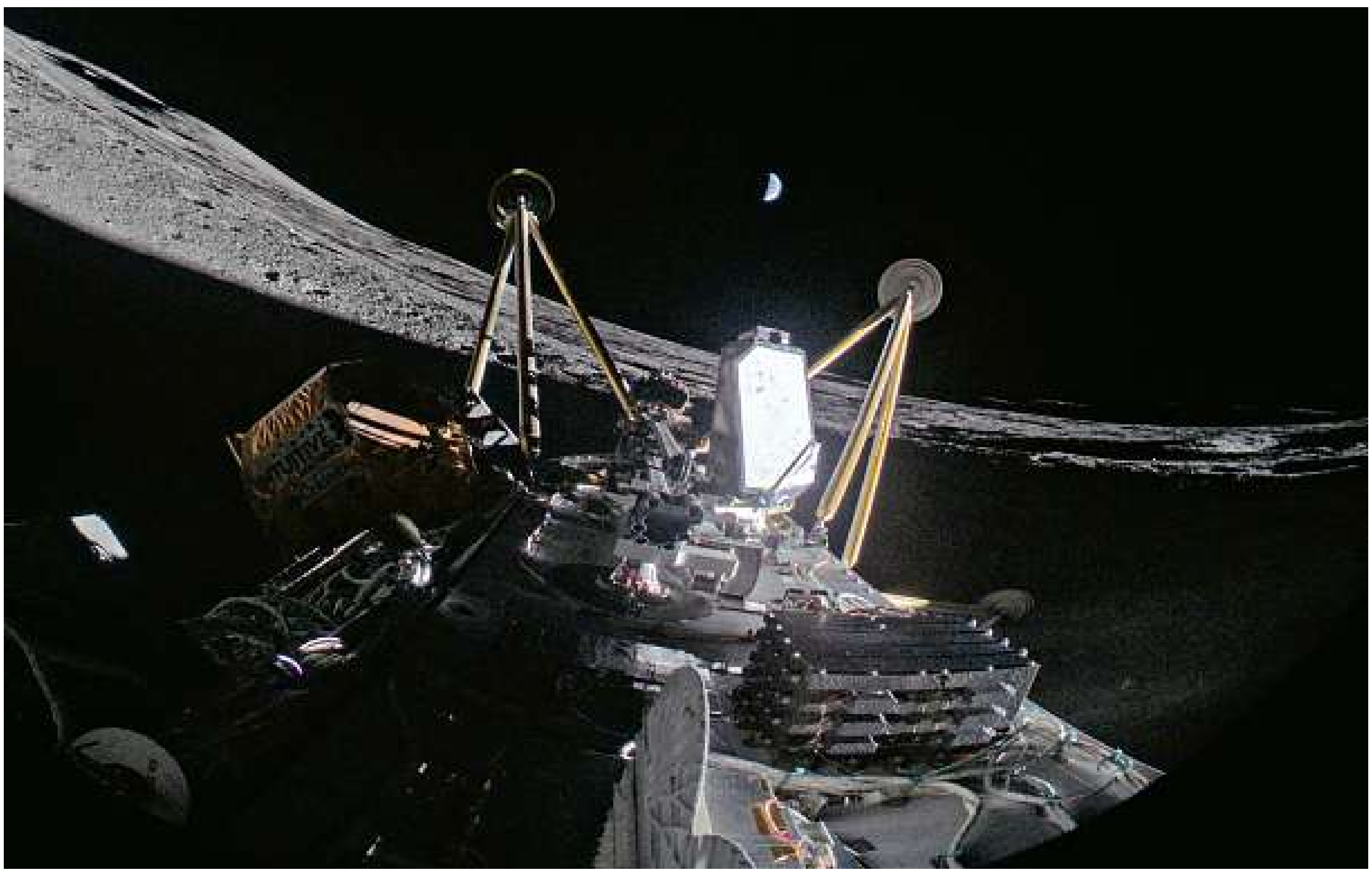
The Agriculture Department said last month it plans to invest as much as $1 billion to address egg costs, including $500 million for expanded biosecurity measures at egg-producing farms.

Cal-Maine Foods, the largest U.S. egg producer and one of the few publicly traded egg companies, has reported rising profits from the rise in egg prices and saw its stock surge in the years since the bird flu outbreak. The shares have gained about 50% over the past 12 months.

Antitrust authorities often open investigations when high prices appear to stem from unusual disruptions to supply chains, said Lisa Phelan, an antitrust partner at Morrison Foerster. "There can be anticompetitive efforts to deal with the crisis and that is not OK either," she said.

The egg industry has been criticized by some interest groups, such as farmer advocacy organization Farm Action, which has petitioned lawmakers and law enforcement to investigate egg pricing.

Space Probe Misses Landing Target, Is Declared Dead



INTUITIVE MACHINES/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

LUNAR LIST: Intuitive Machines' moon lander, shown in a handout photo from the company, was declared inoperative, ending the spacecraft's mission.

White House Cancels $400 Million In Grants and Contracts to Columbia

The Trump administration is canceling roughly $400 million in federal grants and contracts to Columbia University, the government said Friday.

By Liz Essley Whyte, Matt Barnum and Douglas Belkin

The Ivy League school has come under scrutiny by the Trump administration for an alleged failure to protect Jewish students. The grants in question are from the Department of Health and Human Services, the General Services Administration and the Education Department.

"Universities must comply with all federal antidiscrimination laws if they are going to receive federal funding," Education Secretary Linda McMahon said. "Columbia has abandoned that obligation to Jewish students studying on its campus."

A Columbia spokesperson said the school is reviewing the agencies' moves and pledged "to work with the federal government to restore Columbia's federal funding," adding that the school is "committed to combatting antisemitism and ensuring the safety and wellbeing of our students, faculty, and staff."

A person with knowledge of the discussions said the university will have a 30-day review period to address the government's concerns and potentially reinstate the contracts.

The Trump administration was aiming to cut a much higher number of grants, worth billions of dollars altogether, but decided Friday to keep intact some National Institutes of Health grants to Columbia, a person familiar with the matter said.

Columbia received more than $639 million in grants from the NIH, a division of HHS, in 2024, according to government data.

The administration announced a review of Columbia's contracts and grants earlier this past week. The agencies said at the time that they were considering stop-work orders for $51.4 million in contracts with Columbia and a "comprehensive review" of more than $5 billion in grant commitments to the school.

The Justice Department has said it is sending a task force to visit Columbia and other universities that have dealt with antisemitism. Those schools had some of the biggest pro-Palestinian demonstrations that disrupted campuses last year and prompted rebukes from across the political spectrum.

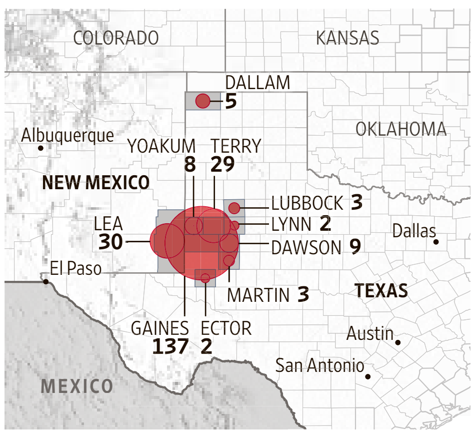
Columbia drew especially heated criticism from some alumni for what they perceived as the university's tepid response.

The protests led the school to move classes online in April. A month later Columbia canceled its main graduation ceremony, and in August, President Minouche Shafik resigned 13 months into the job.

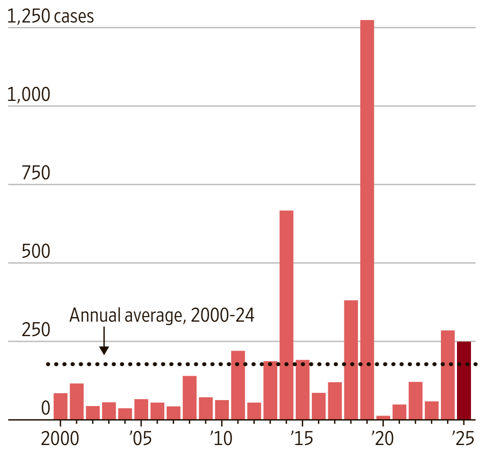
YUKI IWAMURA/ASSOCIATED PRESS

A pro-Palestinian encampment at Columbia University in April 2024. The school has come under scrutiny by the Trump administration for an alleged failure to protect Jewish students.

Counties affected by the current measles outbreak in Texas and New Mexico



Measles cases in the U.S.



Note: 2025 data compiled from news reports and health departments in Alaska, California, Florida, Georgia, Kentucky, New Jersey, New Mexico, New York City, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, Texas and Washington state—the areas the CDC identified as having cases this year—and is the most recent data available as of March 7.

Sources: Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (historical data); health departments, news reports (counties, 2025)

Measles Outbreak Doubles Over the Past Two Weeks

BY JOSEPH PISANI

The number of people sickened by measles in Texas and New Mexico has surpassed 200, more than doubling over the past two weeks, state health officials said.

The Texas outbreak, which has been spreading through the South Plains region since late January, ticked up to 198 cases on Friday. Officials reported another 30 cases across the border in New Mexico.

Twenty-three people have been hospitalized, and one school-age child who wasn't vaccinated died in Lubbock, Texas. Most of those sickened weren't vaccinated, or their vaccination status wasn't known.

A second person might have died of measles this past week. New Mexico's department of health on Thursday reported that a person in Lea County, which borders Texas, tested positive for measles after death. But the official cause of death for the person, who wasn't vaccinated, hasn't been determined. The early spread occurred in the Mennonite community in Gaines County, Texas, which has high levels of unvaccinated people.

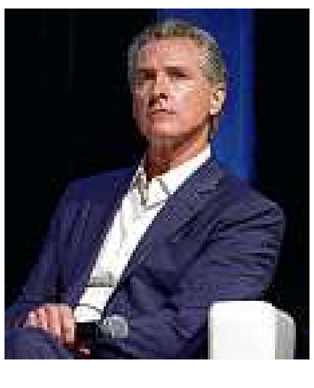
Katherine Wells, director of Lubbock Public Health, said the jump in numbers is likely due to more people getting tested. "This is growing how I would expect it to grow," Wells said.

Wells said measles-testing capabilities were set up in Lubbock on Monday, producing test results in 24 hours.

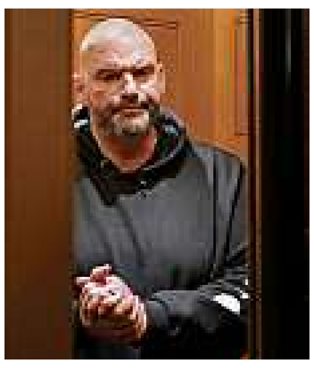
Democrats Fight Over How to Fight Back

Moderates fear being too confrontational with Trump will repel centrist voters

By Aaron Zitner
And Katy Stech Ferek



Clockwise from left: Senate Democrats with pictures of constituents they say are hurt by Trump's actions; Gov. Gavin Newsom of California; Sen. John Fetterman (D., Pa.).



CLOCKWISE FROM LEFT: CHIP SOMODEVILLA/GETTY IMAGES, DAMIAN DOVARGANES/ASSOCIATED PRESS, ALEX WROBLEWSKI/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

The Democratic Party, overpowered by President Trump's command of the national political debate, is fighting over how to respond.

When Rep. Al Green of Texas stood up, shook his cane and yelled at Trump during the president's address to Congress this past week, the progressive group Indivisible called it the leadership the party needs. But to Rep. Tom Suozzi of New York, Green's outburst was a distraction from the pocketbook issues that win elections.

Their diverging approaches reflect a schism inside the party over Democrats' most promising pathway back to power. Progressives are urging core supporters to flood town hall meetings and congressional phone lines to demand an aggressive response to Trump. Moderates say that approach risks turning off centrist voters in highly competitive districts—such as Suozzi's.

The confrontation crowd believes that angry voters turning out at town hall meetings have scared GOP lawmakers, who in turn could become a moderating force on Trump. Many are unwilling to accept that their party has little ability to counter the president's efforts to fire federal workers, idle entire agencies and unwind longstanding ties with U.S. allies, even though Democrats don't control the House, the Senate or the White House.

"Be in their faces," said Michele Harney, 68, who attended a constituent meeting held recently by Rep. Suhas Subramanyam (D., Va.). She recited the slogan of former First Lady Michelle Obama, "When they go low, we go high," then added: "I'm tired of going high."

"We can't just go about like it's business as usual. We need wartime leaders at this point, because that's what this is," said Daniel Callahan, 42, who attended a town hall meeting held by Rep. Chrissy Houlahan (D., Pa.) and said he was frustrated by what he said was her bipartisan posture.

Evan Roth Smith, a Democratic pollster with the firm Blueprint, urged a more cautious approach. The party right now isn't a compelling alternative to Trump, he said.

In a mid-February Blueprint poll, 65% of voters agreed with the statement "no one has any idea what the Democratic Party stands for any more, other than opposing Donald Trump." Smith said that Democrats should discard any gesture that distracts from showing how the party would help voters if they regained power.

Rahm Emanuel, the former congressman and White House chief of staff to former President Barack Obama, has said that confrontation won't help Democrats reach voters. "They're close to having you on mute, anyway. If it's only one tone, they'll shut you down," Emanuel said at a February rural panel.

The divide over tactics surfaced again on Thursday, as Suozzi and nine other Democrats joined all Republicans in voting to censure Green for his breach of decorum, a gesture to the political center. Five of the Democrats represent highly competitive districts, including three where a majority of voters backed Trump last year.

Where progressives criticized the censuring Democrats, Lauren Harper Pope of the Welcome PAC, which supports centrist Democrats, said those who censured Green know what it takes to win over voters in competitive districts.

The censure vote was only one recent case where the party's centrist and progressive impulses were at odds.

Gavin Newsom, the governor of California, broke with liberals by saying trans athletes should be banned from women's sports, calling it "an issue of fairness. And I think Democrats have lost that." His comments were denounced by more liberal lawmakers.

On Capitol Hill, Democratic mayors of four big cities defended so-called sanctuary city policies that limit cooperation with Trump's deportation program aimed at removing people who are in the U.S. illegally.

Other Democrats have argued that voters won't trust the party unless it proves it is serious about border security. In January, the Laken Riley Act, which imposes harsher penalties on some people in the country illegally, passed with support from 48 Democrats in the House and 12 in the Senate.

The party also took a centrist approach in choosing Sen. Elissa Slotkin of Michigan, a state that backed Trump for president last year, to give its official response to Trump's address. Slotkin, who served in Iraq as a CIA analyst, delivered a calm, centrist message that said lawmakers should focus on cutting grocery prices, securing the border and fixing the legal immigration system.

To Simon Rosenberg, a longtime Democratic strategist, protest politics works. Rosenberg, who uses his Hopium Chronicles substack and podcast to encourage Democrats to call their elected officials and organize against vulnerable GOP lawmakers, says the crowds at town hall meetings can both affect policy in Washington and help Democrats in the midterm elections.

During Trump's address, Green was ejected from the House chamber for his outburst, and other Democrats later walked out. Those who remained sat stone-faced, even as Trump gave a special honor to a 13-year-old cancer survivor in the audience. They displayed small signs with anti-Trump slogans.

Sen. John Fetterman (D., Pa.) derided it as a "protest paddle bonanza" and said the party was wrong to "snub" the young cancer survivor.

But Ezra Levin, a co-founder of Indivisible, says party leaders don't understand the media environment, which requires messaging pitched to spread online. "If you're not going to create messages that get eyeballs and eardrums, then nobody is going to see your message," he said.

Funding Bill Faces Uncertain Prospects

By Siobhan Hughes

WASHINGTON—House Democratic leaders said they would oppose a Republican measure to keep the government funded beyond March 14 and avoid a government shutdown, after GOP leaders rejected their efforts to write in protections against further cuts to federal workers and services.

"Republicans have decided to introduce a partisan continuing resolution that threatens to cut funding for healthcare, nutritional assistance and veterans benefits through the end of the current fiscal year," House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D., N.Y.) and members of his leadership team wrote in a letter to colleagues. "That is not acceptable."

The move sets up a showdown next week when the bill funding the government for the rest of the fiscal year, known as a continuing resolution, comes to floor. It also adds to the unpredictability surrounding the vote, given the fluid dynamics in the House.

KAYLA BARTKOWSKI/GETTY IMAGES

Hakeem Jeffries

Speaker Mike Johnson (R., La.) has relied heavily on Democratic votes to pass such measures in the past, amid Republican rank-and-file griping over spending and other issues. If Democrats do follow through on their threat, Johnson would have to rally almost every Republican vote to his side.

Johnson, who has a narrow 218-214 majority in the House, has said he believes he has the votes to pass the spending measure. He scored a major victory last month when he successfully pushed through the budget framework for Republicans' tax cuts and border package largely along party lines, losing only one GOP vote. But Johnson has also maintained that the blame for any government shutdown would fall squarely on Democrats.

"The Democrats threw in this outrageous requirement, the stipulation, hey, we won't fund the government unless you tie the hands of the executive branch," Johnson said on Fox News on Friday. Democrats "know we will not do that," he said. "It looks like they were trying to engineer a shutdown of the government, which is terribly irresponsible."

House Republicans expected to unveil their spending measure as soon as Friday. A continuing resolution extends funding at the prior year's levels and hamstrings efforts to initiate new programs.

Rep. Rosa DeLauro (D., Conn.), the top Democrat on the House Appropriations Committee, and her counterpart in the Senate have been trying to reach a deal with Republicans to fund the government through the end of the fiscal year. But Republicans dismissed Democrats' push for protections against billionaire Elon Musk's work through his Department of Government Efficiency to slash programs.

Funding is due to expire at 12:01 a.m. on March 15. But signs are emerging Johnson might be able to keep in line enough Republicans to pass a spending bill on a party-line basis. Some of the House Republicans who have always voted against their party's spending bills have started to shift course, and brought around, they say, by promises made by the Trump administration.

"Next week I plan to vote for a clean CR with the understanding that the President will immediately...clean up spending," said Rep. Keith Self (R., Texas), who has never voted for one of Johnson's spending bills, in a social-media post.

Judge Declines To Limit DOGE's Access to Payments

By Jan Wolfe
And Jacob Gershman

A federal judge on Friday declined to limit access to a Treasury Department payment system by Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency.

U.S. District Judge Colleen Kollar-Kotelly in Washington, D.C., rejected a request by a retirees' group and two labor unions to block DOGE from accessing the payment system, which processes tax refunds, Social Security payments, Medicare spending and federal salaries.

The challengers said an injunction was necessary to protect the private data of average Americans.

The judge said those privacy concerns are understandable, but noted she had not been presented with evidence showing private data on the Treasury Department payment system was being compromised.

Kollar-Kotelly said the plaintiffs had not met their burden "of demonstrating that such a breach or improper disclosure is likely."

The ruling clears one hurdle for DOGE, whose mission is to find ways to cut costs and reduce government spending.

But its practical impact is limited, because a different federal judge in New York last month blocked DOGE from accessing the Treasury payment system.

U.S. District Judge Jeannette Vargas in Manhattan had ruled that Treasury's "rushed and ad hoc" process for giving DOGE access had created a "realistic danger that confidential financial information will be disclosed."

Vargas indicated she could lift her injunction if the Trump administration met certain conditions. She ordered the Treasury Department to submit a report by March 24 that details whether DOGE employees have been adequately vetted and trained to access the financial system, as well as steps taken to "minimize any threats resulting from increased access" by DOGE.

The vast majority of government payments from any agency pass through the Treasury system, including retirement and healthcare benefits, housing assistance and educational grants. Federal agencies determine who qualifies for these benefits. That information is then transmitted to the Treasury, which disburses the payments.

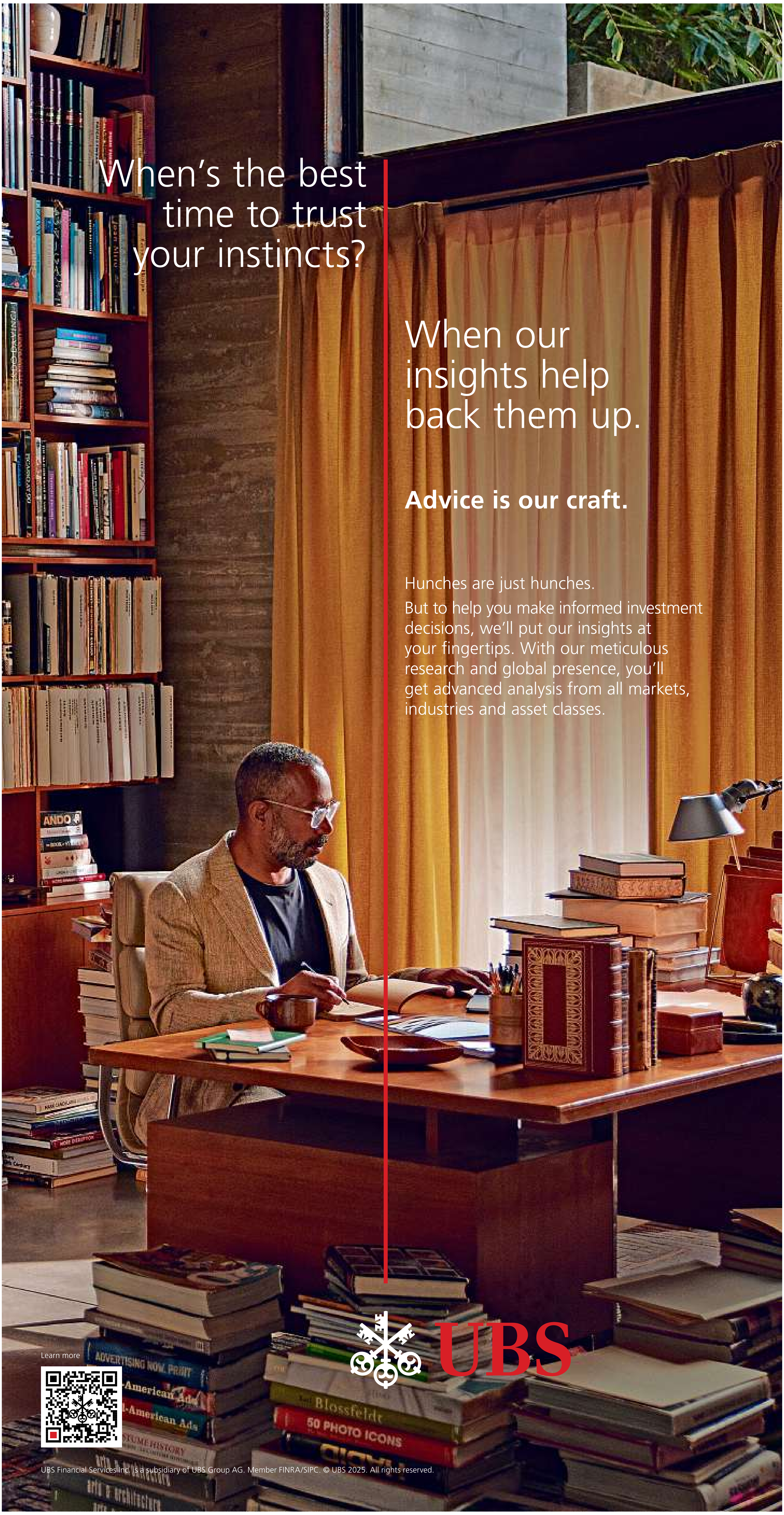
Trump created DOGE through a Jan. 20 executive order, saying it would provide recommendations for how to slash federal spending. The president has said that Musk is its leader, but administration lawyers have previously described the billionaire CEO's role as advisory.

The Trump administration's initiatives to shrink the federal government have prompted a flood of lawsuits alleging the president is exceeding his powers and encroaching upon the authority of Congress.

While the Trump administration has fended off some of those challenges so far, plaintiffs have won early victories in others, including over efforts to freeze federal spending.

KENT NISHIMURA/REUTERS

Elon Musk


When's the best time to trust your instincts?
When our insights help back them up.
Advice is our craft.
Hunches are just hunches.
But to help you make informed investment decisions, we'll put our insights at your fingertips. With our meticulous research and global presence, you'll get advanced analysis from all markets, industries and asset classes.
UBS
Learn more
UBS Financial Services Inc. is a subsidiary of UBS Group AG. Member FINRA/SIPC. © UBS 2025. All rights reserved.

FTX Chief Makes Play For Pardon

Continued from Page One

on all the dark money that he'd contributed to Republican politicians, pass the blame to lawyers and rail against "the woke agenda."

Then he was convicted of fraud and sentenced to 25 years in prison. He mostly went silent—until recently. Now, from behind bars in the Metropolitan Detention Center in Brooklyn, Bankman-Fried is orchestrating an extraordinary public-relations blitz that looks very much like a campaign to make the most audacious trade of his career: support for President Trump's agenda in return for a presidential pardon.

Bankman-Fried has told associates that he has been interested in seeking a Trump pardon ever since last November's election, a person familiar with the matter said, though no official pardon request has been submitted yet. The White House didn't respond to a request for comment.

There is little downside to Bankman-Fried's long-shot effort to secure a pardon. As the appeal that he filed last year works its way through the courts, Bankman-Fried, 33 years old, is staring down a sentence that would last until his 50s.

His efforts coincide with Trump's evolution from crypto skeptic to full-throated supporter. After previously calling bitcoin a scam, Trump held the first-ever White House crypto summit on Friday. In January, crypto enthusiasts applauded when Trump, a Republican, pardoned Ross Ulbricht, founder of underground drug bazaar Silk Road, whose release had become a cause célèbre in bitcoin circles.

But they are unlikely to be as welcoming of a pardon for Bankman-Fried, who remains widely loathed across the crypto industry.

The first stop of his media tour to spin a different narrative came in February, when he gave a phone interview to the New York Sun and said his political views had shifted. He called the Biden administration's crypto policy destructive and explicitly praised the Republican Party.

Sam Bankman-Fried gave a jailhouse interview to 'The Tucker Carlson Show' on Thursday.

Days later, in February, came a long thread on X in which Bankman-Fried expressed sympathy for Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency's deep cuts in the federal workforce.

The crowning touch of his campaign came on Thursday, when Bankman-Fried gave a jailhouse interview to "The Tucker Carlson Show," which was released on social-media channels like X and YouTube. Appearing on video in a brown jumpsuit, he criticized Washington bureaucrats and crypto regulators—and suggested that he went to prison out of political retribution.

The founder is orchestrating an extraordinary public-relations blitz.

He also discussed his relationship with another famous resident of his Brooklyn detention center's unit, Sean "Diddy" Combs, the hip-hop kingmaker awaiting trial on charges related to his alleged role in sex trafficking. Bankman-Fried said that Diddy had been kind to him.

The aftershocks of his appearance with Carlson were felt right away.

Mark Botnick, a communications veteran who acted as Bankman-Fried's spokesman throughout his trial, quit representing him after the Carlson interview, saying it had been arranged behind his back.

It appeared to blindside U.S. authorities, too. The interview hadn't been approved by the Federal Bureau of Prisons, according to a person familiar with the matter. Bankman-Fried spoke with Carlson through a link that is typically used by inmates to communicate with their lawyers, the person said.

After the interview, he was placed in solitary confinement, but he was out by Friday afternoon, according to a person familiar with the matter.

Bankman-Fried didn't respond to a request for comment through the federal-prison email system.

Behind the scenes, Bankman-Fried and his parents have been getting advice on seeking a pardon since January from Kory Langhofer, an Arizona lawyer and former federal prosecutor who worked for Trump's 2016 and 2020 campaigns, according to a person familiar with the matter.

"It may be time for a calmer discussion about FTX," Langhofer said. "Much of what people (including jurors) were told about the collapse is simply incorrect."

Bankman-Fried is trying to highlight in media appearances and in any interaction with Trump's team that FTX customers are set to be made whole with interest through the bankruptcy proceedings—at least in dollar terms. Many of those creditors remain furious that they missed out on bitcoin's huge rally since November 2022.

He also hopes to undo what he believes has been his wrongful portrayal as a drug-using millennial participating in sex parties, the person said, and wants to set the record straight on his political beliefs, which he believes have been misconstrued. While he has given heavily to Democrats, he also donated to Republican causes, including millions to a group supporting Sen. Mitch McConnell (R., Ky.).

The downfall of Bankman-Fried began with the swift implosion of FTX in late 2022, when a run on his exchange revealed an $8 billion hole. A month later, he was arrested in the Bahamas and charged by U.S. prosecutors with orchestrating one of the largest financial frauds in American history.

At his trial in downtown New York, the jury deliberated for only a few hours before returning a verdict of guilty.

As his parents lobbied on his behalf in private, Bankman-Fried took his pardon campaign public.

As he tells it, Bankman-Fried had center-left politics when he donated millions to Democrat Joe Biden's campaign in 2020, but became so disillusioned by the administration's policies that he lurched right. By the 2022 midterm elections, only days before FTX declared bankruptcy, Bankman-Fried said he was privately giving as much to conservative politicians as liberals.

As Bankman-Fried was behind bars, Trump and crypto embraced each other. On the campaign trail, Trump drew interest—and millions of dollars—from crypto executives looking to secure influence. Last summer, Trump headlined a bitcoin conference. He licensed his image to promote a cryptocurrency, opened his campaign to crypto donations and, days before his inauguration, launched his own meme coin: $TRUMP.

On Friday, two dozen of the industry's most powerful figures descended on the White House for a crypto summit and to discuss Trump's plans to establish a strategic bitcoin reserve.

In the phone interview with the New York Sun, Bankman-Fried made an overt play to curry favor with the president. As it happens, the judge in his trial, Lewis Kaplan, also oversaw the 2023 trial in which Trump was found liable for sexually abusing and defaming E. Jean Carroll and ordered to pay $5 million in damages. In the Sun interview, Bankman-Fried drew a direct line between the two cases.

"I know President Trump had a lot of frustrations with Judge Kaplan," he said. "I certainly did as well."

A few days later, Bankman-Fried posted on X for the first time in more than a year and seemingly expressed his support for the DOGE cuts.

His latest appearance came this past week on Carlson's show. At the beginning of the nearly 45-minute interview, the former Fox News anchor said they had never talked before but that Bankman-Fried looked healthier and less fidgety than when Carlson used to see him on TV.

Bankman-Fried said he had been playing chess with and sometimes losing to his fellow inmates—and sounded bemused by his fate.

"If someone told me three years ago you'll be hanging out with Diddy every day, I'd be like, oh, that's interesting," Bankman-Fried said. "I wonder how that's going to happen—I guess he gets into crypto or something?"

Gene Hackman Died Of Heart Disease

BY VICTORIA ALBERT AND BETSY MCKAY

Gene Hackman, the actor who was found dead in his home with his wife last month, died of heart disease, officials in New Mexico said Friday.

Hackman's wife, classical pianist Betsy Arakawa, died of hantavirus pulmonary syndrome, a disease caused by rodents, according to New Mexico's chief medical examiner Heather Jarrell.

The autopsy of Hackman, who was 95, revealed signs of advanced Alzheimer's disease, severe heart disease and prior heart attacks, Jarrell said. The actor tested negative for hantavirus.

Arakawa was last seen returning home on the night of Feb. 11, and is thought to have died soon after, Santa Fe County Sheriff Adan Mendoza said. Hackman is believed to have survived for approximately another week, officials said, with the last registered activity on his pacemaker occurring on Feb. 18.

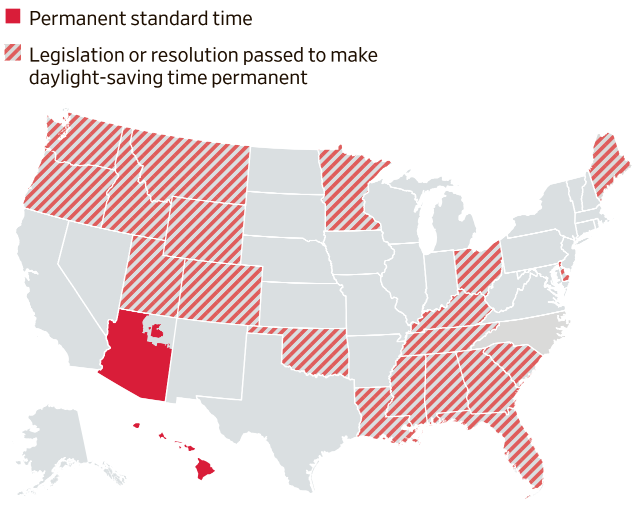
Officials said it wasn't clear whether Hackman was aware his wife had died. Hackman didn't appear to be dehydrated at the time of his death, Jarrell said.

When asked if there was a possibility that he was trying to get help, Mendoza said, "I don't know if we'll ever have the answer to that question—whether he was going to go for help, or he wasn't sure."

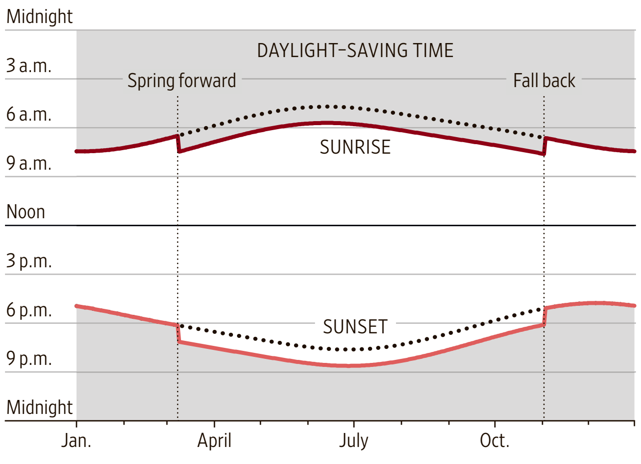
Hackman and his wife were found dead at their home in Santa Fe, N.M., on Feb. 26. Hackman was found dead near the kitchen and Arakawa was found dead in a bathroom.

The U.S. first adopted the clock change during World War I, as a way to reduce energy use.

What states want to do with daylight-saving time*



How daylight-saving time affects sunrise and sunset times†



*Navajo Nation lands within Arizona observe daylight-saving time. As of Febraury 2025
†Sunrise and sunset times are for Washington, D.C., in 2025.
Sources: National Conference of State Legislatures (states); U.S. Naval Observatory Astronomical Applications Department (times)

Daylight-Saving Debate

Continued from Page One

some places daylight-saving time saves electricity, while in others it uses more, with the overall effect across the U.S. basically a wash.

Separately, traffic-flow data the researchers are analyzing suggest that daylight saving might lead people to drive more—which doesn't exactly save energy either.

More driving is certainly the case when daylight-saving time *starts* each March, which is understandable: A lot of outdoor sports practices begin the week after the clocks change, for example. And Kotchen suspects it is also true across daylight-saving time in general: No matter what time the sun rises, most people aren't going to hit the golf course or grab a meal with friends *before* they go to work.

Daylight time

Many businesses favor daylight time over the alternative: standard time. An outdoor cafe might attract customers later in the evening, while a golf course could fit another foursome in before nightfall.

But for some lawmakers, eight months of daylight time isn't enough. In an effort led by Secretary of State Marco Rubio, then a Republican senator from Florida, the Senate in 2022 passed the "Sunshine Protection Act." The bill proposed making daylight-saving time permanent, and it passed by unanimous consent. But it went no further.

Sen. Ed Markey, a Democrat from Massachusetts who co-sponsored the 2022 bill, has been backing daylight time for decades.

"It's time to lock the clock so we can spring forward into permanent sun and smiles," Markey said in a statement to The Wall Street Journal.

Twenty states have passed legislation or resolutions to move to permanent daylight time, according to the National Conference of State Legislatures. But they haven't actually moved: Federal law doesn't currently allow states to go to permanent daylight time.

However, the law doesn't preclude states from staying on permanent standard time. For example, Arizona stays on standard time year-round, excluding the parts of the state that are within the Navajo Nation. The extreme heat in the summers would make the later part of the day much hotter under daylight time.

Standard time

Sleep scientists say that lawmakers who want permanent daylight time are picking the wrong side. Research suggests staying on standard time would be better, for health reasons.

The American Medical Association in 2022 called for permanent standard time. The period after the spring clock change, after all, has been associated with increased health risks, such as shorter sleep, more car accidents and an increase in heart attacks.

Additionally, daylight time puts body clocks and alarm clocks at odds with each other, the organization said.

The body clocks that organize our daily rhythms tend to respond to the sun's position in the sky, explains sleep scientist Elizabeth Klerman, professor of neurology at Massachusetts General Hospital and Harvard Medical School. Our social clocks—the times that are on our watches and phones—are what is set by society so we can coordinate our schedules.

Ideally, our body clocks and social clocks should be closely aligned. Standard time, when daylight hours are earlier in the morning, is the better option, sleep experts said.

Support is unclear

Kotchen, the Yale economist, isn't sure the public would support going on permanent daylight-saving time or standard time for long. The U.S. experimented with permanent daylight time starting in January 1974, in response to the 1973 oil shock. People hated it: They struggled to get up, rouse children for school and go to work in dark mornings. Clock changing was reinstated that fall.

The experiment yielded no definitive energy savings—which was one of the main points in the first place.

Year-round standard time might not fly either: The transition to daylight-saving time is harsh—maybe more so since it moved in 2007 to early March from early April—but people might miss the late-summer light.

"I think what we have now is probably like splitting the difference in a way that is the right balance," Kotchen said.

Trump on Thursday appeared to have lost his enthusiasm for tackling the issue of clock resets. "A lot of people like it one way," he said. "A lot of people like it the other way."

U.S. WATCH

SOUTH CAROLINA

Inmate Executed By Firing Squad

The state on Friday executed a death-row inmate by firing squad, the first time in modern history the method has been used in South Carolina.

The 67-year-old inmate, Brad Sigmon, was convicted of a 2001 double-murder and a year later was sentenced to death. He chose his method of execution and selected the firing squad over electrocution or lethal injection.

Sigmon's lawyer, Gerald King, didn't respond to a request for comment. King's legal efforts in the courts to halt Sigmon's execution failed, as did last-minute appeals to South Carolina Gov. Henry McMaster for clemency.

—Ginger Adams Otis

POLITICS

Santos Fundraiser Gets Prison Term

A former campaign fundraiser for former Rep. George Santos was sentenced to one year and one day in prison for impersonating a high-ranking congressional aide while raising campaign cash for the disgraced New York Republican.

Sam Miele acknowledged he committed access-device fraud by charging credit cards without authorization to send money to the campaigns of Santos and other political candidates, and for his own use.

—Associated Press

OKLAHOMA

Educator Pushes For Trump Bibles

Oklahoma's top education official said he is joining country music singer Lee Greenwood in an effort to get $59.99 leather-bound "God Bless the USA" Bibles into classrooms after a legislative panel rejected his request for $3 million to fund the effort.

State Superintendent Ryan Walters said he is teaming up with Greenwood to help ensure the Trump-endorsed Bibles get to Oklahoma schools.

—Associated Press

P2JW067000-4-A00800-1--------XA

U.S. Threatens More Sanctions on Russia

Trump's remarks follow Moscow's latest missile, drone attacks on Ukraine

By Tarini Parti

WASHINGTON—President Trump is "strongly considering" imposing far-reaching sanctions and tariffs on Russia until a peace agreement is reached in the war in Ukraine.

"Based on the fact that Russia is absolutely 'pounding' Ukraine on the battlefield right now, I am strongly considering large scale Banking Sanctions, Sanctions, and Tariffs on Russia until a Cease Fire and FINAL SETTLEMENT AGREEMENT ON PEACE IS REACHED," Trump wrote on social media on Friday.

He added that both Russia and Ukraine need to get to the negotiating table "before it is too late." The Kremlin didn't immediately respond to a request to comment.

Russia launched its latest aerial bombardment of Ukrainian cities early Friday with 67 missiles and 194 attack drones, according to the Ukrainian Air Force.

The majority were intercepted, the air force said, but officials reported damage to power and gas facilities.

Russia repeatedly has targeted Ukraine's electricity grid, often resulting in blackouts in cities nationwide.

Earlier this past week, the Trump administration said it ordered a pause to intelligence-sharing with Ukraine, a move that deprives Kyiv of a key tool in fighting Russian forces. The U.S. also has suspended weapons shipments to Ukraine.

Asked if he thought Russian President Vladimir Putin was striking Ukraine in an effort to take advantage of the intelligence-sharing pause, Trump said: "I actually think he's doing what anybody else would do. I think he wants to get it stopped and settled."

Speaking to reporters in the Oval Office, Trump said of Putin: "I think he's hitting them harder than he's been hitting them. And I think probably anybody in that position would be doing that right now."

Trump said he believed Putin wanted to end the war. "I'm finding it more difficult, frankly, to deal with Ukraine, and they don't have the cards," he noted.

The president also said that he has had a good relationship with Putin, and thinks the Russian leader will "be more generous than he has to be" to end the war.

Trump's latest comments come after a recent fiery Oval Office meeting with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky made the path forward for the peace agreement uncertain.

Top U.S. officials are planning to meet with Ukrainian officials in Saudi Arabia this coming week to set the stage for potential peace talks between Kyiv and Moscow.

Trump made a similar sanctions and tariff threat against Russia in January, but didn't follow through. At the time, he stressed that he didn't want to hurt Russia.

"I love the Russian people, and always had a very good relationship with President Putin," he wrote.

INNA VARENYTSIA/REUTERS

A residential building in the Ukrainian town of Pokrovsk was damaged by Russian strikes.

The efficacy of Trump's threat of tariffs is questionable. Russia exported about $2.9 billion worth of goods to the U.S. in 2024, according to Census Bureau data, down from $29.6 billion in 2021, before the war started.

The U.S. and its allies have been hitting Russia with sanctions and other punitive measures for years, including an effort to cap the price of oil exported by Russia and kick Russian banks out of the SWIFT international payments messaging system.

Russia's economy has been suffering from persistently high inflation, labor shortages and interest rates at a historic high of 21%.

Trump could further target Russia's oil, including some of its biggest oil producers such as Rosneft and Lukoil.

The U.S. president has faced criticism from Democrats, some Republicans and diplomats for, at times, echoing Putin's talking points about Ukraine and publicly criticizing Zelensky. He has said he has spoken directly with the Russian leader since taking office about ending the war.

Trump has said Putin would "keep his word" after a peace deal is reached.

Zelensky, who told Trump in the Oval Office meeting about Putin's history of invading Ukraine despite previous cease-fire agreements, has since said his meeting with Trump was "regrettable."

"Ukraine is ready to come to the negotiating table as soon as possible to bring lasting peace," Zelensky wrote on social media earlier this past week. "Nobody wants peace more than Ukrainians."

Germany Considers Nuclear Options for Its Defense

By Bertrand Benoit

BERLIN—President Trump's embrace of Russia is causing Europeans to rethink their security and giving currency to an idea the U.S. has long sought to avoid: a nuclear-armed Germany.

Friedrich Merz, who is poised to become Germany's chancellor, said Berlin should start talks about expanding the French and British nuclear deterrents to cover Europe, according to an interview the conservative politician did with the Frankfurter Allgemeine Sonntagszeitung weekly.

Asked if Germany should pursue its own arsenal, Merz didn't rule it out, saying "there is no need for this today."

The remarks broke with a longstanding taboo, showing how violently the foundations of Germany's and Europe's security are being shaken. Merz is still negotiating to form a government and has yet to be elected chancellor, but a German leader hasn't called for an alternative to the U.S. nuclear deterrent in Europe since the end of the Cold War.

THOMAS FREY/DPA/ZUMA PRESS

U.S. tactical nuclear weapons are stored at the Büchel Air Base in Germany, and could be used if the U.S. president give the order.

After World War II, the Federal Republic of Germany was welcomed into the Western alliance as a bulwark against the Soviet bloc. Yet unlike France and the U.K., it renounced pursuing its own nuclear weapons and was brought in under the U.S. nuclear umbrella.

U.S. tactical nuclear weapons are now stored at the Büchel Air Base in western Germany, ready to be deployed by the German Air Force should the U.S. president give the order.

The U.S. hasn't said that it wants to pull troops out of Europe. but Trump tried to do so in his first term. He is now seeking a detente with Russia's autocratic leader, Vladimir Putin, which some analysts say might have irreparably damaged the credibility of the U.S. deterrent in Europe.

Nowhere in Europe is the sense of abandonment more palpable than in Germany, where the U.S. maintains its second-largest overseas military presence. To fill the security gap, Germany would have four options, said Christian Mölling, director of the Europe's Future program at the Bertelsmann Foundation, a think tank: "The Americans maintain their nuclear deterrent; the Europeans take it on; a mix of the two; or you try to compensate conventionally…All of these are risky," he said, referring to nonnuclear, military forces.

On the conventional side, Merz and his future coalition partners have said they would exempt military spending from the country's tough fiscal rules, de facto removing any limit on spending and allowing Germany to rapidly accelerate its rearmament.

On the nuclear side, researchers and some politicians say Berlin's fastest route to rebuilding a deterrent could be to replicate its arrangement with the U.S. This could see French nuclear bombers stationed in Germany with the mandate to protect the country or German pilots flying German planes armed with French nuclear weapons, with Paris holding the key to their use.

Reacting to "the historical appeal of the future German chancellor," French President Emmanuel Macron recently said he would start a "strategic debate" about extending Paris's nuclear deterrent to European allies.

The French arsenal was developed under President Charles de Gaulle to reduce reliance on the U.S. Unlike Britain's, it is independent from NATO. Still, with warheads in the low hundreds, neither the British nor the French arsenals are a match for Russia's nearly 6,000 warheads.

For Germany, subcontracting its security to France and the U.K. could make it hostage to political shifts in Paris and London, much as it is now subject to Trump's whims.

Macron stressed that the decision to strike "had always been and would always be in the hands of the [French] president." Marine Le Pen, the nationalist politician polls suggest could succeed Macron, said this week of the French deterrent that "we shouldn't share it, let alone delegate it."

Germany is a signatory to the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons, which bans it from developing nuclear weapons and prevents other signatories from helping it do so. It also renounced the weapons in the treaty that paved the way for German reunification.

If Berlin develops an arsenal, it would have to do so clandestinely, not just because it would violate its obligations, but because the effort would make it a target for enemies.

Germany has a small stockpile of weapons-grade uranium for use in a civilian research nuclear reactor operated by the Technical University of Munich. It is generally thought to have the scientific and industrial base required for weapons development, but it likely would need outside help to procure enough nuclear material for a bomb without being detected.

"No one has ever managed to produce enough material for a bomb without being detected," said Alexander Bollfrass, head of strategy, technology and arms control at the International Institute for Strategic Studies.

NATO Hunts Sea Saboteurs

Continued from Page One

and scoured the 750-foot-long ship, digging through its logs and inspecting its anchor, which was torn from its chain during the incident. But Finnish and other officials familiar with the probe said they weren't able to find enough evidence to issue arrest warrants or for prosecutors to press charges related to deliberate wrongdoing. The ship was released on March 2, but three crew members are still under investigation and must remain in the country, Finland's police said.

Proving sabotage is difficult and requires significant evidence or testimonies to support the finding, said investigators, prosecutors and officials involved in the probes. To issue an arrest warrant or bring a case, prosecutors must provide substantial evidence of intentional wrongdoing, rather than an accidental and unnoticed dropping of an anchor.

"Even if you show it was deliberate, it's extremely unlikely you'll find a paper trail linking the incident to a state actor," said Elisabeth Braw, an expert in combat below the threshold of warfare.

The difficulties of prosecuting such cases are frustrating Western officials who are trying to combat what they said is a hybrid war against critical infrastructure in the West that they blame on Russia. The Kremlin, which didn't respond to a request for comment, has denied attacks on Western infrastructure in the past.

The North Atlantic Treaty Organization has taken a newly aggressive posture in response to such events in the Baltic, home to a handful of Russia's ice-free commercial ports, and one of the busiest trade corridors in the world. But holding anyone accountable is proving hard.

The Eagle S captain told police the December incident was an accident, according to people familiar with the investigation. Caravella LLC-FZ, the Emirati company that owns the ship, didn't respond to requests for comment.

Having found no link between the damaged cable and the Kremlin or any other country, the Finnish government has released the ship, the people said.

To keep the ship until now, prosecutors have focused on lesser offenses such as environmental and customs violations, these people said.

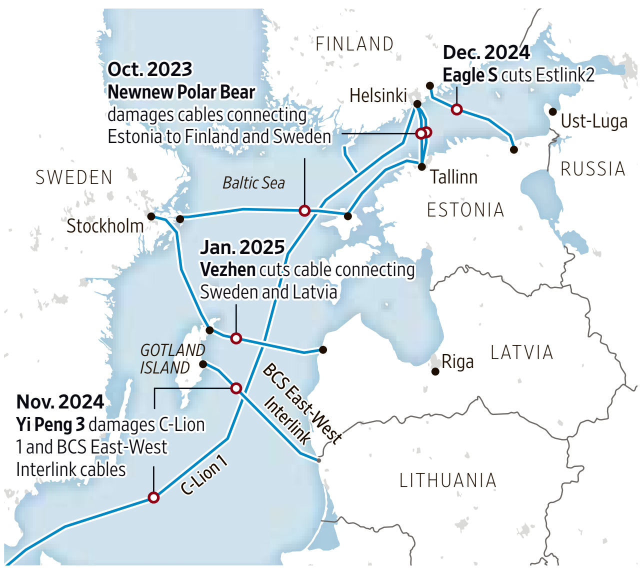
Captains of other vessels also have blamed mistakes for recent damage their ships are linked to in the Baltic.

In November, the Chinese-flagged Yi Peng 3 was suspected of dragging its anchor for miles along the Baltic seafloor. Western intelligence agencies alleged in private at the time that the captain was acting on the orders of Russian operatives while the ship was moored in a Russian dock that month, The Wall Street Journal reported.

Investigations by European authorities, including a search of the ship that Beijing only permitted to take place on the condition that Chinese officials led it, didn't result in evidence to support that allegation, people familiar with that probe told the Journal.

Beijing didn't respond to a request for comment.

The possibility that the anchor dropped accidentally has been all but ruled out, investigators said, adding there was a chance that gross negligence or bad weather played a part.



Note: Locations are approximate.
Sources: TeleGeography (cables); MarineTraffic (ship positions)
EMMA BROWN/WSJ

JOHAN NILSSON/TT NEWS AGENCY/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

A crew member is on lookout from a ship near Karlskrona, Sweden, as part of a NATO Baltic Sea patrol mission.

Investigators established only that the FSB, Russia's largest security service, which also manages the country's borders, held the ship for two days after it was loaded in one of Russia's Baltic ports. They weren't able to find out why it was held. The FSB didn't respond to a request for comment.

Across the world's 450 subsea cable systems, spanning nearly one million miles, more than 150 technical faults and other problems occur each year, according to the International Cable Protection Committee, a trade group. Up to 80% of cable-damage incidents are caused by accidents linked to commercial fishing and ship anchors, the ICPC said.

Overall trends in accidents are hard to assess but the number of incidents involving severe harm is increasing, said Braw. Four major Baltic incidents, which damaged undersea cables and a gas pipeline, occurred during the past 16 months. They all involved ships that had been operating between Russian ports or were carrying Russian cargo. The Kremlin has denied wrongdoing.

The incidents prompted NATO to launch a new mission, Baltic Sentry. It is conducting naval patrols and enhanced drone, satellite and electronic surveillance of Baltic Sea areas that are packed with critical infrastructure such as data and power cables, as well as gas pipelines and offshore wind farms.

In the first incident of suspected sabotage, in October 2023, Chinese bulk carrier Newnew Polar Bear cut a data cable and a natural-gas pipeline with its anchor. The ship was allowed to continue its journey despite being under investigation.

The Yi Peng 3 cut two data cables in the same region in the November incident. The Danish navy effectively forced the ship to stop, and China ordered the captain to wait for investigators to board the vessel, which was loaded with Russian fertilizer.

A month later, Finland detained the Eagle S, registered in the Cook Islands, on suspicion it had cut the power cable to Estonia.

On Jan. 26, Vezhen, a Bulgarian bulk carrier that had just departed the Russian port Ust-Luga, was detained and boarded by Swedish special police after damaging a subsea cable, in the first deployment of NATO's Baltic Sentry. The ship was detained and later released by Swedish prosecutors.

The owner said armed Swedish officers "aggressively" boarded the Vezhen.

NATO, inspired by Finland's decisive raid on the Eagle S, will continue acting forcefully to deter attacks on critical infrastructure, said James Appathurai, NATO assistant deputy secretary-general in charge of hybrid warfare. "The captains and crews of ships that are thinking of acts of sabotage should be aware," he said.

As the U.S. and its Western allies tightened sanctions against Russian energy exports, Moscow started deploying warships to escort its "shadow fleet" of tankers in the Baltic, sometimes including powerful missile ships, said several European officials.

Watch a Video

Scan this code for a video on the island key to NATO's Russia strategy.

SPORTS

By Jared Diamond

The Small-Market Teams Battling Baseball's $400 Million Monster

The Los Angeles Dodgers have the highest payroll in Major League Baseball history. The Arizona Diamondbacks and San Diego Padres are the NL West rivals left trying to keep up.

Ken Kendrick insists he and his business partners "don't spend a whole lot of time thinking about the Los Angeles Dodgers."

That might be an act of self-preservation.

As owner of the Arizona Diamondbacks, Kendrick is responsible for putting up the cash to build a roster capable of beating the Dodgers in the National League West. The problem is that the Dodgers have a payroll of nearly $400 million, a record figure that has sparked consternation and ferocious debate about baseball's entire economic system.

Suffice to say that the Diamondbacks don't have quite those resources at their disposal. In a sport with no salary cap, the situation has left them wondering how to keep pace with the wealthy neighbor next door that seems to have a bottomless wallet.

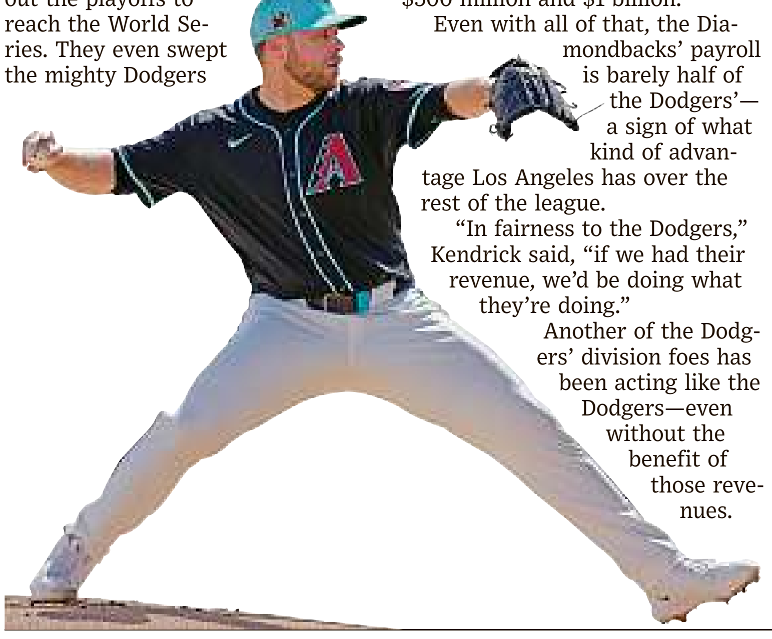
"You've either got to go and keep up with them and play a little bit better baseball than they're going to play," ace pitcher Corbin Burnes said, "or hopefully in four or five years, they stop spending money."

Burnes's presence in the clubhouse shows which of those paths the Diamondbacks have chosen. They stunned the industry earlier this winter when they signed Burnes, one of the sport's top starters, to a six-year contract worth $210 million. It was the richest free-agent deal in Diamondbacks history and the largest this offseason by any franchise outside New York.

Burnes's arrival pushed the Diamondbacks' estimated opening day payroll to over $211 million, which is 13th the major leagues, according to data compiled by Spotrac. As recently as 2022, the Diamondbacks ranked 24th—a massive increase in spending that has coincided with the Dodgers reaching new heights of extravagance.

"Economically," Kendrick said, "it is uncomfortable."

It also might be the only way for the Diamondbacks to have a realistic shot of competing with the Dodgers, who have won the division they share in 11 of the past 12 seasons. The Diamondbacks were able to extend their budget because of their surprising success in 2023, when despite winning just 84 games in the regular season, they stormed throughout the playoffs to reach the World Series. They even swept the mighty Dodgers in the division series.



In the wake of their unexpected pennant, attendance climbed nearly 20% in 2024. Diamondbacks president Derrick Hall said they are expecting another 20% increase this year, in part thanks to "a lift" in demand for season tickets following the Burnes acquisition.

The Diamondbacks recently held a capital call that led to three new limited partners buying equity this past fall, which infused more cash into the club, people familiar with the matter said. The reason was primarily to help fund a planned renovation to Chase Field that is expected to cost between $500 million and $1 billion.

Even with all of that, the Diamondbacks' payroll is barely half of the Dodgers'—a sign of what kind of advantage Los Angeles has over the rest of the league.

"In fairness to the Dodgers," Kendrick said, "if we had their revenue, we'd be doing what they're doing."

Another of the Dodgers' division foes has been acting like the Dodgers—even without the benefit of those revenues.

Several years ago, San Diego Padres owner Peter Seidler authorized a wild spending spree in an all-out effort to dethrone the Dodgers and bring the franchise its first World Series championship. Despite playing in one of baseball's smallest media markets and ranking near the bottom of the sport in payroll for decades, the Padres' stretched their budget to over $290 million in 2023, third-highest in MLB.

Seidler's plan was to find out just how much he could improve revenues in San Diego by doling out long-term contracts to a collection of stars, like Fernando Tatis Jr. and Manny Machado. He wasn't sure if the gambit would work. But he knew that he was tired of the Padres living in the shadow of the powerhouse two hours up Interstate 5.

The city responded in a way that had previously seemed impossible in a place like San Diego. The Padres averaged over 40,000 fans a game in 2023, trailing only the Dodgers and New York Yankees. Revenues soared.

Shortly after that season, Seidler died at the age of 63. In an acknowledgment that they had perhaps overextended themselves, the Padres slashed their payroll by more than $60 million in 2024.

In an effort to top the Dodgers and Shohei Ohtani, the Padres, above, have given long-term deals to Fernando Tatis Jr. and Manny Machado. The Diamondbacks signed Corbin Burnes, left, to a $210 million deal.

WSJ; ORLANDO RAMIREZ/GETTY IMAGES; ISTOCK; HARRY HOW/GETTY IMAGES; ROSS D. FRANKLIN/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Chief executive Erik Greupner said the cut was part of "a long-term plan that was set years ago." They wound up losing to the Dodgers in the postseason.

This offseason has been tumultuous, too. Sheel Seidler, Peter's widow, sued two of Peter's brothers in an attempt to become the Padres' controlling owner. The litigation is ongoing. A few weeks ago, MLB appointed John Seidler, another of Peter's brothers, as the team's control person. Greupner said the Padres continue to receive "the resources we need."

The Padres still have yet to bring a title to San Diego. But they haven't stopped trying. The Padres now have the sixth-highest payroll in baseball in 2025 and believe that their current level of spending is sustainable considering how much they have grown their business.

"We're putting everything that we have, that we can generate in our market, into this team," Greupner said. "And for that to be a top-10 payroll is pretty amazing."

To compete with the Dodgers, nothing less will do.

America's Push Into F1 Continues With Entry of Cadillac Team

By Joshua Robinson

The U.S. now hosts three Formula One Grand Prix races—in Las Vegas (pictured), Miami and Austin, Texas.

MIKE BLAKE/REUTERS

FORMULA ONE announced on Friday that it would expand for the first time in a decade next season when the U.S.-based Cadillac F1 joins the grid as the sport's 11th team.

It's no coincidence that Cadillac's arrival coincides with a period of unprecedented popularity for F1 in America. The U.S. now hosts three Grands Prix—in Miami, Las Vegas and Austin, Texas—up from just one five years ago. So it seemed only a matter of time before the sport admitted a second American outfit on top of the perennial backmarker Haas F1 Team.

The Cadillac project is backed by General Motors and TWG Global, the holding company run by Los Angeles Dodgers and Chelsea F.C. co-owner Mark Walter, who had been working on joining F1 for more than three years. But in order to reach the world's premier motor sport series, Cadillac first had to overcome plenty of headwinds.

Rival teams, for one, had been reluctant to slice off an extra share of their collective earnings in the middle of an F1 boom. Not only is the sport more popular than it has been in decades, it also has greater reach than ever before with a record 24 Grands Prix on the calendar.

The sport's organizers also demanded guarantees that Cadillac would be more than just another set of decals on a car. They wanted them in the sport as a full manufacturer. So even though it will begin racing next year with Ferrari engines, Cadillac has committed to developing its own power unit in the coming years, with an aim of making the transition by the end of the decade. That promise was ultimately what unlocked negotiations between the team and F1 last year.

"As we said in November, the commitment by General Motors to bring a Cadillac team to Formula One was an important and positive demonstration of the evolution of our sport," F1 chief executive Stefano Domenicali said.

Cadillac has said that it hopes at least one of its seats will go to a U.S. driver, even if Americans haven't had much luck competing in F1 in recent memory. The last American world championship came in 1978 with Mario Andretti, who had been one of the original driving forces of Cadillac's push into the sport. But since then no American driver has won so much as a single race. The last one to represent the stars and stripes was Florida's Logan Sargeant who scored just one point in 36 starts in 2023 and 2024.

Far more successful have been the Americans in F1 boardrooms. Los Angeles-born Zak Brown won a constructors' world championship as CEO of the McLaren team last season. And Colorado-based Liberty Media has been largely responsible for the sport's recent transformation—that's the company that bought Formula One in 2017.

Trump Goes All In for Crypto

Continued from Page One
ups. For crypto executives, the Trump administration has yielded a spectacular return on their investment.

Between the election and the inauguration, Trump met with at least eight crypto executives, collecting more than $50 million in donations for his inaugural fund and related groups, according to people familiar with the meetings. He asked the donors how they wanted the industry regulated and who should do it.

During last year's election campaign, crypto executives donated more than $16 million to pro-Trump groups. Super PACs backed by the industry spent more than $130 million on pro-crypto congressional candidates in both parties.

Trump was president-elect when he signed the meme-coin deal, which has generated around $350 million worth of cryptocurrency USDC for entities affiliated with him, according to the blockchain analysis firm Chainalysis. That figure, which includes both trading fees and what are essentially sales of the $TRUMP token, doesn't include some unrealized losses.

For now, crypto sales and trading are now essentially free from federal oversight until Congress creates a new framework. Those rules are expected to be looser than ones that govern Wall Street.

Crypto executives who gathered for lunch last month in Northern California's Los Altos Hills were jubilant. Coinbase had just announced that regulators agreed to drop a lawsuit that sought to regulate the company as a stock exchange. The SEC lawsuits had been a costly obstacle for the industry.

"The topic of conversation was how everybody's cases have suddenly and magically disappeared," said Trevor Traina, a crypto entrepreneur who was at the lunch. "The new badge of honor in Silicon Valley is if the SEC has dropped your case."

This article is based on interviews with more than two dozen cryptocurrency executives, lobbyists, congressional aides and people close to Trump and his family. A White House spokeswoman said Trump was "delivering on his pledge to make America the global leader in cryptocurrency." The Trump Organization and Trump's super PAC didn't respond to requests for comment.

Last weekend, after Trump previewed the creation of a strategic bitcoin reserve, bitcoin rose 9% in 24 hours to about $93,000. On Thursday, Trump signed an executive order establishing the reserve and a separate stockpile that would include smaller cryptocurrencies, a major win for the smaller tokens that had been lobbying to be a part of the stockpile.

On Friday, the Trump administration hosted a crypto event at the White House orchestrated by Sacks. It was the hottest ticket in town.

LIAM KENNEDY FOR WSJ

Above, President Trump speaking at the Bitcoin 2024 conference in Nashville, Tenn.; below, the president's son Barron Trump, center, who played a role explaining to his father why he should take crypto seriously, people in the industry said.

Among those who wrangled an invite for the few dozen available seats was the co-founder of a crypto project backed by Trump.

Opening the summit, Sacks recounted what one crypto entrepreneur had just told him: "A year ago, you thought it'd be more likely that you'd end up in jail than at the White House."

'Scam' no more

Trump had criticized cryptocurrency for years, calling the industry a "scam" and a "disaster waiting to happen."

The Biden administration, also skeptical of crypto, took the position that cryptocurrencies should fall under the same investor protection laws that apply to stocks. Biden's SEC chair, Gary Gensler, said the industry was rife with fraud, speculation and conflicts of interest.

In 2022, a cascade of crypto-market failures and bankruptcies wiped out or froze many investors' funds and later exposed fraud at FTX, one of the world's biggest exchanges. Gensler responded with lawsuits against such exchanges as Coinbase and Binance, hoping courts would force them to comply with investor-protection laws.

As the campaign heated up in late 2023, crypto companies began to meet with Trump's campaign team. They said that embracing the industry would help Trump win support from swing-state voting blocs the campaign was chasing—Black voters and young men, groups that cared about crypto.

"You had the Trump team, I think, understanding increasingly over time that this could help them in western Pennsylvania, this could help them in southwestern Michigan," said Paul Grewal, chief legal officer to Coinbase. "This could help them knock off key demographic blocks in swing districts."

Executives also began building relationships with Trump's family throughout 2023, including with Donald Trump Jr. Trump's 18-year-old son, Barron, also had a significant role explaining to his father why he should take crypto seriously, people in the industry said.

Former Trump campaign manager Paul Manafort, who had worked with crypto companies, helped usher industry executives into Trump's circle, said Trump advisers. Manafort didn't respond to a request for comment.

The companies also reached out to the Biden campaign, and, later, the presidential campaign of Vice President Kamala Harris, but made little progress.

In June last year, Sacks and Traina co-hosted a fundraiser in Silicon Valley for Trump with a number of top crypto execs. During the dinner, JD Vance and Traina made the case to Trump on loosening regulations, as attendees criticized Gensler's approach to the industry. Trump told them he wanted to be the "crypto president."

The dinner raised $12 million for Trump. In July, he spoke at the Bitcoin 2024 conference where he pledged to fire Gensler on his first day as president and hire crypto-friendly regulators. "The moment I'm sworn in, the persecution stops, and the weaponization ends," he said.

Trump had criticized cryptocurrency for years, calling it a 'scam.'

Trump later directed that pro-cryptocurrency language be added to the GOP platform.

In September, Trump launched the cryptocurrency venture World Liberty Financial, which promised to "make crypto and America great."

His sons, Donald Jr. and Eric Trump, serve as the fund's "Web3 Ambassadors," and Barron is "Chief DeFi Visionary." An entity affiliated with Trump and his family members owns 60% of the equity interests.

"Crypto is one of those things we have to do," Trump said at the time. "Whether we like it or not, we have to do it."

The project swiftly drew criticism, including from crypto venture capitalist Nic Carter, who accused Trump's inner circle of "cashing in" on crypto in a news article. Soon after, top Trump adviser Steve Witkoff, who co-founded the project, invited Carter to a Miami coffee shop and told him the startup would be operated with integrity.

Trump has since appointed Witkoff as his top negotiator in the Middle East and for the war in Ukraine.

Carter supports Trump but remains concerned. "Presidents shouldn't be running businesses, especially not stuff where they can directly influence the outcome, which is clearly the case in crypto," he said. As for Witkoff, Carter said, the role of peace negotiator was likely a better fit than crypto kingpin. Witkoff, Carter noted, had pronounced meme coins as "me-me coins."

World Liberty Financial also drew criticism over its potential for foreign entities and those with business before the U.S. to channel money to Trump and his family without public disclosure.

In November, Chinese-born crypto entrepreneur Justin Sun invested $30 million in World Liberty Financial, which was struggling to meet fundraising targets. Afterward, Sun, who was battling an SEC lawsuit accusing him and several of his companies of fraud, became a World Liberty adviser.

Last month, the SEC asked a court to pause its fraud lawsuit, which Sun has called meritless. A representative for Sun didn't respond to a request for comment. The White House didn't respond to a question about whether Trump had played a role in the SEC decision.

Barron Trump, a freshman at New York University, joined strategy calls and contributed industry connections for the family's crypto project, said people familiar with the matter. The first lady's office declined to comment on Barron's behalf.

"The president should be proud of having a son who is that focused and that thorough in his thinking," said Witkoff, who has stepped away from World Liberty Financial since he started working for the White House.

Bo Loudon, an 18-year-old friend of Barron Trump, has touted his connections in calls with cryptocurrency executives seeking access to the Trump family, said two people who joined the calls.

Loudon in one call said it would cost tens of thousands of dollars to keep him on retainer, serving as a conduit to the Trump family, according to a person on the call. Loudon didn't respond to requests for comment.


KENNY HOLSTON/PRESS POOL

CAMILO FREEDMAN/BLOOMBERG NEWS

You're welcome

Crypto executives celebrated Trump's November victory and soon started lining up for dinners with Trump at Mar-a-Lago.

Brad Garlinghouse, CEO of Ripple, in a post on X congratulated the president-elect and ticked off four points for Trump's "100-day checklist," including firing Gensler from the SEC. Ripple gave $15 million to Trump entities, including the inaugural committee, ahead of a Garlinghouse dinner with Trump in January, said a person familiar with the matter.

Lobbyists told clients a donation of $1 million to a Trump super PAC would afford donors an invitation to a large group dinner at Mar-a-Lago, where the president might make an appearance. Donors who gave $5 million or more were promised a meeting with the president-elect.

In early December, bitcoin's price crossed $100,000. Trump marked the milestone with a post on Truth Social: "YOU'RE WELCOME!!!"

During the transition, a friend pitched the president-elect on a Trump token, said a person familiar with the matter. Trump and first lady Melania Trump launched their meme coins days before the inauguration.

Executives and investors complained the tokens undermined industry credibility and raised ethical questions. But Trump was antsy to make a deal before he became president, a person who discussed the matter with him said.

Trump has since told Mar-a-Lago associates the coin might now be worth more than the club itself.

Two Towns' Bond Faces Big Test

Continued from Page One
tario, just across what a city website calls "the friendliest border in the world."

"They're basically Northern International Falls, and we're Southern Fort Frances," said Harley Droba, 46, a downtown business owner and former mayor of International Falls. "I mean, we are one town of 12,000 people."

Now, that tightknit bond could fray, as the U.S. and Canada plunge headlong into a trade war. Adding to the drama: President Trump's musings about Canada as the 51st state are setting free wild guesses about what could come next.

"So we're both going to have to change our name. They'll be National Falls and we'll be Fort Frances, Minn.," cracked Heather Johnson, executive director of the Fort Frances Chamber of Commerce.

The two cross-border cities are like neighbors who borrow cups of sugar. International Falls residents play golf in Canada because the U.S. side lost its course. Fort Frances denizens go to movies in the U.S. The pair have long held a multiday celebration that covers both Canada Day and the Fourth of July. For years, the two also competed in an annual summertime tug of war across the Rainy River that sent the loser into international waters.

Promotions for Rainy Lake, a fishing and recreational mecca bordering both towns, have touted the idea of a "two-nation vacation."

"We have our rivalries when it comes to sports and stuff especially on the hockey side," said Alex McQuarrie, 37, an owner of The New Home Appliances Store in downtown Fort Frances. Competition between the Fort Frances Muskies and the International Falls Broncos high-school hockey teams is fierce. But, "we're definitely sister communities."

Johnson, of the Fort Frances chamber, crosses the border every Monday night to bowl in a mixed league of men


JOE BARRETT/WSJ

Harley Droba, former mayor of International Falls

and women—Americans and Canadians. While in the U.S., she typically will buy gas and stop at the grocery store for items she can't find back home, such as Bugles to top off her favorite holiday dish.

Her daughter-in-law is American and lives with her son in Canada—one of many ties that make the two cities seem like a big family that is now in an uncomfortable spat.

"We just always assumed we were best friends, and so it's been a little bit of a shock. We're just a little hurt," she said.

President Trump this week imposed 25% tariffs on most goods from Canada and Mexico. Canada responded with its own tariffs. On Thursday, the U.S. paused tariffs on Canadian and Mexican goods covered under a previous trade deal until April 2.

Droba, the former International Falls mayor who owns Flowers on Main Street and The Library Bistro, said he and other business owners are already feeling the effects.

"We've seen a drop in our numbers and you can listen to it in the restaurant. I mean, the Canadians that are coming over, that's their No. 1 conversation," he said.

"There's worry in the air for sure," said Isaac Johnson, 26, owner of Coffee Landing Cafe in downtown International Falls, where he says residents gather "to try to solve the world's problems—and they think they do."

Chief among the quandaries is the question of how long the tariffs will last and what ripple effects might follow.

"It's the uncertainty of the unknown. This has been a bit of a pinball: Where are these tariffs gonna land, what's gonna be included and what's excluded?" said Drake Dill, International Falls' current mayor, who said he has met with his Fort Frances counterpart to discuss potential joint actions.

The town's largest employer, a mammoth paper plant that snakes along the downtown riverfront, relies on Canadian timber for some of its pulp, meaning tariffs could significantly raise costs.

The plant's owner, Packaging Corporation of America, declined to comment. An industry trade group said this week that it "remains concerned that new North American tariffs have potential to seriously disrupt our industry's complex, cross-border supply chains."

Meanwhile, small-business owners like Leanne Guba, owner of Hometown Hobby and Crafts, are facing their own supply-chain issues. She has held off placing orders with some of her Canadian manufacturers.

But Canadians are also fighting back. Some grocery stores are now labeling products by country of origin, so Canadians can boycott American-made goods.

Pam Williams, owner of 4 Your Pets, in Fort Frances, said customers began asking which of her pet-food products were made in Canada about a month ago.

"Mainly, most of my treats and my food were all Canadian. I did have a couple of stuff that was made in the U.S., which now they don't want, and I have, like, one from Italy, which they don't mind. Italy is fine."

P2JW067000-4-A01100-1--------XA

OPINION

Watching Trump From Ukraine

By Bernard-Henri Lévy

Kyiv, Ukraine

President Volodymyr Zelensky receives me in a secure basement. It's Wednesday, Feb. 26, two days before his White House meeting. How does he feel? "Good. But nothing is decided. I still don't know what President Trump wants or if I will really make this trip."

Because he doesn't trust him? Because he doesn't believe in the goodwill of an ally who called him a "dictator"? Mr. Zelensky bursts out laughing. "No. The problem is, above all, that I don't know why he is doing this. Doesn't he understand that Putin is unreliable and that . . ." He hesitates. "At the same time, fortunately, there is the Senate and the House. It's on them. I rely on their bipartisan support, and the overwhelming strong public opinion. Like two years ago, remember? When Congress asked questions, listened to our answers, and ended up unlocking the military aid package we had been waiting on for months."

I raise the worst-case scenario: Could Ukraine continue without America? "It would be difficult," Mr. Zelensky says. "They have the technology. The intelligence. Suppose Germany, for example, agrees to deliver Patriots to us—they would need American authorization." And Europe? Doesn't he believe in a European alternative?

Zelensky on the U.S. president: 'The problem is, above all, that I don't know why he is doing this. Doesn't he understand that Putin is unreliable?'

"Yes, of course. I believe in Immanuel, for example." He means French President Emmanuel Macron, but he pronounces it with an initial "ee" sound, as if it were spelled with an I. In his accent is a tone of true camaraderie. "If this Washington meeting happens, it will be thanks to him, Immanuel. I thank him for that; he is a true friend; and also. . . . Do you know that he is a military expert? He knows, from a distance, the smallest detail regarding our front line."

Speaking of the front line, does Mr. Zelensky know that I am soon leaving for Pokrovsk, in the Donetsk region? If he signs the agreement with Mr. Trump, does it still make sense for me to go? He doesn't hesitate: "Of course. Your presence will please the soldiers. It will warm their hearts. And for that matter . . ." He seems to think aloud. "I think I'm going to do it, this trip. I'm not sure of anything, but that, I'm going to do."

* * *

I feel as if it happened suddenly. I hadn't been back to the front line for eight months. I realize that the drone war has truly replaced trench warfare. We are in a command center on the outskirts of Pokrovsk, an eastern stronghold where the Russians are throwing all their forces to break through. In an underground bunker, a former factory, a dozen Ukrainian soldier-geeks sit in front of a wall of computers. Some are barefaced. Others, in sweat shirts and balaclavas, communicate via microphone with men whose voices alone can be heard as they operate reconnaissance and attack drones.

Suddenly, on one of the screens, three silhouettes appear, walking in a snowy landscape scattered with sparse, aligned trees. Silence falls in the bunker. The man in the balaclava selects one of the silhouettes, at random, with his mouse. Follows it. Loses it. Zooms in on the image. Finds it again. Transmits the coordinates. The silhouette disappears in a cloud of gray, poorly pixelated snow. But the cloud dissipates. And it reappears, getting up, staggering. Is he wounded? Just dazed by the impact? The other two silhouettes join it. They continue, also stumbling, toward a denser cluster of trees.

The man in the balaclava gives a new order into his microphone. The first silhouette collapses for good in a brief convulsion, while the other two huddle between the birch trees. An hour passes. "They will freeze and die there," the man in the balaclava says. When they attempt an escape, he takes his time, follows them, whispers one last order. When the smoke clears, two motionless shapes remain, resembling felled trees.

* * *

When the hunter becomes the hunted, there aren't 36 ways to escape. To escape conventional drones, one must be equipped with conical antennas placed on the roof of the car, jamming communication between the drone and its pilot, as we were. But for drones connected to their pilot by a miles-long fiber-optic cable—which form much of the Russian arsenal—there is no other solution than to drive without stopping, at full speed, on icy tracks made almost invisible by the snow; then, on arrival, to run for cover into a *posadka*, one of these peculiar forests without undergrowth, with just slender, almost bare alders, planted during Soviet times to hold the rich black soils of Donbas against violent winds.

Here there aren't three lost Russian soldiers but 50 miners from the closed Pokrovsk mine who have eight days and eight nights to set up one of these fortifications, made of excavated and raised earth, buried metal nets, craters dug in the snow, or cones. A ballet of miners turned into lumberjacks. A shuttle of felled trees, cut as far away as possible with an electric saw, then carried on men's backs. A cluster of thicker trunks where we take shelter when a drone hums. We sit around a fire fed by chips cut with an ax from the logs. Witnessing the ingenuity of the Ukrainians, I can't help but think of those Russians sent to slaughter like cannon fodder.

* * *

Oleksandr Syrskyi, commander-in-chief of the Ukrainian armed forces, hasn't changed since our last meeting, eight months ago, on the Kharkiv front. He has high, lean cheekbones and slightly slanted, laughing eyes, barely visible as they are sunk into their emaciated sockets, and the bearing of a silent centurion. He avoids interviews and feels comfortable only here, in the improvised and icy command tent near Pokrovsk where he has summoned me.

The victor of the Battle of Kyiv, then liberator of Izyum, in the Kharkiv region, Mr. Syrskyi has a reputation as a tough officer, not sparing of his troops' lives. What always strikes me is his gruff fraternity and camaraderie with his men; his way, when they wait for him, like today, in 15-degree weather, frozen in a statuesque salute, of ordering them to come immediately to take shelter with him; his tendency to move from outpost to outpost, never far from the battlefield. As always, he gives me an update on his needs—today, if the Americans withdraw, Franco-Italian SAMP-T missiles.

Scenes from Pokrovsk: Above, soldiers watch Trump and Zelensky. Below, a reconnaissance unit with four men, a dog and a Renault VAB.

MARC ROUSSEL(2)

Then, as usual, a message to Mr. Macron: "It's good, our pilots are trained, and your Mirage jets are, since this morning, precisely this morning, operational and in the sky." He bursts into a great laugh that narrows his gaze even further—he can't tell me more, but to Western defeatists who believe Ukraine is on its knees, he has a surprise in store. The last time I heard him speak and laugh like this was a few days before his lightning offensive into the Kursk region of Russia.

* * *

Oksana Ribaniak is 21. She is slight, frail. But with her childlike physique and long red hair braided into a ponytail, she is the commander of an otherwise all-male drone unit that is helping the infantry block the Russian offensive on Pokrovsk.

"I have been at war for three years," she says. "I commanded an artillery unit, I was seriously wounded, and I now command this drone unit—but, deep down I am a poet." She has two collections ready to go to print, delayed only by the war. Is there another country besides that of Taras Shevchenko (1814-61) where a war leader would say something like that?

She suddenly lowers her voice, looks away. Her large, implacable green eyes have filled with tears, and her pretty mouth tightens into a half-smile. She had a fiancé, Maksym Emets. He was a poet, too. They met through work. They envisioned a future together. But he died in combat a few weeks ago. And she now has only one purpose, or rather two: the defense of Ukraine and the defense of Maksym's work.

* * *

What is left to say about the Anne of Kyiv Brigade, created in 2024, equipped by France, trained by France, and named by Messrs. Zelensky and Macron during the 80th anniversary of the Normandy landings after a Ukrainian princess who married King Henri I to become the queen of France from 1051 to 1060?

Desertions, corruption, disorganization—it's all been said. And that's why I decided to see for myself. First, I headed to the north of Pokrovsk, in the abandoned mine that serves as its headquarters. Since the beginning of 2025, a solid officer with 27 years of experience, a veteran of the terrible battles of Sumy, has reigned. He says simply, "The brigade wasn't missing much—maybe a conductor. Let's say I was that. It wasn't rocket science."

Then, farther south and closer to the front, among the ranks of a reconnaissance unit consisting of four men, a dog and a brand-new Renault VAB, tasked with identifying, in the vast white expanse of this desperately flat terrain, a posadka where night and next-day drone operators can ambush.

"All this controversy was very unfair," says the unit leader, whom I know only by his first name, Dmytro. "You are in the hottest zone of the front. How could anyone expect us to adapt instantly? We are men, not North Koreans." In the meantime, he has found the perfect posadka. He parks the vehicle and shows me how, when drones fly in formation under a bright blue sky, they can be shot down with a machine gun.

The great pride of the Anne of Kyiv Brigade is its Caesar self-propelled guns, which are ultramobile, mounted on wheels, precise and effective. We are on an inspection mission with the brigade's commander, Taras Maksymov. We drive for about an hour on icy dirt roads in an ordinary car, without armor or jamming systems, because the Russians are so close. We arrive not in a posadka, but in a crater dug deep enough that only the cannon's muzzle appears—and barely—under camouflage nets as white as the snow.

The men are waiting for us. There are six of them. They pass time by smoking cigarettes and reciting poems to each other.

Attention. Shell in the breech. Loading the white powder bag. Calculating air pressure and wind speed. Everything is ready? Is the reconnaissance drone in place? Fire! We wait a minute or two to debrief the drone and ensure the Russian position on the other side has been destroyed.

As the cannon, now identified by the enemy, moves out to a new position a few kilometers away, we leave as well, hurrying off among the dry, bare branches that catch on our clothes and scratch our faces. The Anne of Kyiv Brigade hasn't always lived up to the legend that preceded it. But it hasn't lost a single one of the 18 Caesar guns France delivered to it.

* * *

This scene should have gone earlier in the story, but I recount things as they come to me. We are near Pokrovsk, in a gigantic hangar transformed into a repair workshop for tanks and other vehicles. Pale light. Carcasses of rusted scrap metal. Half-destroyed or simply dismantled machines. Mechanics with grease-covered gloves work, experts in examining a remnant of an engine, an intact armor plate or a still usable steel rivet. Then, everything stops.

At both ends of the hangar, computers have been set up so the men can watch, live, the globally broadcast conversation between Mr. Trump and their president. At first when Mr. Zelensky speaks, the tank surgeons are pleased because they feel he is in control, a good messenger of their suffering and heroism.

Then, JD Vance and Mr. Trump drown out Mr. Zelensky's voice and insult him. The men in Pokrovsk say nothing. A mixture of stupefaction (such vulgarity) and dread (they, in the grease and blood, understand how indispensable foreign aid is) but also pride. This young president's standing up to the most powerful men in the world is the image of that calm and mocking boldness, which in Ukrainian is called *nakhabstvo* and in Yiddish *chutzpah.* That pride is evident on their faces.

I don't know if Mr. Zelensky's allies will be able to rise to his level. I don't know if the Americans will grasp that in Mr. Zelensky's dignity lies their "city upon a hill" creed and that American leaders, from the Founding Fathers all the way to Kennedy and Reagan, would have been proud of a deep bond with this leader.

I don't know, really, if any of this will be properly understood after that incident, display, fiasco, debacle, monstrosity—call it what you will—in the Oval Office. But I do know that with this blend of irony, morality, composure and disdain for human baseness, which Mr. Zelensky never abandoned for a single moment, he has again entered the legend of this century.

Mr. Lévy is author of "Israel Alone" and author and director of the documentary "Glory to the Heroes." This article was translated from French by Emily Hamilton.

Pennsylvania Did DOGE Before Elon Musk Made It Cool

CROSS COUNTRY
By David Yarkin

The Trump administration will soon announce a cost-saving measure to centralize purchasing in the General Services Administration. Like other changes from Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency, this initiative will face fierce opposition from government employees who benefit from the status quo. But unlike mass layoffs and the takeover of federal IT systems, this is a change that fans of good government—even dyed-in-the-wool Democrats—ought to embrace. It has roots in both Republican and Democratic administrations. I know because I led such an initiative 20 years ago.

In 2003, Pennsylvania's new governor inherited a $2 billion deficit. A centrist Democrat, Ed Rendell was determined to erase the deficit, which impaired his ability to enact campaign promises. He created the Office of Management and Productivity—the DOGE of its era—and hired a team of bright young consultants to pore over budget documents and organization charts to find ways to save. One recommendation was "strategic sourcing," a procurement strategy that had swept through the private sector, in which purchasing decisions moved from many departments to a central authority. The idea was to reduce costs by maximizing buying power. As the state's new chief procurement officer, my job was to implement the plan as fast as possible.

My team analyzed contracts, scrutinized orders, terminated existing agreements and created new ones, saving millions for taxpayers: $2 million on asphalt, $14 million on office supplies, $7 million on furniture. To publicize our initiative, we used the state's loudest megaphone—Mr. Rendell himself—to announce new cost-saving contracts. Michael Dell joined the governor to announce Pennsylvania's new personal-computer contract, which saved state taxpayers $19 million annually. Government procurement, once the boring beat for the press corps, became sexy.

In most cases, these contracts worked as planned. Goods and services were delivered on time. Pennsylvania taxpayers saved nearly $140 million a year. Funds otherwise wasted on overhead were redeployed where they mattered—a government fairy tale if ever there was one.

A warning for DOGE: Foundational changes in government come with failures alongside successes. The mistake we made was putting all our eggs in one supplier's basket without sufficient safeguards. By awarding all business to one supplier, we took on massive operational risk, trusting that the supplier would deliver. While most did, in one of our most important contracts—food delivery—the supplier failed. Miserably.

We learned the hard way that a little redundancy in procurement isn't necessarily a bad thing.

Before strategic sourcing, facilities serving food to residents in state veterans homes, prisons and mental hospitals were free to buy their food from dozens of distributors. We consolidated vendors, awarding the contract to one supplier, saving $14 million annually. If ignorance was bliss, we were mighty happy. Weeks passed with no complaints. We assumed no news was good news. It wasn't.

Our food vendor announced it could no longer deliver to dozens of state prisons and hospitals because it didn't have sufficiently broad inventory to support the state's changing food orders. Food is the lifeblood of these institutions. And with little notice, they'd have none within the week.

The state hurtled into panic mode. We found food, but we paid through the nose for it. Our reputation with the agencies was in tatters. And we had to fend off pushback from the original food provider, which claimed that the agencies' variable purchasing behaviors were the cause of their challenges.

When the dust settled, we asked the people closest to the contract if they had noticed warning signs. There were early indicators. One prison received only half the products it ordered. Soon thereafter, a second prison received dozens of boxes of products it never ordered, instead of the items it did. Days later, a state hospital experienced similar discrepancies. These issues were too isolated to get the attention of those who could solve the problem. Leadership didn't hear about them until it was too late.

Mr. Musk shouldn't take from our experience that strategic sourcing doesn't work. On the contrary. It's a potent tool that delivers massive taxpayer savings. But as DOGE consolidates the federal government's supply base, it must mitigate risk by regularly monitoring performance. If one supplier falters, DOGE must intervene before issues become untenable.

There is cause for optimism. This week, members of the National Association of State Procurement Officials gathered to share best practices at their semiannual conference. Leaders from Florida to Massachusetts exchanged notes on tracking vendor performance. The federal government can follow their lead and ensure that American taxpayers are getting their money's worth.

Mr. Yarkin is the founder and CEO of Procurated.

OPINION

REVIEW & OUTLOOK

The Two Trumps on Taxes

Bonus depreciation is a good idea, an auto interest deduction isn't.

The story of Republican tax policy in the Trump era is the contest between pro-growth ideas and anti-growth income redistribution. An example of both was on display in President Trump's speech to Congress on Tuesday.

The good idea was Mr. Trump's proposal to let companies deduct the full cost of capital expenditures in the year they are made. This spurs investment and the economy's supply-side. Mr. Trump's 2017 tax reform provided such "bonus depreciation," which began to phase out in 2023 and is set to expire at the end of next year.

Mr. Trump on Tuesday pitched extending full expensing retroactively to this January. "It was one of the main reasons why our tax cuts were so successful in our first term," he said. He's right. Bonus depreciation complemented his tax reform's cut in the corporate rate to 21% from 35% and the elimination of U.S. tax on repatriated foreign income.

All of this encouraged companies to repatriate foreign earnings and invest in new plants and productivity-enhancing equipment in the U.S., which lifted real wages. Business investment rose 5.6% in 2018, versus 3.3% in 2016, and it remained strong until late 2019 when the costs and uncertainty of Mr. Trump's tariffs started to bite.

Business investment has remained sluggish since the post-pandemic rebound amid the Biden regulatory blitz, which suppressed animal spirits. Fixed investment growth averaged 3.7% in 2023 and 2024 and fell 3.2% in the fourth quarter. One risk now is that uncertainty from the Trump tariff whiplash will further slow investment.

As Eli Lilly CEO David Ricks said last week when announcing a $27 billion investment in four new U.S. pharmaceutical plants, "tax reform is the carrot. When that's not in balance, I don't think they're going to get the outcome they want" with tariffs. It's "essential" that the tax reforms "are extended permanently this year."

Unlike the Biden green-energy and chip tax credits, full expensing is available to all businesses and doesn't distort investment. Companies don't get a bigger tax break for investing in, say, hydrogen than natural gas production—or factories for manufacturing electric-vehicle batteries than for gas guzzlers. Businesses, not government, decide where to make investments.

As for the anti-growth idea, Mr. Trump also highlighted a tax deduction for loan interest payments on U.S.-made cars. This is subsidy for consumption of a subset of a single product, akin to Mr. Biden's elective-vehicle favoritism. The interest deduction could help offset higher prices from his tariffs and boost demand in the short term.

But the subsidy would also fuel higher prices and make cars less affordable over time, which is what has happened with homes from the mortgage interest deduction. The carve-out would further complicate the tax code while subsidizing debt over investment. The Tax Foundation estimates a deduction for all auto loans would cost the Treasury some $60 billion over 10 years.

Bureaucrats will decide whether a car counts as "made in America" amid a corporate lobbying blitz. This is what has happened with the Inflation Reduction Act's rules for EV credits, which are conditioned on a certain share of their battery components and minerals being made in North America and countries with which the U.S. has free-trade agreements.

Mr. Trump was right Tuesday when he said the 2017 tax reforms were crucial to his first-term economic success. Extend them, Mr. President, don't undermine them with bad ideas to please narrow political interests.

Impeach Judges, Say the Right's AOCs

Articles against judges who rule against Trump are a corrosive stunt.

President Trump's flurry of executive actions has prompted inevitable lawsuits and court rulings. Some of those judges have ruled his way, and some haven't. What matters is getting the law correct, with appeal to the Supreme Court if necessary. Yet the right's latest brain burp is that judges who ruled against Mr. Trump should be impeached.

This is an Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez-style stunt: Removing an impeached judge takes two-thirds of the Senate, which is possible for severe misconduct but not on partisan lines over appealable disputes. Republicans in the House, though, have introduced resolutions to impeach three federal judges for "high crimes and misdemeanors." They're being urged on by Elon Musk, who wrote on X: "The only way to restore rule of the people in America is to impeach judges."

Arizona Rep. Eli Crane and seven others filed impeachment articles against Judge Paul Engelmayer, who temporarily blocked Mr. Musk's government-efficiency crew from Treasury payment systems. That view of the law might be wrong, and his order was overbroad, or at least confusing, since another judge later clarified that it didn't restrict access by Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent. But impeachable?

"Judge Paul Engelmayer, in violation of his oath of office, did knowingly and willfully use his judicial position to advance personal interests and political gain," Mr. Crane's resolution claims. It also says the judge "interfered with the will of the people."

Tennessee Rep. Andy Ogles has filed two sets of impeachment articles. One is against Judge John Bates (a George W. Bush appointee, as it happens), who temporarily ordered the government to restore some health webpages, including one on HIV monitoring, that were pulled down after Mr. Trump told the executive branch to recognize only two genders.

Mr. Ogles's other resolution is against Judge Amir Ali, who ordered a temporary halt on what he has called Mr. Trump's "blanket suspension of congressionally appropriated foreign aid." That dispute has already once reached the Supreme Court, which in a 5-4 vote this week declined to intervene for now, though one way to read that outcome is as not-so-subtle hint to Judge Ali about staying in his lane.

This is how the judiciary works, and the GOP ought to have the patience to let it, especially given that two-thirds of the Justices with the final say are conservatives. Republicans yelling for impeachments are joining the left in undermining the judiciary as an institution. Ms. Ocasio-Cortez filed articles last year to remove Justices Clarence Thomas and Samuel Alito. The latter resolution cited the psuedo-controversy about flags flown by Justice Alito's wife.

This stuff might be good for AOC's fundraising, but it's corrosive to the republic, and the same goes for Mr. Crane and Mr. Ogles.

Virginia Isn't for DEI Lovers Anymore

Universities are no longer a safe space for violating civil-rights laws, and Friday was a banner day on that score. The University of Virginia banned DEI in colleges state-wide, and the Trump Administration pulled some $400 million in funding from Columbia University.

The UVA board of visitors adopted a plan to dissolve all DEI programs on campus as well as all DEI offices and positions across the UVA system. The plan covers "admissions, hiring, promotion, compensation, financial aid, scholarships, prizes . . . discipline, housing, graduation ceremonies and all other aspects of student, academic and campus life." The goal is to make sure UVA complies with the Constitution and the 1964 Civil Rights Act.

This is a major departure for UVA, which has been all-in for DEI. In 2020 the school's Racial Equity Task Force called for $950 million for racial equity initiatives. By 2021 the school tied for the second largest number of DEI personnel among major universities with 94 and had 6.5 DEI staff for every 100 professors, according to a report by Jay Greene and James Paul of the Heritage Foundation. In March 2024, Open the Books reported UVA was spending $20 million a year for 235 DEI employees.

The UVA faculty won't be pleased by the board's decision. In a meeting of the Faculty Senate Executive Council in February, DEI committee chair Eric Ramirez-Weaver said the committee was looking for "workarounds" to preserve race preferences and DEI on campus. The goal was to find "how new recruiting techniques can be done post the Harvard decision," he said, referring to the Supreme Court's 2023 ruling that found preferences in admissions violated the Constitution.

The UVA board resolution says it will make sure there are no such efforts to "circumvent prohibitions on the use of race," and it will have to be vigilant. Texas passed a DEI ban in 2023, but schools reshuffled staff into positions that pursue the same goals.

The University of Texas at Austin Dell Medical School kept its dean for health equity, according to Do No Harm, a group that tracks DEI in medicine. The school's website still says students should "demonstrate an understanding of the root causes of health inequities," including "socialization of dominant cultural norms, beliefs and values."

On Feb. 26, Texas state Sens. Brandon Creighton and Paul Bettencourt said they will block funding increases until schools demonstrate compliance. Public universities typically get 30% to 40% of their funding from state and federal sources.

At least 11 states including Florida, Tennessee, Iowa and Idaho have passed laws restricting DEI. The UVA ban is notable given that Democrats control both houses of the state Legislature. The board's unanimous decision included the votes of four board members appointed by former Democratic Gov. Ralph Northam as well as those appointed by Gov. Glenn Youngkin.

Also on Friday, the Trump Administration canceled $400 million or so in federal grants and contracts to Columbia for failing to protect Jewish students from discrimination. Columbia was ground zero for last spring's antisemitic campus protests, and this week protests broke out again at the school and nearby Barnard College. Police made multiple arrests.

The sanction against Columbia is a warning to all schools that they risk losing funds if they practice or tolerate discrimination. Virginia is wise to act first.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Has Vance Said Thank You to Ukraine Once?

JD Vance last week intimated that Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky hadn't been grateful enough for U.S. aid ("Putin Wins an Oval Office Spectacle," Review & Outlook, March 1). "Have you said thank you once?" he asked. Respectfully, the vice president has it backward: We should be thanking the Ukrainians for repelling Russia's invasion, sustaining the war effort and materially diminishing Vladimir Putin's military capabilities.

With zero American lives lost in battle and less than $375 spent per American (based on a total of $120 billion in aid), Mr. Zelensky's military and civilian population have helped America and its allies by destroying or disabling thousands of Russian aircraft and land-based vehicles, communication systems and other equipment. Russia's military command structure, morale and recruiting have been degraded. American defense contractors have tested new weapons systems in wartime conditions and Ukrainian fighters have innovated in unforeseen ways. Our economy has benefitted from Americans building war material in American plants and sending them to Ukraine. Mr. Zelensky has thanked America many times for our support. It is now time for America to thank him.

Fred Walker
Wyndmoor, Pa.

Mr. Zelensky should be grateful for American aid, but we should be grateful for how well Ukrainians have used it. If they had folded, we would have Russia on the doorstep of a North Atlantic Treaty Organization ally. Incidentally, if we value the country's minerals so much, why risk letting Mr. Putin gobble them up?

Mitchell Keiter
Beverly Hills, Calif.

My parents reminded me more than once as I grew up that "children should be seen and not heard." Might this also apply to vice presidents?

Chris C. Caudill
Lincoln, Neb.

In "JD Vance's Forgotten Wars" (Review & Outlook, March 5), you take Mr. Vance to task for insulting our British and French allies. You add that "London and Paris need to bulk up their militaries after years of underinvestment in defense" and that no one needs to be shy in telling them. The caveat: "Every other recent U.S. Vice President has managed to do this without insulting them, which isn't too much to ask."

Maybe so. But being polite hasn't seemed to work thus far. Perhaps a little embarrassment will do the trick.

Michael Spivack
Miami

Sports Should Embrace Tradition Over Trends

The U.S. military and Catholic schools have long recognized the connection between pride in one's appearance and performance. May I suggest that the recent decline in popularity of some professional sports is partially due to leagues permitting "anything goes" dress codes ("It's Good to Be a Clean-Shaven Yankee" by Matthew Hennessey, op-ed, Feb. 27)?

At my Christian school in Philadelphia in the 1980s, it wasn't uncommon to see students threatened with detention for rebelling against the sartorial policy. We were reminded that we represented a respected institution, and, should we choose to defy the standards, a hundred boys stood ready to take our places.

Similarly, as a U.S. Army recruit in the late 1990s, I spent hours in basic training "spit-shining" my leather boots, starching my uniforms and shaping my patrol cap. Neat, sharp appearances inspired soldiers to act in a professional manner.

As Mr. Hennessey notes, the Yankees "weren't chasing fashions and fads" by banning beards; they were gunning for championships. It worked. As quaint as it may sound today, the popularity of players such as Joe DiMaggio, Jackie Robinson and Ted Williams was enhanced by their professional appearance and demeanor. I think it's significant that these players were also veterans.

Teams worried about declining interest or attracting talent shouldn't drop their standards. They should, as Mr. Hennessey notes, turn to tradition: the policies that have formed thousands of academic, military and athletic greats throughout the years.

Christian M. DeJohn
Newtown Square, Pa.

An Inefficient Federal Employee Speaks Out

I am an inefficient federal employee who received a deferred-resignation offer in January ("Inside DOGE's Federal Takeover," Page One, March 1). In my 10 years of federal service as a chaplain in the Department of Veterans Affairs, I have developed and provided 16 cohorts of an inefficient group for veterans suffering moral injury. Each group meets weekly for 90 minutes over three months and requires two clinicians to facilitate. On average only five veterans complete each cohort. I can say with only some degree of certainty that the program has prevented two veterans from dying by suicide.

My individual encounters are as inefficient as my group work. Recently I sat with a veteran for more than two hours, listening to his experience of killing someone 40 years ago, which has troubled him since. Those two hours didn't fix the problem, and so the veteran plans to join the next 12-week moral-injury group. In another encounter, I visited a woman at the bedside of her veteran spouse, who was on life support after he hanged himself the day after Christmas. That meeting took three hours.

Elon Musk wants to make the federal workforce more efficient. Yet efficiency alone isn't the highest good, and inefficient work isn't necessarily wasteful. I still have my job. If I am fired for my inefficiency, I hope that the more productive private sector develops a quick fix for moral injury and a more efficient way to prevent veteran suicide.

Rev. Chris J. Antal
Philadelphia

In Defense of Elbridge Colby

Your March 4 editorial "The Debate Over Elbridge Colby" suggests Mr. Colby, the nominee for undersecretary of defense for policy, embraces American isolation and decline. On the contrary, I believe he represents an essential recalibration of American hard power to address the contemporary security environment.

Mr. Colby's thinking acknowledges resource scarcity, shifting global dynamics and the consequences of past policy blunders. These pages have long published articles on our declining shipbuilding and defense-industrial capabilities, as well as our dismal military recruitment numbers and the fiscal dilemma of a growing national debt. Given each of these, it is only logical for America to make a priority of regions according to strategic importance, lest we continue to overstretch our capabilities.

For America's allies, Mr. Colby's outlook provides sincere clarity, something desperately needed to salvage any hope of preserving the postwar alliance system. Such a wake-up call to free-riding European allies is overdue. Pressuring them to look out for themselves strengthens America and the West.

David Solomon
Vienna

Evaluating the Tariff Threat

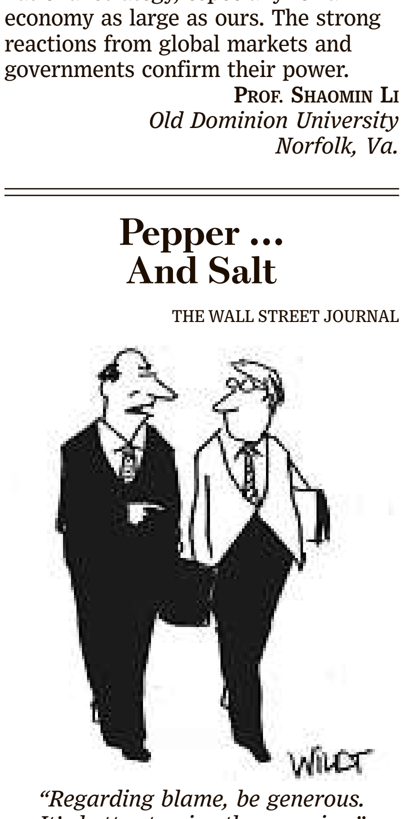
Regarding "Tariffs Go Into Effect on Canada, Mexico" (Page One, March 4), history and analyses suggest the effect will be minimal. Since 2018, U.S. tariff revenues annually have averaged 0.3% of gross domestic product. With President Trump's new tariffs, that figure may rise to 1.3%, based on my calculations. Meanwhile, the Tax Policy Center projects that by 2026 the average U.S. household's after-tax income will decline by shy of 1%. Tax cuts, supply-chain shifts and domestic manufacturing growth help offset costs. Tariffs can, however, be an effective tool of national strategy, especially for an economy as large as ours. The strong reactions from global markets and governments confirm their power.

Prof. Shaomin Li
Old Dominion University
Norfolk, Va.

Letters intended for publication should be emailed to wsj.ltrs@wsj.com. Please include your city, state and telephone number. All letters are subject to editing, and unpublished letters cannot be acknowledged.

Pepper ... And Salt

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL



"Regarding blame, be generous. It's better to give than receive."

OPINION

Snap Out of It, Democrats

DECLARATIONS
By Peggy Noonan

Democrats looked like fools Tuesday night. We don't need to dwell on how they sat grim-faced, seething, or walked out while the president spoke. One stood, yelled, brandished his cane and was removed by the sergeant at arms. Others held up little paddles bearing little insults. Some wore special color-coded outfits. Almost all refused to show normal warmth or engagement. From my notes, as the camera turned and dwelled on the furious faces: "They look like the green room in hell."

On Tuesday they looked as if they aren't going to win for a long time. That's dangerous for America.

All while Donald Trump romped.

Three thoughts. One, these aren't serious people. Two, their job was to show they are an alternative to Mr. Trump, and instead they showed why he won. Third and most important, they will continue to lose for a long time. I hadn't known that until Tuesday.

Sometimes a party takes a concussive blow, such as the 2024 presidential loss, and you can see: They'll shape up and come back, they're pros, they lost an election but not their dignity. But now and then you see: No, these guys don't know what happened, they are going to lose over and over before they get the message.

What I saw Tuesday night is that the Democratic Party in 2025, as evinced by its leaders on Capitol Hill, is too proud and stupid to change. I saw 1981. The Reagan era had begun, the Democrats had taken quite a drubbing—a landslide loss by a sitting Democratic president, and the loss of the Senate majority they had held since 1955. It was the kind of blow that reorders the mind: Democratic policies weren't popular! They had just been massively repudiated! But the blow didn't reorder their minds. They kept doing the same thing, as if they had a secret death wish. They lost in another landslide in 1984, and again in '88. Finally, as 1992 approached, they realized: We need to readjust our policy stands to be more in line with those of the American people. They did, and Bill Clinton squeaked in.

We are in "Death Wish II."

In this space we believe two strong and healthy parties vying for popular support is good for the country, and we offer advice for the Democrats.

I will start with something they won't believe. In politics, there is bringing the love and bringing the hate. When the 13-year-old boy who had brain cancer and has always wanted to be a cop is appointed as an honorary Secret Service agent, laminated ID and all, and the child, surprised by the gesture, hugs the normally taciturn head of the Secret Service, the only thing to do, because you are human, is cheer that child. And when the president honors a young man whose late father, a veteran and policeman, had inspired his wish to serve, and dreams of attending West Point, and the president says that he has some sway in the admissions office and young man you are going to West Point—I not only got choked up when it happened I'm choked up as I write. The boy with cancer high-fives the young man, and the only response to such sweetness is tears in your eyes.

JIM LO SCALZO/SHUTTERSTOCK

Democratic lawmakers at President Trump's speech Tuesday night.

That moment is "the love." *It was showing love for regular Americans.* To cheer them is to cheer us. It shows admiration for and affiliation with normal people who try, get through, endure and hold on to good hopes.

The Democrats brought the hate. They sat stone-faced, joyless and loveless. They don't show love for Americans anymore. They look down on them, feel distance from them, instruct them, remind them to feel bad that they're surrounded by injustice because, well, they're unjust.

Mr. Trump says: No, man, I love you.

Which is better? Which is kinder, more generous? Which inspires? Which *wins?*

Democrats have to understand where they are. They have completely lost their reputation as the party of the workingman. With their bad governance of the major cities and their airy, abstract obsessions with identity politics and gender ideology, they have driven away the working class, for whom life isn't airy or abstract. Democrats must stop listening to the left of the left of their party. It tugs them too far away from the vast majority of Americans. They have been radical on the border, on crime, on boys in the girls' locker room. They should take those issues off the table by admitting they got them wrong.

Why do they allow the far left to punch so far above its weight? It's not only money. "They play dirty, make threats, make people uncomfortable," a Democratic elected official said. Normal Democrats want to dodge a fight with them. But the fight has to be had. The sooner you have it, the sooner it's over and the party makes itself into a fighting force again.

In the near term, James Carville says the party should play possum—"roll over" and make believe they're dead when the predator approaches. (It almost worked for Joe Biden.) I'd add play shrewd possum—align with what the Trump administration is doing that might be productive, but with a variation that shows you have a heart, you are protective of the excellent and the diligent and deserving of protection. Help Elon Musk fight waste, fraud and abuse, but make clear you are protecting essential programs and peerless professionals. Mr. Musk is going to make bad mistakes; he's new to government and doing everything everywhere all at once. When he does, the possum should become a lion.

Know your stuff, have the data. "Trump bad" isn't enough to win. You have to start realizing how popular he is with your own voters. He's a masculine presence, he's funny, and he likes Americans. Those are three powerful qualities in America right now.

Democrats on Capitol Hill are pushed to act like jerky drama queens by activists in their base. Leave that to Nancy Mace. If they need behavioral role models: Take the seriousness of John Roberts and Amy Coney Barrett, who present themselves as even-keeled adults and speak thoughtfully, and add in the public good cheer and capability of Elena Kagan. Sen. Elissa Slotkin was calm and plain-spoken in her response. Emulate her. It will help retrieve and rebuild your party's reputation.

Taking all bait won't work. The administration is throwing new chum in the water every day, you'll look disorganized, insatiable and desperate if you endlessly swim to it.

Be strategic. Mr. Trump is a man who goes too far. He confuses boldness with wildness, can't see the line. He'll give you opportunities. Take the big ones.

Stop listening to your consultants. They know the Democratic Party but not America. They've always had the media in their pocket and it's made them lazy and lacking in insight. Keep going to town halls in small and medium-size towns and listen, listen, listen.

If Democrats don't wise up and sober up, Mr. Trump and the Republicans will know there is no major party to slow them, temper them, stop them. This wouldn't be good. They need an opponent. The Democratic Party's not reporting for duty is a dangerous thing.

Trump's Tariffs Stir a New Patriotism—in Canada

By Elliot Kaufman

Prime Minister Justin Trudeau once called Canada the world's first "postnational state." This was in 2015, his rookie year on the job. A decade on, somehow still prime minister (though on his way out), Mr. Trudeau finds himself standing at the front of what can only be called a nationalist movement.

The Maple Leaf, which Mr. Trudeau lowered to half-staff for nearly six months in 2021 in a fit of historical self-flagellation, is colonizing new territory. Next to a made-in-Canada product, accompanied by a "Buy Canadian" or "Shop Canadian" sign, the flag has become the best possible endorsement.

His trade war sets off a burst of nationalism in the country Justin Trudeau once called 'postnational.'

This is a trade war, started by the behemoth to Canada's south, and rallying around the flag has helped Mr. Trudeau's down-and-out Liberals recover 10 or 15 points in the polls. The prime minister's replacement as party leader, expected to be the environmentalist central banker Mark Carney, suddenly has a chance to win the next federal election.

Conservative leader Pierre Poilievre is the more pro-American candidate, and the only one capable of speaking about President Trump without compulsive denunciations. Presumably, he would stand a better chance of working with Mr. Trump to resolve the dispute amicably. But if that sounds to you like a political strength rather than a liability, you are misreading the moment. Canadian nationalism is real—and aggrieved.

Doug Ford, the premier of my native province of Ontario, may be Canada's most successful Conservative politician. He won his third straight majority last week. On the eve of Mr. Trump's 25% tariffs, he threatened to cut off electricity exports to the U.S. "with a smile on my face." Of border states such as New York, Michigan and Minnesota, he said, "They rely on our energy, they need to feel the pain."

That's the spirit. "Canadians are angry," Mr. Trudeau said Tuesday. "We're going to choose to not go on vacation to Florida or Old Orchard Beach" in Maine. "We're probably going to continue booing the American national anthem." Mr. Ford pulled U.S. booze from the shelves of Ontario's government liquor-store monopoly. Airlines report that demand for U.S. travel has taken a hit. Surveys say most Canadians have begun spontaneous boycotts in their own small ways.

Do Americans even think of Canada? America's best ally, trading partner and friend, Canada feels jilted, betrayed out of the blue. It doesn't help that during Mr. Trudeau's decade in power, productivity has been stagnant and growth weak. Investment fell, while government spending soared. Canada's economy has rarely been less globally competitive and more vulnerable to tariffs than it is now.

Canadians think of America—especially while they think of themselves. When the U.S. was seen as a radical and rebellious experiment in liberty, English Canada defined itself in contrast as loyal to tradition, crown and altar. When the U.S. later came to be seen as right-wing—heartless capitalists, incorrigible racists, violent, rude and fat—Canadians swung the other way. Nationalism in Canada became a left-wing movement, whose principal points are the social safety net, multiculturalism, peacekeeping, politeness and, lest we forget, single-payer healthcare.

"I am Canadian," Molson's beer commercials announced. But with lines like "I have a prime minister, not a president," "I can proudly sew my country's flag on my backpack," and "I believe in peacekeeping, not policing, diversity, not assimilation," the message I hear is "We are not American." Which is what makes Mr. Trump's "51st state" and "Gov. Trudeau" gibes funny, and what leaves Canadians unable to laugh.

Nor should they. Insulted and demeaned, Canadians have been offered one bogus reason after another for the tariffs. Fentanyl? Illegal immigration? The trade deficit? It may not be more complicated than beggar-thy-neighbor; Mr. Trump would like to reach into Canadian industry and grab a handful.

An Israeli once told me a definition of American exceptionalism: "Ocean, Ocean, Canada, Mexico." Countries with bad neighbors don't take good ones for granted. Canada rallied to America's side after 9/11, not only welcoming stranded passengers to Gander, Newfoundland, but sending thousands of troops to Afghanistan, holding down bloody Kandahar in the longest combat deployment in Canadian history.

As President John F. Kennedy told Ottawa in 1961, "Geography has made us neighbors. History has made us friends. Economics has made us partners. And necessity has made us allies. Those whom nature hath so joined together, let no man put asunder."

Former Prime Minister Stephen Harper, as sober and pro-U.S. as they come, said in February that he would accept "any level of damage" to preserve Canada's independence. "I would be prepared to impoverish the country and not be annexed, if that was the option we're facing," he added. That isn't the choice, but why does Mr. Trump give Canadian allies reason to think it could be?

If Canada were an ocean away like Britain and had the self-assurance granted by British history, perhaps its leaders could supplicate Mr. Trump more fully, like Prime Minister Keir Starmer has done, and emerge unscathed. Mr. Trudeau, who has often disparaged Mr. Trump, can't even get a meeting.

Outlining Canada's retaliation to the tariffs on Tuesday, Mr. Trudeau cited the morning's Journal editorial. "It's not in my habit to agree with The Wall Street Journal," he said, "but Donald, they point out that even though you're a very smart guy, this is a very dumb thing to do." On Thursday U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent called Mr. Trudeau a "numskull" for retaliating.

Mr. Poilievre, the Conservative leader, pledges to "put Canada first." Campaigning against national decline, he is still likely to win the next election. But right now Canadians want to show that they can also put America last.

In recent days, Mr. Trump granted a one-month reprieve from the tariffs for automakers and some others, scheduling another heart attack for next month. New U.S. reciprocal tariffs could come any day. Can simmering Canada keep its balance, or will the trade war spiral? Nobody said nationalism was a smooth ride.

Mr. Kaufman is a member of the Journal's editorial board.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.
PUBLISHED SINCE 1889 BY DOW JONES & COMPANY

Lachlan Murdoch
Executive Chairman, News Corp

Rupert Murdoch
Chairman Emeritus, News Corp

Robert Thomson
Chief Executive Officer, News Corp

Emma Tucker
Editor in Chief

Almar Latour
Chief Executive Officer and Publisher

Liz Harris, *Managing Editor*
Charles Forelle, *Deputy Editor in Chief*

Elena Cherney, *Senior Editor;* David Crow, *Executive Editor;* Chip Cummins, *Newswires;* Taneth Evans, *Digital;* Alex Martin, *Print & Writing;* Michael W. Miller, *Features & Weekend;* Bruce Orwall, *Enterprise;* Philana Patterson, *Audio;* Amanda Wills, *Video*

Paul A. Gigot
Editor of the Editorial Page
Gerard Baker, *Editor at Large*

DOW JONES MANAGEMENT:
Mae M. Cheng, *EVP, General Manager, Leadership;* David Cho, *Barron's Editor in Chief;* Jason P. Conti, *General Counsel, Chief Compliance Officer;* Dianne DeSevo, *Chief People Officer;* Jared DiPalma, *Chief Financial Officer;* Artem Fishman, *Chief Technology Officer;* David Martin, *Chief Revenue Officer, Business Intelligence;* Dan Shar, *EVP, General Manager, Wealth & Investing;* Ashok Sinha, *Chief Communications Officer;* Josh Stinchcomb, *EVP & Chief Revenue Officer, WSJ | Barron's Group;* Sherry Weiss, *Chief Marketing Officer*

EDITORIAL AND CORPORATE HEADQUARTERS:
1211 Avenue of the Americas, New York, N.Y., 10036
Telephone 1-800-DOWJONES

DOW JONES | News Corp

How to Read Trump's Ukraine 'Hardball'

BUSINESS WORLD
By Holman W. Jenkins, Jr.

Donald Trump isn't going about it the way I would. But if it turns out that when a U.S. president says he wants the Ukraine war to end, that war then ends, it would be extremely useful information for global players to have.

This actually would make the world a safer place and strengthen deterrence.

I'm not ready to retreat from my prediction of a year ago. Though an out-of-left-field deal from Mr. Trump seemed possible, your main expectation, under either party's then-presidential candidate, was half-baked drift unless or until Russia mounted a competent threat to capture Kyiv, and then a panicked, unpredictable response. And Mr. Trump himself miscalculates now if he thinks the U.S. could wash its hands in such a case.

Still, a decent chance exists that Mr. Trump will succeed in imposing a cease-fire.

On the weekend, Lord Peter Mandelson, the British ambassador to the U.S., publicly advised Volodymyr Zelensky to accept U.S. mediation as the "only show in town."

He might have added: Mr. Trump is a freak of democracy, having concretely promised voters he would end the war. Any traditional politician (say Joe Biden) would have mumbled, kicked the can down the road—anything but lay out an intelligible endgame that voters could judge him by.

Many politicians may suspect Mr. Trump grasped these red-hot tongs out of ignorance and childishness. Maybe so. But his political capital and that of the U.S. is now engaged. Mr. Zelensky and the Europeans would be dolts not to jump in with their own oars and start paddling toward the opportunity that has been created. One outcome isn't in the cards: Even Mr. Trump can't redeem a misbegotten and costly error for Mr. Putin in starting the war.

So readers aren't weighed down by misapplied analogies, Mr. Trump echoes Eisenhower, who told South Korea's Syngman Rhee that if he didn't sign a cease-fire the U.S would cut off aid.

He brings his own style, but we might notice how previous presidents dealt with inconvenient allies.

In pressuring the Zelensky government the last few days, Mr. Trump has gotten tough on military sharing. He has gotten tough on Ukrainian refugees. His government has reportedly reached out to Mr. Zelensky's domestic political opponents. This isn't very nice but it's nicer than how President Kennedy dealt with a difficult ally, approving the coup that led to the murder of South Vietnam's President Ngo Dinh Diem and his brother.

But in treating with Mr. Putin, aren't we treating with a killer and aggressor? In a period of 30 years, the U.S. managed to cuddle up with two of history's three biggest mass murderers. At the start of World War II, Stalin was Hitler's ally, enabling Hitler to overrun Europe. Two years later, FDR was finagling with Stalin over to deal to defer a Polish sellout (Poland was a U.S. ally) until FDR could wrap up the Polish vote in Chicago.

Mao still owns the record for killing his own people. Yet Nixon also saw that South Vietnam was no longer a strategic imperative after the Sino-Soviet split. Even in 1968, a few Nixon voters probably suspected "peace with honor" would become "cut and run."

But who needs historical analogies? We have plenty to analyze without changing the subject to something somebody did or said in another time under different circumstances.

Last week's White House blowup between the Trump administration and President Zelensky is an endless revelation. People, including Trump officials, in their seven-day-a-week jobs turn out not to be making decisions for the reasons that outside kibitzers imagine. The Ukraine war isn't a sporting event. Mr. Trump says its continuation hurts U.S. interests. He wants to reduce America's costs and risks. Like any U.S. leader he notices that Russia and China are among the few powers that can end the U.S.'s existence. Or as President Obama might put it, the U.S. will always care more about its relations with big players than small players. If Moldova invades Ukraine, that's a headache for the State Department. A tenuously secure dictator with 5,800 warheads whose regime seeks internal stability by stirring up external conflict? That's a presidential-level, 24/7 problem in deterrence. Ukraine is where that problem needs managing now.

Mr. Trump would perhaps like to do nothing for Ukraine and ask nothing of Mr. Putin and still get a deal. That's the path of least resistance given his domestic MAGA constituency and U.S. budget constraints. Happily Ukraine and its European friends are pushing back. A bad deal would also be dangerous for America down the road. One especially useful outcome of Mr. Trump's hardhearted gamesmanship is that Europe is taking self-defense seriously.

WORLD NEWS

Insurgents Test Syria's New Government

Ambushes by Assad loyalists stretch the forces of the former rebels now in power

By Jared Malsin
And Saleh al-Batati

Syrian government forces are responding to clashes and ambushes by partisans of the deposed Assad regime, the biggest domestic military challenge yet to the former rebel group trying to hold the country together.

Government security forces launched an operation along Syria's Mediterranean coast, the heartland of the Assads' Alawite religious minority, after deadly ambushes on security forces by gunmen loyal to the old regime, according to the state news agency SAN'A.

The battles overnight were among the fiercest since the new government's forces overthrew Bashar al-Assad in early December, ending more than a decade of civil war. The clashes reignited tensions across Syria, with throngs of supporters of the government taking to the streets in support of the security operation.

The developments added to challenges facing the new government headed by former rebel leader Ahmad al-Sharaa, who is also negotiating with Kurdish-led militias controlling a swath of northeast Syria and contending with an Israeli demand—backed by military strikes—that it demilitarize southern Syria.

"Old-regime remnants are taking advantage of the military and security capacity limitations of the Syrian government to try to derail Syria's political transition," said Lina Khatib, an associate fellow at London think tank Chatham House.

Reinforcements poured in Friday morning, according to images published by SAN'A.

KARAM AL-MASRI/REUTERS

Syrian government forces riding into battle against Assad-regime loyalists in the coastal province of Latakia on Friday.

Syrian authorities also imposed curfews until Saturday morning in the coastal provinces of Tartus and Latakia, both Alawite-majority areas.

Syrian officials on Friday afternoon said government forces had retaken Tartus and Latakia, and were pursuing old-regime loyalists holed up in the town of Qardaha, the Assad family's ancestral home.

Highlighting the risk of wider unrest, a former commander from Assad's forces, Brig. Gen. Ghiath Sulayman Dalla, said that he and other former military leaders had formed a "Military Council for the Liberation of Syria" that he said aimed to free "the entire Syrian territory from all occupying and terrorist forces."

Dalla was sanctioned by the U.S. in 2020 for leading Syrian military forces during indiscriminate attacks on civilians, including chemical attacks.

Sharaa's forces, which numbered around 25,000 when Sunni Islamist rebels helped overthrow Assad last year, are thinly stretched in a country of about 24 million people. His government now faces the dilemma of cracking down on pro-Assad forces without alienating Alawites.

On Friday, residents of the coastal region and security analysts tracking the situation said armed men carried out beatings, arbitrary arrests and looting during the security campaign.

"The way it's being handled carries massive risks," said Nanar Hawach, a senior analyst for Syria at International Crisis Group. "If this continues, the honeymoon is destined to end, and localized insurgencies will likely start popping up."

A spokesman for the government in Damascus didn't immediately respond to a request for comment on the alleged abuses. A Syrian security official told SAN'A that the Interior Ministry was working to stop the "excesses."

Since the fall of Assad, Sharaa has preached a message of reconciliation, and his government has investigated attacks on Alawites. Accounting for about 10% of Syria's population, Alawites sometimes occupied privileged positions in the Assad regime but also fell victim to its repressive divide-and-conquer instincts. Many opposed the regime.

Turkey and Saudi Arabia, two Sunni Muslim powers, voiced support for the Syrian government.

FRANCE

World War II Bomb Stops Paris Trains

The disposal of an unexploded half-ton British-made bomb from World War II caused hours of transportation chaos Friday on rail and road networks in Paris, including the suspension of high-speed train links with London and Brussels.

The bomb was dug up near train tracks north of Paris, forcing a shutdown of the rail network serving Gare du Nord, France's busiest station, while police disposal officers worked to remove and destroy the bomb's fuse. A portion of the A1 highway—a major artery into northern Paris—and sections of the capital's always-busy beltway also were closed.

Transport Minister Philippe Tabarot said that nearly 500 trains were canceled, affecting roughly 600,000 people.

—Associated Press

POLAND

Premier Issues Call For Larger Military

Poland is working to prepare large-scale military training for every adult male, Prime Minister Donald Tusk told parliament.

He said there is a need for an army of 500,000 soldiers, including reservists. Last year, the Polish government said that the military was made up of about 200,000 soldiers.

Security fears have grown as Russia continues to pound Ukraine, and as the Trump administration has withdrawn military and intelligence support for Kyiv while putting its commitments to NATO in question.

President Andrzej Duda said Friday that he was submitting an amendment to the constitution that would oblige the country to spend at least 4% of its gross domestic product each year on defense.

—Associated Press

GAZA STRIP

USAID Cuts Leave Aid Groups in Lurch

The Trump administration's cuts to USAID have frozen hundreds of millions of dollars in contractual payments to aid groups, leaving them paying out of pocket to preserve a fragile cease-fire, according to officials from the U.S. humanitarian agency.

USAID was supposed to fund much of the aid to Gaza as the truce progressed, and the Trump administration approved more than $383 million on Jan. 31 to that end, according to three USAID officials. But since then, there have been no confirmed payments to any partners in the Middle East, they said.

Two senior officials at aid organizations confirmed they haven't received any of the promised funds, after spending millions of dollars on supplies and services.

—Associated Press

WORLD WATCH

SUNDAY ALAMBA/ASSOCIATED PRESS

I AM WOMAN: On Friday, the eve of International Women's Day, celebrants in Lagos, Nigeria, showed off one of the day's symbolic colors, signifying justice, dignity and loyalty to the cause.

Only Human
Sam Altman wants to scan your eyeball **B2**

EXCHANGE

Master Builder
He's a dealmaker, but is he fun? 'No, he is not.' **B3**

DJIA 42801.72 ▲ 222.64 0.52%   **NASDAQ** 18196.22 ▲ 0.7%   **STOXX 600** 553.35 ▼ 0.46%   **10-YR. TREAS.** ▼ 9/32, yield 4.317%   **OIL** $67.04 ▲ $0.68   **GOLD** $2,904.70 ▼ $11.90   **EURO** $1.0834   **YEN** 148.03

DELIVERY WARS

JOSEPHINE CHU AND KAITLYN WANG/WSJ; RYAN DORGAN FOR WSJ

Walmart's thousands of stores are powering the most serious challenge Amazon has faced in its race to deliver everything, everywhere

By Sarah Nassauer

A DECADE AGO, Walmart's thousands of stores across the country made it look like a dinosaur in the online-shopping era. Now the retail giant is mounting one of the few serious challenges to Amazon.com's dominance in e-commerce, and those very stores are central to its strategy.

Walmart delivered five billion items on the same day they were ordered last year, double the number delivered in 2023. It can now deliver most of the 120,000 products in its sprawling supercenters, including meat, eggs and milk, to 93% of U.S. households the same day, sometimes in hours.

Amazon doesn't release figures that allow an exact comparison of its same-day delivery reach. But Walmart's sprawling delivery network, which in some areas is faster than Amazon's, represents a leap that would have been unimaginable just a few years ago.

"I am very, very grateful that we have 4,700, roughly, stores," which now double as fast-delivery hubs, John Furner, chief executive of Walmart U.S., said in an interview. "It's something that perhaps a few years ago people would not have expected we would have been able to deliver at scale."

To make most of those speedy deliveries, the retailer relies on thousands of freelance drivers using a system called Spark, created by Walmart, which uses an app to coordinate online orders from its ubiquitous superstores.

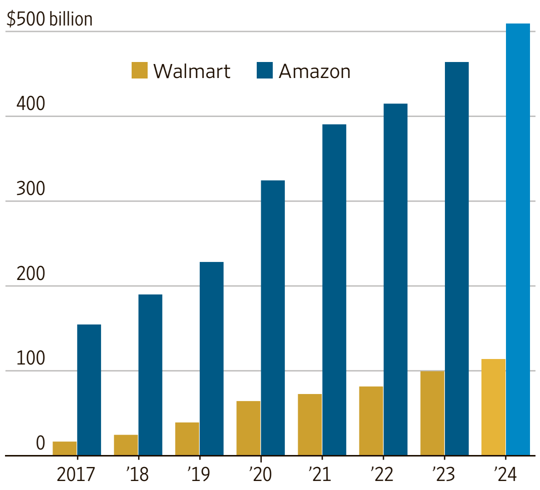
About 41% of all U.S. e-commerce sales go through Amazon, a much bigger share than Walmart's 9%. Amazon could overtake Walmart this year as the country's largest company by revenue if sales trends persist. Walmart reported $681 billion revenue in 2024; Amazon's was $638 billion.

But over years of attempts, tests and failures, Walmart has carved out a niche that has Amazon working to catch up—fast delivery of online orders that often include inexpensive groceries, and increasingly other items it sells in its stores, such as clothing, decor, batteries and prescription medicines.

An Amazon spokeswoman declined to disclose the share of U.S. households that can now receive its same-day shipments. Shoppers in more than 3,500 U.S. cities and towns have access to grocery delivery in some form through Amazon, she said, and the company can deliver millions of items the same day. The company says it delivered over two billion items it calls "everyday essentials," such as cleaning supplies and paper towels, the same day or next day in the U.S. last year. Those figures don't include fresh groceries, but it's working to rapidly add those items to its same-day delivery warehouses, she said.

Walmart employees pack online orders, above, that freelance drivers like Samantha Atkinson, left, collect and deliver to customers.

Annual e-commerce revenue



Note: Walmart e-commerce revenue includes Sam's Club. Amazon's revenue excludes AWS and physical store revenue. Walmart's figure for 2024 is an estimate and corresponds to the fiscal year ending Jan. 2025.
Source: Visible Alpha

"I don't think that Walmart will ever really get to the sheer size Amazon has online," said Blake Droesch, retail analyst for Emarketer, which tracks e-commerce. "But Walmart is one of the only retailers that's had the capital and strategy to marshal a true defense."

Walmart overall is profitable, but its e-commerce operations, which generate 18% of company revenue, aren't. Executives have said e-commerce is getting closer to profitability, but they haven't set a specific timeline for when they expect to reach that milestone. They are building other, more profitable businesses beyond traditional retail, such as advertising. In that way they're operating like a tech startup—much like Amazon, which famously didn't report a profitable year until nearly a decade after it started.

Investors haven't been scared off. Walmart's stock has doubled in two years to record highs and its market value is nearly $737 billion. Amazon's market capitalization is greater than $2.1 trillion.

If the discount retailer can provide high-qual-

Please turn to page B5

Fashion's Hottest Designer Steps Out of the Shadows

In a declining luxury market, Alaïa is a bright spot. Pieter Mulier gets the credit.

By Rory Satran

Paris

At this past week's Alaïa fashion show, at the company's new headquarters in Paris, the crowd was packed with devotees dressed head-to-toe in the brand's sculptural wool pea coats, split-leg jeans, sneaker-like Mary Jane shoes and skinny "Teckel" handbags (inspired by the dachshund dog breed).

Alaïa is having a legitimate "moment," as fashion people love to say, and the man responsible for that is its ebullient Belgian creative director Pieter Mulier.

The 45-year-old designer was once a classic number two. People in the fashion industry knew of him and his work, but most consumers didn't know his name. The Alaïa brand soared in the supermodel era of the 1980s and 1990s, and had become slightly dusty in recent years. Now, under Mulier, it again draws a cultish following among fashion's most elite

Please turn to page B4

CRAIG MCDEAN

Pieter Mulier, Alaïa's head designer, is generating a cult following for his pea coats, shoes and 'Teckel' bags, and showed in Paris this past week.

SCIENCE OF SUCCESS | BEN COHEN

How the Avocado Conquered America

Every now and then, you come across a product that makes you question how you could have possibly existed without it.

It's happened with many of the dazzling creations that have swept the nation in the 21st century, like Facebook and the iPhone—and the avocado.

As it turns out, the history of avocados conquering America is as rich and slightly nutty as the avocado itself.

These days, the average American devours about 9 pounds of avocados a year. If that sounds like a lot of avocados, that's because it is. In the 1970s, it was less than 1 pound. In the 1990s, it was still less than 2 pounds. Even since 2000, America's national avocado consumption has quadrupled.

And the reason avocados have exploded in the U.S. is that most of them are no longer grown in the U.S.

We have developed such a voracious appetite for this versatile fruit that the U.S. now annually brings in nearly 3 billion pounds of avocados. In fact, 90% of the avocados that Americans eat are imported—and close to 90% of those imports come from Mexico.

It's hard to remember a time when their availability was so lim-

Please turn to page B4

EMIL LENDOF/WSJ

THE SCORE | THE BUSINESS WEEK IN 6 STOCKS

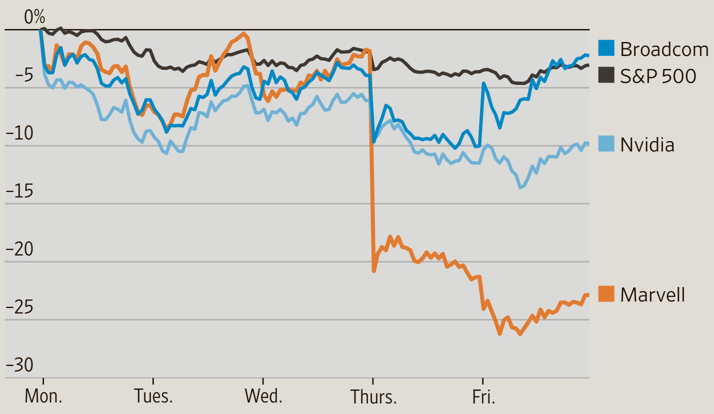
Walgreens to Go Private, Tariffs Whipsaw Markets

MARVELL TECHNOLOGY

▼ MRVL 20%

Chip stocks lost some power on Thursday, as investors searching for the next AI giant digested modest results from chip maker Marvell Technology. Marvell flagged a slowdown in its data-center business, reporting narrowly better-than-expected revenue and in-line projections for this quarter. The day's broader selloff included fellow semiconductor manufacturer Broadcom, with its shares declining 6.3% ahead of its own earnings report late Thursday. Both Marvell and Broadcom have developed fast-growing businesses building custom AI chips for tech giants such as Amazon.com and Alphabet's Google. Marvell shares **plummeted 20% Thursday**.

Performance of chip stocks this past week



Source: FactSet

WALGREENS BOOTS ALLIANCE

▲ WBA 7.5%

In one of the biggest leveraged buyouts in recent memory, the pharmacy chain on Thursday was sold to private-equity firm Sycamore Partners for $10 billion—91% lower than its peak valuation of $106 billion in 2015. Over the years, Walgreens failed to keep up with competition, the rise of e-commerce and the growing power of pharmacy-benefit managers. The Wall Street Journal first reported the deal talks with Sycamore. Walgreens shares **rose 7.5% Friday**.

$10 billion
Sycamore's deal to buy Walgreens

GAP

▲ GAP 19%

Gap posted better-than-expected sales and profit in its latest quarter, as its turnaround efforts show results. Among its brands, Gap, Banana Republic and Old Navy logged gains of 7%, 4% and 3% in comparable sales, respectively, offsetting a 2% decline from Athleta. Gap also said it has "minimal" exposure to tariffs. Chief Financial Officer Katrina O'Connell said less than 10% of Gap's products come from China and less than 1% come from Canada and Mexico. Gap shares surged **19% Friday**.

$4.15 billion
Gap's fourth-quarter revenue, compared with Wall Street expectations for $4.07 billion, per Factset

BRANDON BELL/GETTY IMAGES

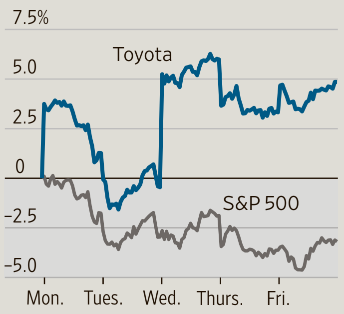
Toyota shares rallied after President Trump suspended tariffs on goods that fall under the U.S.-Mexico-Canada trade agreement.

TOYOTA MOTOR

▲ TM 6.5%

The ever-shifting tariff landscape had global auto stocks on edge, as traders digested developments from the Trump administration. On Wednesday—the day after 25% tariffs on Mexico and Canada went into effect—President Trump suspended until April 2 the levies on goods that fall under the United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement trade deal. American depositary receipts of Toyota **rallied 6.5% Wednesday**.

Toyota Motor performance this past week



Source: FactSet

KROGER

▼ KR 3%

Chief Executive Rodney McMullen resigned from Kroger following a board investigation into his personal conduct, ending a more than four-decade career at the grocery giant. Kroger, the biggest U.S. supermarket chain by sales, said Monday that lead independent director Ronald Sargent will serve as chairman and interim CEO. Kroger said the conduct wasn't related to Kroger's financial performance, operations or reporting, and didn't involve any Kroger associates. Kroger shares **fell 3% Monday**.

TARGET

▼ TGT 3%

Target on Tuesday said its February sales fell year-over-year, citing declining consumer confidence and cold weather, and warned that its sales could be flat this year. U.S. consumer confidence has been slipping, in part on fears of higher prices due to the Trump administration's tariff campaign. A similar reading from Walmart spooked investors last month, when executives set lower-than-expected fiscal-year revenue and profit targets. Target shares **fell 3% Tuesday**.

—*Francesca Fontana*

ILLUSTRATION BY DANIEL HERTZBERG; WORLD FOUNDATION

KEYWORDS | CHRISTOPHER MIMS

The Creepy Eyeball Scanner Powering Sam Altman's *Other* Startup

The CEO of OpenAI imagines a future where you'll need to constantly prove you're human—and your iris will be the key

Imagine a world full of basketball-sized "Orbs" that stare deep into our eyes, capturing the unique pattern of our irises.

These ubiquitous Orbs would allow us to do anything requiring identification, online or in real life, from buying bread to paying taxes. It's a vision reminiscent of other recent efforts—including Amazon's attempt to replace credit cards with our palms, and Ant Group's efforts in China to make it possible to pay with your face.

The big difference? The builders of an app called World—including Chief Executive Alex Blania and his co-founder Sam Altman of OpenAI fame—envision a time in the not-too-distant future when you can't do much *without* an ocular check-in. AI agents will be so prevalent, and so humanlike, that we'll need to repeatedly prove we're human to prevent those AIs from masquerading as humans on everything from payment platforms to social networks.

To accelerate adoption of what World calls its "anonymous proof-of-human" system, the company recently launched a mini app store inside its app, which is available for iPhones and Android devices.

World's mini app store is part of a broader strategy to create an "everything app." These apps—also called "super apps"—are common throughout Asia, where WeChat, Grab, Alipay and KakaoTalk allow users to do everything from shopping and chatting to ordering a meal or a ride.

World's mini app store, which currently includes services to send and receive cryptocurrency, chat with verified humans and access microloans, is a first step toward creating what Altman, Blania and their team hope will be a vast ecosystem reaching more than a billion people. And as the company's identification system expands, they anticipate their main competitor will be Elon Musk's own attempt at an everything app: X.

"I think it will take a while until we seriously collide," Blania told me on Tuesday, "given that X is primarily now a social network." The app formerly known as Twitter has yet to launch its payment service, a key component of Musk's vision. Besides, World has yet to properly launch in the U.S. No Orbs to gaze into…yet.

Within about 12 months, however, Blania believes the two services will start to compete in earnest. If so, it would be a notable development in part because making everything apps work in the West has proved extremely difficult. The bottom line is that, for most people with an Android phone or iPhone who haven't grown up in the tech ecosystems of Asia, those app stores already offer the versatility and flexibility that everything apps do.

Sam Altman's involvement in World might also encourage competition with X, by virtue of Musk's pugilistic nature and the already intense rivalry between Altman and Musk. World is no mere side project for Altman, says Blania, who speaks with him a couple of times a week: "He's involved in essentially every major decision that I make."

Few people in the U.S. have heard of World, formerly known as Worldcoin. If they have, it's probably on account of the company's unique biometric identification system, the Orb. So far, Orb-ing millions of people hasn't proved popular with governments around the world, as more than a dozen have either suspended its operations in their countries or else examined its handling of personal data.

World investor and venture capitalist Ben Horowitz said on a recent episode of his podcast with Marc Andreessen that with the loosening of restrictions on crypto companies in the U.S., he anticipates World will become "legal" in the U.S. this year. At present, the company doesn't scan eyeballs in the U.S. or allow Americans to hold its Worldcoin token, for fear of regulators, Altman has said. When I asked how long it will be until World sets up locations in the U.S. where people can walk in, present their irises and become part of the network, Blania declined to say. But, he adds, the effort is "top of mind" for him.

The World app—and its Orb eyeball scanner—have 'verified' 11 million people worldwide.

In general, Blania brushes aside concerns about regulators both in the U.S. and abroad.

"I know the properties of the system, I'm extremely convinced about its compliance, and about the fact that I think it exceeds the actual expectations of these regulators," he says. "It's just a matter of getting them to understand every part of the system."

World recently hired a former X executive to be the company's head of privacy.

Other systems that rely on biometrics have unnerved users and governments in the past. It's easy to forget the hue and cry once raised about Face ID on the iPhone, the face-scanning technology most people now use to unlock their Apple devices. When it was introduced, there were concerns about it both as a potential security liability and because of the way it evoked mass-surveillance systems in China that rely on face recognition.

World says its network is anonymous and secure, and only proves you're a person—but it could be made part of a broader identity system. One of World's distinguishing features is that it is an "anonymous proof of human" system. That is, its eyeball scan can verify *that* you're a human being and not an AI, but without additional software and systems, it can't identify *who* you are. What could drive people to adopt a system like World's will be the rise of ever-more-sophisticated AIs that will make doing business on the internet almost impossible without something like it, says Tiago Sada, chief product officer at the company.

World's "proof of human" powers were a unique enabler of a new mini-app in the World app store called Credit, says Diego, the Argentina-based developer of the app, who goes by only his first name. Credit gives people microloans of between $5 and $100 with no collateral—but will ban users who default on loans. People can't circumvent the ban by creating a new Credit account, because of their unique, durable, and bot-proof identifier on the World network, Diego says. The app has racked up 70,000 users in Argentina since its launch in December, and is turning a profit, he adds.

While it seems that the ambitions of both World and X put them on a collision course, there are also plenty of reasons to be skeptical about how likely they are to achieve their goals.

World has only Orb-verified 11 million people worldwide, despite the fact that it literally pays them—via Worldcoin crypto tokens—to get their eyeballs scanned. (At its start, World doled out 25 tokens per scan, roughly $25 at today's prices, and now offers 16 tokens per scan.) And the launch date for X's Money Account service is unclear. The company has said it will count Visa as its first partner. X did not respond to requests for comment.

Visa CEO Ryan McInerney said on the company's most recent earnings call that X Money will use Visa's systems to allow users to fund their "X Wallet" with a debit card, which will also enable peer-to-peer transactions on X.

X has vastly more users than World does, but it's unclear how many people will be eager to entrust an Elon Musk-owned company with their financial lives.

In the end, it's trust that is most likely to decide the fate of both companies. Blania says he's sure that in time, regulators and privacy experts will validate his confidence in the security of World.

"The way this system is built, it is provably much more secure" than its potential competitors, he says. "It's like actual privacy rocket science that I think has never been deployed in that way in the world."

P2JW067000-4-B00300-1--------XA

The Walgreens Billionaire Sees His Empire Come Apart

In Monaco, Stefano Pessina built a $100 billion company. A new deal to take it private values it at $10 billion.

By Benjamin Katz

Stefano Pessina spent half a century building a pharmacy behemoth that stretches almost three times further than the Roman empire ever did. Now he may have to watch it come apart.

This past week, the Italian billionaire and biggest shareholder of Walgreens Boots Alliance backed a deal to sell the company to a private-equity firm that will likely dismantle the conglomerate and sell it for parts.

It's a personally searing epilogue to a stunning career characterized by Pessina's fierce, and—as he describes it—"very cold" approach to dealmaking that involved buying more than 1,000 businesses. Pessina himself isn't ready to leave. As part of the deal to take Walgreens private in one of the biggest leveraged buyouts in recent memory, Pessina would roll his roughly 17% stake into the new entity.

The 83-year-old is often cited as the richest man in Monaco, but largely eschews the city-state's opulent lifestyle. He's a ruthless dealmaker, but described often as humble. He runs one of the world's largest health companies, but has fought to keep cigarettes on his shelves.

In 2006, in the midst of a coup that would see his Alliance UniChem take over the storied British chain Boots, local press clamored to make sense of the billionaire figure, who—even in his birth country, Italy—remained a mystery.

Hyper rational and quietly confident, he was described in a 2007 Guardian article as having a tendency to "gargle" his 'r's—a dead giveaway in Italy of his upper-middle class upbringing. He had found romance in one of his early deals, the purchase of a drug wholesaler from Ornella Barra, who would later become his second wife. She is now chief operating officer of Walgreens' international business.

"Is he great fun? No, he is not," Nigel Rudd, the former Boots chairman, told the Financial Times in a 2019 interview. "He is remorseless, just awesome actually. I rank him as one of the most talented business people and deal-doers I have ever met."

A spokesman for Walgreens said Pessina declined to comment.

A graduate in nuclear engineering, Pessina abandoned academia in 1968 feeling alienated from the rise of radical student activism on campus. He stayed in Milan to work for a marketing firm when the bombing of Milan's Piazza Fontana by far-right fascist groups kick-started almost two decades of political violence, terrorist attacks and assassinations across Italy.

In 1977 he took over his father's fledgling and failing pharmaceutical wholesaler. It was there that he got his taste for dealmaking. He spent the next 20 years expanding at an interminable pace, at times taking on money-losing businesses from owners who were desperate to exit. He believed scale was needed to compete.

The business had grown too big for Italy's boot, pushing him to expand his conquest beyond the border. He started in France, then moved to Spain, Greece and Morocco, and in 1997 he combined with UniChem, which gave his budding empire a foothold in Britain.

But it was his 2006 deal to combine with the 175-year-old British retailer, Boots, that captured the attention of his much bigger U.S. rivals. The deal was partly negotiated with Rudd on the deck of Pessina's yacht, which he kept moored off the coast of Sardinia. It expanded Pessina's reach from more than 1,000 stores to about 3,000, but it came at a time when British retailers were collapsing at a rapid rate.

Just over six months after Boots and Alliance combined, he orchestrated a historic leveraged buyout of the combined entity in a $22 billion deal backed by the U.S. buyout giant KKR. It remains the biggest take-private deal in European corporate history.

His ambition became to go global, and that meant getting a foothold in the U.S. Initially Walgreens purchased a 45% stake. Then in December 2014, it came back for the rest for a combined total of $22 billion.

It was about the same price Pessina and KKR had paid to take the company private, but with two major coups for Pessina: with a roughly 17% stake, he was now the largest shareholder of the combined Walgreens Boots Alliance and, despite being executive chairman of the smaller entity, Pessina was given the reins.

Pessina's empire had reached its pinnacle. Its more than 13,000 stores stretched from Norway to Chile, Alaska to Thailand, with a market cap of over $100 billion dollars.

The Walgreens deal also began his empire's decadelong decline.

With the rise of Amazon quickly eating into drugstores' nonmedical revenues, he spent billions buying more stores. He fought against pushes from other senior executives that saw an incongruence between selling health products while keeping cigarettes and beer on its shelves. CVS, his biggest rival, itself stopped selling tobacco products in 2014.

And he was convinced that the real opportunity was in convincing shoppers to trust Walgreens not only to fill prescriptions and sell them deodorant and nail polish, but to diagnose and manage their long-term health conditions.

Walgreens had made an earlier bet on Theranos founder Elizabeth Holmes to use its blood-test technology to create health hubs in its stores. The startup was later revealed to be a fraud. Pessina ended the partnership he inherited and in 2017 sued Theranos for $140 million before reaching a settlement for an undisclosed sum.

By 2019, Walgreens had already lost about a third of its value since its peak, and, at its Deerfield, Ill., headquarters, Pessina was grumbling about the short-termism that came with running a public company.

It was true that the group's total sales were slipping annually with rising costs and increasing competition, but he was more excited about expansion. Market share, he said, was still growing.

"These things will be just a small wrinkle in the life, in the face of our old company," Pessina said. Companies he purchased "have seen two worldwide wars, they have seen the largest recessions of the modern era, and they have been able to come out always stronger."

Months later, Pessina attempted what would have been the biggest deal of his lifetime and in U.S. history. He wanted to take his empire private. This time, at a reported valuation of $70 billion.

He entered talks with KKR, the same firm that had helped him charge the gates in his deal to take-private Alliance Boots, but they couldn't agree on a deal.

Aside from a period when business picked up during the Covid-19 pandemic, Walgreens' business has since crumbled at a faster pace. Pessina formally stepped down as CEO in 2021 to become chairman shortly after selling Alliance Healthcare, the business that started his empire, for $6.5 billion.

The company's current CEO is drastically cutting costs and closing over a thousand stores.

The company's value dropped to $7.1 billion at the end of last year—down 93% from the $106 billion behemoth it had been a decade earlier.

Sycamore, a New York-based firm that specializes in buying retailers, is set to purchase the pharmacy chain in a roughly $10 billion deal that the Journal has reported will involve stripping down Pessina's conglomerate.

About 30 years ago, a reporter for Italy's biggest newspaper, Corriere della Sera, asked Pessina, then in his mid-50s, what it was that he liked doing most. "Building," was his simple answer.

▲ Ornella Barra and Pessina at a 2010 masked ball benefit

FROM TOP: SHAUN CURRY/I-IMAGES/ZUMA PRESS, NICK HUNT/PATRICK MCMULLAN/GETTY IMAGES

Stefano Pessina

- **Birthplace:** Pescara, Italy, two years before it was bombed in World War II.
- **Citizenship:** He renounced his Italian citizenship to become a citizen of Monaco in 2012.
- **Dining:** He eats just one meal a day at dinner so he can have good bottle of wine.
- **Nonsmoker:** He fought to sell cigarettes at Walgreens but doesn't smoke.

THE INTELLIGENT INVESTOR | JASON ZWEIG

Don't Let Your Politics Shape Your Portfolio

ETFs like Defiance MAGA play on ideology

A proposed new exchange-traded fund, Defiance MAGA Seven ETF, would invest in seven companies the manager expects to benefit from the Trump administration's policies.

Defiance's chief executive, Sylvia Jablonski, declined to comment while the fund is still in registration with the Securities and Exchange Commission. However, mixing politics with your portfolio—regardless of your party affiliation—is an old, persistent and pernicious idea.

What makes this kind of investing so fruitless? Let us count the ways.

For starters, any idea obvious enough to occur to you and me is already in the market price. Defense and aerospace stocks are bound to boom in this administration? That was priced in months ago. Coinbase will prosper under President Trump's favorable policies toward cryptocurrencies? That, too, has long been priced in.

Many stocks that got a "Trump bump" up to and after the election have done badly since Inauguration Day—probably because investors who put their money where their vote was drove these companies' stock prices to unsustainable heights.

Between late last September and the end of October, Trump Media & Technology Group's stock more than quadrupled. So far this year, it's lost 34%.

Shares of CoreCivic, which operates private prisons, nearly doubled right after the 2024 election. So far this year, the stock is down almost 12%.

Furthermore, stock prices aren't driven exclusively by presidential policy. Inflation, interest rates, commodity prices, the value of the dollar, wars, natural disasters and changes in other nations' policies are among the countless factors that can knock stock prices up or down. U.S. presidents have some control over some of those forces, but total control over none.

And once your political scruples rule out any kind of stock, you own only a segment of the market—which is likely to behave quite differently from the market as a whole, for better or (more likely) for worse.

Technology is the biggest industry sector, constituting more than 30% of the S&P 500's market value—and contributing much of the market's gain in recent years.

Tech companies also have tended—until recently—to be "woke," for example by instituting policies to encourage gender and racial diversity. Shunning the woke can mean underweighting technology stocks and overweighting industrial, financial and energy companies.

Political filters can have quirky consequences. The God Bless America ETF (ticker symbol: YALL) has lagged the S&P 500 by 0.7 percentage point since the election. While President Biden was in office, it outperformed significantly.

YALL won't invest in companies that take "politically left" stands on social and political issues. But that's a subjective judgment.

Consider Amazon.com or Facebook parent Meta Platforms. Before the 2024 election, they acted woke. Ever since, they've been scrambling in the opposite direction. They aren't yet eligible for inclusion in the fund, says Adam Curran, YALL's portfolio manager. "I'm a grudgeholder," he tells me.

The Point Bridge America First ETF (ticker: MAGA) owns companies whose employees and political-action committees donate significantly to Republican candidates and have the majority of their assets within the U.S.

The fund holds about 150 stocks from the S&P 500, weighting them equally. Since inception in late 2017, MAGA has trailed the S&P 500 by an average of 3 percentage points annually. (Over the same period, MAGA has roughly matched a version of the S&P 500 that weights each stock equally.)

Why would a company's political contributions determine its profitability? MAGA's portfolio manager, Hal Lambert, thinks firms that donate to Republicans "have more of a free-market viewpoint and are focused more on their shareholders."

If you're a Democrat, you might be smirking as you read this. But it isn't just Republican-leaning portfolios that might disappoint their investors.

Consider ESG investing, which seeks to make businesses and the world [E]nvironmentally cleaner, [S]ocially fairer and [G]overned better—generally from the viewpoint of people who are left of center. Until recently, ESG was a popular strategy, amassing trillions of dollars in assets.

Yet many people who pumped money into these funds helped neither their own returns nor the causes they sought to advance.

The performance of ESG funds has been mediocre. One of the biggest such funds, iShares ESG Aware MSCI USA ETF, has underperformed the S&P 500 by an average of about 0.3 percentage point annually since it launched at the end of 2016. Another, Vanguard ESG U.S. Stock ETF, has lagged the market by 0.1 percentage point annually since its inception in late 2018.

As my colleague James Mackintosh pointed out near the peak of the ESG craze, while shunning "bad" companies and investing in "good" ones might give you a warm fuzzy feeling, it isn't likely to make the world a better place.

You're not starving "bad" companies of capital or showering "good" ones with surplus money; they've already sold shares to the public, so what you do with your dollars seldom has any direct impact.

With political passions running high on both sides, it can feel almost impossible to remain dispassionate.

That's because, more than ever, politics is about identity: The people who agree with us are right (and good), and those who disagree are wrong (and bad). Politics has become so polarized that our opinions feel like facts, and facts we don't like are just opinions.

But the stock market doesn't know or care how you vote. As I've written, staying disciplined in your investing approach is one of the keys to long-term success.

Letting your political views penetrate your portfolio is a good way to express pride or anger. It's unlikely to boost your returns and can wreak havoc on your investing discipline.

ALEX NABAUM

The Rich, Nutty Story Of Avocados' Popularity

Continued from page B1
ited that avocados were more like a luxury item. Except that time wasn't very long ago.

They were only allowed into the country from Mexico in 1997. They weren't accessible across the country until 2007. Now they are beloved everywhere in America—and not just because they are healthy and delicious.

"The success of the avocado industry is rooted in our trade relationship with Mexico," said David Ortega, a Michigan State University professor of food economics and policy.

But recently, this fruit that owes its success to free trade has found itself on the front lines of a trade war.

This past week, President Trump slapped Mexican imports with 25% tariffs and left companies in the avocado business scrambling to decide whether to eat the costs—or feed them to consumers. Before they could make their decisions, the White House swerved and suddenly delayed the tariffs for a month, which means they'll have to navigate the uncertainty all over again soon.

But no matter what happens next, there are two things that probably won't change about the avocado economy.

The first is that U.S. companies will keep importing from Mexico because that's the only way they can meet the year-round demand. The chances of American farmers making enough avocados on their own are roughly the same as their chances of making avocados neon pink.

The second is that U.S. consumers will keep buying avocados.

I know I will. This is where I have to reveal my personal biases and admit that I happen to love avocados. I love them in sandwiches, salads and smoothies. I love them in sushi rolls and burrito bowls. I bet I would love Tom Brady's famous avocado ice cream, too.

As much as I love avocados now, I don't remember having avocado-related feelings of any kind as a child during the 1990s in New Jersey. My toddler knew how avocados tasted before she knew how to walk. I didn't know much about them until I was an adult. I must have had guacamole, but I can't recall ordering avocado in a restaurant or wiggling open a ripe avocado and having the satisfaction of seeing that exquisite green.

And there's a perfectly logical explanation for why I didn't grow up with avocados in my life.

Until recently, most Americans didn't.

Ben Faber is one of the lucky exceptions. As a soils, water and subtropical crops farm adviser at the University of California's Cooperative Extension, he has been studying avocados since the 1980s—and he's seen the industry evolve in ways that he never could have predicted.

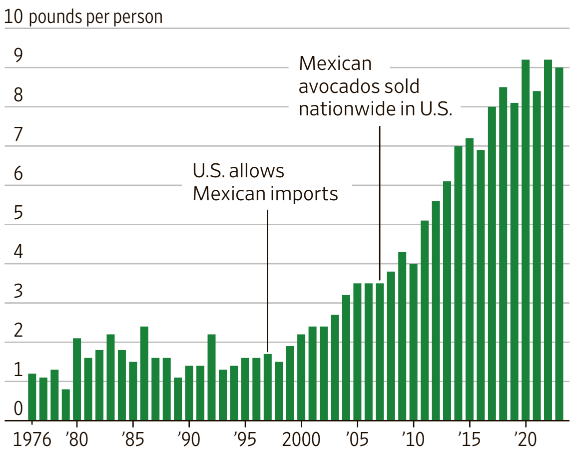
"Nobody in Wisconsin even knew how to spell avocado," he said. "And now people in Wisconsin want their avocado toast."

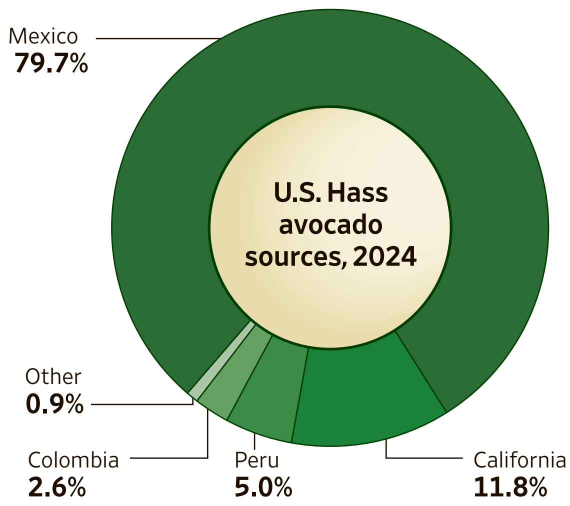
So how did that happen?

It's a tale of economics, geopolitics, marketing, government legislation, scientific advances, dietary trends—and weevils.

An effort to rebrand avocados as a superfood helped turbocharge sales across the U.S.

U.S. per-capita availability of avocados





Sources: USDA, Economic Research Service (availability); Hass Avocado Board (sources)

The U.S. blocked Mexican avocados from entering the country in 1914, when seed weevils were discovered in Mexico's orchards. America's plant-health officials decided the most effective way to stop pests from migrating north of the border was to ban Mexican avocados outright. And that policy remained in place for nearly a century.

Improved ventilation was a key to ripening avocados, making them easier to sell.

For most of that time, avocados were difficult to find outside of California. But inside California, Mary Lu Arpaia didn't even have to leave home to find them. She grew up with two avocado trees in her suburban backyard.

Now a professor at the University of California, Riverside, she started her career there in 1983, when unripe avocados sold in grocery stores felt like baseballs. But it was around that time when avocado researchers became obsessed with an idea that would revolutionize their industry: ripening.

To increase awareness, demand and sales, avocado growers realized they had to give consumers a product they actually wanted, something just firm enough to buy in the morning and eat for dinner that night.

Basically, avocados had to be more like bananas.

It was a simple insight that would change the industry forever. Through a series of experiments, researchers figured out how to improve ventilation on pallets of ripening avocados.

As soon as Americans were able to grab softer avocados in a grocery store, they began filling their shopping carts with them. These days, you can feel a bunch of plump avocados and pick the ones that are immediately ready to be smashed into guacamole. But that's only possible because of all that ripening progress.

"It laid the foundation for this avocado renaissance," Arpaia said.

The next twist in the national avocado saga came when the U.S. began sourcing avocados elsewhere. At first, the supply came from a different hemisphere altogether because countries like Chile were able to provide avocados in the winter.

But it was only a matter of time before the world's largest producer of avocados was able to crack the U.S. market.

Growing avocados requires precisely the right combination of geography, altitude, climate, sunlight, rain, irrigation, topography and soil quality. One of the few places with ideal conditions for avocado production is the Mexican state of Michoacán. What Michigan is for cars, Michoacán is for *los aguacates.*

This fruit from Mexico was finally permitted to cross the border in the 1990s, when the U.S. relaxed import rules after signing the North American Free Trade Agreement, which is easily the most consequential treaty in the history of avocados.

But it still took 15 years after Nafta was signed for avocados to make their way from Mexico to all of the U.S. The first wave of imports brought them to Northeast and Midwest states in 1997, and the first time avocados grown in Mexico were finally permitted everywhere in America was 2007—which means avocados went nationwide the same year as iPhones.

And almost every avocado you buy today helps sell more avocados.

That's because of a decision made in Washington, D.C., long before this past week's tariffs drama.

At the behest of California avocado growers, Congress established a federal program in the early 2000s that collects a few pennies for every pound of fresh Hass avocados sold in the U.S., whether they were grown domestically or imported.

That modest fee of 2.5 cents funded marketing campaigns that promoted health benefits of avocados and rebranded the food as a superfood—similar to the way California dairy processors paid for the classic "Got Milk?" ads.

Now that we've all got avocados, the organization's goal is to make them the most popular and desirable fruit in the U.S.

And to make sure we never, ever have to go back to life before avocados.

FROM TOP: MEDIOS Y MEDIA/GETTY IMAGES; ALFREDO ESTRELLA/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

Fashion's Hottest Designer

Continued from page B1
editors and buyers.

Mulier has done this by putting on artistic ready-to-wear fashion shows, like this week's sculptural tour de force, while not forgetting customers like his 80-year-old mother. In a declining luxury market, Alaïa is a bright spot for parent company Richemont. Its fashion group's sales increased 7% in its third quarter that ended in December 2024.

Richemont, which is dwarfed by conglomerates LVMH and Kering, is better known for its jewelry and watch brands including Cartier and Vacheron Constantin than its fashion holdings. But between Alaïa and the also-buzzy Chloé, the publicly traded group is gaining traction.

'My job at Alaïa is to take it from a maison to a brand.'
— PIETER MULIER

"My job at Alaïa is to take it from a *maison* to a brand," says Mulier in an interview at one of his Paris stores the day after his show. The creative director since 2021, who splits his time between Paris and Antwerp, is wiry in his typical white T-shirt and jeans.

Raised in coastal Belgium, Mulier grew up scurrying around his grandfather's expansive shirtmaking atelier. By osmosis, that prepared him to take over Alaïa, which was founded in 1964 by Tunisian-Parisian couturier Azzedine Alaïa, who died in 2017.

For decades, Mulier excelled at executing the vision of fellow Belgian fashion designer Raf Simons, currently the co-creative director of Prada. Simons plucked Mulier from architecture school in the early 2000s, telling him he was a fashion designer, not an architect. For the first two years that Mulier worked at Simons' namesake brand, he ordered fabrics, helped the patternmakers, adjusted buttons and even cleaned up. Then, he became the older, revered designer's right-hand man when the two moved on to work at bigger fashion houses—Jil Sander, Dior and Calvin Klein.

Mulier might have stayed under the radar had it not been for the 2015 documentary "Dior and I." It chronicled the eight frenzied weeks in which Simons created his first haute couture collection for Dior in 2012. "We nearly died because it was so intense," Mulier remembers.

He emerged as the charismatic breakout star of "Dior and I," a chatty, diplomatic foil to Simons' slightly awkward genius. His relationship with the "petits mains"—lifelong female seamstresses in the atelier—was the heart of the film. In one scene, head seamstress Florence Chehet said, "I don't know Raf very well yet. However I adore Pieter...Working with him is like cake." Today, Mulier still keeps in touch with the women, who have long been retired.

"That movie opened another world for me personally," says Mulier. "People started to call me."

But the faithful lieutenant was in no rush to leave Simons. "I was very content," he says. He watched young designers peak and crash at big houses. Plus, working with Simons kept him on his toes, going from Jil Sander's strict minimalism, to Dior's classic couture, to Calvin Klein's large-scale Americana.

Deep down, he did harbor a desire to branch out on his own: "I dreamt of it, but I thought if it comes, it comes," he says.

It came. In 2020, a few years after Simons and Mulier left Calvin Klein, the house of Alaïa called. Its founding designer rose to fame in the 1980s and '90s with his stretchy knits and curvy shapes beloved by supermodels like Naomi Campbell and Stephanie Seymour. In 1995, Cher Horowitz in the movie "Clueless" put the brand into the pop cultural canon when she called Alaïa "like, a totally important designer."

Important—yes. Hot—no longer. Enter Mulier. He and Simons mutually decided to end their professional partnership after Calvin Klein ("He's still my best friend. And we don't talk about fashion now.")

Mulier was already in talks to take over what he calls a "much bigger, much more commercial" Italian house, which he called off to pursue Alaïa.

It wasn't a *fait accompli*. The interview process took a full year, which is on the long side for such an appointment. To nab the job, he designed full clothing and accessories collections, and created a bible of his vision for the brand which he still uses today and shares with his staff. "I never change my mind," he says.

Pieter Mulier says fashion shows are like dreams. His Paris Fashion Week runway featured sculptural and artistic looks and music sung by Egyptian soprano Fatma Saïd.

He's shown minimalist ballgowns on a makeshift runway at his home in Antwerp, full latex looks on a bridge over the Seine, revealing spiral dresses at the Guggenheim in New York and this week, exaggerated pleated skirts with midriff-baring tops.

"I don't think a show is made to show something commercial. I think it's made to give an impression of what a dream is," he says. At this week's show, he spun together elements including sculpture by the artist Mark Manders and music sung by Egyptian soprano Fatma Saïd. Taken together, he says, the art combines in a Bauhaus-like way. He collaborates with his team to layer in more commercial pieces that jibe with that bigger concept.

"Over the past few seasons with Mulier, it's been growing exponentially within the top customer base," says Heather Kaminetsy, the North American president at Munich-based retailer Mytheresa. She says that immediately after the show this week, the brand's top clients were frantically texting their personal shoppers to express interest in certain looks, including even more experimental pieces like those with wiry hoods.

Mulier's time at Alaïa has been so successful that talk of him joining another, bigger house is inevitable. For now, he's focused on Alaïa, although he says, "If ever I go to another house—which, we'll see—I would do it again, to brief teams to all think the same way. That's actually the most difficult part of our job, to communicate with people in a very clear way, so that everybody goes in the same direction."

ALAÏA (2)

Walmart uses cheap grocery deliveries to entice online shoppers to order more expensive items.

Walmart Races Amazon to Your Front Door

Continued from page B1
ity products like Wagyu beef and appealing apparel "at a Walmart price in a very convenient fast delivery service, I think it's a winning proposition," said Furner.

Walmart's spark

Over the past decade, Walmart executives realized they needed to use their grocery business to fend off Amazon's expansion. Walmart gets more than 50% of its U.S. revenue from selling meat, eggs, lettuce and other groceries. It has used its scale to drive down prices for those items, which draw shoppers for regular trips.

That setup works when shoppers also pick up higher-margin items in the part of the store insiders call "the other side of the box": clothing, home decor or small appliances. Walmart executives hoped a version of the same system could work online—use groceries to lure online business away from competitors, then make money on bigger, more profitable purchases.

"We think we've done the harder part," said Doug McMillon, soon after he became CEO in 2014. "We have the stores, the associates and the expertise in a physical world that others are going to need to build out."

When McMillon took the top job, Walmart was running a small test in Denver of a service that allowed shoppers to buy groceries online and pick them up in store parking lots. Dubbed "online grocery shopping," it started with a handful of stores that offered both pickup and delivery.

Under McMillon, Walmart seized on the idea of using pickup to grow online more profitably. Around 1,000 of its 4,600 U.S. stores offered the pickup service by 2017. Internally it was rebranded as "online grocery pickup" or OGP, a moniker that many Walmart workers still use today.

Executives knew shoppers loved fast grocery delivery, even if pickups offered better profit margins. By 2016, Walmart was working with driver services such as Uber and Lyft, tacking deliveries on to its parking-lot pickup system. Those relationships proved complex and costly for both parties, and Walmart cycled through several partners.

That led it to build its own system, called Spark, named after the company's six-pointed yellow logo. In 2018 Walmart announced a test of its own network of independent drivers to expand its grocery-delivery reach, which at the time covered about 40% of U.S. households. Today tens of thousands of Spark drivers, who aren't Walmart employees and are paid by the delivery, make the majority of the retailer's same-day deliveries.

Walmart pays Spark drivers about $10, plus tip, to pick up orders from Walmart workers at stores, and sometimes collect items from shelves. If an order includes many items or is a longer drive, the payment goes up.

Creating the network contributed to shrinking profit margins for Walmart as wages were rising over the past decade. It created operational snafus when Walmart workers picking products for online orders and roving robots scanning shelves clogged store aisles, issues Walmart has mostly managed. Impulse purchases all but disappeared when shoppers skipped the traditional checkout lines. But executives and Walmart's board decided the bigger risk was that people would stop shopping at Walmart altogether.

Overnight Bud Light

Samantha Atkinson became a Spark driver last year to supplement her income running a small online cosmetics company. Four days a week, she spends about four hours in the morning crisscrossing southeast Idaho delivering groceries from Walmart in her black Nissan Murano.

The 43-year-old mother of three young-adult daughters likes to start as the sun comes up to have her pick of the most lucrative orders that may have been loaded into the Spark app overnight, she said. Walmart gradually increases how much it pays for undelivered orders to entice drivers to take them.

Often those orders were placed late the night before, but didn't get delivered, so include beer or cold medicine. "I often wake them up," said Atkinson. "I'm like, 'Hello. I have your Bud Light!' "

Typically she earns around $100 a day before paying for gas and other expenses, collecting three or four orders at a time from the store parking lot. She aims to earn at least $15 for a basic delivery that isn't too far away, she said, which includes the pay from Walmart and any tip.

Her cosmetics business includes many hours alone in front of a screen, she said. Making Walmart deliveries, she said, "lets me connect with people in a weird, unexpected way."

Extending the range

Walmart's same-day delivery coverage has stretched from about 76% of U.S. households two years ago to 93% today. It now reaches into small towns such as Elizabethtown, Pa., (population: 12,000) and Trenton, Texas (population: 815).

To expand the range, Walmart spent years working on technology that could more accurately predict exactly how far the delivery service could reach without food spoiling or drivers becoming frustrated, said Parvez Musani, a technology executive at Walmart who has worked on the project.

For example, a ride can take longer in rush-hour traffic or a dense urban area. "It's seamless to the drivers," said Musani. The technology designs delivery areas using shopper and census data, driving time and other factors. Walmart started fully using it in late 2024.

The system allowed Walmart to increase its delivery radius in a more precise way than its previous, ZIP Code-based approach, said Musani.

Managers have had to make adjustments to reduce delivery mistakes. For example, when Walmart workers load the car of a delivery driver, one order generally goes in the trunk, the second in the back seat and the third in the front passenger seat to prevent delivery errors.

The transition to online delivery has been rough and expensive. Walmart paid $3.3 billion in 2016 for Jet.com, an online seller of groceries and other items, which it later shut down. It invested heavily to build a personal-shopping and fast delivery service for wealthy New Yorkers, only to shut it down two years later.

Walmart still uses drivers from other companies such as Roadie and Uber Eats in some areas to meet demand, but more than 80% of deliveries come from its Spark network.

More than a third of Walmart's online customers have been willing to pay an additional fee on top of typical delivery charges to receive their items in a few hours, John David Rainey, Walmart's finance chief, said last month during an earnings call. If shoppers aren't members of the Walmart+ subscription program, fees average around $10 per delivery, plus tip.

High-end shoppers

Walmart generally charges the same price whether people order online or shop in person. That's an extension of its longstanding practice of keeping prices the same across its stores, regardless of geographic region.

In addition, speedier shipping and more premium products have helped the company in recent quarters make inroads with higher-income shoppers, which it defines as households that earn more than $100,000. It also has found its way into some of those homes because American Express offers the Walmart+ program as a free perk to Platinum cardholders.

Amazon continues to expand rapidly. In addition to over 1,000 shipping facilities around the U.S., it owns Whole Foods grocery stores, and more than 200 million people globally subscribe to its Prime membership. The similar Walmart+ offers free delivery for orders over $35.

But Amazon has struggled to dominate the fresh-food delivery business. Some early efforts such as Amazon Fresh grocery and Amazon Go convenience stores have been redesigned or scaled back. It's tried several models for delivery through Whole Foods and Amazon Fresh.

Amazon executives are still debating if they can build a dominant grocery business through delivery or if they need hundreds more stores, according to people familiar with the situation.

The company is testing placing an Amazon Grocery store next to Whole Foods locations, where shoppers can buy Diet Coke, Doritos and other nonspecialty brands, so they don't have to go to a competing store to complete their grocery shopping. And Amazon has added milk, eggs and 3,000 other frequently purchased fresh grocery items into its same-day-delivery fulfillment centers in Phoenix, Orlando, Fla., and Kansas City, Mo., so they can be purchased at the same time as nongrocery Amazon orders. By the end of the year, most of its same-day fulfillment sites will have a similar assortment, said the spokeswoman.

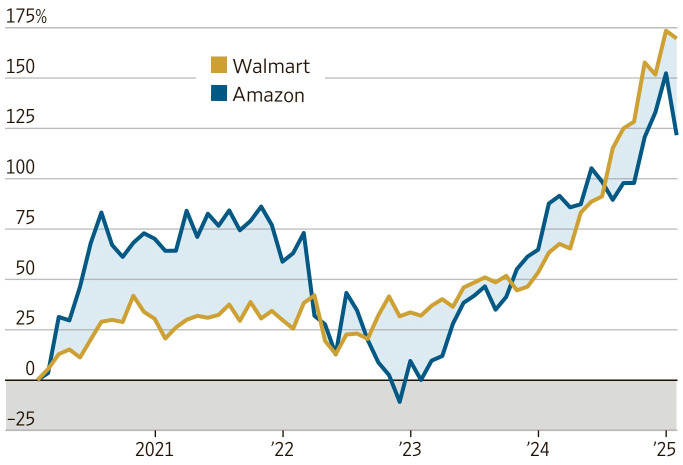
To offer large-scale grocery deliveries, "you have to have a perishables business and a mass physical presence," Amazon CEO Andy Jassy told analysts on a conference call last spring.

Ramchandra Apte, a software engineer, recently moved from Chicago into a New Jersey apartment near New York City. When Walmart offered a discount for Walmart+ and higher-tier subscription called In-Home, he signed up, even though there's a Whole Foods closer to him than Walmart.

Whole Foods is "more expensive, and I have to carry all the groceries," said Apte, who doesn't own a car. "It's a pain."

He still orders nongrocery items from Amazon but finds Walmart delivery is a bit faster for groceries. "I make plenty of money," the 23-year-old said. "I am just trying to save time mostly, and also get good value for the money I spend."

Share price performance, past five years



Source: FactSet

5 Billion
items delivered last year by Walmart on the same day they were ordered

41%
of all U.S. e-commerce sales go through Amazon

9%
of all U.S. e-commerce sales go through Walmart

FROM TOP: JOSEPHINE CHU AND KAITLYN WANG/WSJ; RYAN DORGAN FOR WSJ (2)

To prevent delivery errors, one order generally goes in the trunk, the second in the back seat and the third in the front passenger seat. Walmart can now make same-day deliveries to 93% of U.S. households.

MARKETS DIGEST

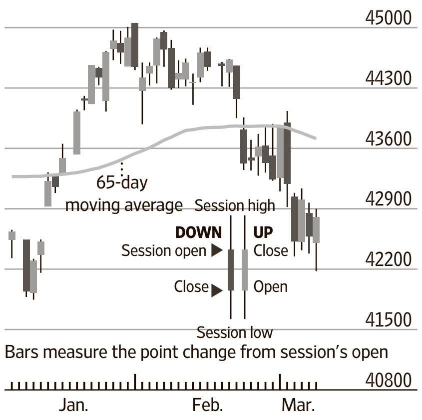
Dow Jones Industrial Average

42801.72 ▲ 222.64 or 0.52%

All-time high 45014.04, 12/04/24

	Last	Year ago
Trailing P/E ratio	25.64	26.94
P/E estimate *	19.62	18.68
Dividend yield	1.87	1.90

Current divisor 0.16268413125742

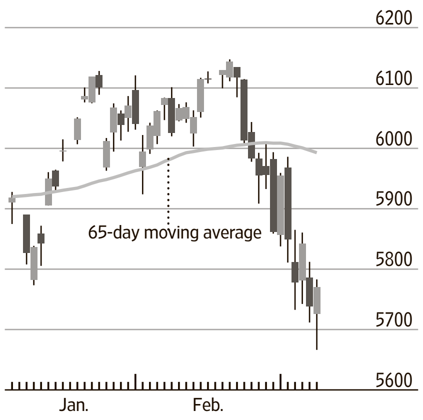


S&P 500 Index

5770.20 ▲ 31.68 or 0.55%

All-time high 6144.15, 02/19/25

	Last	Year ago
Trailing P/E ratio *	23.37	23.83
P/E estimate *	21.15	21.10
Dividend yield *	1.33	1.44

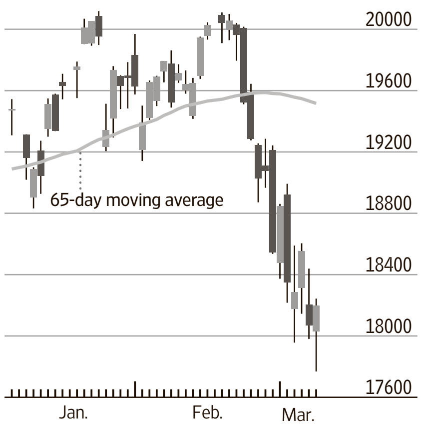


Nasdaq Composite Index

18196.22 ▲ 126.97 or 0.70%

All-time high: 20173.89, 12/16/24

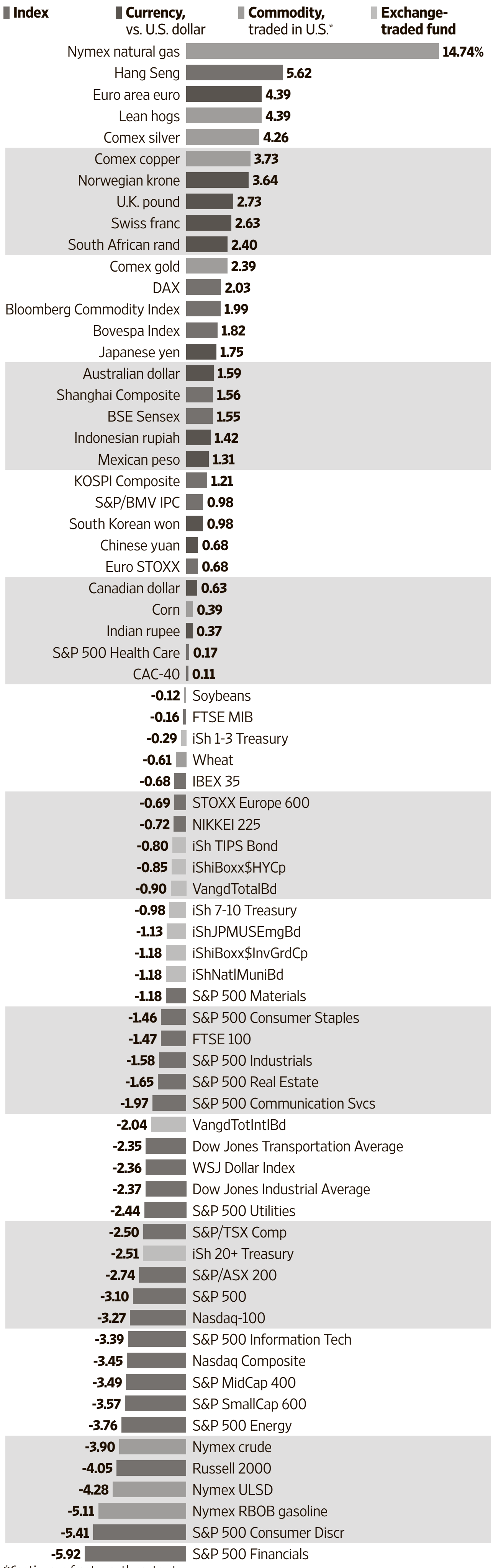
	Last	Year ago
Trailing P/E ratio *†	29.85	32.89
P/E estimate *†	25.17	31.32
Dividend yield *†	0.79	0.80



Weekly P/E data based on as-reported earnings from Birinyi Associates Inc. † Based on Nasdaq-100 Index

Track the Markets: Winners and Losers

A look at how selected global stock indexes, bond ETFs, currencies and commodities performed around the world for the week.



*Continuous front-month contracts

Sources: FactSet (indexes, bond ETFs, commodities), Tullett Prebon (currencies).

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

Methodology

Performance reflects price change (except DAX, Bovespa, and Tel Aviv 35, which reflect total returns). Commodities are represented by the continuous front-month futures contract. Bond exchange-traded fund performance may diverge from that of their underlying index. Bond categories are represented by the following ETFs: U.S. Bonds Total Market: Vanguard Total Bond Market; 1-3 Yr U.S. Treasuries: iShares 1-3 Year Treasury; U.S. 7-10 Yr Treasuries: iShares 7-10 Year Treasury; 20+ Yr U.S. Treasury: iShares 20+ Year Treasury; Treasury Inflation-Protected Securities (TIPS): iShares TIPS; Investment Grade Corporate Bonds: iShares iBoxx $ Investment Grade Corporate; High Yield Corporate Bonds: iShares iBoxx $ High Yield Corporate; Municipal Bonds: iShares National Muni; International Bonds: Vanguard Total International; Emerging Market Bonds: iShares J.P. Morgan USD Emerging Markets.

Major U.S. Stock-Market Indexes

	High	Low	Latest Close	Net chg	% chg	52-Week High	52-Week Low	% chg	YTD % chg	3-yr. ann. % chg
Dow Jones										
Industrial Average	42898.68	42175.62	42801.72	222.64	0.52	45014.04	37735.11	10.5	0.6	9.3
Transportation Avg	15662.68	15348.86	15610.42	124.13	0.80	17754.38	14781.56	-0.7	-1.8	1.8
Utility Average	994.27	973.06	991.49	19.58	2.01	1079.88	835.53	15.9	0.9	-0.2
Total Stock Market	57113.18	55909.80	56988.37	295.17	0.52	61024.05	49376.46	11.5	-2.4	10.3
Barron's 400	1208.01	1178.74	1205.48	9.84	0.82	1356.99	1092.05	6.3	-3.7	7.8
Nasdaq Stock Market										
Nasdaq Composite	18243.58	17768.59	18196.22	126.97	0.70	20173.89	15282.01	13.1	-5.8	12.4
Nasdaq-100	20253.22	19736.81	20201.37	148.74	0.74	22175.60	17037.65	12.1	-3.9	14.9
S&P										
500 Index	5783.01	5666.29	5770.20	31.68	0.55	6144.15	4967.23	12.6	-1.9	11.2
MidCap 400	2996.08	2919.79	2987.09	19.60	0.66	3390.26	2825.94	1.2	-4.3	5.9
SmallCap 600	1319.97	1288.68	1315.05	7.23	0.55	1544.66	1241.62	0.3	-6.6	1.2
Other Indexes										
Russell 2000	2084.40	2033.69	2075.48	8.93	0.43	2442.03	1942.96	-0.3	-6.9	2.1
NYSE Composite	19607.91	19291.71	19573.06	66.72	0.34	20272.04	17388.09	9.4	2.5	7.6
Value Line	589.03	576.63	587.70	4.50	0.77	656.04	568.94	-2.3	-3.8	-0.6
NYSE Arca Biotech	6079.56	5971.14	6024.34	18.46	0.31	6318.63	4861.76	13.1	4.9	7.7
NYSE Arca Pharma	1047.26	1035.83	1036.93	-6.16	-0.59	1140.17	912.71	1.4	11.0	9.8
KBW Bank	123.75	120.41	123.41	-0.64	-0.51	140.59	96.78	24.4	-3.2	1.0
PHLX§ Gold/Silver	164.85	159.11	161.59	0.97	0.60	175.74	116.83	37.7	17.8	0.8
PHLX§ Oil Service	65.96	63.97	65.33	2.07	3.27	95.25	63.26	-21.7	-10.0	-6.4
PHLX§ Semiconductor	4642.57	4455.76	4629.59	141.74	3.16	5904.54	4306.87	-6.6	-7.0	14.3
Cboe Volatility	26.56	23.09	23.37	-1.50	-6.03	38.57	11.86	58.5	34.7	-13.8

§Nasdaq PHLX

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

Trading Diary

Volume, Advancers, Decliners

	NYSE	NYSE Amer.
Total volume*	1,243,956,753	12,186,110
Adv. volume*	820,373,928	4,486,799
Decl. volume*	415,453,070	7,343,723
Issues traded	2,827	293
Advances	1,553	127
Declines	1,200	149
Unchanged	74	17
New highs	36	2
New lows	71	1
Closing Arms†	0.65	2.16
Block trades*	5,567	164

	Nasdaq	NYSE Arca
Total volume*	8,135,424,215	410,047,993
Adv. volume*	5,702,884,158	257,294,902
Decl. volume*	2,327,407,955	150,714,012
Issues traded	4,538	2,163
Advances	2,458	1,605
Declines	1,933	527
Unchanged	147	31
New highs	53	58
New lows	215	78
Closing Arms†	0.52	1.97
Block trades*	44,928	2,156

* Primary market NYSE, NYSE American NYSE Arca only.
†(TRIN) A comparison of the number of advancing and declining issues with the volume of shares rising and falling. An Arms of less than 1 indicates buying demand; above 1 indicates selling pressure.

International Stock Indexes

Region/Country	Index	Close	Latest Net chg	Latest % chg	YTD % chg
World	MSCI ACWI	852.10	1.72	0.20	1.3
	MSCI ACWI ex-USA	351.72	–1.32	–0.37	7.9
	MSCI World	3740.37	9.44	0.25	0.9
	MSCI Emerging Markets	1128.55	–2.71	–0.24	4.9
Americas	MSCI AC Americas	2171.23	10.95	0.51	–1.8
Canada	S&P/TSX Comp	24758.76	174.72	0.71	0.1
Latin Amer.	MSCI EM Latin America	2034.81	15.54	0.77	9.8
Brazil	Bovespa	125034.63	1677.08	1.36	4.0
Chile	S&P IPSA	3956.53	3.63	0.09	9.5
Mexico	S&P/BMV IPC	52839.63	23.20	0.04	6.7
EMEA	STOXX Europe 600	553.35	–2.55	–0.46	9.0
Eurozone	Euro STOXX	563.41	–5.11	–0.90	11.5
Belgium	Bel-20	4469.34	5.97	0.13	4.8
Denmark	OMX Copenhagen 20	2070.52	–32.84	–1.56	–1.5
France	CAC 40	8120.80	–76.87	–0.94	10.0
Germany	DAX	23008.94	–410.54	–1.75	15.6
Israel	Tel Aviv	2467.04	...	Closed	3.0
Italy	FTSE MIB	38592.81	–186.86	–0.48	12.9
Netherlands	AEX	911.34	0.62	0.07	3.7
Norway	Oslo Bors All-Share	1704.82	20.53	1.22	3.6
South Africa	FTSE/JSE All-Share	88570.16	310.08	0.35	5.3
Spain	IBEX 35	13257.10	22.90	0.17	14.3
Sweden	OMX Stockholm	1020.36	–0.95	–0.09	6.9
Switzerland	Swiss Market	13076.68	47.29	0.36	12.7
Turkey	BIST 100	10507.11	48.03	0.46	6.9
U.K.	FTSE 100	8679.88	–2.96	–0.03	6.2
U.K.	FTSE 250	20129.12	–29.95	–0.15	–2.4
Asia-Pacific	MSCI AC Asia Pacific	187.96	–1.72	–0.91	3.5
Australia	S&P/ASX 200	7948.20	–146.51	–1.81	–2.6
China	Shanghai Composite	3372.55	–8.55	–0.25	0.6
Hong Kong	Hang Seng	24231.30	–138.41	–0.57	20.8
India	BSE Sensex	74332.58	–7.51	–0.01	–4.9
Japan	NIKKEI 225	36887.17	–817.76	–2.17	–7.5
Singapore	Straits Times	3914.48	–2.58	–0.07	3.3
South Korea	KOSPI	2563.48	–12.68	–0.49	6.8
Taiwan	TAIEX	22576.07	–139.36	–0.61	–2.0
Thailand	SET	1202.03	12.48	1.05	–14.2

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

Percentage Gainers...

Company	Symbol	Latest Session Close	Net chg	% chg	52-Week High	Low	% chg
Dogwood Therapeutics	DWTX	6.60	2.17	48.98	29.28	1.62	-28.5
Willdan Group	WLDN	41.80	9.58	29.73	50.00	23.83	69.4
NetClass Technology Cl A	NTCL	10.27	2.06	25.09	10.76	4.59	...
Alpha Technology Cl A	ATGL	22.50	4.40	24.31	57.32	1.15	448.8
Visionary Holdings	GV	6.05	1.16	23.72	9.60	1.00	126.7
BioXcel Therapeutics	BTAI	3.37	0.63	22.99	52.80	1.72	-93.2
GEN Restaurant Group	GENK	6.25	1.16	22.79	14.46	5.00	3.0
LZ Technology Holdings	LZMH	12.04	2.22	22.54	14.56	4.40	...
Yoshiharu Global	YOSH	13.97	2.56	22.44	16.50	2.70	258.0
American Public Education	APEI	23.50	4.25	22.08	25.60	11.43	91.2
Junee	JUNE	5.00	0.90	21.95	5.97	2.75	...
Inflection Point II Cl A	IPXX	12.99	2.29	21.40	15.18	10.28	24.4
Ameresco	AMRC	11.09	1.80	19.38	39.68	9.04	-47.5
Gap Inc	GAP	23.15	3.67	18.84	30.75	18.54	10.7
Coffee Holding	JVA	9.57	1.47	18.15	9.93	1.15	625.0

Percentage Losers

Company	Symbol	Latest Session Close	Net chg	% chg	52-Week High	Low	% chg
Scienture Holdings	SCNX	1.58	-0.83	-34.44	44.56	1.51	-93.8
Avalon GloboCare	ALBT	7.23	-3.67	-33.67	21.60	2.11	25.2
ReTo Eco-Solutions	RETO	5.41	-2.09	-27.87	34.60	3.25	-73.9
ModivCare	MODV	2.75	-0.80	-22.54	33.64	2.70	-91.7
China SXT Pharm	SXTC	4.31	-1.23	-22.15	26.96	2.40	-72.9
Intuitive Machines Cl A	LUNR	8.77	-2.49	-22.11	24.95	3.15	60.3
CareCloud	CCLD	1.66	-0.45	-21.33	4.84	1.01	23.9
BigBear.ai	BBAI	3.34	-0.86	-20.48	10.36	1.17	30.0
HomesToLife	HTLM	3.89	-0.87	-18.28	13.74	2.57	...
Potbelly Corp.	PBPB	9.66	-2.15	-18.20	13.48	6.28	-24.8
National CineMedia	NCMI	5.22	-1.13	-17.80	7.60	3.71	33.2
Entravision Comms	EVC	1.73	-0.35	-16.83	2.73	1.33	16.1
Genesco	GCO	27.11	-5.29	-16.33	44.80	23.21	2.3
Gorilla Technology Group	GRRR	28.41	-5.50	-16.22	44.15	2.09	310.5
Samsara	IOT	35.36	-6.52	-15.57	61.90	27.14	-9.7

Most Active Stocks

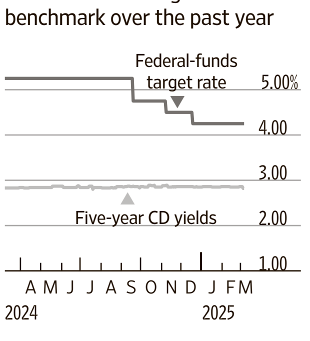
Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	% chg from 65-day avg	Latest Session Close	% chg	52-Week High	Low
Bit Origin	BTOG	616,073	7378.8	0.62	121.43	6.04	0.16
SUNation Energy	SUNE	479,365	29038.7	0.40	125.01	313.50	0.16
NVIDIA	NVDA	340,206	35.3	112.69	1.92	153.13	75.61
Ford Motor	F	150,335	100.6	9.90	3.02	14.85	9.06
Direxion TSLA Bull 2X	TSLL	142,011	84.9	10.66	-0.84	41.50	4.94

* Common stocks priced at $2 a share or more with an average volume over 65 trading days of at least 5,000 shares †Has traded fewer than 65 days

Consumer Rates and Returns to Investor

U.S. consumer rates

A consumer rate against its benchmark over the past year



Selected rates

5-year CDs

Bankrate.com avg†:	**2.82%**
Popular Direct	**4.15%**
Miami Lakes, FL	800-274-5696
Synchrony Bank	**4.15%**
Draper, UT	800-677-0718
Merrick Bank	**4.20%**
South Jordan, UT	866-638-6851
America First FCU	**4.25%**
Riverdale, UT	801-627-0900
KS StateBank	**4.30%**
Manhattan, KS	785-587-4000

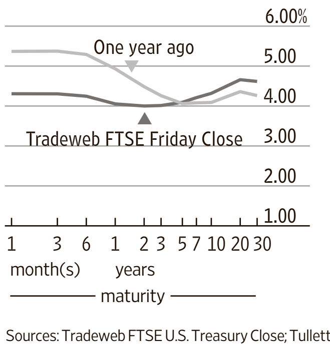
Interest rate	Yield/Rate (%) Last	Week ago	52-Week Range (%) Low	High	3-yr chg (pct pts)
Federal-funds rate target	4.25-4.50	4.25-4.50	4.25	5.50	4.25
Prime rate*	7.50	7.50	7.50	8.50	4.25
SOFR	4.35	4.36	4.27	5.40	4.30
Money market, annual yield	0.41	0.41	0.33	0.51	0.33
Five-year CD, annual yield	2.82	2.85	1.69	2.89	2.32
30-year mortgage, fixed†	7.08	7.05	6.69	7.72	2.96
15-year mortgage, fixed†	6.45	6.44	6.02	7.11	3.05
Jumbo mortgages, $806,500-plus†	7.17	7.11	6.78	7.79	3.05
Five-year adj mortgage (ARM)†	6.18	6.24	5.88	6.78	3.25
New-car loan, 48-month	7.73	7.45	7.18	7.94	4.15

Bankrate.com rates based on survey of over 4,800 online banks. *Base rate posted by 70% of the nation's largest banks.† Excludes closing costs.

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data; Bankrate.com

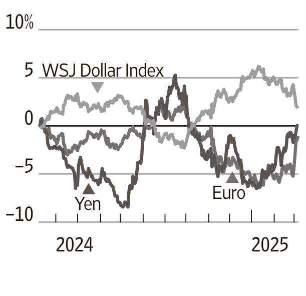
Treasury yield curve

Yield to maturity of current bills, notes and bonds



Forex Race

Yen, euro vs. dollar; dollar vs. major U.S. trading partners



Sources: Tradeweb FTSE U.S. Treasury Close; Tullett Prebon; Dow Jones Market Data

Corporate Borrowing Rates and Yields

Bond total return index	Close	Yield (%) Last	Week ago	52-Week High	Low	Total Return (%) 52-wk	3-yr
U.S. Treasury, Bloomberg	2238.520	4.210	4.140	4.880	3.630	3.371	–1.365
U.S. Treasury Long, Bloomberg	3149.880	4.670	4.530	5.050	3.990	–0.753	–9.163
Aggregate, Bloomberg	2136.010	4.670	4.580	5.310	4.100	4.078	–0.535
Fixed-Rate MBS, Bloomberg	2115.970	4.970	4.850	5.570	4.340	4.555	–0.487
High Yield 100, ICE BofA	3865.847	6.546	6.409	7.871	6.208	8.133	5.192
Muni Master, ICE BofA	598.205	3.407	3.319	3.760	3.074	1.687	0.892
EMBI Global, J.P. Morgan	921.028	7.349	7.291	8.073	7.084	7.804	3.839

Sources: J.P. Morgan; Bloomberg Fixed Income Indices; ICE Data Services

Currencies

U.S.-dollar foreign-exchange rates in late New York trading

Country/currency	Fri in US$	Fri per US$	US$ vs, YTD chg (%)
Americas			
Argentina peso	.0009	1064.8625	3.3
Brazil real	.1728	5.7875	-6.4
Canada dollar	.6957	1.4375	-0.1
Chile peso	.001076	929.57	-6.5
Colombia peso	.000242	4134.00	-6.2
Ecuador US dollar	1	1	unch
Mexico peso	.0493	20.2835	-2.6
Uruguay peso	.02358	42.4050	-2.9
Asia-Pacific			
Australia dollar	.6307	1.5855	-1.9
China yuan	.1382	7.2343	-0.9
Hong Kong dollar	.1287	7.7705	0.02
India rupee	.01147	87.149	1.8
Indonesia rupiah	.0000613	16300	0.2
Japan yen	.006755	148.03	-5.8
Kazakhstan tenge	.002038	490.75	-6.5
Macau pataca	.1249	8.0071	0.04
Malaysia ringgit	.2265	4.4145	-1.3
New Zealand dollar	.5709	1.7516	-2.0
Pakistan rupee	.00357	280.050	0.6
Philippines peso	.0174	57.402	-1.2
Singapore dollar	.7515	1.3307	-2.5
South Korea won	.0006908	1447.67	-2.1
Sri Lanka rupee	.0033829	295.60	0.8
Taiwan dollar	.03045	32.842	0.1
Thailand baht	.02966	33.720	-1.8
Vietnam dong	.00003921	25505	0.1
Europe			
Czech Rep. koruna	.04343	23.026	-5.4
Denmark krone	.1453	6.8845	-4.4
Euro area euro	1.0834	.9231	-4.4
Hungary forint	.002722	367.33	-7.6
Iceland krona	.007365	135.77	-2.3
Norway krone	.0921	10.8613	-4.6
Poland zloty	.2597	3.8506	-6.8
Sweden krona	.0991	10.0915	-8.8
Switzerland franc	1.1365	.8799	-3.0
Turkey lira	.0274	36.4911	3.2
Ukraine hryvnia	.0242	41.2500	-1.9
UK pound	1.2923	.7738	-3.2
Middle East/Africa			
Bahrain dinar	2.6529	.3769	-0.04
Egypt pound	.0197	50.6728	-0.3
Israel shekel	.2758	3.6260	-0.4
Kuwait dinar	3.2454	.3081	-0.1
Oman sul rial	2.5974	.3850	unch
Qatar rial	.2747	3.640	-0.1
Saudi Arabia riyal	.2666	3.7516	-0.1
South Africa rand	.0548	18.2520	-3.3

	Close	Net Chg	% Chg	YTD % Chg
WSJ Dollar Index	99.34	−0.13	−0.13	−3.32

Sources: Tullett Prebon, Dow Jones Market Data

Commodities

	Close	Friday Net chg	% Chg	52-Week High	Low	% Chg	YTD % chg
DJ Commodity	1058.00	3.16	0.30	1095.84	942.52	9.75	3.48
FTSE/CC CRB Index	303.04	1.97	0.65	316.63	265.48	9.56	2.13
Crude oil, $ per barrel	67.04	0.68	1.02	86.91	65.75	-14.06	-6.53
Natural gas, $/MMBtu	4.399	0.097	2.25	4.450	1.575	143.71	21.08
Gold, $ per troy oz.	2904.70	-11.90	-0.41	2947.90	2156.30	33.33	10.48

MARKET DATA

Futures Contracts

Metal & Petroleum Futures

	Open	Contract High	hi lo	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Copper-High (CMX)-25,000 lbs.; $ per lb.							
March	4.7920	4.7560		4.6570	**4.6830**	–0.0960	4,359
May	4.7755	4.7955		4.6805	**4.7100**	–0.0975	128,974
Gold (CMX)-100 troy oz.; $ per troy oz.							
March	2900.90	2927.30		2900.50	**2904.70**	–11.90	812
April	2919.20	2938.80		2905.30	**2914.10**	–12.50	329,381
May	2928.00	2949.10	▲	2924.30	**2928.20**	–12.40	304
June	2947.00	2967.40		2935.40	**2942.90**	–12.30	114,948
July	2964.00	2964.00	▲	2956.00	**2955.10**	–12.40	30
Aug	2967.10	2992.80		2961.60	**2968.30**	–12.50	26,268
Palladium (NYM) - 50 troy oz.; $ per troy oz.							
March	952.00	952.00		952.00	**945.80**	3.80	3
June	949.50	964.50		943.50	**955.50**	3.80	19,708
Platinum (NYM)-50 troy oz.; $ per troy oz.							
March	976.50	976.50		976.40	**961.60**	–13.20	221
April	979.80	987.20		964.50	**966.50**	–13.20	59,137
Silver (CMX)-5,000 troy oz.; $ per troy oz.							
March	32.930	32.930		32.405	**32.548**	–0.515	2,472
May	33.210	33.310		32.560	**32.809**	–0.529	117,329
Crude Oil, Light Sweet (NYM)-1,000 bbls.; $ per bbl.							
April	66.34	68.22		66.12	**67.04**	0.68	239,110
May	66.03	67.84		65.81	**66.75**	0.75	227,280
June	65.54	67.39		65.44	**66.36**	0.77	202,704
July	65.16	66.95		65.06	**65.90**	0.77	104,510
Sept	64.44	66.08		64.32	**65.16**	0.75	115,707
Dec	63.55	65.08		63.43	**64.22**	0.72	181,357
NY Harbor ULSD (NYM)-42,000 gal.; $ per gal.							
April	2.2132	2.2728		2.2028	**2.2160**	–.0078	96,134
June	2.1300	2.1905		2.1287	**2.1502**	.0109	62,134
Gasoline-NY RBOB (NYM)-42,000 gal.; $ per gal.							
April	2.0969	2.1505		2.0944	**2.1087**	.0075	105,379
May	2.1029	2.1573		2.1016	**2.1168**	.0088	99,608
Natural Gas (NYM)-10,000 MMBtu.; $ per MMBtu.							
April	4.286	4.426		4.132	**4.399**	.097	208,149
May	4.334	4.478		4.191	**4.454**	.096	232,640
June	4.649	4.784		4.523	**4.764**	.086	107,359
Sept	4.621	4.768		4.512	**4.750**	.096	97,965
Oct	4.648	4.798		4.542	**4.779**	.098	127,051
Jan'26	5.394	5.588	▲	5.326	**5.567**	.140	126,958

Agriculture Futures

	Open	Contract High	hi lo	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Corn (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
March	450.25	456.75		448.00	**455.25**	5.75	885
May	464.75	471.00		460.75	**469.25**	5.25	756,635
Oats (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
March	378.00	378.00	▲	378.00	**360.50**	–5.75	2
May	373.50	375.25		365.50	**371.50**	–5.75	2,626
Soybeans (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
March	1011.00	1015.00		1010.00	**1010.25**	–3.75	394
May	1027.25	1031.50		1021.00	**1025.00**	–2.25	382,968
Soybean Meal (CBT)-100 tons; $ per ton.							
March	296.80	297.60		295.40	**296.50**	–.60	563
May	304.80	306.40		301.90	**304.40**	–.50	257,985
Soybean Oil (CBT)-60,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
March	42.94	43.18		42.68	**42.87**	.27	445
May	43.23	43.88		42.77	**43.42**	.25	236,924
Rough Rice (CBT)-2,000 cwt.; $ per cwt.							
March	12.87	12.94		12.87	**13.25**	.36	177
May	13.17	13.53		12.98	**13.48**	.35	11,609
Wheat (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
March	534.50	535.00		532.75	**533.75**	–3.25	74
May	554.00	555.50		544.50	**551.25**	–2.75	234,859
Wheat (KC)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
March	546.25	550.00		546.25	**551.25**	–.25	41
May	566.00	567.75		556.25	**564.75**	–1.00	131,466
Cattle-Feeder (CME)-50,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
March	273.975	277.600		273.750	**276.975**	2.950	9,600
April	274.350	278.750		274.125	**278.150**	3.725	25,030
Cattle-Live (CME)-40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
April	196.500	200.950		196.400	**200.275**	4.000	130,125
June	192.800	196.875		192.725	**196.475**	3.850	93,484
Hogs-Lean (CME)-40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
April	86.650	87.500		86.375	**87.350**	.700	87,286
June	97.150	99.100		96.925	**98.100**	1.075	58,479
Lumber (CME)-27,500 bd. ft., $ per 1,000 bd. ft.							
March	640.50	645.50		626.00	**642.00**	10.00	749
May	645.50	668.50		644.00	**664.00**	14.00	5,290
Milk (CME)-200,000 lbs., cents per lb.							
March	18.38	18.38		18.26	**18.36**	.07	4,528
April	17.27	17.39		17.13	**17.20**	...	5,683
Cocoa (ICE-US)-10 metric tons; $ per ton.							
March	8,141	8,141		8,141	**8,141**	105	66
May	8,181	8,678		8,138	**8,292**	105	41,726
Coffee (ICE-US)-37,500 lbs.; cents per lb.							
March	390.20	390.20		390.20	**390.20**	–2.80	131
May	389.00	392.05		379.05	**384.40**	–2.75	78,728
Sugar-World (ICE-US)-112,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
May	18.28	18.45		18.22	**18.31**	.18	357,413
July	17.90	18.10		17.88	**17.99**	.19	193,795
Sugar-Domestic (ICE-US)-112,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
May	37.26	37.26		37.26	**37.26**	.80	1,063
Sept	36.76	36.76		36.76	**36.76**	...	1,819
Cotton (ICE-US)-50,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
March	64.76	64.76		64.76	**64.76**	.86	7
May	65.21	66.20		64.66	**66.07**	.86	141,701
Orange Juice (ICE-US)-15,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
March	310.00	310.00		310.00	**303.00**	14.00	128
May	289.50	299.35		289.50	**298.40**	6.75	7,566

Interest Rate Futures

	Open	Contract High	hi lo	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Ultra Treasury Bonds (CBT) - $100,000; pts 32nds of 100%							
March	123-110	124-000		122-050	**122-080**	–23.0	2,615
June	122-250	123-250		121-300	**122-020**	–23.0	1,757,409
Treasury Bonds (CBT)-$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%							
March	117-130	118-040		116-250	**116-290**	–14.0	91,428
June	117-040	117-300		116-160	**116-210**	–15.0	1,770,658
Treasury Notes (CBT)-$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%							
March	110-260	111-100		110-150	**110-175**	–7.5	6,028
June	110-265	111-115		110-150	**110-185**	–7.0	4,675,273
5 Yr. Treasury Notes (CBT)-$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%							
March	107-202	107-310		107-130	**107-155**	–4.7	38,005
June	107-262	108-060		107-180	**107-210**	–4.7	6,111,849
2 Yr. Treasury Notes (CBT)-$200,000; pts 32nds of 100%							
March	103-110	103-155		103-074	**103-081**	–2.2	1,535
June	103-172	103-216		103-134	**103-148**	–2.3	3,854,308
30 Day Federal Funds (CBT)-$5,000,000; 100 - daily avg.							
March	95.6750	95.6775	▼	95.6700	**95.6700**	–.0100	338,813
April	95.6950	95.7000	▼	95.6750	**95.6750**	–.0250	497,521
Three-Month SOFR (CME)-$1,000,000; 100 - daily avg.							
Dec	95.6300	95.6325	▼	95.6300	**95.6300**	–.0025	1,069,492
March'25	95.7250	95.7400		95.6975	**95.7050**	–.0250	1,317,245

Currency Futures

	Open	Contract High	hi lo	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Japanese Yen (CME)-¥12,500,000; $ per 100¥							
March	.6767	.6812	▲	.6754	**.6762**	–.0016	278,473
June	.6833	.6882	▲	.6824	**.6832**	–.0016	101,441
Canadian Dollar (CME)-CAD 100,000; $ per CAD							
March	.6999	.7006		.6934	**.6964**	–.0033	303,329
June	.7030	.7036		.6964	**.6994**	–.0032	37,063
British Pound (CME)-£62,500; $ per £							
March	1.2882	1.2944	▲	1.2877	**1.2920**	.0025	192,142
June	1.2882	1.2941	▲	1.2874	**1.2918**	.0026	40,076
Swiss Franc (CME)-CHF 125,000; $ per CHF							
March	1.1331	1.1417	▲	1.1328	**1.1375**	.0034	83,326
June	1.1449	1.1536	▲	1.1448	**1.1495**	.0035	11,267
Australian Dollar (CME)-AUD 100,000; $ per AUD							
March	.6334	.6339		.6283	**.6310**	–.0028	180,048
June	.6343	.6343		.6287	**.6314**	–.0028	25,077
Mexican Peso (CME)-MXN 500,000; $ per MXN							
March	.04926	.04938		.04913	**.04929**	...	142,584
June	.04867	.04878		.04854	**.04870**	...	4,347
Euro (CME)-€125,000; $ per €							
March	1.0794	1.0894	▲	1.0786	**1.0847**	.0040	601,400
June	1.0844	1.0947	▲	1.0839	**1.0901**	.0041	82,399

Index Futures

	Open	Contract High	hi lo	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Mini DJ Industrial Average (CBT)-$5 x index							
March	42651	42944		42208	**42838**	222	70,792
June	43009	43300		42565	**43196**	225	2,146
Mini S&P 500 (CME)-$50 x index							
March	5766.00	5791.00	▼	5673.00	**5776.00**	29.75	2,115,168
June	5821.00	5844.50	▼	5725.00	**5829.75**	30.50	61,849
Mini S&P Midcap 400 (CME)-$100 x index							
March	2971.70	2998.30	▼	2921.50	**2989.60**	19.90	42,323
June	2998.70	3021.40	▼	2947.00	**3013.00**	19.20	35
Mini Nasdaq 100 (CME)-$20 x index							
March	20214.50	20286.25	▼	19765.50	**20229.75**	140.50	273,526
June	20430.25	20501.75	▼	19980.50	**20445.25**	141.50	9,567
Mini Russell 2000 (CME)-$50 x index							
March	2073.30	2100.90	▼	2034.10	**2077.30**	6.90	454,862
June	2091.80	2117.40	▼	2052.00	**2095.00**	6.60	7,798
Sept	2095.00	2120.30	▼	2073.50	**2112.50**	5.70	19
Dec	2125.00	2132.00	▼	2125.00	**2134.70**	9.40	117
Mini Russell 1000 (CME)-$50 x index							
March	3145.60	3163.80	▼	3097.90	**3157.50**	16.80	6,304
U.S. Dollar Index (ICE-US)-$1,000 x index							
March	104.16	104.21	▼	103.43	**103.81**	–.22	37,530
June	103.77	103.88	▼	103.13	**103.50**	–.18	2,054

Source: FactSet

Exchange-Traded Portfolios | wsj.com/market-data/mutualfunds-etfs

Largest 100 exchange-traded funds. Preliminary close data as of 4:30 p.m. ET

Friday, March 7, 2025

ETF	Symbol	Closing Price	Chg (%)	YTD (%)
CommSvsSPDR	XLC	100.29	0.64	3.6
CnsmrDiscSel	XLY	205.67	–0.18	–8.3
DimenUSCoreEq2	DFAC	33.89	0.56	–2.0
EnSelSectorSPDR	XLE	87.43	1.71	2.1
FinSelSectorSPDR	XLF	49.12	–0.53	1.6
HealthCrSelSect	XLV	149.28	0.01	8.5
IndSelSectorSPDR	XLI	134.25	1.17	1.9
InvscNasd100	QQQM	202.50	0.72	–3.8
InvscQQQI	QQQ	491.79	0.74	–3.8
InvscS&P500EW	RSP	176.69	0.94	0.8
iShBitcoin	IBIT	49.43	–2.39	–6.8
iShCoreDivGrowth	DGRO	63.31	1.13	3.2
iShCoreMSCIEAFE	IEFA	78.16	1.01	11.2
iShCoreMSCIEM	IEMG	54.89	0.44	5.1
iShCoreMSCITotInt	IXUS	71.61	0.84	8.3
iShCoreS&P500	IVV	578.51	0.52	–1.7
iShCoreS&P MC	IJH	59.74	0.62	–4.1
iShCoreS&P SC	IJR	107.81	0.51	–6.4
iShCoreS&PTotUS	ITOT	125.75	0.54	–2.2
iShCoreS&PUSGrw	IUSG	132.34	0.33	–5.0
iShCoreS&PUSVal	IUSV	94.05	0.81	1.6
iShCoreTotUSDBd	IUSB	45.83	–0.07	1.4
iShCoreUSAggBd	AGG	98.35	–0.12	1.5
iShEdgeMSCIMinUSA	USMV	93.82	0.80	5.7
iShEdgeMSCIUSAQual	QUAL	176.83	0.35	–0.7
iShGoldTr	IAU	54.91	0.07	10.9
iShiBoxx$IGCpBd	LQD	108.32	–0.16	1.4
iShMBS	MBB	93.13	–0.08	1.6
iShMSCI EAFE	EFA	84.43	1.04	11.7
iShMSCIEAFEValue	EFV	60.00	1.37	14.4
iShNatlMuniBd	MUB	106.41	–0.05	–0.1

ETF	Symbol	Closing Price	Chg (%)	YTD (%)
iSh1-5YIGCpBd	IGSB	52.11	–0.04	0.8
iSh1-3YTreaBd	SHY	82.38	–0.01	0.5
iShRussMC	IWR	86.76	0.74	–1.9
iShRuss1000	IWB	315.98	0.53	–1.9
iShRuss1000Grw	IWF	378.85	0.43	–5.7
iShRuss1000Val	IWD	189.67	0.65	2.5
iShRuss2000	IWM	205.95	0.33	–6.8
iShS&P500Grw	IVW	96.55	0.34	–4.9
iShS&P500Value	IVE	194.14	0.80	1.7
iShSelectDiv	DVY	134.30	0.99	2.3
iSh7-10YTreaBd	IEF	94.39	–0.13	2.1
iShShortTreaBd	SHV	110.20	0.05	0.1
iSh20+YTreaBd	TLT	90.11	–0.32	3.2
iShUSTech	IYW	149.09	1.10	–6.5
iShUSTreasuryBd	GOVT	22.80	–0.13	–0.8
iSh0-3MTreaBd	SGOV	100.43	0.03	0.1
JPMNasdEqPrem	JEPQ	53.76	0.67	–4.6
JanusHendersonAAA	JAAA	50.66	0.06	–0.1
JPM EqPrem	JEPI	58.20	0.59	1.2
JPM UltShIncm	JPST	50.51	0.02	0.3
PacerUSCashCows	COWZ	56.23	1.76	–0.4
ProShUltPrQQQ	TQQQ	67.41	2.07	–14.8
SPDRBbg1-3MTB	BIL	91.51	0.04	0.1
SPDR DJIA Tr	DIA	428.26	0.55	0.6
SPDR Gold	GLD	268.39	0.05	10.8
SPDRPtfDevxUS	SPDW	37.50	1.00	9.9
SPDRS&P500Value	SPYV	52.03	0.81	1.7
SPDRPtfS&P500	SPLG	67.75	0.53	–1.7
SPDRS&P500Growth	SPYG	83.63	0.38	–4.9
SPDR S&P 500	SPY	575.92	0.56	–1.7
SchwabIntEquity	SCHF	20.38	0.94	10.2
SchwabUS BrdMkt	SCHB	22.18	0.45	–2.3
SchwabUS Div	SCHD	28.46	1.39	4.2

ETF	Symbol	Closing Price	Chg (%)	YTD (%)
SchwabUS LC	SCHX	22.74	0.53	–1.9
SchwabUS LC Grw	SCHG	26.17	0.31	–6.1
SPDR S&PMdCpTr	MDY	546.20	0.71	–4.1
SPDR S&P Div	SDY	138.67	1.63	5.0
TechSelectSector	XLK	218.54	1.45	–6.0
VanEckSemicon	SMH	225.09	2.42	–7.1
VangdSC Val	VBR	191.25	0.75	–3.5
VangdExtMkt	VXF	178.94	0.26	–5.8
VangdDivApp	VIG	199.59	0.93	1.9
VangdFTSEAWxUS	VEU	62.41	0.87	8.7
VangdFTSEDevMk	VEA	52.58	1.06	10.0
VangdFTSE EM	VWO	45.96	0.42	4.4
VangdGrowth	VUG	388.71	0.22	–5.3
VangdHiDiv	VYM	131.23	1.29	2.9
VangdInfoTech	VGT	575.87	1.23	–7.4
VangdIntermBd	BIV	75.97	–0.09	1.7
VangdIntrCorpBd	VCIT	81.33	–0.10	1.3
VangdIntermTrea	VGIT	58.88	–0.07	1.5
VangdLC	VV	264.89	0.51	–1.8
VangdMegaGrwth	MGK	323.81	0.13	–5.7
VangdMC	VO	262.87	0.74	–0.5
VangdMBS	VMBS	46.02	–0.13	1.5
VangdRealEst	VNQ	92.42	0.60	3.7
VangdRuss1000Grw	VONG	97.52	0.45	–5.6
VangdS&P500ETF	VOO	529.51	0.54	–1.7
VangdST Bond	BSV	77.85	–0.06	0.8
VangdSTCpBd	VCSH	78.58	–0.04	0.7
VangdShortTrea	VGSH	58.46	–0.02	0.5
VangdSC	VB	228.37	0.59	–5.0
VangdTaxExemptBd	VTEB	50.07	–0.04	–0.1
VangdTotalBd	BND	73.00	–0.11	1.5
VangdTotIntlBd	BNDX	48.49	...	–1.1
VangdTotIntlStk	VXUS	63.88	0.85	8.4
VangdTotalStk	VTI	283.34	0.47	–2.2
VangdTotWrldStk	VT	119.34	0.63	1.6
VangdValue	VTV	174.45	0.89	3.0

Borrowing Benchmarks | wsj.com/market-data/bonds/benchmarks

Money Rates

March 7, 2025

Key annual interest rates paid to borrow or lend money in U.S. and international markets. Rates below are a guide to general levels but don't always represent actual transactions.

Inflation

	Jan. Index level	Chg From (%) Dec. '24	Jan. '24
U.S. consumer price index			
All items	**317.671**	0.65	3.0
Core	**323.842**	0.57	3.3

International rates

	Latest	Week ago	—52-Week— High	Low
Prime rates				
U.S.	**7.50**	7.50	8.50	7.50
Canada	**5.20**	5.20	7.20	5.20
Japan	**1.625**	1.625	1.625	1.475
Policy Rates				
Euro zone	**2.90**	2.90	4.50	2.90
Switzerland	**1.00**	1.00	2.25	1.00
Britain	**4.50**	4.50	5.25	4.50
Australia	**4.10**	4.10	4.35	4.10
Overnight repurchase				
U.S.	**4.37**	4.38	5.45	4.00

U.S. government rates

	Latest	Week ago	—52-WEEK— High	Low
Discount				
	4.50	4.50	5.50	4.50
Federal funds				
Effective rate	**4.3300**	4.3300	5.3400	4.3300
High	**4.5500**	4.5500	5.6500	4.4700
Low	**4.3200**	4.3200	5.3300	4.3000
Bid	**4.3200**	4.3200	5.3300	4.3200
Offer	**4.3300**	4.3300	5.3600	4.3300
Treasury bill auction				
4 weeks	**4.230**	4.235	5.285	4.230
13 weeks	**4.210**	4.195	5.255	4.195
26 weeks	**4.135**	4.180	5.170	4.110

Other short-term rates

	Latest	Week ago	—52-Week— high	low
Call money				
	6.25	6.25	7.25	6.25
Commercial paper (AA financial)				
90 days	**4.27**	4.30	5.37	4.26
Secured Overnight Financing Rate				
	4.35	4.36	5.40	4.27

	Latest	Value Traded	—52-Week— High	Low
DTCC GCF Repo Index				
Treasury	**4.370**	37.500	5.471	4.286
MBS	**4.395**	70.494	5.526	4.294

Weekly survey

	Latest	Week ago	Year ago
Freddie Mac			
30-year fixed	**6.63**	6.76	6.88
15-year fixed	**5.79**	5.94	6.22

Notes on data:

U.S. prime rate is the base rate on corporate loans posted by at least 70% of the 10 largest U.S. banks, and is effective December 19, 2024. **Other prime rates** aren't directly comparable; lending practices vary widely by location; **Discount rate** is effective December 19, 2024. **Secured Overnight Financing Rate** is as of March 6, 2025. **DTCC GCF Repo Index** is Depository Trust & Clearing Corp.'s weighted average for overnight trades in applicable CUSIPs. Value traded is in billions of U.S. dollars. **Federal-funds rates** are Tullett Prebon rates as of 5:30 p.m. ET.

Sources: Federal Reserve; Bureau of Labor Statistics; DTCC; FactSet; Tullett Prebon Information, Ltd.

Dividend Changes

Company	Symbol	Yld %	Amount New/Old	Frq	Payable / Record
Increased					
American Tower REIT	AMT	3.1	1.70 /1.62	Q	Apr28 /Apr11
Great Elm 8.5% Nts 2029	GECCI	8.5	.5372 /.53125	Q	Dec31 /Dec15
MFA Financial	MFA	13.1	.36 /.35	Q	Apr30 /Mar31
Travel + Leisure	TNL	3.7	.56 /.50	Q	Mar31 /Mar17
Global Indemnity	GBLI	4.1	.35	Q	Mar28 /Mar21
JD.com ADR	JD	1.7	.76	A	Apr29 /Apr08
Marex Group	MRX	1.6	.14	Q	Mar31 /Mar17
Medtronic	MDT	3.0	.70	Q	Apr11 /Mar28
NXP Semiconductors	NXPI	1.8	1.014	Q	Apr09 /Mar19
South Bow	SOBO	8.4	.50	Q	Apr15 /Mar31
Torm	TRMD	33.7	.60	Q	Apr02 /Mar20
Vermilion Energy	VET	4.6	.0911	Q	Apr15 /Mar31
VersaBank	VBNK	0.7	.01743	Q	Apr30 /Apr04
WPP ADR	WPP	6.0	1.53842	SA	Jul07 /Jun06
Reduced					
Sunrise Realty Trust	SUNS	11.3	.30 /.42	Q	Apr15 /Mar31
Stocks					
Ohmyhome	OMH		1:10		/Mar10
PMGC Holdings	ELAB		1:7		/Mar10
Foreign					
Betterware de Mexico	BWMX	12.3	.3212	Q	Mar25 /Mar18
Canadian Natural Rscs	CNQ	5.5	.41172	Q	Apr04 /Mar21
GeoPark	GPRK	7.4	.147	Q	Mar31 /Mar19
Special					
Guild Holdings	GHLD	...	.50		Mar31 /Mar17

Note: Dividend yields as of 3:30 p.m. ET

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

KEY: A: annual; M: monthly; Q: quarterly; r: revised; SA: semiannual; S2:1: stock split and ratio; SO: spin-off.

Bonds | wsj.com/market-data/bonds/benchmarks

Global Government Bonds: Mapping Yields

Yields and spreads over or under U.S. Treasurys on benchmark two-year and 10-year government bonds in selected other countries; arrows indicate whether the yield rose(▲) or fell (▼) in the latest session

Coupon (%)	Country/ Maturity, in years	Yield (%) Latest(●)	Previous	Month ago	Year ago	Spread Under/Over U.S. Treasurys, in basis points Latest	Prev	Year ago
4.125	**U.S.** 2	**4.000** ▲	3.960	4.277	4.512			
4.625	10	**4.317** ▲	4.281	4.483	4.090			
4.750	**Australia** 2	**3.778** ▼	3.849	3.801	3.765	**-23.2**	-12.2	**-75.8**
3.500	10	**4.409** ▼	4.493	4.369	4.019	**8.8**	21.7	**-6.8**
0.000	**France** 2	**2.401** ▲	2.329	2.227	2.810	**-160.9**	-164.2	**-171.2**
3.000	10	**3.512** ▼	3.541	3.093	2.743	**-80.9**	-73.5	**-134.4**
2.200	**Germany** 2	**2.250** ▼	2.255	2.046	2.838	**-176.0**	-171.6	**-168.4**
2.500	10	**2.843** ▲	2.837	2.375	2.309	**-147.**	-143.9	**-177.8**
2.950	**Italy** 2	**2.496** ▼	2.540	2.375	3.351	**-151.**	-143.1	**-117.1**
3.650	10	**3.951** ▼	3.992	3.471	3.605	**-37.0**	-28.4	**-48.2**
0.800	**Japan** 2	**0.843** ▲	0.839	0.794	0.199	**-316.7**	-313.2	**-432.3**
1.200	10	**1.524** ▲	1.512	1.303	0.734	**-279.8**	-276.4	**-335.3**
2.500	**Spain** 2	**2.435** ▼	2.488	2.278	2.975	**-157.**	-148.3	**-154.7**
3.450	10	**3.443** ▼	3.499	3.014	3.111	**-87.8**	-77.7	**-97.6**
4.125	**U.K.** 2	**4.196** ▼	4.217	4.177	4.595	**18.6**	24.6	**7.3**
4.250	10	**4.603** ▼	4.622	4.481	4.087	**28.2**	34.6	**0.0**

Source: Tullett Prebon, Tradeweb FTSE U.S. Treasury Close

Corporate Debt

Prices of firms' bonds reflect factors including investors' economic, sectoral and company-specific expectations

Investment-grade spreads that tightened the most...

Issuer	Symbol	Coupon (%)	Yield (%)	Maturity	Spread*, in basis points Current	One-day change	Last week
Nordea Bank	...	4.375	**4.47**	Sept. 10, '29	**46**	–9	n.a.
Toyota Motor Credit	...	4.350	**4.33**	Oct. 8, '27	**33**	–8	24
Citigroup	C	4.450	**4.70**	Sept. 29, '27	**71**	–7	70
Dell	DELL	6.500	**5.81**	April 15, '38	**149**	–7	n.a.
International Business Machines	IBM	3.500	**4.73**	May 15, '29	**65**	–6	54
Caterpillar Financial Services	...	4.850	**4.48**	Feb. 27, '29	**47**	–4	43
Commonwealth Bank of Australia	...	1.875	**4.57**	Sept. 15, '31	**56**	–4	n.a.
Verizon Communications	VZ	4.125	**4.44**	March 16, '27	**45**	–4	43

...And spreads that widened the most

Issuer	Symbol	Coupon (%)	Yield (%)	Maturity	Current	One-day change	Last week
Corebridge Global Funding*	...	4.650	**4.57**	Aug. 20, '27	**64**	13	49
Intesa Sanpaolo	...	7.800	**6.48**	Nov. 28, '53	**191**	9	193
Brighthouse Financial Global Funding	...	5.650	**5.13**	June 10, '29	**113**	8	105
Toronto–Dominion Bank	TD	4.861	**4.56**	Jan. 31, '28	**62**	7	58
Procter & Gamble	PG	3.000	**4.48**	March 25, '30	**39**	6	n.a.
Wells Fargo	WFC	3.900	**5.67**	May 1, '45	**102**	6	95
Baker Hughes Holdings	...	5.125	**5.34**	Sept. 15, '40	**105**	5	107
BMW US Capital	...	4.600	**4.50**	Aug. 13, '27	**57**	4	n.a.

High-yield issues with the biggest price increases...

Issuer	Symbol	Coupon (%)	Yield (%)	Maturity	Bond Price as % of face value Current	One-day change	Last week
Walgreen	...	4.400	**5.47**	Sept. 15, '42	**88.000**	13.00	72.219
Transocean	RIG	6.800	**10.17**	March 15, '38	**76.000**	0.75	78.425
Hughes Satellite Systems	...	5.250	**10.38**	Aug. 1, '26	**93.500**	0.63	93.250
Teva Pharmaceutical Finance	...	6.150	**5.95**	Feb. 1, '36	**101.556**	0.31	101.527
Rakuten	...	9.750	**6.96**	April 15, '29	**109.775**	0.26	110.000
Rockies Express Pipeline	...	6.875	**7.04**	April 15, '40	**98.500**	0.25	98.613
Navient	NAVI	5.625	**7.41**	Aug. 1, '33	**88.959**	0.16	89.276
Occidental Petroleum	OXY	7.500	**5.51**	May 1, '31	**110.223**	0.05	110.777

...And with the biggest price decreases

Issuer	Symbol	Coupon (%)	Yield (%)	Maturity	Current	One-day change	Last week
Nissan Motor Acceptance	...	5.300	**5.52**	Sept. 13, '27	**99.500**	–0.38	100.246
Paramount Global*	PARA	6.875	**6.43**	April 30, '36	**103.522**	–0.36	104.649
Occidental Petroleum	OXY	7.875	**5.66**	Sept. 15, '31	**111.920**	–0.34	112.943
Teva Pharmaceutical Finance Netherlands III	...	4.100	**6.30**	Oct. 1, '46	**74.250**	–0.25	n.a.
Venture Global Calcasieu Pass	...	4.125	**5.87**	Aug. 15, '31	**90.750**	–0.25	91.140
Verde Purchaser	...	10.500	**7.89**	Nov. 30, '30	**108.250**	–0.25	109.250
DISH DBS	...	7.750	**17.97**	July 1, '26	**88.500**	–0.20	89.375
Bausch Health	...	11.000	**11.00**	Sept. 30, '28	**100.000**	–0.19	101.250

*Estimated spread over 2-year, 3-year, 5-year, 10-year or 30-year hot-run Treasury; 100 basis points=one percentage pt.; change in spread shown is for Z-spread.

Note: Data are for the most active issue of bonds with maturities of two years or more

Source: MarketAxess

New Highs and Lows

The following explanations apply to the New York Stock Exchange, NYSE Arca, NYSE American and Nasdaq Stock Market stocks that hit a new 52-week intraday high or low in the latest session. **% CHG**-Daily percentage change from the previous trading session.

Friday, March 7, 2025

Highs

Stock	Sym	52-Wk Hi/Lo	% Chg
AcresCmclRlty	ACR	21.25	1.8
AGNC InvPfdC	AGNCN	26.10	0.1
Agric&NatSolnsA	ANSC	10.61	0.1
AlamosGold	AGI	24.59	-0.5
Alibaba	BABA	145.36	0.5
AmerPubEduc	APEI	25.60	22.1
AspenInsPfd	AHLpF	26.21	0.4
AutoZone	AZO	3636.96	...
BEST	BEST	2.82	-0.7
BJ'sWholesale	BJ	116.00	2.8
BBVA	BBVA	14.28	2.1
BayviewAcqnA	BAYA	10.88	0.3
BlackHawkAcqn	BKHA	10.51	0.1
BlackSpadeII	BSII	10.35	...
BristolMyers	BMY	63.11	1.5
CelularityWt	CELUW	4583.60	264.7
CheckPoint	CHKP	230.65	3.0
CoffeeHolding	JVA	9.93	18.1
CollectiveMining	CNL	7.01	-1.0
CerveceriasUnid	CCU	15.10	1.1
DRDGOLD	DRD	13.51	4.6
DTCloudAcqn	DYCQ	10.67	...
DT CloudStar	DTSQ	10.23	0.3
DrugsMadeInAm	DMAA	10.00	0.1
DynavaxTechs	DVAX	14.63	0.4
DynexCapital	DX	14.47	2.5
EaglePointPfdA	EICA	24.32	-0.3
EmbotellAndinaB	AKO.B	21.80	0.4
EurekaAcqnA	EURK	10.27	0.2
FirstIndRlty	FR	58.17	-0.2
GigCapital7	GIGGU	10.20	0.5
GileadSciences	GILD	118.42	1.2
GoldFields	GFI	20.40	4.5
GoldResource	GORO	0.74	-12.9
ING Groep	ING	20.79	3.7
JackHenry	JKHY	193.02	4.2
Kroger	KR	67.57	4.6
LZ Technology	LZMH	14.56	22.5
McDonald's	MCD	323.17	3.5
MelarAcqnIA	MACI	10.25	0.4
MillicomIntl	TIGO	29.20	1.1
MoneyLionWt	ML.WS	0.25	1.2
NetClassTech	NTCL	10.76	25.1
Nokia	NOK	5.26	1.4
OaktreeAcqIIILife	OACC	10.12	0.4
Oil-Dri	ODC	48.00	2.5
Oncocyte	OCX	4.17	7.1
PB Bankshares	PBBK	17.75	-0.5
PalvellaTherap	PVLA	25.22	2.5
ParkHaBio	PHH	7.98	11.4
PhenixfinNts2028	PFXNZ	23.43	-0.2
PrestigeCnsHlth	PBH	89.65	2.2
RFAcqnII	RFAI	10.36	...
SagtecGlobal	SAGT	4.20	-10.0
SenecaFoods A	SENEA	90.07	3.6
StellarVCap	SVCCU	10.12	0.2
TG Therap	TGTX	38.58	9.2
TakedaPharm	TAK	15.22	1.1
TizianaLife	TLSA	1.91	12.7
VelocityFinl	VEL	20.98	8.5
Verizon	VZ	46.20	4.1
Visionary	GV	9.60	23.7
WeisMarkets	WMK	81.39	5.3
WheatonPrecMtls	WPM	71.81	0.4
XPeng	XPEV	23.89	6.2
Yum!Brands	YUM	163.30	2.1
ZaiLab	ZLAB	37.99	2.9

Lows

Stock	Sym	52-Wk Hi/Lo	% Chg
ACV Auctions	ACVA	13.02	-0.4
Abits	ABTS	0.25	-21.4
AcurxPharm	ACXP	0.45	-29.9
AdialPharm	ADIL	0.70	...
AdicetBio	ACET	0.79	-5.9
AdvanceAuto	AAP	33.08	5.2
AdvancedBiomed	ADVB	3.31	...
AdvantageSolns	ADV	2.04	-8.9
AehrTestSys	AEHR	8.35	0.2
AlgomaSteel	ASTL	6.37	-5.3
AlgomaSteelWt	ASTLW	0.52	-14.2
AmkorTech	AMKR	19.65	4.0
AptevoTherap	APVO	2.54	-5.2
ArbeRobotics	ARBE	1.15	-0.8
ArcturusTherap	ARCT	14.11	-8.9
AresMgmtPfdB	ARESpB	48.31	1.0
ArgoGroupNts42	ARGD	19.69	-0.6
Armlogi	BTOC	1.50	-4.2
AssemblyBiosci	ASMB	10.89	-2.7
AtlasClear	ATCH	1.27	-12.0
AureusGreenway	AGH	0.56	16.2
AytuBioPharma	AYTU	1.23	-2.3
BanzaiIntl	BNZI	1.14	1.7
BetaBionics	BBNX	15.85	-9.4
BeyondAir	XAIR	0.24	0.5
Big5SportingGds	BGFV	1.02	-2.3
BloomZ	BLMZ	0.22	-1.0
BoltBiotherap	BOLT	0.42	-3.1
BonNaturalLife	BON	0.82	5.4
BoundlessBio	BOLD	1.64	-0.6
BowmanConsult	BWMN	18.60	-2.0
BrilliA	BRIA	2.30	-1.0
BrookfldBRP7.25Nt	BEPJ	24.17	-0.2
CCC Intelligent	CCCS	8.99	-0.6
CDW	CDW	164.98	0.7
CaesarsEnt	CZR	26.92	-1.5
Caesarstone	CSTE	3.24	-2.7
Camtek	CAMT	65.52	1.4
CanopyGrowth	CGC	1.14	...
Cardlytics	CDLX	1.99	-10.7
Cato	CATO	2.74	-3.9
CheetahNetSupply	CTNT	1.55	-1.5
Chegg	CHGG	0.80	1.7
ChinaLiberalEduc	CLEU	2.42	-10.0
ChurchillDowns	CHDN	109.40	-1.1
CleanEnerFuels	CLNE	1.78	-1.9
Cohu	COHU	16.88	-4.6
CompassPfd	CODIpB	22.98	-0.4
CompassPfdC	CODIpC	22.78	-1.0
Cooper	COO	82.61	-6.6
CoreNaturalRscs	CNR	66.54	-3.8
CreativeGlblTech	CGTL	2.80	-2.4
CreativeRealities	CREX	1.70	-1.6
Cutera	CUTR	0.09	-15.8
CXApp	CXAI	0.97	-0.9
CXAppWt	CXAIW	0.06	-1.7
Cyngn	CYN	4.70	-14.2
DatavaultAI	DVLT	0.69	-3.1
Decent	DXST	0.86	-10.2
DeckersOutdoor	DECK	122.62	-3.9
DesktopMetal	DM	1.96	1.0
DestinationXL	DXLG	1.89	-1.0
DigitalBridge	DBRG	9.49	0.1
DonnelleyFin	DFIN	45.09	2.9
ECDAutoDesign	ECDA	0.57	5.9
ENDRA LifeSci	NDRA	3.45	-3.8
EagleMaterials	EXP	205.44	-3.3
EducDev	EDUC	1.29	-0.1
Eightco	OCTO	1.02	-27.0
EmeraldHldg	EEX	3.88	0.3
Endava	DAVA	22.30	1.5
Enviri	NVRI	5.78	3.2
EsperionTherap	ESPR	1.56	6.3
Etsy	ETSY	45.85	-0.3
Expion360	XPON	0.91	-3.1
FTAI Infra	FIP	4.86	-0.4
Fathom	FTHM	0.72	-7.7
FergusonEnts	FERG	163.01	0.7
FirstAdvantage	FA	12.90	-0.6
FirstGuarBcshs	FGBI	7.36	-0.5
5EAdvMatls	FEAM	3.04	-10.8
FloraGrowth	FLGC	0.62	-6.8
Fluor	FLR	35.10	-1.2
FordMotor6%Nts	FpC	21.61	-0.1
ForresterRes	FORR	10.06	1.6
Freshpet	FRPT	89.59	6.3
GameSquare	GAME	0.60	-2.7
Genfit	GNFT	3.11	7.7
Globant	GLOB	138.24	-0.2
GraphjetTech	GTI	0.11	-14.6
Greenlane	GNLN	0.51	-3.9
GryphonDig	GRYP	0.21	-1.9
Harte-Hanks	HHS	4.66	-1.2
HeidmarMaritime	HMR	1.45	-5.0
HepionPharm	HEPA	0.08	-1.0
HeritageDistilling	CASK	0.53	-16.3
HewlettPackardPfd	HPEpC	46.40	-8.9
HewlettPackard	HPE	14.93	-12.0
Hexcel	HXL	56.85	0.2
HiRollerTech	ROLR	3.17	-8.8
HK Pharma	HKPD	1.26	-6.6
Hydrofarm	HYFM	3.20	-1.7
IdealPower	IPWR	4.60	0.6
ImpactBioMed	IBO	0.83	-23.1
IncannexHealthcare	IXHL	0.82	-19.4
InfinityNatrlRscs	INR	14.83	2.4
IovanceBiotherap	IOVA	3.58	...
Iridex	IRIX	1.22	-0.8
J.Jill	JILL	20.81	...
JamfHolding	JAMF	13.11	-2.8
Kaixin	KXIN	0.96	-8.8
Karman	KRMN	27.76	2.2
KestraMedTech	KMTS	20.75	-3.9
KeyTronic	KTCC	2.61	-1.4
KingswayFin	KFS	7.21	-0.3
Kirkland's	KIRK	1.17	-3.3
KronosWorldwide	KRO	7.33	-8.1
KyvernaTherap	KYTX	2.50	...
LanzaTechGlobal	LNZA	0.64	0.8
LifezoneMetals	LZM	4.20	-1.1
LightwaveLogic	LWLG	1.08	5.4
LipellaPharm	LIPO	2.20	-10.2
LivaNova	LIVN	38.91	-2.1
LiveOakBcshs	LOB	28.56	-2.0
LiveVentures	LIVE	7.04	-5.1
LiveWire	LVWR	1.90	3.1
LotusTech	LOT	1.59	-8.2
Lovesac	LOVE	16.70	-3.8
LuckyStrike	LUCK	8.90	0.1
Lulu'sFashion	LVLU	0.53	-9.2
LuokungTech	LKCO	1.10	-17.6
MAC Copper	MTAL	9.52	-6.0
MGM Resorts	MGM	30.69	1.2
MKS Instrum	MKSI	80.36	2.9
MVB Financial	MVBF	17.29	0.5
MSG Ent	MSGE	31.22	-1.3
MaidenNts46	MHLA	14.37	...
MammothEnergy	TUSK	1.95	-8.4
ManhattanAssoc	MANH	166.31	1.0
MaravaiLifeSci	MRVI	2.63	10.9
MarineProducts	MPX	8.22	5.8
MartinMarietta	MLM	448.50	-3.3
Marygold	MGLD	0.93	0.5
MawsonInfr	MIGI	0.46	-5.5
MDxHealth	MDXH	1.49	-6.9
MegaMatrix	MPU	0.63	-0.5
MethodeElec	MEI	6.26	-6.2
Micropolis	MCRP	3.06	-11.3
MixedMartialArts	MMA	0.60	31.1
ModivCare	MODV	2.70	-22.5
Momentus	MNTS	1.88	-11.5
MongoDB	MDB	181.05	-2.8
Movado	MOV	17.83	-0.2
MullenAuto	MULN	1.35	-3.2
NayaBiosciences	NAYA	0.29	0.1
NerdWallet	NRDS	9.07	...
NetApp	NTAP	91.16	2.1
NeumoraTherap	NMRA	1.30	-2.0
Neuraxis	NRXS	1.99	4.3
NewGenIvf	NIVF	1.15	-16.8
NextTechnology	NXTT	0.45	-1.4
nVentElectric	NVT	52.78	-0.8
Offerpad	OPAD	1.64	0.6
OntoInnovation	ONTO	127.54	-1.1
OrionOffice	ONL	2.34	-8.1
PDF Solutions	PDFS	20.98	2.5
PMGC	ELAB	0.63	-0.4
PMV Pharm	PMVP	1.20	...
PebblebrookPfdF	PEBpF	18.25	0.5
PhathomPharm	PHAT	5.01	-14.2
Playtika	PLTK	4.87	5.3
PsyenceBiomed	PBM	0.87	2.2
PubMatic	PUBM	9.69	-2.3
PurpleInnovation	PRPL	0.70	0.9
QVCA	QVCGA	0.25	7.3
ReadyCapPfdC	RCpC	16.34	0.2
RenttheRunway	RENT	3.70	-5.5
RentokilInit	RTO	22.17	1.3
Repay	RPAY	5.82	-1.5
ReShapeLife	RSLS	0.85	-4.9
Ridgetech	RDGT	0.85	-11.7
RingEnergy	REI	1.08	-2.7
RobertHalf	RHI	53.53	-0.8
RxSight	RXST	24.79	-1.8
SAIHEAT	SAIH	0.45	-5.3
SPS Commerce	SPSC	125.95	-3.4
SagtecGlobal	SAGT	3.50	-10.0
Scienture	SCNX	1.51	-34.4
scPharm	SCPH	2.91	-6.1
Semrush	SEMR	9.73	-1.6
ServiceTitan	TTAN	86.13	-0.8
Shutterstock	SSTK	19.59	0.8
ShuttlePharm	SHPH	0.42	-11.9
Sigmatron	SGMA	1.23	-0.8
Silvaco	SVCO	4.56	-1.6
SiyataMobile	SYTA	2.23	-2.9
SkycorpSolar	PN	3.65	-0.5
SleepNumber	SNBR	6.91	1.1
Smith&Wesson	SWBI	9.17	-10.9
SoloBrands	DTC	0.67	-1.0
SonomaPharm	SNOA	1.90	-7.0
SproutSocial	SPT	24.00	-4.0
StardustPower	SDST	0.62	-1.3
SteakholderFds	STKH	1.20	-4.7
StevenMadden	SHOO	28.47	-1.8
StrataSkinSci	SSKN	2.51	-4.5
TEN Holdings	XHLD	0.57	-18.5
T.RowePrice	TROW	97.26	1.8
TandemDiabetes	TNDM	17.92	-4.1
Target	TGT	112.10	0.9
Teradata	TDC	22.62	0.3
TivicHealth	TIVC	3.40	-14.5
TradeDesk	TTD	63.82	-0.1
Traeger	COOK	1.82	0.9
TransCodeTherap	RNAZ	1.51	-7.1
Trex	TREX	54.70	-2.3
TritonIntlPfdF	TRTNpF	24.21	0.7
TriumphFinl	TFIN	61.02	-0.9
TrueCar	TRUE	2.09	-2.3
UraniumRoyalty	UROY	1.69	-2.3
Valuence I	VMCAU	11.37	-1.2
VentureGlobal	VG	8.62	1.4
VerraMobility	VRRM	20.60	-0.6
VinFastAutoWt	VFSWW	0.25	-11.0
VitalEnergy	VTLE	20.61	-0.1
Volato	SOAR	1.61	-2.2
Volcon	VLCN	0.66	0.5
VulcanMatls	VMC	218.71	-6.1
BerkleyDeb59	WRBpF	20.21	-1.1
WearableDevices	WLDS	0.65	2.7
WesternCopper	WRN	0.98	1.0
WillScot	WSC	27.58	-5.5
Wingstop	WING	209.61	4.2
XOMARoyalty	XOMA	20.77	0.6
YXT.COM	YXT	0.95	-24.8
YatraOnline	YTRA	0.85	-3.9
YouxinTechnologyA	YAAS	1.70	-8.0
ZW DataAction	CNET	1.40	-4.2

BIGGEST 1,000 STOCKS

How to Read the Stock Tables

The following explanations apply to NYSE, NYSE Arca, NYSE American and Nasdaq Stock Market listed securities. Prices are consolidated from trades reported by various market centers, including securities exchanges, Finra, electronic communications networks and other broker-dealers. The list comprises the 1,000 largest companies based on market capitalization.

Underlined quotations are those stocks with large changes in volume compared with the issue's average trading volume.

Boldfaced quotations highlight those issues whose price changed by 5% or more if their previous closing price was $2 or higher.

Footnotes:
i-New 52-week high; l-New 52-week low; dd-Indicates loss in the most recent four quarters.

Stock tables reflect composite regular trading as of 4 p.m. ET and changes in the official closing prices from 4 p.m. ET the previous day.

Friday, March 7, 2025

YTD % Chg	52-Week Hi	52-Week Lo	Stock	Sym	Yld %	PE	Last	Net Chg
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

A B C

D E F

G H I

J K L

M N

O P Q

R S

T U V

W X Y Z

Mutual Funds

Data provided by LSEG

Top 250 mutual-funds listings for Nasdaq-published share classes by net assets.

e-Ex-distribution. **f**-Previous day's quotation. **g**-Footnotes x and s apply. **j**-Footnotes e and s apply. **k**-Recalculated by LSEG, using updated data. **p**-Distribution costs apply, 12b-1. **r**-Redemption charge may apply. **s**-Stock split or dividend. **t**-Footnotes p and r apply. **v**-Footnotes x and e apply. **x**-Ex-dividend. **z**-Footnote x, e and s apply. **NA**-Not available due to incomplete price, performance or cost data. **NE**-Not released by LSEG; data under review. **NN**-Fund not tracked. **NS**-Fund didn't exist at start of period.

Friday, March 7, 2025

Fund	NAV	Net Chg	YTD % Ret
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

BUSINESS & FINANCE

ESPN Rewards Smith With $100 Million-Plus Contract

The commentator's five-year deal bucks trend of pay cuts across the industry

By Joe Flint And Isabella Simonetti

DAVID L. NEMEC/NBAE/GETTY IMAGES

Stephen A. Smith is a featured commentator and executive producer of ESPN's 'First Take.'

Many TV anchors are taking pay cuts these days. ESPN's Stephen A. Smith is getting a raise.

Smith, a featured commentator and executive producer of the sports network's morning sports talk show "First Take," signed a new five-year deal with the network, the company said Friday. It is valued at more than $100 million, according to a person familiar with the agreement, a sharp jump from his current $12 million-a-year deal.

Smith hasn't been shy about advocating for a substantial payday. "First Take" is among ESPN's highest-rated studio shows, and Smith has built a significant audience on social media thanks to a seemingly never-ending stream of hot takes on everything from the NBA to Donald Trump.

"I'm fully aware of what I'm worth, and I will never apologize to that for anybody," Smith said on "Who's Talking to Chris Wallace" last fall.

Smith's pay increase comes as big media outlets, including NBC and CBS, are trimming costs for talent and behind-the-scenes producers.

ESPN parent Disney recently cut nearly 6% of staff across its ABC News Group and Disney Entertainment Networks operations. ESPN itself has parted ways with on-air talent in recent years, including basketball anchor Jeff Van Gundy, analyst Jalen Rose and reporter Suzy Kolber.

Still, ESPN has invested heavily in personalities who reliably drive eyeballs and headlines. In 2023, the network signed a five-year deal valued at more than $85 million to license the show of YouTube star Pat McAfee.

News of Smith's new deal was previously reported by the Athletic.

While fewer people are tuning into cable TV these days, sports continue to draw a consistently large audience—as do shows about sports. So far this year, "First Take" averages a little over 500,000 viewers per episode, according to Nielsen. That makes it the most popular non-news program on cable in that hour.

"Fans are captivated by his deep sports knowledge, strong opinions and unmistakable flair," said ESPN Chairman Jimmy Pitaro. "Stephen A. works incredibly hard to elevate the sports conversation day-in and day-out and we are grateful he will remain at ESPN."

Deal negotiations went on for months, and were led by Pitaro and Smith's team at Endeavor and Envisionary. Last week, Smith accompanied Pitaro to a gathering of ABC advertising executives and partners, which Disney executives saw as a sign the deal was nearing, a person familiar with the event said.

With his bold social-media persona, Smith stands apart in his ability to draw audiences beyond sports fans. "The Stephen A. Smith Show" podcast has more than 1.1 million subscribers on YouTube, with people tuning in for his barbs—and then for the backlash to those barbs. He recently appeared on Bill Maher's HBO show "Real Time."

"He's polarizing, but people will still tune in," said B.J. Schecter, a sports journalist and executive director of the Center for Sports Media at Seton Hall University.

Former Spy Chief Is Convicted Over LVMH Dealings

By Nick Kostov

PARIS—France's former top intelligence official, Bernard Squarcini, was found guilty Friday of illegally taking advantage of his networks to serve private interests, including those of luxury giant **LVMH** and its chairman, Bernard Arnault.

The verdict caps a months-long courtroom drama that at times resembled a spy novel, with a Paris court convicting Squarcini of charges including influence peddling, breaching professional secrecy and the appropriation of a national defense secret.

Arnault and LVMH weren't on trial and weren't accused of any wrongdoing. The luxury group earlier reached a €10 million settlement, equivalent to $10.8 million, with the French state that excluded it from the case.

Nicknamed "The Shark," the 69-year-old Squarcini led France's domestic intelligence service from 2008 to 2012 before moving on to work as a security consultant for LVMH.

The trial laid bare Squarcini's clandestine network, which prosecutors alleged he used to gather intelligence on figures seen as threats to LVMH's interests, including high-profile journalists and luxury rival Hermès.

The proceedings detailed, for example, how Squarcini oversaw surveillance on François Ruffin—a journalist-turned-lawmaker—and his left-wing publication, Fakir. This covert operation aimed to thwart Ruffin's planned disruptions at LVMH shareholder meetings and undermine his satirical documentary targeting the group's practices.

The Paris court Friday handed Squarcini a four-year prison sentence, with two years suspended, which will be served under electronic monitoring. It also fined him €200,000 and barred him from working in the private intelligence sector for five years.

Squarcini had denied the charges and has already filed an appeal, according to his lawyer, Marie-Alix Canu-Bernard, who added that the court shouldn't have heard the case because it lacked the authority to access relevant classified information.

The case gained wider attention in November when Arnault himself was called to the witness stand. During his appearance, the billionaire stated that he was unaware of the illicit surveillance activities orchestrated by Squarcini. His testimony was marked by tension, particularly under scrutiny from Ruffin's legal team.

LVMH declined to comment.

Ruffin's lawyer, Benjamin Sarfati, expressed satisfaction with the court's decision, adding that it was important to hold powerful figures accountable, even if Arnault and LVMH weren't among the defendants. He also said France needs to introduce rules that would prevent public servants from immediately moving to work for private companies.

Canadian Retailer Hudson's Bay Nears Bankruptcy Filing

Hudson's Bay, the Canadian department store chain founded in 1670, is preparing for a bankruptcy filing within days, people familiar with the matter said.

By Alexander Gladstone, Soma Biswas and Jodi Xu Klein

The chain became a standalone business following its December 2024 deal to spin off its Saks Fifth Avenue subsidiary through a combination with Neiman Marcus Group. As part of that transaction, Saks acquired Neiman Marcus for $2.65 billion, establishing a new entity, Saks Global, which also owns Bergdorf Goodman.

Saks Global doesn't plan to file for bankruptcy, people familiar with the matter said.

A representative for Hudson's Bay declined to comment.

Hudson's Bay, based in Toronto, operates more than 80 stores and is one of the oldest companies in North America, tracing its roots to the fur trade during colonial times.

Its striped wool blanket, still sold today, is an emblem of Canada. The blankets were initially traded for beaver pelts in the 1700s.

Hudson's Bay has been owned since 2008 by NRDC Equity Partners, a private investment firm controlled by American retail and real-estate mogul Richard Baker, who has a record of scooping up retailers and profiting from their valuable real-estate holdings.

In 2013, Hudson's Bay acquired Saks Fifth Avenue, combining it with Lord & Taylor to create one of the largest retailers in North America. Baker's firm later sold Lord & Taylor to Le Tote, after which both Lord & Taylor and Le Tote filed for bankruptcy.

Retailers in Canada face pressure from inflation and high interest rates that have squeezed household budgets. Shoppers are cutting back on discretionary spending and trading down to discount chains.

Women's Soccer League Signs a Deal With 'Gen Z Whisperer' Alex Cooper

By Katie Deighton

The National Women's Soccer League has signed a season-long sponsorship deal with Alex Cooper's beverage brand Unwell Hydration, bringing the "Call Her Daddy" podcaster into the league's efforts to reach young women.

Cooper will appear at games and promote the league as part of the deal, which will cost Unwell Hydration just over $3 million, according to a person familiar with its terms. It is the first partnership for the brand since its introduction at the end of last year.

The NWSL also said it signed E.l.f. Cosmetics, also popular among young women, as a presenting partner of its annual Challenge Cup game for the next three seasons.

A wave of sponsorships is connecting women's sports to women's brands—marketers that historically sat out men's sports due to a lack of budget, relevant audiences or both. Every sports league is striving for younger consumers' TV viewership and ticket sales as social media and other entertainment options crowd the field.

AARON IDELSON/UNWELL

Alex Cooper will appear at games and promote the league.

"We in professional sports are all after the next generation of consumers, and I like to describe Alex as the Gen Z whisperer," said Jessica Berman, NWSL's commissioner.

The league needs to sell soccer to women who may not have grown up watching it on ESPN, or may have been too young to witness the glory days of the U.S. women's team. Much of the league's strategy involves promoting the stadium atmosphere as more welcoming to young female fans than male-dominated sports events can be, Berman said. The Unwell Hydration deal will lean on Cooper's ability to bring large groups of women to offline events.

The partnership will kick off at the 2025 NWSL Challenge Cup in Orlando on Friday with a $25 ticket-and-swag promotion welcoming new fans. The league and the brand are also forming a fan club called Unwell FC that will offer more ticket promotions and exclusive merchandise.

Many people in the media think young people "want to just sit on our phones and we don't want to go out," Cooper said. "But we do want to be a part of live events. We just have to feel included and incentivized."

Unwell Hydration's promotional strategy has leaned heavily on the social-media reach of Cooper, whose Unwell Network develops and distributes podcasts for a Gen Z audience and builds on the best-friend-reveals-all tone of her own show.

Unwell Hydration plans to grow sales by targeting athletes and women who exercise—or need hydration to ease a hangover, Cooper said. A December "Call Her Daddy" episode featuring Washington Spirit player Trinity Rodman demonstrated an appetite for pro-soccer interviews among listeners, according to Cooper, who added she played Division 1 soccer in college.

"This is an opportunity for me to, yet again, expand on what Unwell is," Cooper said.

CORPORATE WATCH

SALVATORE FERRAGAMO

Shares Tumble Following Earnings

Shares of Salvatore Ferragamo tumbled as the Italian luxury fashion firm continues to struggle with a brand revamp strategy.

The stock fell 15.9% in Milan Friday, bringing its losses over the past 12 months to 45%. Shares of others in the luxury sector slid Friday, too, with industry bellwether LVMH trading nearly 3% lower. Burberry and Cartier owner Richemont were down more than 5%, while shares of Gucci parent Kering and Brunello Cucinelli lost around 4% and Moncler slid 2%.

Late Thursday, Salvatore Ferragamo reported a net loss of €68.1 million, or $73.5 million, for last year, compared with net profit of €26.2 million in 2023.

It also confirmed preliminary figures released in January, with revenue of €1.035 billion, down 11% year over year.

JACOPO RAULE/GETTY IMAGES

The Italian luxury fashion company swung to a loss in 2024 as its revenue declined.

Salvatore Ferragamo didn't provide guidance figures for 2025, but said it remains cautious on its short-term expectations.

It noted that the luxury sector faced a difficult phase last year due to a slowdown in Asian markets, which was particularly acute in China, once a growth engine for high-end brands.

—Andrea Figueras

WAYFAIR

Furniture Retailer Cuts Tech Jobs

Wayfair is cutting 340 technology jobs following a five-year modernization effort by the online furnishings retailer. Wayfair said it is streamlining and refocusing its technology organization after the transformation, which included a comprehensive replatforming and migration to the cloud.

The Boston company said it expects to incur charges of $33 million to $38 million, primarily cash employee-related costs, with the bulk of the cash payments over the next 12 months.

Wayfair currently has about 13,500 employees, according to data from FactSet.

—Colin Kellaher

MDA SPACE

Aerospace Firm Forecasts Growth

MDA Space isn't worried about the threat of tariffs, thanks to customers that extend far beyond its borders and its limited dependence on U.S. suppliers.

Chief Executive Mike Greenley said 90% of the Canadian aerospace company's 4.39 billion Canadian dollar, or $3.07 billion, backlog is outside the U.S., and about one-quarter of its component suppliers lie south of the border.

MDA specializes in advanced space technology, manufacturing satellite systems and other equipment for use in space missions.

The company's backlog as of the end of the fourth quarter grew to C$4.39 billion, up from C$3.1 billion a year earlier. For the full year, MDA expects revenue to grow to a range of C$1.5 billion to C$1.65 billion, up from C$1.08 billion last year and topping analyst expectations of C$1.38 billion.

—Adriano Marchese

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Activist Mantle Ridge Builds Cognizant Stake

Investor doesn't plan to nominate directors at the tech-services firm

By Lauren Thomas And Ben Glickman

Activist investor Mantle Ridge has built a stake of more than $1 billion in **Cognizant Technology Solutions** and believes shares of the tech-services firm are undervalued, according to people familiar with the matter.

Mantle Ridge started buying up shares in the second half of 2022, when the stock was trading in the range of the high $50s to low $60s. Cognizant shares now trade at around $83 per share, giving the company a market value of more than $41 billion.

Mantle Ridge has been privately engaging with Cognizant about the company's progress on boosting its share price, the people said. Cognizant named a new CEO, Ravi Kumar, in January 2023.

The engagement reflects a new approach for the activist firm, which has so far elected to work behind the scenes at Cognizant. Mantle Ridge isn't planning to nominate board directors at this time, the people said.

However, Mantle Ridge still believes Cognizant shares are undervalued and that the market doesn't fully appreciate the progress that has been made, the people said. It believes the company has more room to grow and intends to remain closely engaged with management, they said.

Cognizant said in a statement that it has been constructively engaging with Mantle Ridge.

Since Kumar's appointment, it said it has improved performance and driven total shareholder return of approximately 40%.

Teaneck, N.J.-based Cognizant helps companies update their IT systems and outsource certain business functions. Its peer group includes Accenture, Infosys and Cap Gemini. Cognizant has grappled with stagnant growth in recent years.

Mantle Ridge expects Cognizant should be able to quickly meet the growth targets made as part of its full-year guidance released in February, the people familiar with the matter said.

Cognizant is expected to host an analyst day later this month to discuss its focus on capitalizing on businesses looking to implement artificial intelligence.

Unlike many other activist investors, Mantle Ridge typically focuses on only one or two positions at a time.

Earlier this year, the firm run by Paul Hilal secured three board seats and effectively ousted the chief executive of **Air Products and Chemicals** after a shareholder vote.


FROM LEFT: STEFAN WERMUTH/BLOOMBERG NEWS; ANDREW KELLY/REUTERS

Cognizant CEO Ravi Kumar, left, and Paul Hilal, founder and CEO of Mantle Ridge, right.

Canada Finalizes Tobacco Settlement, Ending Litigation

By Adriano Marchese And Michael Susin

Philip Morris's Canadian affiliate, Rothmans, Benson & Hedges, along with other major tobacco brands, will pay 32.5 billion Canadian dollars, equivalent to $22.73 billion, to settle all smoking-related lawsuits in Canada.

The Stamford, Conn., tobacco major said Friday that the allocation of the settlement amount between its unit and those of **British American Tobacco** and **Japan Tobacco** has been resolved. The massive sum will be paid over time, with some money coming from profit on traditional tobacco products.

For Philip Morris, the court in the Creditors Arrangement Act proceeding approved a plan of compromise and arrangement for Rothmans, Benson & Hedges that will allow it to retain C$750 million in accumulated cash.

The settlement, which will be funded through upfront payments and a share of future profits from traditional tobacco products, allows the affiliates to keep alternative nicotine products—such as e-cigarettes and heated tobacco—outside of the agreement.

In a separate statement, Lucky Strike maker British American Tobacco said the court approval would allow its Canadian subsidiary Imperial Tobacco Canada to emerge from its creditor protection under the Canadian Companies' Creditors Arrangement Act in effect since 2019.

The companies will pay $22.73 billion to settle smoking-related suits in Canada.

BAT has already made a £6.2 billion provision, equivalent to $7.99 billion, related to the proposed settlement in Canada, according to the company's latest earnings.

The FTSE 100 cigarette maker—which also houses the Kent and Dunhill brands—said the settlement would be funded by its subsidiary's funds and the profits generated from the future sale of tobacco products in Canada.

The sanction, however, won't impact BAT's current guidance for 2025, it added.

The long-running case began in 1998 and went to trial in 2012. A few years later, a Canadian court ordered the tobacco companies to pay billions of dollars in damages to Quebec smokers and former smokers.

More than one million people were represented in class-action suits against the tobacco companies claiming cigarette makers should be held responsible for selling a harmful product and obscuring the health effects of smoking.

Part of the settlement will also include a number of operating rules and restrictions on how the companies can run their traditional cigarette business until the settlement amount is paid off.

Mistral AI Plots a Way To Surpass DeepSeek

By Mauro Orru And Najat Kantouar

BARCELONA—French artificial-intelligence startup **Mistral AI** plans to release models that its chief executive said could outperform **DeepSeek**'s latest version, embracing open source as a cost-effective approach to develop increasingly powerful AI without spending billions of dollars.

Mistral AI and some other startups make their models available to the public. That open-source approach allows smaller companies to learn from each other and improve their models in the race against larger and better-funded rivals like ChatGPT maker **OpenAI**.

"We are going to release very strong models that are going to outperform DeepSeek pretty soon," Mistral AI co-founder and Chief Executive Officer Arthur Mensch said in an interview at the Mobile World Congress in Barcelona. Mensch said he saw DeepSeek as a contributor to the open-source realm rather than a competitor.

"The story with open source is that you have different companies that are building on top of one another," he said, pointing out that an AI startup can keep the throne as the best model provider only for a limited time before another company releases a better version.

Chinese AI company DeepSeek rattled markets in January after it developed a model that it said nearly matched American rivals despite using inferior chips, raising questions about the need to spend huge sums on advanced gear provided by **Nvidia** and other tech giants.

The U.S. has been leading the charge with big-ticket investments. Washington in January announced Stargate, an AI joint venture that aims to build data centers in the U.S. for OpenAI.

OpenAI, **SoftBank Group**, **Oracle** and MGX are the initial equity funders in Stargate, while **Arm**, **Microsoft** and **Nvidia** are technology partners. The companies are committing $100 billion initially but plan to invest up to $500 billion during the next four years.

Mensch said Paris-based Mistral AI has raised more than $1 billion so far.

NOTICE OF SALE

NOTICE OF PUBLIC AUCTION

Reference is hereby made to the Indenture, dated as of March 29, 2007 (as amended, modified or supplemented from time to time, the "**Indenture**"), among Alesco Preferred Funding XV, Ltd., as issuer (the "**Issuer**"), Alesco Preferred Funding XV, LLC, as co-issuer (the "**Co-Issuer**"), Alesco Preferred Funding XV (L2), Ltd., as Second Tier Issuer, and U.S. Bank Trust Company, National Association, as successor in interest to U.S. Bank National Association, as trustee (in such capacity, the "**Trustee**"). In accordance with the applicable provisions of the Indenture and the Uniform Commercial Code as in effect in the State of New York ("UCC"), the following assets will be sold (individually or on a portfolio basis) to the highest qualified bidder(s) at a Public Auction to be **held at 10:00 a.m. (prevailing Eastern time) on March 19, 2025** (the "Bid Deadline")*:

Lot #	CUSIP	Issue	Remaining Original Face
1.	65819VAC9	North Carolina Farm Bureau Mutual Insurance Company	12,500,000
2.	744589AA0	Public Service Mutual Ins.Co	10,000,000
3.	00829EAA6	Affinity Bank Capital Trust III	10,000,000
4.	99MSB3ZW1	Ariel Holdings Ltd.	13,300,000
5.	066533AA8	BankVest	10,000,000
6.	073708AA7	Beal Financial Master Trust Series A	1,600,000
7.	07371QAA6	Beal Statutory Trust X	9,250,000
8.	107023AA1	Bremer Financial Corporation	10,500,000
9.	U12280AA8	CAC Capital Trust I	3,000,000
10.	14916GAA6	Cathay III	13,500,000
11.	12613DAA3	CNB Capital Trust II	4,000,000
12.	20343XAA9	Community Bancorp	20,000,000
13.	99MSB5RJ4	Community Bancshares Capital Trust II	8,000,000
14.	12642GAA1	CTBI Preferred Capital Trust III	14,000,000
15.	98MSC9FQ4	Cypress Bank, FSB	1,570,000
16.	879ESCAC5	ESC Telecorp PCS	6,047,000
17.	879ESCAE1	ESC Telecorp PCS	13,953,000
18.	30247VAA9	FBOP Master Trust	5,000,000
19.	30247VAB7	FBOP Master Trust	15,000,000
20.	318458AA4	First Acceptance Statutory Trust I	1,600,000
21.	318491AA5	First American Bank Capital Trust II	5,000,000
22.	31850VAA5	First American Capital Trust III	9,000,000
23.	32009HAA4	First Defiance Statutory II	9,000,000
24.	99MSB3N61	First National Corporation	1,000,000
25.	32115GAA7	First National of Nebraska II	5,000,000
26.	393577AA9	GreenBank Capital Trust I	5,000,000
27.	99MSB3N87	Gulf State Bancorp	4,000,000
28.	42235LAA0	Heartland Capital Trust C	4,000,000
29.	404256AA7	HNB Capital Trust III	12,000,000
30.	45904WAA9	International Bancshares Capital Trust XI	14,000,000
31.	64944RAA3	New York Community Bancorp, Inc.	17,800,000
32.	81484WAA2	Security Pacific Capital Trust XI	10,000,000
33.	830820AA4	Sky Bank Financial Capital Trust IV	5,000,000
34.	U9113QAA2	United Security Assurance Cap Trust I	13,300,000
35.	937307AA4	Washington Banking Master Trust	4,000,000
36.	971896AA3	Wilshire Statutory Trust IV	8,900,000

Additional Information. All bids must be submitted by the above-noted Bid Deadline in accordance with the terms and conditions set forth in a bid package (the "**Bid Package**") relating to this Public Auction. In addition, please be advised that the sale of the above-noted assets (individually or on a portfolio basis) will be made only to the highest qualified bidder(s) and may be subject to a reserve level. For additional information regarding this Public Auction, and to obtain a Bid Package, please contact Dock Street Capital Management, LLC, 575B Riverside Avenue, Westport, CT 06880, Attn: David Crowle, Managing Partner, Telephone No. 212-457-8258, Facsimile No.: 212-457-8269, E-mail: dcrowle@dockstreetcap.com. The Public Auction will be a public disposition (within the meaning of Section 9-610 of the UCC).

Disclaimer. The Trustee is authorized at this Public Auction, if it deems it necessary or advisable or is required by applicable law: (a) to restrict the prospective bidders on, or purchasers of, any of the above-noted assets to be sold to those persons who (i) represent and warrant that they are a "qualified institutional buyer," as such term is defined in Rule 144A(a)(i) promulgated by the SEC under the Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "**Act**"), and a "qualified purchaser" for purposes of Section 3(c)(7) of the United States Investment Company Act of 1940, as amended; and (ii) agree that they will not resell such assets without compliance with the registration requirements of the Act and applicable state securities laws or pursuant to valid exemptions therefrom and (b) to impose such other limitations or conditions in connection with this Public Auction as the Trustee deems necessary or advisable in order to comply with the Act or any other applicable law, or requirements of the Indenture.

* All information contained herein is made to the best of the knowledge of the Trustee as of the close of business on March 6, 2025.

Indexes End Week Lower Amid Uncertainty

An ugly week on Wall Street ended with tumultuous trading Friday as major stock indexes seesawed before finishing slightly higher.

FRIDAY'S MARKETS

The S&P 500 index dropped 3.1% in the week ended March 7, its biggest one-week decline since Sept. 6.

The Nasdaq was down 3.45%, and the Dow was down 2.4% on the week.

Investors turned defensive out of concern about the Trump administration's unpredictable tariff policies and how they would impact economic growth.

That fueled sharp declines in technology and financial stocks, which had pushed indexes to record highs earlier this year.

"So much is happening from a news headline perspective," said Alex Coffey, a senior trading and derivatives strategist at Schwab. "There have been several moments in the past two weeks when we've had pretty sizable bounces in some megacap tech names but every single time they've been getting slammed back down."

U.S. stocks fell initially when the monthly jobs report showed hiring picked up a touch in February, with 151,000 jobs added, but slightly under expectations. The unemployment rate crept up to 4.1%, while it had been forecast to hold steady.

Indexes later rebounded to positive territory after Federal Reserve Chairman Jerome Powell delivered remarks about taking a "wait-and-see" approach to interest rates.

Indexes still finished the week significantly lower.

U.S. Treasury yields edged higher, with the 10-year yield moving up to 4.317%. The greenback also weakened, with the WSJ Dollar Index dropping to its lowest level since the days after President Trump's election in November.

McDonald's stock gained about 4.2% for the week.

The fast-food chain is viewed as a strong performer in times of contraction when budget-conscious consumers turn away from more expensive options.

Elsewhere:

- **The euro strengthened above $1.08.**
- **The European stock rally paused.**
- **Benchmarks retreated 0.9% in France and about 1.8% in Germany. Still, they managed to notch weekly gains, after a surge in European defense stocks.**

—Chelsey Dulaney and Matt Wirz

Blackstone Raises $8 Billion For Real-Estate Debt Fund

By Peter Grant

Blackstone closed this week on an $8 billion commercial real-estate debt fund, matching the record for this type of investment vehicle and offering another sign of a property-market rebound.

The firm, which is one of the world's largest commercial property owners, took about two years to raise the fund, which will be active in North America, Europe and Australia. Blackstone also raised the only other $8 billion real-estate debt fund, which closed in September 2020.

Debt funds are among the so-called nonbank lenders that formed after the global financial crisis because bank appetite for real-estate risk greatly declined. These funds have taken advantage of some large lenders continuing to be cautious on the sector and are helping fuel commercial real estate's budding recovery.

Still, raising money for any type of real-estate investment has been tough since interest rates soared in 2022. Commercial real estate is a highly leveraged business. So when debt costs more, property values tend to be worth less.

Total global real-estate fundraising by private-equity firms that invest in real estate was $10 billion in the fourth quarter of last year, a five-year low, according to data firm Preqin. Blackstone took longer to raise this fund than the one of the same size closed in 2020.

But the commercial real-estate sector is showing signs of recovery so far this year. Debt markets have improved with the issuance of commercial mortgage-backed securities up nearly threefold in 2024, compared with 2023. Sales activity has also picked up, giving the market more clarity on property values.

Blackstone's latest real-estate debt fund, which started investing in late 2023, makes property loans and buys existing loans. Often, the fund makes loans in partnership with banks, with the banks taking the more senior less-risky piece of the debt and Blackstone taking the riskier, higher-yield piece.

The firm has tailored the fund's strategy to take advantage of the problems facing numerous borrowers and lenders even as markets recover, said Tim Johnson, global head of Blackstone Real Estate Debt Strategies.

For example, the fund is buying loans from banks and insurance companies that want to reduce the size of their real-estate debt portfolios.

The fund also is getting involved in properties that have expiring loans that were made when interest rates were low. If the property is worth less, the existing lenders aren't willing to refinance the loan for the same amount.

"That's not a loan a bank wants to refinance dollar for dollar," Johnson said. "Someone has to step in and fill that gap."

JUTHARAT PINYODOONYACHET FOR WSJ

The move by Blackstone, a huge commercial property owner, is another sign of a property-market rebound.

Millennium Puts Up Unusual Loss for February

By Peter Rudegeair

About $900 million in losses spread across two teams at hedge fund Millennium Management contributed to the firm's worst monthly performance in over six years in February.

Millennium lost 1.3% last month, people familiar with the matter said. The losses, while modest in absolute terms and relative to other hedge funds, stand out in light of Millennium's long record of consistently positive returns and sharp risk management. The firm has only had one down year since Chief Executive Israel "Izzy" Englander founded it in 1989 and hadn't lost more than 1% in a given month since late 2018.

February was a choppy time in markets. Concerns over slowing economic growth and the impact of President Trump's tariffs and other policies added to volatility and helped erase prior gains.

A broad hedge-fund index compiled by research firm HFR declined 0.47% in February. Only about half of hedge funds that HFR tracks made money in the month, down from nearly 80% in January.

With about $75 billion in assets under management, Millennium divides money across more than 340 semiautonomous teams of investment professionals to produce returns that aren't correlated with broader markets. Each team has its own specialty, from trading tech stocks to betting on the convergence of bond prices.

The firm imposes strict limits on risk-taking. Teams' buying power can be cut in half once their losses reach 5%, The Wall Street Journal previously reported. When losses reach 7.5%, a portfolio manager likely is out of a job, though Millennium sometimes can make exceptions.

Millennium's trouble in February included some wrong-way bets on which stocks get added to and subtracted from market indexes. Portfolio managers Glen Scheinberg and Pratik Madhvani and their respective teams each lost hundreds of millions of dollars last month on these so-called index-rebalancing trades, people familiar with the matter said.

Banks Regain Ground From Private Credit Firms

By Jodi Xu Klein

Private credit firms are looking for new avenues of growth after years of rapid expansion as they lose ground to banks that are regaining market share in corporate lending.

Direct lenders have made strides in recent years snatching up market share in funding large corporations as banks retreated under tighter regulation. But since the second half of last year, banks have regained ground, outpacing direct lenders in lucrative mega loans.

In the first two months of 2025, banks increasingly replaced private debt with syndicated loans, reversing last year's trend, PitchBook LCD data show. **Morgan Stanley** last week marketed $3.9 billion in loans for software company **Kaseya** to refinance **Golub Capital**'s private debt and preferred equity—the largest such bank-led refinancing tracked by PitchBook since 2023.

The share of direct lending to private-equity-backed businesses dropped to roughly 24% of the total loan volumes in the first two months of 2025, from a peak of 68% in the fourth quarter of 2022, according to PitchBook LCD.

Banks' comeback adds to the already fierce competition among rapidly growing nonbank financiers. These lenders sit on nearly $2 trillion in capital globally, according to law firm Dechert. In response, private credit powerhouses like **Blackstone** and **Blue Owl Capital**, while still pursuing financings of more than $1 billion, are expanding into asset-based lending, specialty loans and core middle-market financing—intensifying competition in the market for smaller financings.

"Firms like Blackstone can be full capital solutions providers and go down-market or up-market," said Brad Marshall, global head of private credit at New York-based Blackstone, which manages $453 billion in its overall credit strategies.

"We prefer making larger loans for more mature businesses, but sometimes the better opportunity is the middle market," he said. "That's the space we can flex down to, providing a long runway for companies to help them grow into larger businesses."

The public market has reopened since late last year. Banks were able to unload $5.5 billion in debt backed by social-media company X at 97 cents on the dollar in February as demand roared back for loans. The banks, including Morgan Stanley and **Bank of America**, had been stuck with the debt financing Elon Musk's purchase of the company since 2022.

The upper end of the direct-lending market has grown less appealing for direct lenders because of dropping yields. Banks priced recent leveraged buyout loans—traditionally prime territory for private lenders—in the range of 7% to 7.5%. Private credit seeking double-digit returns is unlikely to compete.

Marc Lipschultz, co-chief executive at Blue Owl Capital, a $250 billion New York-based alternative asset manager, said banks' comeback brought down loan pricing for borrowers.

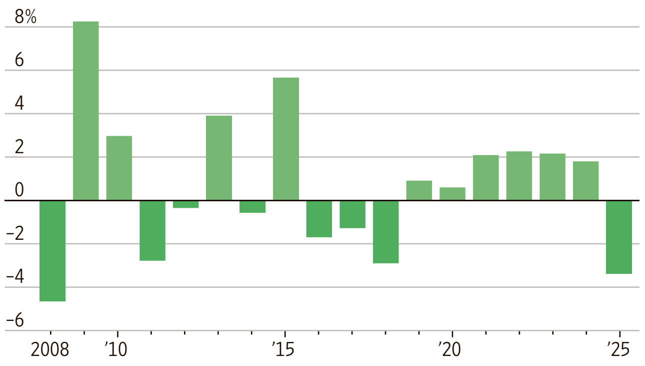
"But we are not competing on pricing," Lipschultz said. "Our borrowers pay a premium and agree to tighter covenants because they come to us for speed, for dedicated capital and for the collaboration they will get in difficult times."

The firm continues to focus on making large direct loans, solo or together with other investors, for companies with enterprise values of around $1 billion.

"Banks and private credit are going to exist in parallel," he said. "There are highly cyclical sectors we are just never going to be big in." Meanwhile, the firm is prioritizing asset-backed financing as a key growth strategy.

The Week When the Dollar Was Battered, In Numbers

WSJ Dollar Index, performance at the start of a year



Note: Shows percentage change in the index from Dec. 31 to March 7 of each year.
Source: Dow Jones Market Data

The U.S. dollar has been battered this week by major economic and foreign-policy shake-ups by the Trump administration.

The WSJ Dollar Index is having its worst week since November 2022. The index's weekly loss held at about 2.5% after Friday's slightly underwhelming jobs report. It also marked the worst start to the year since 2008. The index is down 3.4% so far in 2025.

Investors are questioning the "U.S. exceptionalism" narrative that has underpinned the recent rise of the dollar and U.S. stocks. President Trump's tariffs could dent U.S. growth and confidence, according to economists.

Meanwhile, the withdrawal of U.S. support for Ukraine, and broader concerns that the U.S. can no longer be counted on for protection, have lit a fire under European governments.

That should mean higher military spending, increased government borrowing and a jolt to the region's stagnating economy, which in turn point to higher interest rates and a stronger currency.

The euro is having its best week since March 2009. The currency has risen about 5% this week to nearly $1.09 as investors brace for an acceleration in defense outlays across the continent. Only weeks ago, investors were discussing a potential return to parity, or a 1:1 exchange rate, with the dollar.

Sweden's krona is the real standout. The dollar has fallen more than 6% against the krona this week. Sweden is home to a number of defense companies, and is expected to benefit from higher European military spending.

—Chelsey Dulaney

Tech Millionaire Pivots to Plant a Trillion Trees

By Perry Cleveland-Peck

For a tech millionaire, Yishan Wong, founder of the reforestation company Terraformation, is remarkably dismissive of his former industry.

"I've worked on a lot of large-scale tech and there's this subtle rule you learn: To solve a big problem, you want as little tech as possible," the former CEO of Reddit and director of engineering at Facebook said. When it comes to fixing the climate, he says, you want to keep it simple.

Wong, who started his career at PayPal (after flipping burgers at Burger King during high school), says he decided to do something about climate change in 2017 while sitting on a beach in Hawaii and realizing that it was "like, really, really hot—unusually hot." As befits a systematic engineer, he took a systematic approach to the problem and evaluated "all the climate change proposals that anyone had ever made" thinking there might be some technological solution. He concluded that in fact a high-tech approach would generate more problems than it solved.

"Silicon Valley is great at marketing, and they make it sound like new tech is awesome, but really no one hates technology more than a technologist because in the lab when it is half formed it breaks all the time. So you want a very low-tech, reliable solution," he said.

In the end, Wong settled on planting trees—on a global scale. "We have the lowest level of ignorance about it compared with every other mass-scale climate-change solution," he said. The only hurdle, he added, is there might not be enough land to do it at the scale he envisages.

In 2020, a global initiative to grow, restore and conserve a trillion trees around the world was presented at the World Economic Forum in a bid to restore biodiversity and help fight climate change. It was launched at the event in Davos, Switzerland, by **Salesforce** CEO Marc Benioff, a tech billionaire and environmentalist. Prominent backers included Donald Trump.

Trees absorb carbon dioxide from the air and release oxygen. A single mature tree will store about 22 kilograms of carbon a year, according to the European Environment Agency, about as much as is produced by burning half that weight in coal.

Terraformation has been variously described as a for-profit company whose goal is to help the world plant a trillion trees, a reforestation business that wants to see 3 billion acres of woodland restored, or a "seed-to-carbon accelerator" that serves as a conduit to channel cash and know-how into forestry projects.

The seed-to-carbon accelerator is Terraformation's bid to "catalyze a decentralized worldwide effort" to restore native biodiverse forests "because we as one company cannot and should not do it all," he said.

Wong says that a lot of people want to get into the mass-reforestation business, but most of them lack skills or resources. This is where his accelerator can help, he says. It might be providing basic business skills, or linking developers with native seed suppliers, or solving simple plant-nursery problems such as knowing about shading or how to keep pests out.

Last month, Terraformation marked its fifth anniversary as a company.

PATRICK KELLEY/TERRAFORMATION

Yishan Wong is drawn to trees as a way to fight climate change because he sees them as more reliable than tech.

HEARD ON THE STREET

FINANCIAL ANALYSIS & COMMENTARY

Property Insurance Looks Rosy

Recent results have been strong despite inflation and disasters

A Southern California home last month after it was destroyed in the Palisades Fire.

BRANDON BELL/GETTY IMAGES

Recent headlines about property and casualty insurance have been rough. Words including "crisis" have been used to describe the market, particularly in places like California.

But Warren Buffett recently used a different word to describe the improvement in his P&C insurance business at Geico in 2024: "spectacular."

Recently reported fourth-quarter results show that last year was overall a strong one for publicly traded national property-and-casualty insurers, particularly in personal insurance. These are the primary insurers that write policies for homeowners, drivers and businesses. And despite the devastating California wildfires that started the catastrophe season early this year, things appear set up for that good performance to continue.

Of course, insurance is sometimes a matter of luck. But last year was hardly placid: Global insured losses from natural disasters reached $145 billion, more than 50% above the 21st-century average, according to the brokerage and risk manager Aon.

Yet over the past couple of years, insurers have successfully asked state regulators for permission to raise rates to compensate for higher loss costs, and those increases are now flowing through results. The average annual property-insurance premium for single-family homes with mortgages was up a record $276 in 2024, or 14%, according to Intercontinental Exchange's ICE Mortgage Monitor. Motor-vehicle insurance costs were 12% higher in January than a year prior, according to the Labor Department's consumer-price index.

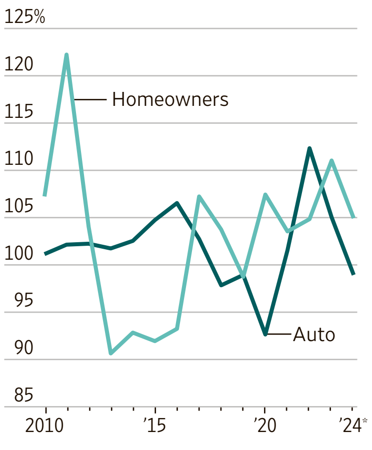
Higher premiums are making up for some difficult years for insurers in the postpandemic period. A leap in underwriting profitability for some insurers in 2020, when far fewer people were driving and getting into accidents, was then met with an inflationary surge in many claims costs, such as what it cost to repair or replace a car. That rapid change in fortune made it tough for insurers to respond quickly with price changes. But now, pricing has caught up with costs in many business lines.

Buffett's **Berkshire Hathaway** has long made collecting insurance premiums, including through Geico, a key part of how it funds its investments. Geico's pretax underwriting profit was $7.8 billion last year, up from $3.6 billion in 2023 and a loss in 2022.

This was the pattern for many insurers. Industrywide, the personal-auto combined ratio—a measure of what an insurer pays out in claims and related expenses, as a percentage of premiums—is estimated at 98.8% for 2024, according to data compiled by the Insurance Information Institute. That represents an improvement from about 105% in 2023, and north of 110% in 2022.

And investors are jumping on the bandwagon. So far in 2025, P&C insurers in the S&P 500 are up about 7%, compared with declines

Combined ratio for personal insurance by line, annually



*Estimate
Source: Insurance Information Institute

for banks and the broader index.

Of course, the past often isn't the best guide to insurers' success. As Buffett often notes, insurers don't actually know their cost of goods sold—that is, the claims they will eventually be forced to pay out—until months, years or in some cases decades later.

Still, as best as can be discerned right now, the forward outlook for many big insurers looks promising. For one, there is a lot of growth potential in a market with rising rates. Large national carriers might now be able to grab additional market share just by keeping their rates steady or with small decreases in key growth markets, even as smaller or regional rivals might have to keep raising prices.

This past week, **Progressive** said its net premium growth last year was equivalent to adding the premium of 2023's eighth-largest auto insurer. "We feel really good about our pricing, and we'll continue to watch it very closely," Progressive Chief Executive Tricia Griffith said on the company's earnings call. "When we believe we can grow more, or that we want to let out some of that in terms of rate decreases like we did in Florida, we'll do so."

There could be further cost increases for insurers coming from tariffs, which would drive up the price of imported auto parts, lumber and other key inputs to claims coverage. But if tariffs take time to begin to affect prices, that would give insurers some time to adjust pricing before the full brunt of their effects. "Most personal insurers are fairly sanguine about potentially higher claim costs stemming from tariffs," KBW analysts said in a recent note.

Higher costs for the insurance that insurers buy, called reinsurance, aren't slowing down primary insurers right now. In the past couple of years, some primary insurers shifted their reinsurance to cover mostly "tail risk" events. This means they can get protection from big losses such as the Los Angeles wildfires, for which insured losses are estimated in the tens of billions. But many insurers tried to keep their overall reinsurance costs in check by not buying as much protection for lesser losses. That could be a benefit if underwriting results are strong, since they won't be sharing that boost with reinsurers.

As always with insurers, there is a looming possibility of a series of major losses, or that the next disaster will be "the big one." But Fitch Ratings recently wrote that in general strong capital levels, prudent management of aggregate risk and use of the reinsurance market can help the P&C industry weather volatility in losses from natural disasters.

Eliminating bigger risks would only be possible by getting out of the insurance business altogether—and for both investors and for society, that isn't the ideal path. Pricing those risks more accurately is the art of insurance.

—Telis Demos

JUSTIN SULLIVAN/GETTY IMAGES

The chip maker is projecting $4.4 billion in AI revenue for the current quarter, 9% above Wall Street estimates.

AI Strength Buoys Broadcom

Broadcom's last earnings report made the chip maker a $1 trillion company. Its latest one should help it reclaim that mantle.

Broadcom helps tech giants like Google design their own processors for artificial-intelligence uses. So it benefits greatly from the many billions of dollars being poured into AI development by those companies.

But that also makes Broadcom a prime target of growing worries by investors about the sustainability of AI spending. These were stoked by new developments like China's DeepSeek and the potential for further restrictions on advanced chip sales to foreign markets like China.

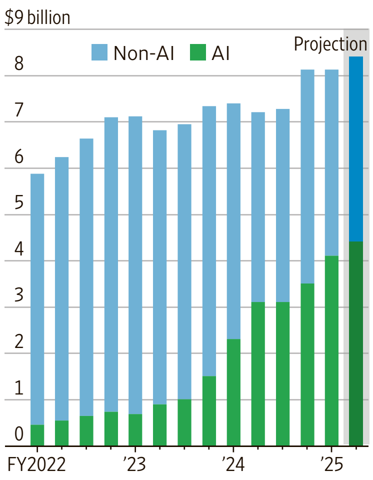
Broadcom has a lot of exposure to other segments of the chip market that aren't faring nearly as well, such as industrial components and radio-frequency chips that go in **Apple**'s iPhone.

Those worries, and the market's brutal downturn over the past couple of weeks, caused Broadcom to lose its $1 trillion crown. Its shares lost 22% over the past month ahead of the company's fiscal first quarter report late Thursday, far outpacing the S&P 500's 6% decline.

But the latest results should help Broadcom recover much of that lost ground—and its crown.

Broadcom said its AI business generated $4.1 billion in revenue in the quarter ended Feb. 2, up 78% from the same period last year. That easily topped the $3.75 billion analysts were expecting, according to consensus estimates by Visible Alpha. Broadcom also projected $4.4 billion in AI revenue for the current quarter, 9% above

Broadcom's chip revenue, quarterly



Note: Latest fiscal year ended Nov. 3
Source: Visible Alpha

Wall Street estimates.

Both were stronger beats than those shown by AI chip rival **Marvell Technology** in its quarterly report Wednesday.

Broadcom announced in its earnings call that it is working with four more "hyperscalers"—tech giants that operate massive data centers—on designs for AI accelerator chips. These could add to the three such customers Broadcom already serves.

The market certainly liked that news: Broadcom's shares jumped nearly 9% on Friday following the company's report.

More big tech customers would ease worries about the volatility of Broadcom's AI business, given the unpredictable swings in quarterly capital spending by tech giants like Google, **Amazon.com** and **Microsoft**. And Broadcom's AI business is getting large enough to offset the weaker areas, such as wireless, which is being impacted by Apple's less-impressive iPhone cycle this year.

Broadcom's AI business made up 50% of its total semiconductor revenue in the just-ended quarter versus 31% a year ago. If investors start warming to AI stocks again, Broadcom should bask in plenty of heat.

—Dan Gallagher

Gap Is Cool Again—And Profitable, Too

Celebrity collaborations, savvy marketing and belt tightening are all boosting results

Creative leadership looks good on **Gap**. It looks even better with a tight belt on.

The clothing company, which also owns Old Navy and Banana Republic, posted some impressive results late Thursday.

Its namesake brand's comparable sales rose 7% last quarter from a year earlier, much higher than expected and marking the fifth consecutive quarter of growth.

Old Navy's and Banana Republic's comparable sales rose 3% and 4%, respectively, also beating expectations by a wide margin.

Shares jumped 19% Friday.

On the earnings call, Chief Executive Richard Dickson said product newness and compelling marketing, particularly on social media, helped lift Gap sales. He said new customer visits rose 25% to Gap's website over the holidays, when it partnered with young TikTok music artists for a gift campaign. Old Navy's holiday campaign featured Jennifer Hudson.

Ever since the company hired Zac Posen as its creative director, the brand has been able to draw high-profile collaborations. Most recently, Gap outfitted Timothée Chalamet with a Bob Dylan-inspired outfit at an Academy Awards nominee dinner. The brand also launched a spring campaign with Parker Posey.

Importantly, while Gap is rebuilding its cultural cachet, it is also growing its cash pile, some of which is being returned to shareholders.

For the fiscal year, Gap spent $5.1 billion on operating expenses, $100 million below the prior year.

Operating margins have risen for eight consecutive quarters, helping Gap post net income growth of 11% last quarter, when Wall Street was expecting a decline.

The resulting free cash flow helped Gap's year-end cash balance swell 38% to $2.6 billion, the highest in 18 years.

Additionally, last quarter Gap made its first share buyback since 2022, and has about $400 million remaining under its repurchase authorization.

Gap thinks it can find another $150 million of cost savings for this fiscal year, which will include cuts across technology, marketing, overhead and store expenses.

Fashion can be fleeting, but financial discipline has lasting appeal.

—Jinjoo Lee

NINA WESTERVELT/BLOOMBERG NEWS

Old Navy's comparable sales rose 3% in the latest quarter, topping views.

STEM and Gender
Why are girls still less likely than boys to become scientists? **C3**

REVIEW

CULTURE | SCIENCE | POLITICS | HUMOR

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL. ★★★★ Saturday/Sunday, March 8 - 9, 2025 | **C1**

Forever in Your Debt
The complicated history of loans between allies
Books C7

Trump Is Overturning the World Order That America Built

As the president embraces Putin, longtime allies are starting to view the U.S. not just as unreliable but as a possible threat to their own security.

By Yaroslav Trofimov

LAURA SALAFIA

AMERICA'S 80-YEAR RUN as the world's strongest power, a relatively benevolent hegemon that attracted willing partners and allies, has been rooted in two major U.S. initiatives launched in response to the upheaval of World War II.

One was to convene the 1944 Bretton Woods conference, which enshrined the idea of free trade and low tariffs, generating unprecedented prosperity for the West. The other, five years later, was to lead the establishment of NATO, an alliance that won the Cold War and has ensured peace in Europe.

To fashion this system out of the chaos and rubble of world war, wrote Dean Acheson, a key adviser to Roosevelt and Truman throughout this period, required America to make "an imaginative effort unique in history and even greater than that made in the preceding period of fighting." Acheson, who first entered politics in the 1930s to combat "America First" isolationists, called his memoir "Present at the Creation."

Both of these legacies are being undone with stunning speed by President Trump. His second administration has targeted America's closest allies with punitive tariffs, has ordered an abrupt stop to military assistance for Ukraine, has frozen foreign aid—and is raising the prospect of a geopolitical realignment toward authoritarian Russia.

In Tuesday's address before Congress, Trump said that "we've been ripped off for decades by nearly every country on earth, and we will not let that happen any longer," adding that now "we reclaim our sovereignty."

His moves have sent the rest of the world scrambling for a response, a profound reshaping of the international order in which America's erstwhile allies are starting to view the U.S. as not just no longer reliable, but perhaps as an outright threat to their own security.

"The U.S. has switched sides from standing with democracies like Canada, like France, like Japan, and is now standing with dictators like Putin. People in free countries all around the world should be very concerned," said Canadian lawmaker Yvan Baker, echoing a view that is also rapidly becoming a European consensus.

Trump has already slapped Canada, with whom he had negotiated a free-trade agreement in his first administration, with 25% tariffs, though he soon paused most of them for the moment. He says he wants the country to stop being an independent nation and join the U.S. as the 51st state. "Trump questioning our sovereignty and trying to destroy our economy is right out of Putin's playbook," Baker said.

France's President Emmanuel Macron, in a dramatic address to the nation on Wednesday that asked for a major rearmament drive, said that Europe cannot permit its future to be decided by Washington and Moscow, and that it must now prepare for an America that is no longer by its side.

"We are entering a new era," Macron said. "Our generation will no longer benefit from the dividends of peace, and it depends on us whether our children tomorrow will be able to collect the dividends of our commitments."

Trump's moves have sent the rest of the world scrambling for a response.

There was a similar despondency among allies during Trump's first administration, but by the end of his term the NATO alliance had emerged stronger and Russia weaker, said Matthew Kroenig, senior director of the Scowcroft Center at the Atlantic Council in Washington who served at the time as a senior Pentagon adviser.

"People are overreacting to rhetoric and symbolism, and not paying enough attention to underlying results," he said. "If six to 18 months from now, our NATO allies are spending more and there is a ceasefire in Ukraine, I would argue that we'd be in a better place than today."

As the Trump administration moved this week to

Please turn to the next page

Inside

A New World Disorder

Top left: European leaders welcome Volodymyr Zelensky in London after his disastrous White House meeting, March 2. Top right: China's Xi and Russia's Putin at a summit meeting in 2024. Above: Ukrainians pay tribute to fallen soldiers at a military cemetery in Lviv, Feb. 23.

Continued from the prior page

cut off military aid and vital intelligence to Ukraine, the president threatened on Friday to impose more sanctions and tariffs on Russia if it doesn't come to the negotiating table. Russia's current trade with the U.S. is marginal.

In his first presidency, Trump openly questioned the value of alliances and free trade, while expressing admiration for authoritarian leaders and contempt for fellow democracies, particularly in Europe. But today, with virtually no opposition in Congress or within the administration, those impulses are pursued with unrestrained, and unmatched, vigor. There is also a new, much more destabilizing ingredient: predatory claims on foreign land, such as Canada, Greenland, the Panama Canal and even the Gaza Strip.

"In his first term, Trump believed that America was played for a sucker. His response was retrenchment," said Michael Fullilove, executive director of the Lowy Institute think tank in Australia. "In his second term, the same conviction is pushing him outwards. Now Trump wants more protection money and more territory—and he is prepared to use coercion to get those things."

Trump administration officials frequently refer to their policy in the Western Hemisphere as "Monroe Doctrine 2.0"—a new incarnation of the 19th-century claim to dominate the Americas.

While Trump says he seeks global peace with his radical shifts in America's generations-old consensus, the explosive combination of his neo-mercantilism and his embrace of 19th-century-like imperial thinking could actually push the world toward a new conflagration, warned Evelyn Farkas, executive director of the McCain Institute, who served as U.S. deputy assistant secretary of defense for Russia, Ukraine and Eurasia under President Obama.

"Both aspects of his foreign policy, the security component as well as the trade and economic component, hold a lot of danger, not just for the United States but for the world," she said. "We are seeing actions put into place that contain the kernels of a potential world war."

Trump's drastic shift is not rooted in American public opinion. A recent CBS-Yougov poll showed that 52% of Americans support Ukraine, versus just 4% supporting Russia. Most Americans, including 59% of Republicans, consider Russia to be either an unfriendly power or outright enemy, according to the survey. Another poll, by Reuters-Ipsos this month, found that 50% of Americans disapprove of Trump's foreign-policy moves, and only 37% approve, a 15% decline in net approval since January.

"The president has a mandate to try to stop the war, but not to pull the rug out from under Ukraine, switch sides, turn over Ukraine to Russia and adopt a spheres-of-influence posture in the world," Farkas said.

The U.S. has not always been a benign world power over the past eight decades, of course. It supported coups and repressive dictatorships in Latin America, Africa and Asia and invaded and occupied Iraq in 2003. But, for more than a century, it didn't attempt to permanently seize other nations' territory. And, in a global contest with authoritarian rivals, it stood as the champion of human rights and democratic values that have taken root around the world under American tutelage, particularly in the nations that it defeated in 1945.

Trump's trade wars, his humiliation of Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky, threats to Canada, Panama and Denmark, and the sidelining of European allies have eroded that legacy around the world, including in Asia. America's image in Asia has changed "from liberator to great disrupter to a landlord seeking rent," said defense minister Ng Eng Hen of Singapore, one of Washington's closest Asian partners.

The critical question these Asian allies are asking themselves is whether, after seeming to accept Russia's right to a sphere of influence in Europe, the Trump administration would also seek a similar accommodation over their heads to divvy up the world with China's Xi Jinping.

Trump's choice for undersecretary of defense for policy, Elbridge Colby, raised eyebrows by testifying during his recent confirmation hearings in the Senate that Taiwan, while being very important to the United States, is not an "existential interest." Trump has threatened to impose tariffs on Taiwan, too, as part of his economic moves against America's closest trading partners.

"China has always thought that America's greatest asymmetric advantage was its alliance system, and now that the U.S. is alienating its allies, China is delighted to see the tensions between the U.S., Europe and Canada," said Rush Doshi, a scholar at the Council on Foreign Relations and Georgetown University who served as deputy senior director for China and Taiwan in Biden's National Security Council. "And obviously, a U.S. that retreats into the Western Hemisphere is going to be outplayed by a China that goes truly global."

President Harry Truman, left, and Secretary of State Dean Acheson, 1949.

Amid this sea change in the world, China is already trying—not without success—to portray itself as a force for global stability, free trade and prosperity. China's special envoy for European affairs, Lu Shaye, said Wednesday it was appalling how Trump has treated Europe, and agreed with the European leaders that the future of Ukraine shouldn't be decided just by Washington and Moscow.

"European friends should reflect on this and compare the Trump administration's policies with those of the Chinese government," Lu said. "In doing so, they will see that China's diplomatic approach emphasizes peace, friendship, goodwill and win-win cooperation."

European governments—well aware that Russia has been able to endure three years of war largely thanks to Chinese economic and political support—aren't likely to take these overtures at face value. But in a new world where the U.S. is going from strategic ally to predator, some rebalancing appears inevitable.

European nations collectively are America's largest trading partner, and the largest source of foreign investment into the U.S. Until now, they have clung to hopes that the trans-Atlantic bond that endured eight decades would somehow survive.

Trump's open embrace of Russian positions over Ukraine in recent weeks has shattered that illusion. "We used to have wake-up calls, but in recent days we received an electroshock," said Wolfgang Ischinger, a former German ambassador to Washington and a former chairman of the Munich Security Conference. In a recent opinion poll by French broadcaster BFMTV, 73% of French respondents said they no longer considered the U.S. an ally—and 67% supported sending French troops to Ukraine to police a cease-fire.

Nowhere is the mood shift more abrupt than in eastern and central Europe, which has been for decades among the most pro-American parts of the world. While French strategic thinking, underpinned by a fully independent nuclear weapons force, is shaped by what Paris and London viewed as an American betrayal during the 1956 Suez crisis, countries such as Poland or the Czech Republic have long credited Ronald Reagan's America for their freedom.

Former Polish President and Nobel Peace Prize winner Lech Walesa, the founder of the Solidarity movement that challenged Communist control of Poland in 1980, put Trump and Vice President JD Vance in a very different category. The scene of Zelensky's humiliation in the Oval Office reminded him "of interrogations at the hands of the Security Service and the courtrooms of Communist tribunals," Walesa wrote in a letter signed by 39 fellow former dissidents, adding that Communist judges and prosecutors at the time "also used to tell us that they hold all the cards, while we have none."

'We used to have wake-up calls, but in recent days we received an electroshock.'

WOLFGANG ISCHINGER
German diplomat

Existential choices are looming in the immediate future for the 500 million Europeans, most of whom are not yet prepared for the costs—such as higher taxes and less social welfare—that would be required to rearm for the harsh new reality, said Rym Momtaz, a Paris-based analyst at the Carnegie Endowment.

"This presents the Europeans with a new, vital, multigenerational choice: What do they do? Are they capable of becoming the fourth pole, so that they are not subsumed into the spheres of influence of Russia, the U.S. or in some way China?" she wondered. "Or do they accept that they can't, and then there will be a division of Europe."

The 27-member European Union—which includes Hungary, a country hostile to Ukraine and aligned with Trump—won't be able to develop anytime soon into a meaningful security actor in its current shape, said Ischinger. The way forward, he suggested, is for some kind of new European Defense Union, with one European defense-industrial market, that would include a coalition of willing EU members plus the U.K. and Norway.

Retired Air Marshal Edward Stringer, a former head of operations at the British defense staff, said that some sort of "east Atlantic alliance"—possibly also including Canada—could replace NATO in coming years. "Europe has a fleeting opportunity to step up to the challenge posed directly and indirectly by Putin and Trump," he said. "Can it mobilize its latent power and take control of its security architecture—or will it become a vassal?"

Europe's biggest economy, Germany, is certainly taking dramatic steps. Incoming Chancellor Friedrich Merz is pushing next week a sea change in the country's security policy, with constitutional amendments that would adjust limits on public debt and allow Berlin to spend hundreds of billions of euros on military procurement. Some two-thirds of European military spending went until now to American defense companies, a crucial connective tissue in the alliance.

But Trump's sudden cutoff of military aid to Ukraine—a country that, European leaders say, is engaged in a war that is existential to Europe's own security—is likely to prompt European nations to prioritize in the future weapons systems that could not be restricted or disabled by Washington.

"We've always followed the principle of hoping for the best, but now we are finally getting around to preparing for the worst—the U.S. becoming an openly hostile power aligned with Russia," said Thorsten Benner, director of the Global Public Policy Institute in Berlin. "Is it too late? We'll see, but it is certainly late in the game."

While the fraying of alliances between the U.S. and fellow democracies certainly favors China, the biggest winner at the end could be Europe, said retired U.S. Navy Adm. James Stavridis, who served as NATO's supreme allied commander. "Events in which the United States disengages could cause Europe to come together with will and unity, and make it a far more important force in international relations," he said.

In his memoir, Dean Acheson noted the rapid collapse of world powers and the sudden disappearance of ancient empires. One of the great architects of the post-World War II order, he lamented the dangerous belief that in international affairs, "as in women's fashions and automobile design, novelty and change are essential to validity and value."

Acheson argued for the opposite: "The simple truth is that perseverance in good policies is the only avenue to success."

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: CHRISTOPHE ENA/PRESS POOL; RAMIL SITDIKOV/BRICS/ASSOCIATED PRESS; YURIY DYACHYSHYN/AFP/GETTY IMAGES; BETTMANN ARCHIVE/GETTY IMAGES

Why Are Girls Less Likely to Become Scientists?

Closing the gender gap in STEM jobs has proved difficult, perhaps because it has more to do with the priorities of men and women than with sexism.

Gender inequity fails to explain why women make up over 40% of STEM graduates in Algeria and only 20% in Finland. Students in Algiers in 2023.

AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

By William von Hippel

Despite years of programs to get girls to code and to pair female scientists with mentors, men outnumber women two-to-one in STEM—science, technology, engineering and math—jobs. The gender gaps are especially wide in some of the fastest-growing and best-paying fields, such as computer science and engineering.

Advocates for closing these gaps argue that women are victims of structural inequities, such as biased hiring practices and unequal parenting demands. They are not wrong, and their effort to encourage girls to pursue STEM and to retain women in these fields makes sense. But I'm not sure they will yield the desired effects.

Sexism is surely a problem, but it may not be the main problem. There's growing evidence that girls and women aren't pursuing STEM careers because they'd simply prefer not to. That is, that sex differences in the STEM workforce may largely be a product of sex differences in interests and priorities.

This is a controversial claim, but there's abundant research to support it. First, if discrimination were preventing women from entering STEM fields, then women in countries with less gender equity, such as in the Middle East and South Asia, would surely be less likely to pursue STEM careers than women in countries with greater gender equity, such as in Scandinavia. After all, there must be more barriers for women who want to be scientists in Algeria than in Finland. In fact, we see the opposite: Women make up over 40% of the STEM graduates in Algeria and only 20% in Finland. This pattern can be seen around the world.

The likely story here is that gender equity matters less than money. Countries with less gender equity tend to be poor, and careers in STEM are one of the clearest routes to financial success anywhere. Women with strong quantitative skills in poor countries have good reason to enter the sciences to make a living. Women in relatively rich countries can afford to pursue less lucrative careers without risking a life of poverty.

Now let's consider the ratios of men to women in different STEM disciplines in the U.S., which have been carefully documented for over 50 years. Even as women have entered these fields in droves and have outnumbered male Ph.D.s in general for over 15 years, the relative ranking of STEM disciplines—from most to least male-dominated—has remained largely unchanged since the 1970s.

Engineering, for example, has always led the list as the most male-dominated discipline in the U.S., as measured in Ph.D.s, followed by math and computer science. Meanwhile, social sciences and life sciences have always had the greatest share of female Ph.D.s. These trends have held steady even as the share of female Ph.D.s in these disciplines has tripled and quadrupled.

Why are women consistently more likely to become sociologists than chemical engineers? Some suggest that women simply prefer fields with more women, but this explanation doesn't seem sufficient. Male Ph.D.s in psychology outnumbered women three to one in 1970, yet women still entered the discipline en masse, and now earn around 75% of all psychology Ph.D.s, according to the National Science Foundation.

> Men and women tend to avoid STEM jobs if they can pursue something else.

A better explanation for lasting sex differences in various disciplines, I believe, is that they reflect the inherent attractiveness of different fields to men and women.

Scores of surveys over the last 50 years show that women tend to be more interested in careers that involve working with other people while men prefer jobs that involve manipulating objects, whether it is a hammer or a computer. These leanings can be seen in the lab, too. Studies published in the Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin in 2016, for example, found that women were more responsive to pictures of people, while men were more responsive to pictures of things.

Consistent with what men and women say they want, the STEM fields with more men, such as engineering and computer science, focus on objects while those with more women, such as psychology and biomedicine, focus on people.

Given the push to get more people—and especially more girls—interested in STEM, it is worth noting that talented students of both sexes tend to avoid a career in math or science if they can pursue something else. STEM jobs aren't for everyone, regardless of how lucrative they may be.

A study of more than 70,000 high-school students in Greece, published in the Journal of Human Resources in 2024, found that girls on average outperformed boys in both STEM and non-STEM subjects but rarely pursued STEM in college if they were just as strong in other things. A study of middle-aged adults who had been precocious in math as teens, published in the journal Psychological Science in 2014, found that only around a quarter of the men were working in STEM and IT.

Large-scale studies around the world show that women are generally more likely than men to have skills in non-STEM areas, while men who are strong in math and science are often less skilled elsewhere. But while everyone seems to be concerned about whether girls are performing well in STEM classes, no one seems all that troubled by the fact that boys are consistently underperforming in reading and writing.

Consider the scores in reading, math and science among high-school students in 80 different countries from Albania to Vietnam, all of whom take the same test in their own language. In every country, female students outperform male students in verbal tasks. The STEM data are bouncier, with girls sometimes outperforming boys and sometimes not.

It is likely, then, that girls who are strong in STEM subjects have more options for what careers to pursue, given their strengths elsewhere.

But this still raises a big question: Why do girls outperform boys verbally in every country? The answer is a complicated mix of neuroscience, biology and life experiences, but it largely boils down to an essential evolutionary difference, which is that females tend to be more socially connected than males, and connection demands strong verbal skills.

The reason for the primacy of social connections among females can be explained largely by child care. Because women have long borne the brunt of reproduction, they have historically needed lots of help raising their children. Men have traditionally helped indirectly, as providers of food and protection, so women who want their kids to reach adulthood had good reason to forge bonds with other women while the men were out hunting.

Connection necessitates caring and communication. We tend to focus on women's under-representation in STEM, but they are also over-represented in careers that emphasize care and communication, such as nursing and teaching.

It is not a coincidence that these jobs typically pay poorly, as we tend to devalue what some call "women's work." The clearest evidence of this comes from an analysis of occupational pay levels from 1950 to 2000, published in the journal Social Forces in 2009, which found that when the share of women in a career grew, those jobs began to pay less.

Market forces have failed to correct this devaluation of care work, but this may change. AI may soon outperform most humans at most STEM tasks, but it looks less likely to replace jobs that require a caring human touch.

Efforts to remove the barriers that may prevent girls and women from pursuing STEM are certainly worthy, but prejudice and discrimination clearly don't tell the whole story. Perhaps the answer is to offer both coding camps for girls and caring camps for boys, and more generally to make sure that so-called "women's work" pays better.

William von Hippel is a social scientist in Australia. This essay is adapted from his new book, "The Social Paradox: Autonomy, Connection, and Why We Need Both to Find Happiness," published by Harper (which, like The Wall Street Journal, is owned by News Corp).

SCIENCE SHORT

A Pharaoh's Tomb in Luxor Is Unearthed, First in a Century

Some mysteries remain: The tomb was empty, and the fate of the mummy is in dispute.

By Aylin Woodward

A mummy labeled as Thutmose II in an Egyptian museum.

The entrance of the newly discovered tomb, found empty.

FROM LEFT: B.O'KANE/ALAMY; EGYPTIAN MINISTRY OF ANTIQUITIES/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

FOR THE FIRST time in more than a century, since Howard Carter unearthed the final resting place of King Tut, Egyptologists have uncovered a decorated royal tomb in Luxor.

Pieces of pottery and other evidence in the sprawling tomb revealed that it belonged to Thutmose II, a young pharaoh who died more than three millennia ago. It is the last missing tomb of known descendants of Egypt's 18th Dynasty, a time when the empire's imperialist interests flourished. Its location established that Egyptians began burying their royals in the famed Valley of the Kings only after Thutmose II's death.

Archaeologists who found the tomb are convinced that it belonged to Thutmose II because inscribed alabaster fragments revealed that his wife and half-sister, Hatshepsut—who became the most powerful female pharaoh in Egyptian history after his death—built the burial chamber in his honor. A ceiling bedecked in yellow stars on a blue background and the discovery of a key religious text used exclusively for kings helped cement the conclusion.

The discovery was announced last month by Egyptian officials and the New Kingdom Research Foundation, affiliated with Cambridge University.

But mysteries remain. Thutmose II's mummified body and the goods and furniture he would have been buried with were missing from the site.

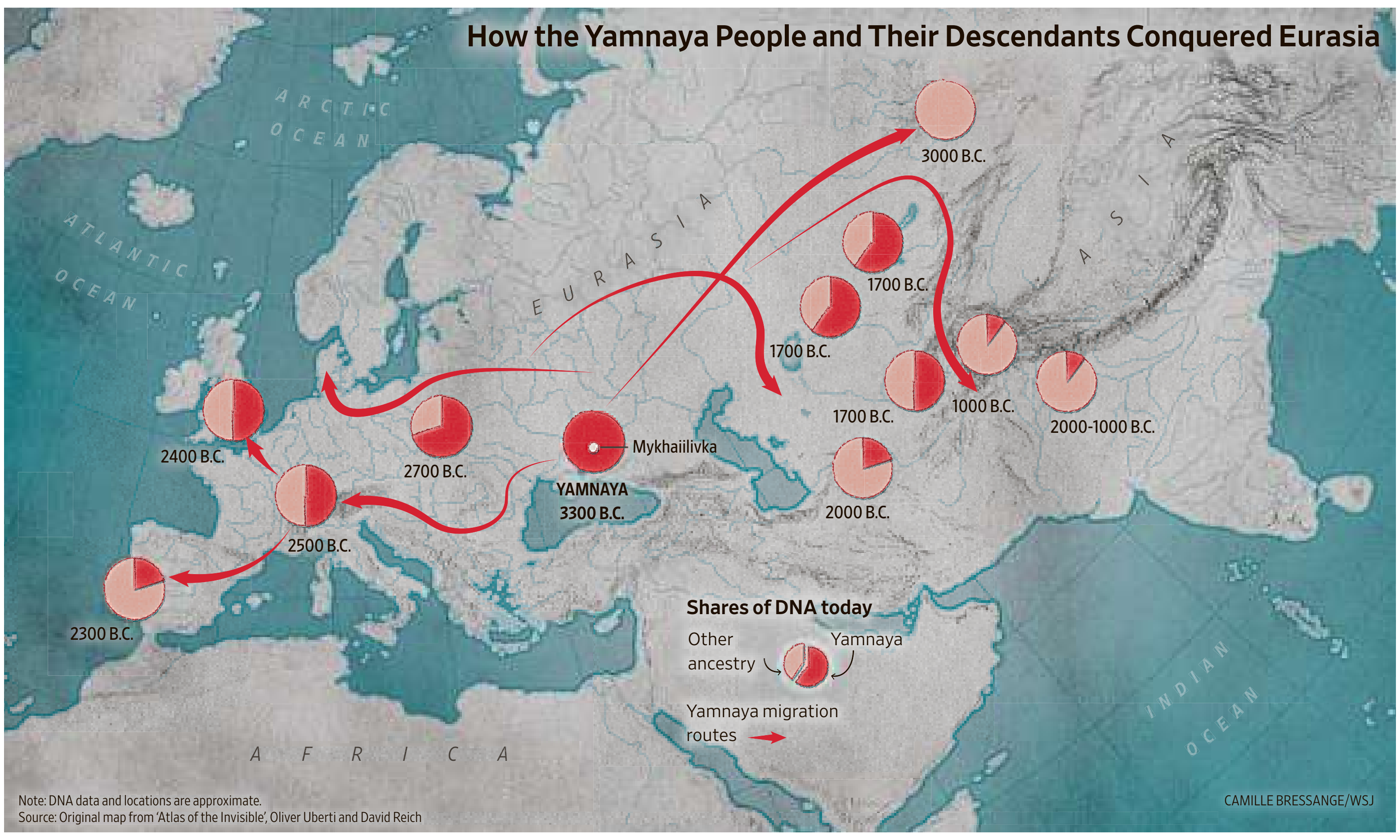
Signs of water damage and the clean sweep of the funerary items suggest the contents were rescued from flooding rather than ransacked by grave robbers, said Piers Litherland, head of the research foundation.

"When it was flooded, the contents of the tomb were removed to a new tomb, which has yet to be found," Litherland said. Such reburials weren't unheard of in ancient Egypt.

The whereabouts of the body are in dispute. At Cairo's National Museum of Egyptian Civilization, a mummy found in 1881 is labeled as Thutmose II, but some scholars say that the individual was too old to be a king who assumed the throne in his teens and reigned for as few as three years.

A museum representative said that evidence, including an inscription on the mummy's shroud, confirms the identity. But the pharaoh's name was misspelled in the inscription, said University of Oxford Egyptologist Trent Hugler, suggesting the body could have been mislabeled by ancient priests.

Many experts believe a second tomb of Thutmose II is still out there, containing the missing funerary items. Litherland thinks a body will be in there, too. "I hope we can clear things up finally with more evidence," he said. "That is what we are employed looking for at the moment."



The Ancient Horsemen Who Created the Modern World

New DNA research shows that half the human beings alive today are descended from the Yamnaya, who lived in Ukraine 5,000 years ago.

By Bojan Pancevski

For about half the people alive today, the story of where they came from just became clearer.

For centuries, historians and linguists have been searching for the cradle of the Indo-Europeans, an ancient people who shaped history and created the world's largest language family, now spoken by over 40% of humanity. Now research led by David Reich, a geneticist at Harvard Medical School who specializes in the study of ancient populations, is making it possible to give a precise answer.

The peoples of Europe and West Asia, as well as everyone descended from their migrations across the globe—some four billion human beings alive today—can trace their ancestry to the Yamnaya, a small community of cattle-herders who lived 5,000 years ago in what is now Ukraine.

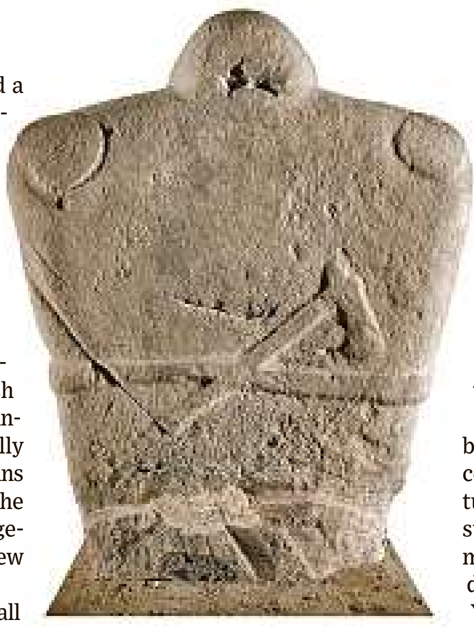
DNA detectives, including at Reich's lab, analyzed DNA samples from the remains of around 450 prehistoric individuals taken from 100 sites in Europe, as well as data from 1,000 previously known ancient samples. In two papers published in the scientific journal Nature last month, the researchers combine genetic evidence with archaeology and linguistics to argue that sometime before 3000 B.C., a previously unknown people migrated from the Volga River to the Ukrainian steppe north of the Black Sea, where they mixed with a local population and formed the Yamnaya.

The Ukrainian hamlet Mykhailivka, now under Russian occupation, was pinpointed as the genetic cradle of the Yamnaya. From there they exploded across Eurasia, spreading their genes and their way of life from Portugal to Mongolia. This expansion, archaeologists and geneticists say, defines much of the world's genetic and cultural heritage to this day. "They changed the populations of Europe, and ultimately, the world," Reich said.

This "incredible expansion laid a foundation for premodern globalization," said Kristian Kristiansen of the University of Gothenburg in Sweden, an authority on the Yamnaya who did not participate in the new research. Their language, which was not written down but can be partly reconstructed by linguists, was the ancestor of 400 later tongues, including Latin and Greek, English and Russian, Urdu and German. Ancient civilizations that we usually think of as antagonists—the Romans and the Celts, the Persians and the Macedonians—all shared this genetic and cultural heritage, the new research shows.

These ancient people did not call themselves Yamnaya. The name was coined by archaeologists from the Russian word yama, meaning "pit," because they buried important people in pits beneath mounds known as kurgans. They were also likely the first people to ride horses and use wheeled carts, technologies that allowed them to conquer the Eurasian steppe.

Only a handful of labs work on ancient DNA research. Scientists can retrieve DNA from human bones, teeth or tissue from museum collections, as well as from ancient cave dwellings, burial grounds, battlefields and disaster sites. DNA is preserved in the most unlikely places: Ancient Europeans mixed their saliva with birch tar to make a glue to repair pots and attach arrowheads. Reich's award-winning lab at Harvard has one of the largest ancient



A Yamnaya engraved stone slab from the third millennium B.C.

DNA databases in the world and uses proprietary gene-analysis software co-developed by Nicholas Patterson, a British mathematician who once worked as a codebreaker for U.K. intelligence services.

The new genetic research reinforces earlier theories about the spread of the Yamnaya based on linguistic and archaeological evidence. The idea that the languages of Europe, Iran and India descend from a single ancient tongue was first proposed by Sir William Jones, a British colonial judge in 18th-century India. Jones taught himself Sanskrit to interpret local laws and suggested that the ancient Indian language had a common ancestor with Latin, Greek and Old Iranian.

DNA evidence shows that the proto-Yamnaya population migrated from the Volga region to Anatolia, presumably spreading their language along the way. Still, some linguists remain cautious. "Genetic evidence alone will never be enough to prove the origin of a language," said Lehti Saag, an ancient DNA researcher at Tartu University in Estonia.

For the peoples living in Eurasia before the Yamnaya arrived, being conquered was tantamount to "cultural erasure," Reich said. The erasure was often physical, too. In many places, indigenous male DNA disappears upon the arrival of the Yamnaya, while indigenous female DNA is traceable in the following generations.

This suggests that the newcomers exterminated the men in the farming and hunter-gatherer populations they encountered, while incorporating the surviving women into their community. The Yamnaya were originally dark-skinned, with dark hair and brown eyes; their descendants in Western Europe inherited genes for blue eyes and lighter skin from the women they conquered.

In other places, "it's a process of almost no mixture with the previous people, who just disappear," Reich said. That is what happened to the highly sophisticated civilization that built Stonehenge in Britain. Shortly after the giant stone structure was completed around 2500 B.C., descendants of the Yamnaya stepperiders landed on Britain's shores.

Within years of their arrival, some 99% of the indigenous people disappeared, according to Reich's analysis of DNA samples from the time. Stonehenge, an apogee of a vanquished culture that took centuries to complete, was turned into a garbage dump.

Experts believe there was likely a religious or ideological driver of the Yamnaya expansion. Since they left no written records, it is impossible to know exactly what they believed

> 'They changed the populations of Europe, and ultimately, the world.'
>
> DAVID REICH
> Geneticist

and what drove them to expand the way they did. But the ancient epics of the cultures they engendered, including the Hindu Rigveda and Homer's Iliad, suggest that they glorified battle and expanded through colonization.

Archaeological evidence from their settlements and burial grounds shows that young Yamnaya men were trained not only in hunting, herding, riding and fishing, but also to be warriors. By analyzing words related to kinship and social order from later cultures descended from the Yamnaya, researchers conclude that they had a patriarchal social structure, in which firstborn sons inherited all their fathers' property. This system of primogeniture created an "expansive dynamism" that encouraged younger sons to embark on conquest, said Volker Heyd, professor of archaeology at the University of Helsinki.

The Yamnaya also had biological advantages. Studies comparing their skeletons with those other contemporary groups show that on average they were about 6 inches taller, possibly as a result of their meat and dairy consumption, researchers believe.

"It was a group of Arnold Schwarzeneggers riding into conquest," Heyd said.

Traces of Yersinia pestis, the bacteria that causes plague, were found in Yamnaya remains, suggesting that they may have developed immunity to the disease and carried it as an unintended "biological weapon" that decimated rival groups.

One group derived from the Yamnaya were the Aryans, who shaped the cultures of ancient India and Iran. In the 20th century, the term Aryan became associated with white supremacy, after theorists of racism falsely identified them as a Germanic race of conquerors superior to other Europeans.

In fact, the new findings show that most people in Europe share Yamnaya ancestry as one element in a complex genetic inheritance, which also includes DNA from earlier hunter-gatherer and farming groups and later migratory peoples such as the Huns or the Mongols.

"Large-scale movement of people is a repeated event in human history, and it's been often disruptive," Reich said. "It occurs again and again."

VLADIMIR SLAVCHEV

Are Americans Really Losing Their Religion?

About 100 million people in the U.S. say they have no religious faith, but a new survey paints a more complicated picture.

By Ryan Burge and Tony Jones

THE BIGGEST STORY in American religion is the dramatic rise of the "nones"—people who say they are atheist, agnostic or have no particular religious faith. The nones are currently at an all-time high of about 30% of the population; for Americans born since 1996, the figure is around 45%. Yet it's striking how little is known about this group. For several decades, social science has been content to lump all 100 million nonreligious Americans into a single category.

That is finally starting to change. Last year we conducted the largest-ever survey of nones, with 12,000 participants. The results challenge the assumption of many religious thinkers that every human being has a deep yearning for God.

In fact, one-third of nonreligious people fall into a category we call the "dones," because they are finished with religion altogether and want nothing to do with it. Not only do people in this group never attend organized religious services; 88% say they never pray at all. Just 6% of the dones agree with the statement "When I die, I will be reunited with loved ones," while 77% percent believe that when they die, "my existence ends."

For the dones, the absence of God and spirituality doesn't seem to negatively affect their mental health or well-being in any way. The share of dones who agreed with the statement "I feel I do not have much to be proud of" was 20%, statistically the same as among Protestants or Catholics.

Things are different in another group representing about 10% of nonreligious Americans. We call them the "zealous nones," because they are evangelical about their unbelief. More than three-quarters of this group tried to persuade someone to abandon their faith during the prior year. Unlike the dones, the zealous nones seem to have more struggles with mental health and well-being. They were 13 points more likely than Christians to say "I feel that my life is not very useful."

But the majority of nonreligious non-Americans have a more complicated attitude toward spirituality. We found that 21% are what we call "nones in name only": over half of this group says they pray daily, and a third attend some kind of religious service at least once a year. And 66% say they feel drawn toward spirituality but are much more resistant to the idea of organized religion.

Many people who have no religious affiliation also say they pray daily.

ISTOCK

There are constant headlines about the rise of anxiety, isolation and mental illness in the U.S., and some commentators point to the decline of religion as a cause. Our research doesn't exactly confirm that idea. While an increase in religious participation may lead to some positive outcomes, a significant number of people are "good without God."

At the same time, the majority of nonreligious Americans do yearn for some kind of connection with a higher power. This suggests that a religious revival is certainly possible in the U.S., so long as the nones aren't seen as a problem to be solved, but a group that needs to be better understood.

Ryan Burge, a professor of political science at Eastern Illinois University, and Tony Jones, a theologian, lead the Making Meaning in a Post-Religious America Project.

P2JW067000-4-C00500-1--------XA

Why I've Become More Mindful About What I Delegate

It's convenient to outsource work but often more satisfying to roll up your sleeves to do it yourself.

By Moshe Bar

A treehouse built by Moshe Bar and his family.

MOSHE BAR

Of everything I have done, little has brought me as much joy as building a treehouse for my children around 15 years ago. Armed with power tools and two left hands, I spent about a year turning a collection of crooked beams into an enduring structure. We all loved it so dearly that my now 20-something kids and I decided to tattoo its image on our skin.

I've spent some time trying to figure out why this labor-intensive project brought me so much satisfaction. The treehouse itself was great fun, but the process of creating it, demanding as it was, invigorated me and lifted my spirits in ways I did not expect.

I learned that I was in good company. Psychological studies consistently show that people value what they have worked for. This phenomenon is called the "IKEA effect," named for the prideful pleasure people feel when they assemble the Swedish manufacturer's flat-pack products themselves.

In one particularly amusing study from 2011, social psychologists at Harvard Business School found that people prized Lego constructions they built themselves over identical pre-assembled models. The phenomenon is apparently not exclusive to humans. Scientists have observed that rats and starlings consistently prefer the food that they worked to get over the same food received without effort.

I thought of these studies after a recent family cooking class. The recipes were for simple ramen and gyoza, but my 13-year-old daughter declared that the meal was the most delicious she had ever tasted. Our investment in every detail of the process clearly elevated the experience.

Modern life often prizes prepackaged conveniences. We buy ready-made products, eat frozen pizzas and replace what's broken instead of fixing it. The more successful we become, the more likely we are to outsource jobs that we might have once done ourselves. Yet the effort of involvement is what gives meaning to so much of life.

I had to be reminded of this recently. Last year I began to notice that though I had been productively busy, I wasn't as excited as I used to be. Not bored, not tired, but a spark I'd long enjoyed was gone. My youngest daughter noted, with incisive candor, that my "wow" wasn't as loud as it had been. She was right.

Ever the scientist, I started probing my routines and habits, searching for what might be missing in my life. The insight came, unexpectedly, during a Talmud study session in November with my beloved teacher, Rabbi Shabtai Rappoport.

We were discussing the concept of shlichut—delegation—in Jewish law, which permits certain commandments to be performed by a proxy. For instance, you can appoint someone to make a charitable donation or officiate at a wedding on your behalf. Other commandments, such as praying or visiting a sick friend, must be performed firsthand. The distinction typically depends on the nature of the task. When the outcome is what matters, delegation is acceptable, but when the experience itself is important, you should do it yourself.

One needn't be a Talmudic scholar—or a patron of IKEA—to draw inspiration from these rules. What I had been missing wasn't success, leisure or even purpose. What I lacked was being more involved in the process.

As I've grown older, I've found myself delegating more of the lab-work I oversee, focusing more on the big picture. Similarly I let others tutor my kids and tend to my little garden. My distance from the granular details of my life and work was by design, but it seems to have left me feeling disconnected from it all. Participation is a form of commitment, and commitment allows for a richer experience.

A recent family trip to Japan for my birthday confirmed this theory. The older children and their mother took upon themselves the burden of planning, sparing me weeks of logistical headaches. The vacation was fabulous, but I sensed my family enjoyed the results even more than I did. My lack of involvement rendered me a guest rather than an agent, and who wants to be a guest in their own life?

The connection between actions and feelings—between engagement and fulfillment—can be seen in a relatively new and popular treatment for depression called behavioral activation (BA). Beyond low mood, one of the most challenging symptoms of depression is anhedonia, a diminished capacity to enjoy ordinary activities, which often leads to avoidance and withdrawal.

Studies show that encouraging patients to get up and do the things they used to enjoy, such as cooking or meeting with friends, can be just as effective as talk therapy in boosting moods and well-being. BA works because it helps patients override their avoidance and regain a sense of control over their lives. Activity is also often easier to manage than analysis.

> The effort of involvement is what gives meaning to so much of life.

Staying active and involved isn't only the best way to enjoy life but also to prolong it. This goes beyond the well-known effects of exercise on physical and mental health. Being involved in purposeful activities that require mental engagement, such as hobbies, social interactions and volunteering, has been shown to improve resilience and reduce dementia.

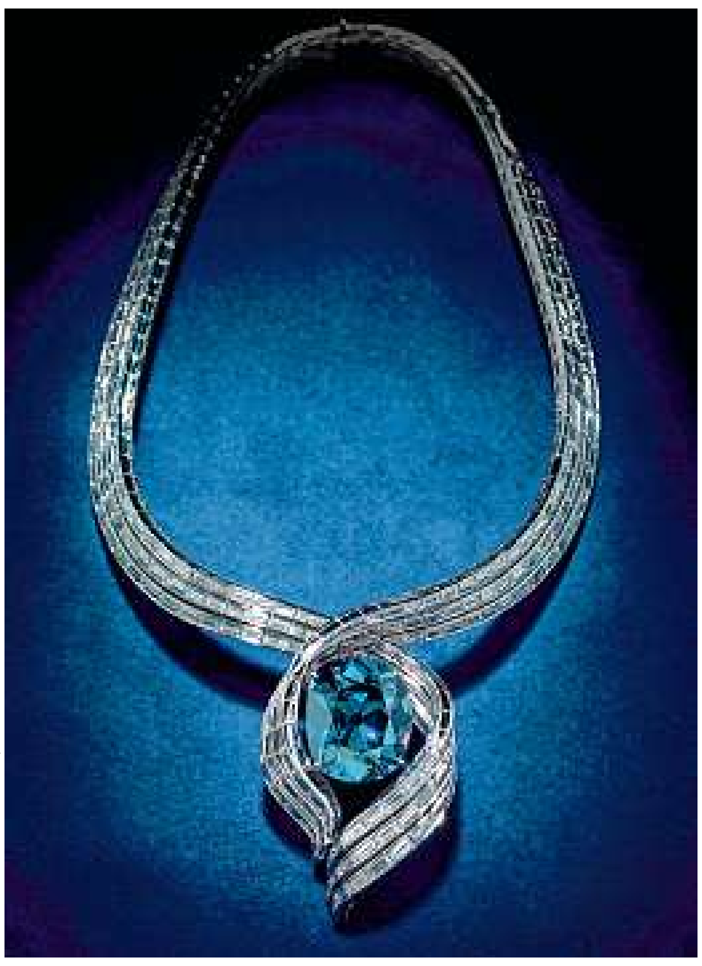
Brain research confirms that cognitive involvement in process-based activities increases brain plasticity, enriches connections between neurons and lowers neurodegeneration. This helps explain why retirees who stop working but don't fill their days with other demanding activities experience an especially steep cognitive decline.

Although this insight hasn't quite nudged me to start washing my own car, cooking all my meals or running all the experiments in my lab, I am now more mindful about what I delegate. I hold on to the projects for which experiencing the process matters.

As a crafts project on a rainy day, my daughter and I invented a board game. It isn't the most exciting game or the most sophisticated. It is honestly a little silly, but we play it far more often than the ones that came shrink-wrapped from a store.

Pleasure and meaning, it seems, aren't necessarily about ease. There is delight in involvement, in details, in rolling up our sleeves and making what we want happen for ourselves.

Moshe Bar is a neuroscientist at Bar-Ilan University in Israel and at Massachusetts General Hospital. His most recent book is "Mindwandering: How Your Constant Mental Drift Can Improve Your Mood and Boost Your Creativity."



FROM LEFT: DONALD E. HURLBERT; GALERIE KUGEL

EXHIBIT

Crown Jewels

FOR MILLENNIA, the mines of Golconda in India's south-central Deccan Plateau were the world's primary source of diamonds. Marco Polo wrote about them; in the "One Thousand and One Nights," Sinbad grabs a bag of them. Later, the Mughal empire and European colonists were driven by the same hunger for precious stones.

In her new illustrated book "Diamonds of Golconda" (Skira), jewelry historian Capucine Juncker spotlights some of the mines' most famous products. The 105.6-carat Koh-i-Noor belonged to royalty in India, Iran and Afghanistan before the British conquest of Punjab won it for Queen Victoria in 1849. India and the Taliban have recently laid claim to it, but the gem remains on display in the Tower of London.

The gargantuan 189.6-carat Orlov, which adorned the scepter of Russia's Catherine the Great in the 18th century, now resides in the Kremlin. And the Louvre is home to the 140.6-carat Regent, which once glittered on the crowns of French monarchs and Napoleon's sword.

Another piece of Golconda bling is the grayish-blue, 45.5-carat Hope diamond (left), named for the Anglo-Dutch banking family that owned it in the 19th century. It ended up in the possession of the jeweler Harry Winston, who donated it the Smithsonian Institution in Washington, D.C., where it is now one of the world's most visited artworks. And if anyone has seen the straw-colored, 138-carat Florentine, get in touch: It vanished in 1921. —*Peter Saenger*

Golconda diamonds: The Hope (left) and the Beau Sancy (above right).

OBITUARIES

DAVID EDWARD BYRD | 1941-2025

Above, Byrd in his New York City studio in 1970; right, his poster for the 1971 Off-Broadway production of 'Godspell.'

ESTATE OF DAVID EDWARD BYRD (2)

His Posters Captured the Psychedelic Age

Designs promoting rock bands and Broadway shows—the Rolling Stones, Jimi Hendrix and 'Godspell,' among others—helped invent the visual identity of an era.

By Jon Mooallem

David Edward Byrd moved to a farm in Port Jervis, N.Y., in 1967 to join a community of young artists known as Fantasy Unlimited, both a hippie commune and a capitalist enterprise. It produced multimedia light shows, featuring projections of undulating color and strobe lights, for dance parties and corporate events alike. "There was an effort to bring that kind of sensual-awareness experience to the corporate world," said a member, Nina Berson.

Byrd, a classically trained painter with a master's degree in stone lithography, wasn't an obvious fit for a psychedelic light show. But after college, "the only job I could get was washing underwear in an Armenian laundry," he recalled. So his college roommate, a group founder, threw him a lifeline.

Meanwhile, the more famous Joshua Light Show was performing with rock bands like Traffic and Iron Butterfly. Joshua White, the creator of the show and another former schoolmate at what is now Carnegie Mellon University, talked the promoter Bill Graham into hiring Byrd to make a poster for a gig at Graham's New York City venue, the Fillmore East.

Byrd didn't know anything about concert posters, but he later wrote that they "should be calling to you across the street, luring you in or punching you in the face." He produced an image of four people staring up from within a tunnel of psychedelic hot pink, purple and orange light. In "Poster Child," a book he wrote with Robert von Goeben in 2023, Byrd said the tightly clashing color combinations were meant to mimic the effect of a strobe light.

"It kind of jiggles and wiggles in your retina," he wrote. "But still your poor brain will keep trying to select one of the colors."

Graham kept hiring Byrd, launching his career. Over the next decade, Byrd's radiant, eclectic work for rock bands and Broadway shows, and also on book jackets, album covers and more, would help invent the visual identity of an era.

He died on Feb. 3 in Albuquerque, N.M., at age 83, from pneumonia brought on by lung damage from long Covid, according to his husband, Jolino Beserra.

Jimi Hendrix Experience

Among Byrd's most enduring images was a 1968 Jimi Hendrix Experience poster. Byrd transformed the guitar god's Afro into a spellbinding expanse of small, meticulous, multicolored circles that fused into the hair of his bandmates behind him. Originals of the poster are now in collections at New York's Museum of Modern Art and the Louvre and have sold online for as much as $12,000.

Byrd had to buy one himself late in life. He thought of posters as ephemeral, to be ripped down or covered over, and saved little of his early work.

Byrd drew inspiration from his wide knowledge of art history. For a Rolling Stones tour poster, he referred to the motion studies of 19th-century photographer Eadweard Muybridge. He rendered the members of Jefferson Airplane as Egyptian figurative art. He gave the Who's "Tommy" a Busby Berkeley look.

In 1969, Byrd based his poster design for a planned "Aquarian Exposition" in Wallkill, N.Y., on a French painter's 1856 portrait of a nude woman holding a water jug. But Byrd wasn't available when the festival—which became known as Woodstock—suddenly had to shift its location, and his poster was never used.

A rock poster 'could be ducks eating a lizard. If it was cool and psychedelic, it didn't matter.'

As White remembers, Byrd came up with his complex concepts quickly. "I don't ever remember him sitting there grumbling, 'What am I gonna do?'" Nor did Byrd agonize over "selling out" with commercial art over fine art. "It's all art." he told Vanity Fair. "After all, John Singer Sargent had to please the Astors. It's all a racket, kiddo."

In 1971, Byrd created a poster for the Stephen Sondheim musical "Follies." The show's title exploded from the dazzling, faintly psychedelic headdress of a showgirl, depicted like a cracked marble bust. Broadway poster designer Frank "Fraver" Verlizzo wrote that the image "single-handedly revitalized interest in the theater poster as an art form. Until then, much of it consisted of celebrity headshots accompanied by artistic brush lettering." Byrd closely followed "Follies" with a poster for "Godspell," another landmark design.

Byrd later told Playbill that theater work was more demanding because, he said, for a rock poster, "It could be ducks eating a lizard. If it was cool and psychedelic, it didn't matter. But with Broadway, you had to read the script."

Placed in foster care

Byrd, born April 4, 1941 in Cleveland, Tenn., was put in foster care at 3, his husband said; while his father fought in World War II, his mother, Veda, sought to find a wealthier husband. Two years later, Veda married a Howard Johnson's executive and retrieved her son. They moved into a Miami Beach mansion—a Midcentury Modern showpiece of plush carpets and lavish pastels that neighbors called "The House of Tomorrow."

In Byrd's book, he recalls a deeply unhappy and uncomfortable childhood there, which included drunken party guests leaping off the balcony into the pool fully dressed while Byrd—a child bartender in a suit and red bow tie—fixed gin slings.

Eventually, a passion for art consumed and defined him. He worked at a Pittsburgh steel mill to pay for art school because his stepfather refused to.

While a freshman, Byrd cracked his pelvis, tailbone and two vertebrae in a car accident, spent six months in the hospital and had to relearn how to walk. His mother came to visit only once and showed up drunk. In 1962, Byrd would find his mother's body next to a bottle of vodka and sleeping pills.

Following his accident, Byrd became addicted to painkillers and sunk into depression. "I think I was just angry, angry, angry," he explained in "Poster Child." Restarting art school, he lived on water and Wonder Bread. After his 1960s success, heroin and opium entered the mix of his addictions. Hoping to make a clean break, in 1980 Byrd moved from New York to Los Angeles to make imagery for a Van Halen tour.

Byrd would land other gigs, including portraits of the band KISS, but he found that his style and star status didn't immediately translate to the West Coast. He took jobs illustrating insurance ads and even packaging diagrams, including "How to Heat an Egg Roll."

In late 1981, he met Beserra, a young mosaic artist, and began to embrace his life in L.A. After 32 years together, they married in 2013.

In 1991, Byrd was hired by Warner Bros to dream up visual materials for the studio's many properties. Those ranged from a set of Looney Tunes postal stamps to merchandise for the TV show "Friends" and style guides for the early "Harry Potter" films.

He called his time at Warner Bros. his "greatest education"—doing hands-on artwork for hours a day surrounded by other artists and using computer illustration software for the first time. Von Goeben noted that people could ask, "'Why did you love it? You were drawing Tweety Bird?' But as David would say to me, 'What's not to love? I get to paint all day.'"

After leaving Warner Bros. in 2002, Byrd kept busy between freelance gigs designing pro-bono posters for charity events or struggling theaters, or T-shirts for animal rescues. All he wanted was to make things. "When he could just get lost in the work, he was happiest," Beserra said. "What saved him, always, was getting out of his own head."

GARY STEVENS | 1940-2025

A New York Radio DJ Who Spun the British Invasion

One of the WMCA 'Good Guys,' he played the latest from the Beatles, Supremes and other 1960s icons.

More stories at WSJ.com/obituaries

By Chris Kornelis

IN MAY OF 1967, Gary Stevens told his listeners that he'd gotten his hands on music from the Beatles that none of them had heard yet. This is what his listeners tuned in for. Decades before the internet, social media, Spotify and MTV, radio was where you first heard new releases—from the Kinks, the Supremes, the Righteous Brothers.

Stevens was one of the WMCA "Good Guys," the New York station's roster of DJs at the height of the British Invasion and the halcyon days of Motown. The Beatles had released "Penny Lane" and "Strawberry Fields Forever," but Stevens was just back from the U.K. and had more than a new single. He had an entire album: "Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band." He claimed that his on-air sidekick, a fictional bear he dubbed the Wooly Burger, was the one who had smuggled it out.

"Not only was he a Good Guy," Stevens's son, Christopher, said recently, "he was a wiseguy."

Stevens was WMCA's star, a local celebrity, the host of its teen-focused 7 p.m. to 11 p.m. slot whose listeners thought of him as a friend.

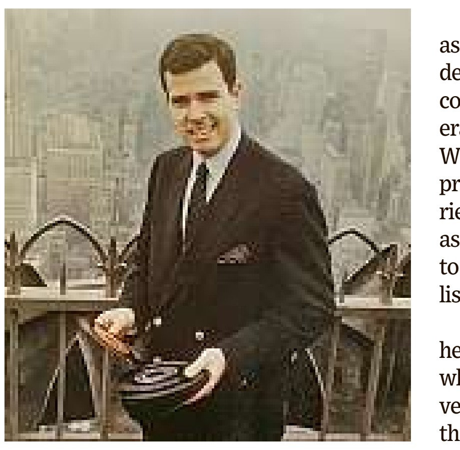
"People were not just tuning in to hear music and call letters and news, they tuned in for a friend, a familiar voice that made you feel good," said Bruce Morrow, aka "Cousin Brucie," who competed against Stevens in the night slot at WABC, where he still hosts a show. He added: "If you were successful, you knew the secret: how to talk right directly to an audience. Gary had that secret."

Stevens fell in love with radio as a child. Growing up in Buffalo, N.Y., he hung around a local radio station. After high school, he drove to the University of Miami in his pale blue Corvette.

Stevens always had flashy cars. When he was making real money in the 1980s, he got into Maseratis and Ferraris, then Jaguars in the '90s and Lamborghinis in the first decade of the 2000s.

"He liked attention, he liked dazzle," Christopher Stevens said, adding: "He didn't care about how fast they went. He liked how loud they were, and he liked the fact that everybody looked at you."

In 1966, when he started dating a British stewardess, he would pick her up at the airport in a white convertible Lincoln Continental. On their first date, he wore a powder blue blazer, a wide tie and a silk handkerchief—an ensemble she found disgusting—but it was the fact that he pushed his peas onto his fork with his fingers that prompted a scolding. He proposed to her that night anyway. It took her a month to say yes. Frankie and Gary Stevens had three children and were married until he died, Feb. 17, at the age of 84.



Stevens in New York in an undated photo.

STEVENS FAMILY

Stevens got to WMCA in 1965 but left the station and the DJ game altogether in 1968, at age 28, telling his wife: "I don't want to be a 40-year-old disc jockey." He went to work on the business side of the industry.

Within the industry, he became known as a powerful broker of radio stations in deals that were part of the industry's consolidation after the loosening of federal ownership laws. But to his former WMCA listeners—strangers who approached him at the airport, his mail carrier in Connecticut—he was still known as the DJ who provided the soundtrack to their '60s and sneaked them an early listen to tracks from "Sgt. Pepper's."

"It was something like we'd never heard before," said Howie Schenker, a fan who was 12 years old when he heard Stevens play the tracks in 1967, of hearing the songs for the first time. "It was stunning to the ears."

Her Type
The secretarial school that trained the best of the 20th century **C12**

BOOKS

A Life Among the Stars
The breezy, boozy, celebrity-filled memoir of Peter Wolf **C11**

A Few Billion Between Friends

The complicated debate among allies over who owed what played a role in leading the world back to war

Mellon vs. Churchill
By Jill Eicher
Pegasus, 368 pages, $32

By Benn Steil

HUM HISTORICAL/ALAMY

DEBT COLLECTOR The U.S. Treasury secretary Andrew Mellon, ca. 1924.

WHATEVER interests and ambitions countries may have, the historian H.W. Brands has observed, they ultimately "get the foreign policies they can afford." Nowhere in modern history is this more clear than in the case of the U.S. and Britain in the 1920s, a decade in which the geopolitical fortunes of the two nations began to diverge. In "Mellon vs. Churchill," Jill Eicher, a former investment manager and U.S. Treasury official, captures this divergence through the clashes of the two governments' respective finance chiefs: Andrew Mellon, the U.S. Treasury secretary from 1921 to 1932, and Winston Churchill, the U.K. chancellor of the exchequer from 1924 to 1929.

Britain, at the time the world's greatest imperial power, exited World War I heavily in debt to the U.S. By the time the pair were allied in a second world war two decades later, the U.S., on whose material support Britain then relied for survival, was able to call the shots—not only in the war but in the "American century" of relative peace that followed. From the World War II-era creation of the Bretton Woods financial architecture and the rupture over U.S. aid terms through to the Suez crisis of 1956, when Washington responded to Britain's invasion of Egypt by threatening to withhold International Monetary Fund support, it became bracingly clear that the rights and privileges of British imperium rested on gold and its new surrogate, U.S. dollars—neither of which could London any longer command in sufficient volume.

In a nutshell, the debt story of the 1920s goes like this. Following World War I, 10 countries owed the U.S. more than $10 billion ($190 billion in today's money), most of which had been used to purchase U.S. goods and munitions during the conflict. Britain's share of the debt, the largest, was $4.6 billion; France owed $4 billion. Their economies in shambles, however, they were in no position to commence timely and full repayment.

President Woodrow Wilson granted Britain a three-year moratorium on interest payments, and London began paying in 1922. But the Tory government almost immediately initiated talks aimed at canceling its debt or at least reducing it significantly. Not only money, but Britain's standing, credit and power in the world were at stake. Following much difficult and at times bitter negotiation, President Warren Harding signed the British Debt Agreement Act in early 1923, giving London 62 years to repay at 3% interest.

But matters hardly ended there. Britain's ability to pay the U.S. was still limited by Germany's ability to pay reparations and France's ability to pay back loans to the British—which was also contingent on reparations from Germany. Although Washington refused, at least officially, to link these payments to debt settlement, the U.S. Dawes Plan of 1924 encouraged U.S. banks to lend to Germany as a means of speeding its recovery and allowing the continued flow of reparations—and, thereby, debt repayment to the U.S.

By 1929, however, the fragility of this circular structure of payments from the U.S. to Europe and back again had become too apparent to ignore, and another Washington initiative—the Young Plan—was signed to reduce German reparation payments. Germany, however, unilaterally canceled reparations in 1933, in the midst of the Great Depression, and Britain, France, Belgium and Italy defaulted the following year. Their debts, and those of seven other nations, remain on the books of the U.S. Treasury.

This sorry tale has many prominent protagonists and antagonists—most notably, U.S. presidents Woodrow Wilson (1913-21), Warren Harding (1921-23), Calvin Coolidge (1923-29) and Herbert Hoover (1929-33), and British prime ministers David Lloyd George (1916-22), Bonar Law (1922-23), Stanley Baldwin (1923-24, 1924-29) and Ramsay MacDonald (1924, 1929-1935). Ms. Eicher's focus on Mellon and Churchill owes partly to their longstanding central roles in the debt drama—at times public and caustic—and partly to the fact that, despite historians' endless fascination with Churchill, his interactions with Mellon have been largely overlooked.

Andrew Mellon, the Treasury secretary under three Republican presidents between 1921 and 1932, was one of the great bankers of the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Age 66 in 1921, and one of the wealthiest men in the country, the austere, soft-spoken, ever impeccably groomed Pittsburgh native was ready for a new final act in life when Pennsylvania Republican Sen. Philander Knox lobbied successfully for Harding to bring Mellon into the cabinet. Over his years in Washington, Mellon's priorities would be to cut taxes, reduce the national debt and restructure Allied debts—all of which he achieved. Had he departed Washington with Coolidge in 1929 and not hung around for the Wall Street crash and subsequent depression, history might have recorded his life as a trifecta of unvarnished accomplishment—in business, in philanthropy and in government.

Winston Churchill would not rise to the pinnacle of political fame until his first term as prime minister, from 1940 to 1945, during the harrowing and triumphant days of World War II. But he considered his elevation in 1924 to chancellor of the exchequer—a post that his father had held in 1886—to have been a major milestone.

Following World War I, Churchill was supremely sensitive to the geopolitical importance of Britain's enormous war debt. President Wilson had, after all, been open about his intention to use American lending, Ms. Eicher writes, "as leverage to persuade the warring nations to adopt his administration's plan for the peace process." Ms. Eicher quotes complaints in the London press, in 1921, that Washington was using war debts "as a club to force disarmament" of rivals and achieve its own naval-dominance aims—in particular, over Britain. But Churchill was determined to maintain British sea power. "Only in that way," he told the House of Commons that year, would Britain "be able to walk hand in hand with the United States, not as a supplicant for protection, but an equal partner in a common victory and an equal partner in the fair future of the world."

> **Debts to the U.S. that Britain and France ran up during World War I remain on the books.**

The war-debt agreement with America in 1923 notwithstanding, the ever-prolific and voluble Churchill was determined to see the debt canceled. He framed it as a moral affront that Washington should treat the debt, incurred in a noble common cause, as a mere commercial obligation. As a practical matter, he was sure the debt would never, and could never, be repaid, dependent as it was on a chain of obligations whose success at each link was premised on a recovery rendered hopeless by the weight of that very debt.

As Ms. Eicher's engaging narrative makes clear, Mellon was hardly blind to this dilemma. Yet, as a banker who had successfully restructured large and precarious debts throughout his career, he was determined to navigate a middle course between hard-liners in Congress, who demanded repayment at a fair rate of interest, and the "cancellationists" in the civil service, academia and the media who argued that such demands were shortsighted and counterproductive. As Mellon himself well understood, Europe could only be a good customer for American goods if it had the wherewithal to buy them. "I should rather have solvent customers in the future," Mellon observed, than "force my customers into bankruptcy."

Instead, Europe was obliged to dump goods in the U.S. to raise the dollars needed to service the debt, undercutting American business. U.S. tariffs, which Mellon publicly defended, only made

Please turn to page C8

Van Gogh In the City Of Light

A Fire in His Soul
By Miles J. Unger
Pegasus, 672 pages, $39.95

By Dan Hofstadter

THOUGH modern art was long a form of expression that the general public found hard to accept, the work of Vincent van Gogh, almost alone, proved easy to assimilate; in truth he is so universally liked as to merit the sappy adjective "beloved." Nor is Van Gogh by any means an unknown character, in part because his devoutly self-absorbed letters, addressed to his brother Theo and which have become our prime source for details about the artist's life, have been available in many translations for more than 100 years.

Yet an inescapable part of Van Gogh's story is the reality of his mental illness, his self-commitment to the asylum in Saint-Rémy, in Provence, and his eventual suicide. No one can begin to consider him without acknowledging his strangely sacred place in the modern canon, rooted in our latent suspicion that madness is really a form of saintly enlightenment. Anyone writing about him will likely be stirred by some wish to understand his derangement, even to volunteer a diagnosis, though that is obviously impossible. How then to say anything fresh about this most widely exhibited, admired and discussed of artists?

That is the hurdle, and also the spur to invention, faced by Miles Unger in "A Fire in His Soul," a chronicle mostly of Van Gogh's two years in Paris (from February 1886 to February 1888). The strategy here is to limit the focus to a rather brief but highly formative period, though the theme is scarcely a new one, the interval having been studied in depth by historians and covered in 1988 by a major exhibition at the Musée d'Orsay titled "Van Gogh à Paris."

When Van Gogh arrived in Paris, at age 32, he had no source of income and had arranged to stay with Theo, who was four years his junior. Theo was then working as an art dealer for the Parisian firm Goupil in a smallish, satellite gallery on the Boulevard Montmartre. For a while the pair roomed—and communed and quarreled—in Theo's cramped apartment in a Montmartre neighborhood known for its bohemian tone. Vincent had been painting seriously for about six years, and was thought by perceptive people to be quite gifted in some occluded, not-yet-realized way. Foremost among those people was Theo himself, a reticent art salesman but an alert judge of quality.

> **The two years Van Gogh spent in Montmartre brought his painting a new sophistication.**

VAN GOGH MUSEUM, AMSTERDAM

STOMPING GROUNDS 'Boulevard de Clichy' (1887) by Vincent van Gogh.

Vincent was broad-shouldered, unkempt, bellicose and furiously energetic. Scattering his brushes and paint pots everywhere in their dwelling, he smoked and drank to excess and carried on in a wild, abrasive manner. Mr. Unger calls him a "desperado," a hanger-on at once demanding of Theo's financial support and ashamed of his dependency.

Theo, by contrast, was pale, temperamentally melancholy and resigned to observing a tidy decorum in his business dealings. He dressed nattily, toiled steadily and gradually rose in the Goupil hierarchy. His never-failing patience with Vincent, though sorely tried during the second year of his brother's sojourn, stemmed in part from his awareness of his brother's unbalanced mental state.

Vincent was "relentlessly self-regarding and self-analytical," Mr. Unger tells us. "It's no coincidence that the bulk of his self-portraits date from his time in Paris, for these were years in which he was searching for his identity, both as an artist and as a man." Mr. Unger writes of the brothers' time together in a sympathetic but slightly appalled and occasionally moralistic manner, doubtless wishing to dodge the pitfalls of imposing a posthumous medical verdict on Vincent's condition in Paris. Regrettably this approach impedes a full engagement with Vincent's condition.

There is an astonishing moment, for instance, in which we learn that Vincent had developed such a wretched case of tooth decay that his teeth were extracted and replaced by dentures. In anybody's medical history this would be symptomatic—but of what? Mr. Unger tentatively puts the crisis down to bad food, heavy smoking and overconsumption of alcohol, but this opinion feels insufficient. It is known that mental-health issues can lead to tooth and gum problems, and that syphilis, which affected Theo and perhaps also Vincent, can manifest in the mouth.

Alongside Van Gogh's day-to-day travails and impetuosities, he was immersing himself in the city's artistic life. He discovered work by the Impressionists and other adventurous colorists. Among the painters he admired were the pointillists Georges Seurat and Paul Signac and a crop of lesser-known but talented people, including Émile Bernard and Maximilien Luce. He enrolled in an art school, where he was befriended by a number of fellow students, notably Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec. Toward the end, he met Paul Gauguin, with whom he would soon form a rewarding relationship in Provence.

In Paris Vincent tried his hand, with quite original results, at *plein air* Impressionism, pointillism and Japanese-inspired pictures that portend his future interest in Gauguin. In Theo's neighborhood a remarkable man named Julien Tanguy kept a busy little

Please turn to page C8

BOOKS

'Physics is an immense edifice that surpasses the strength of a single mind.' —ÉMILIE DU CHÂTELET

FIVE BEST ON WOMEN IN SCIENCE

Olivia Campbell

The author, most recently, of 'Sisters in Science: How Four Women Physicists Escaped Nazi Germany and Made Scientific History'

18 Tiny Deaths
By Bruce Goldfarb (2020)

1 Frances Glessner Lee became the mother of forensic science by pioneering the use of crime-scene models to teach police officers how to observe and interpret evidence. In "18 Tiny Deaths," Bruce Goldfarb documents the ingenious touches Lee made on her crime-scene dioramas—spilling red nail polish to mimic blood spatter, lacing stiff wires into homemade dolls to simulate rigor mortis—to ensure that her creations matched every detail of the case studies they depicted, from the scuffed linoleum to the open dresser drawers. Born in Chicago in 1878, Lee found her calling at age 51 after hearing a medical examiner lament that photographs alone didn't help his students study scenes of unexplained deaths. "Lee thought of the Chicago Symphony Orchestra diorama she had created" long before, Mr. Goldfarb writes. Working with a carpenter, she began crafting models of crime scenes on a 1-foot-to-1-inch scale in the workshop of her New Hampshire home. Lee helped found Harvard's Department of Legal Medicine and taught a scientific homicide seminar to police departments around the country. Mr. Goldfarb's engaging style brilliantly evokes Lee's singular personality while detailing her inimitable contributions.

The Glass Universe
By Dava Sobel (2016)

2 In the late 1800s, the Harvard College Observatory hired a group of women to interpret and catalog the images of stars its telescopes had captured on glass plates. The women were of different ages and circumstances, but all "were good at math, or devoted stargazers, or both," writes Dava Sobel in "The Glass Universe." Their pathbreaking endeavor, carried on for decades, generated findings such as Cecilia Payne's 1925 discovery that stars are composed of hydrogen and helium. Payne had studied physics and chemistry at Cambridge University's women's college before joining the group at Harvard and earning her doctorate in astronomy there; Williamina Fleming was a Scottish immigrant and single mother who had been the observatory director's maid before her career in astronomy; Annie Jump Cannon had practiced photography and studied astronomy in the 12 years between graduating from Wellesley College and being hired by Harvard. Though poorly compensated, the women proved their brilliance by cataloging roughly half a million plates. Their catalog, a "monumental work of stellar classification," Ms. Sobel writes, "is still in regular use." Astronomy students today learn the temperature order of the stars that Cannon developed.

The Scalpel and the Silver Bear
By Lori Alvord and Elizabeth Cohen Van Pelt (1999)

3 The first Navajo, or Diné, woman to become a board-certified surgeon didn't reach that milestone until 1994. Lori Alvord left her home in Crownpoint, N.M., at the age of 16 to study at Dartmouth and then Stanford University Medical School. When she returned home to practice medicine, however, a reckoning awaited. As Dr. Alvord observes in her exquisite memoir, "The Scalpel and the Bear": "For all its technological advances . . . modern medicine still has much to learn about healing." In Navajo culture, she tells us, "medicine is performed by a *hataalii*, someone who sees a person not simply as a body, but as a whole being." Dr. Alvord finally finds harmony in her life, and in those of her patients, by combining modern and traditional medicine. "Bringing the patients' spirits into the healing process was having results: I was seeing fewer complications, and the patients were happier."

HISTORIC COLLECTION/ALAMY

STARGAZERS Women computers at the Harvard College Observatory, ca. 1900.

La Dame d'Esprit
By Judith P. Zinsser (2006)

4 Judith P. Zinsser begins her biography of Émilie du Châtelet discussing the various ways she might introduce her subject. We could meet the French mathematician and physicist in 1749 as a pregnant 42-year-old at her desk in a palace in Lorraine, surrounded by "mathematical and astronomical treatises, the books of physics, and Newton's *Principia* and his *System of the World* that she had translated and on which she was now completing a commentary." Or we might first glimpse du Châtelet in Paris a few months earlier, in the house she shared with her professional collaborator, Voltaire, writing to her paramour (and the father of her unborn child), the poet and army officer Jean François de Saint-Lambert. Born in Paris in 1706, du Châtelet learned from the writers, scientists and other scholars who frequented her father's salon. Her father asked the secretary of the Académie des Sciences to teach the 10-year-old Émilie astronomy, ensuring "her studies in early adulthood rivaled those of her male intellectual contemporaries." She married, had three children and, at 26, was being tutored by France's top mathematicians. Her commentaries and translations of Newton were her magnum opus. "How she managed the entire translation in a single year," Ms. Zinsser writes, "remains a mystery."

The Fossil Hunter
By Shelley Emling (2009)

5 Growing up in 19th-century England, Mary Anning would go fossil-hunting with her father along the English Channel near their home in Lyme Regis. He sold the ammonites they found to passersby, who believed the beautiful shells brought good luck. Even after her father died in 1810, when Mary was 11, she continued searching for fossils. Her blockbuster finds come to life in Shelley Emling's "The Fossil Hunter." Mary's "discovery of the first complete skeleton of a completely unique and grisly 17-foot-long creature," when she was 12, "was nothing short of a small miracle." Funds from the sale of her ichthyosaurus helped feed the Anning family for months. In 1823 Mary "successfully challenged Georges Cuvier—perhaps the most influential figure in science at the time—following her discovery of a plesiosaur." She was the inspiration for the tongue twister that goes, "she sells seashells on the seashore," Ms. Emling writes, and her finds "laid the groundwork for Charles Darwin's theory of evolution."

A Matter Of Debt and Diplomacy

Continued from page C7

the problem worse. As the British press baron Lord Rothermere presciently observed of the debt settlements, they were both bound to collapse and to make "an active contribution towards the destruction of international trade."

Ms. Eicher ably leans on the contrasting characters of Mellon and Churchill to make what might otherwise be a dull and difficult story of interlocking postwar financial tensions into a colorful and lucid one. But it's unfortunate she does not have more to say about the subsequent history, and possible future, of debt diplomacy.

After World War II, the Truman administration, in wholesale contrast to the Harding and Coolidge administrations, made a deliberate decision to place the rapid recovery of democratic capitalist allies, old and new, at the forefront of foreign policy, most notably with the grant-based Marshall Plan. German debts were extinguished—both internal and external. What followed was an extraordinary and enduring economic and diplomatic success. Today, it is difficult to detect either the will or the capacity, in any geopolitical circumstance, to make the sort of short-term national sacrifice such long-term success involved.

The U.S., which in 1985 became a debtor nation for the first time since the Wilson administration, has in the past four decades accumulated prodigious international obligations—now at $8.5 trillion, or nearly a third of the total U.S. debt held by the public. Looking forward, then, what kind of foreign policy can the U.S. afford? Unlike in the 1920s and '40s, its lenders will have a say. Hailing America's new creditor status in 1916, President Wilson crowed: "We can determine to a large extent who is to be financed and who is not to be." Over the subsequent decades the U.S. used that power to great effect—at times wisely, at times not. Now others—most notably, China—will play their hand.

Mr. Steil is the director of international economics at the Council on Foreign Relations and the author, most recently, of "The World That Wasn't: Henry Wallace and the Fate of the American Century."

HULTON-DEUTSCH/GETTY IMAGES

BULLDOG Churchill in 1924.

Van Gogh's Impressions Of Paris

Continued from page C7

shop selling cheap art supplies. Père Tanguy, as he was known, was a true man of the people, which struck a chord with the vaguely socialist Vincent; Tanguy welcomed avant-garde artists and other independent-minded people to his premises. He exhibited art as well, including paintings by Paul Cézanne, Camille Pissarro and Claude Monet.

The effect of Tanguy's collection on Van Gogh was dramatic. Before his arrival in Paris, Van Gogh at the easel thought largely as a draftsman, concentrating on outlines and tonal shades. Now, in Paris, he began a deliberate study of color and its potential. Working fast, he knocked out a large number of flower pictures and cityscapes, and also some remarkably fine portraits, especially of himself, their unusual colors chiming perfectly with their subject's morose expression. And his pieces of this period are by no means simple exercises: One might mention the "Restaurant Interior" (1887), in which pointillist dotting is enlisted, surprisingly, to create a shadowy indoor image, or the "Portrait of Père Tanguy" (1887), with its vivid background composed of Japanese woodcuts.

About a third of Mr. Unger's long book is devoted to Van Gogh's early period in Holland and Belgium before his move to Paris, and one supposes that Mr. Unger's main thesis, the transformative influence of his Paris phase, has somehow misled him into playing down the Netherlandish side of the artist's aesthetic personality. He says of the Hague School of painters—one of whom, Anton Mauve, Van Gogh sought out—that they adapted the ideas of advanced French painting "in a toned-down form pleasing to conservative eyes." This is dreadfully dismissive. The Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, is currently presenting a superb show of works by members of this important group; it proves, if proof were needed, that they possessed an independent vision and a sensitivity to the weather and light of their homeland.

Mr. Unger's tendency to dismissiveness is even more marked in his attitude toward Jean-François Millet, the greatest of the midcentury French painters of rural landscape and farm life. Millet was a stunning draftsman, subtle colorist and perceptive student of the gestures and postures of people at work. Mr. Unger tells us that Van Gogh, in his early pictures of impoverished Dutch peasants and miners, saw his subjects through Millet's "sentimental lens." But Millet was not a sentimentalist; he was a deft, keen observer, and Van Gogh never abandoned Millet as his chief spiritual influence.

The pre-Paris Van Gogh, in Mr. Unger's tale, was a "painter of no particular skill or obvious gifts, a provincial rube clinging stubbornly to outmoded ideas," who was transformed into a genius largely by virtue of going to the right place and meeting the right people. But to make this claim is to confuse talent with what we call facility. It is true that the young Van Gogh had no facility. In drawing he bore down intensely on his line, betraying a latent desire to handle the medium aggressively, and this heaviness would stay with him all his days. What he had was talent, which to discerning people means personality—a unique inner light and an insistence upon its truth.

When the artist arrived in Paris, he already had talent. By the time he left, he had facility too.

It is Mr. Unger's conviction that Van Gogh's brooding, quasimessianic obsession with peasant suffering was somehow holding him back, and was essentially deflected from his real destiny. But this is wrong. The Dutchman's conception of painting as redemptive—a kind of de-Calvinized devotional activity—would never leave him. His fierce, thick strokes, as found in outlines and hatchings, were explicitly intended to evoke and parallel the sacred labor of the peasant. The early drawings—of the coffee drinker, the weaver at his loom, the parsonage garden, the digger and the reaper—and such paintings as "The Potato Eaters" (1885) and "Head of a Peasant Woman in a White Bonnet" (1885), the latter a treasure of the Norton Simon Museum in Pasadena, Calif., already embody essential traits of Van Gogh's vision.

Mr. Unger's portrayal of the artistic life of the French capital in the 1880s is painfully pedestrian, resembling a routine American college course on the subject. Why, for example, must one be treated to another denigration of the academic resistance to the more adventurous painters of the period? Doesn't this historic clash—a conflict between modes of perception—merit some objective analysis instead of prompting yet again the cliché of a bad, benighted orthodoxy versus a good, free-spirited rebellion?

JOSEPH WINTERBOTHAM COLLECTION/BRIDGEMAN IMAGES

ITERATIVE 'Self-Portrait' (1887) by Van Gogh.

Because "A Fire in His Soul" ends (except for a brief coda) with Van Gogh's departure for Provence in 1888, the book doesn't take up the question of what became of the artist's initial interest in peasant themes now that he found himself residing once again in the countryside. In fact, after a hiatus the interest returned in full strength. In Van Gogh's new work, Millet's dominant motif—that of the sower at work—reappeared several times, recast in smoldering colors. In various paintings peasant laborers are depicted tossing seeds, reaping, harvesting olives, weeding vines, picking grapes and washing clothes by a river. With particular keenness Van Gogh put out for his superb portraits people who were clearly representatives of the peasant-farming civilization of the Midi.

Can it be claimed that Mr. Unger has added anything new to our conception of Vincent van Gogh? That's a hard question to answer, but if so, much more has gone by the board. Lost is the tormented, single-minded Van Gogh, a man ferociously following his inner light, a man who borrowed from painters in Paris as he borrowed a little from everyone, a distraught champion of the downtrodden working out his own strange salvation.

Mr. Hofstadter is the author of "Falling Palace" and other works.

‘It behooves us, then, to humble ourselves before the offended Power . . . and to pray for clemency and forgiveness.’ —ABRAHAM LINCOLN

Heaven on Their Side

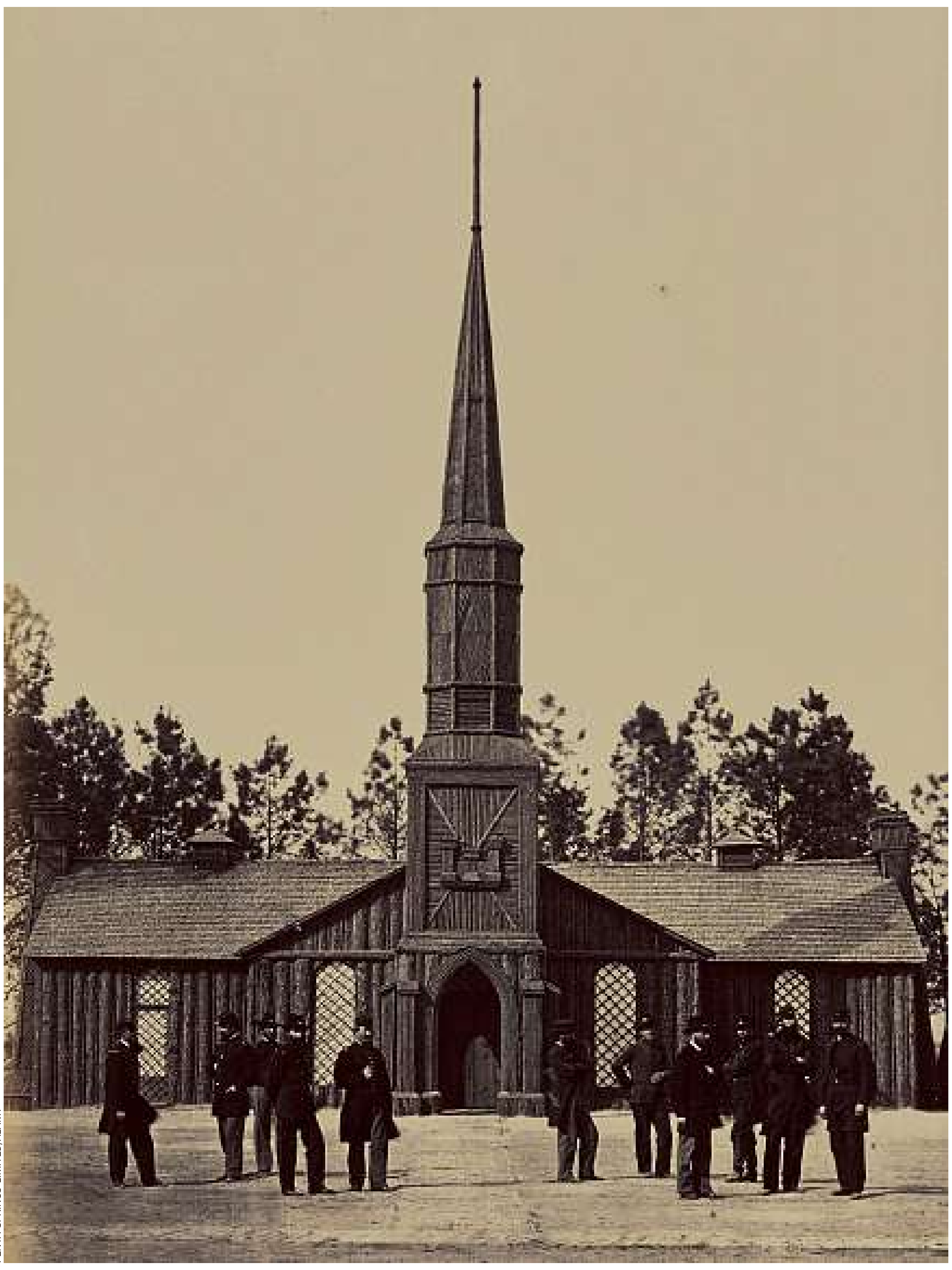
Righteous Strife
By Richard Carwardine
Knopf, 624 pages, $35

By Amanda Brickell Bellows

AS A YOUNG man in Illinois, Abraham Lincoln was a religious skeptic. Raised in the Presbyterian Church, he would later decline to attend services and publicly question Christianity's central tenets. But when the Civil War broke out following his election to the presidency, Lincoln underwent a spiritual transformation.

In “Righteous Strife,” Richard Carwardine explores how Lincoln's faith shaped his actions during the Civil War and how the nation responded to his decisions. Mr. Carwardine, an emeritus Rhodes professor of American history at Oxford University, tackles a topic many Civil War scholars have tended to overlook: the influence of faith in wartime politics and nationalism. To understand how Lincoln and the broader populace viewed the Civil War and slavery through the lens of religion, Mr. Carwardine has studied underused primary sources, including pamphlets, sermons, church reports and newspapers. He argues that Lincoln's “wartime religious turn” prompted the president to issue “executive action to upend the historic social order” and that, for many Americans, “the interpenetration of politics and religion became the wartime norm.”

From the nation's earliest days, religion played an important role in American civic life. The preservation of religious liberty in the Constitution's First Amendment led to the creation of what Mr. Carwardine calls a “free religious marketplace” in the young republic, where Americans were at liberty to practice their religion, be it Protestantism, Roman Catholicism, Judaism or Islam. Between 1790 and 1860, when religious revivals swept across the nation, Americans established no fewer than 50,000 churches serving congregants from two dozen Protestant denominations. Paradoxically, religious pluralism initially led to convergence rather than sectarianism, Mr. Carwardine contends, because the multiplicity of faiths prevented “the dominance of an intolerant majority.”



PENTA SPRINGS LIMITED/ALAMY

GOOD FIGHT Poplar Grove Church in 1865. The church was built near Petersburg, Va., by a Union army regiment.

Among the Protestant churches that composed most houses of worship during the first half of the 19th century, slavery became an increasingly divisive issue. As the profits from cotton production swelled, white Southern ministers and congregants argued that slavery was a “positive good.” By contrast, Mr. Carwardine posits, the idea “that slavery was cruel and unjust was a widely held view” among Northern churchgoers, who supported policies ranging from immediate abolition and gradual emancipation to voluntary migration. By 1861, the Presbyterian, Baptist and Methodist churches in the U.S. split internally over disagreements about slavery.

When the Civil War began, many Americans interpreted the conflict from a faith-based perspective. Mr. Carwardine finds that Lincoln intensified “his inquiry into the spiritual and religious dimensions of humankind” over the next four years, viewing God as a power who directly intervened in human events. To discern the proper course of action as president, Lincoln often prayed but also read petitions and resolutions from different houses of worship. Weeks after the Confederate victory at the First Battle of Bull Run on July 21, 1861, Lincoln recommended a national day of fasting to occur on Sept. 26. It would be the first of several such proclamations during his presidency, encouraging Americans to reflect upon the nation's troubles and to pray for what Lincoln called “a speedy restoration of peace.”

Although Lincoln hoped that the conflict would end quickly, swift Union victory proved elusive. During the war, Lincoln's position on slavery evolved. At first, Mr. Carwardine shows, Lincoln promoted gradual abolition and the emancipation of enslaved people only in Washington, D.C. But continued Union military losses coupled with urgent calls from churches for nationwide abolition convinced Lincoln to reconsider his policy goals.

After the Battle of Antietam in September 1862, Lincoln signed a preliminary emancipation proclamation announcing his intention to liberate enslaved people within the Confederacy on Jan. 1, 1863. According to Mr. Carwardine, it was “an acknowledgement” that Lincoln “had sided with the now-exultant religious forces of antislavery nationalism, who would thereafter work hard to keep the administration true to its declared purpose.”

Witnesses marveled at the pace of change under the Lincoln administration. “We are living years in days, and centuries in years,” wrote one observer in the Christian Recorder, praising God for “every successive step” leading toward slavery's abolition. But there was still much to be done to fully secure the freedom of the nation's four million enslaved African-Americans, many of whom lived in border states that were exempted from the Emancipation Proclamation.

Throughout the remainder of the war, Lincoln conversed with Catholic, Jewish and Protestant Americans to understand their perspectives and consider how popular opinion ought to shape his policies. In the autumn of 1864, Lincoln was re-elected for another term. During his second inaugural address he quoted from Scripture and, Mr. Carwardine observes, “reflected on the purposes of an Almighty God and His judgment on the American nation.”

Abraham Lincoln drew on religious feeling to bolster the Union's resolve—and his own.

“He gives to both North and South, this terrible war, as the woe due to those by whom the offense came,” Lincoln declared, condemning the South for seceding over slavery but also the North for previously perpetuating slavery through commerce and politics. With the war's end in sight, he now called for unity, asking Americans to “achieve and cherish a just and lasting peace.”

One month later, John Wilkes Booth, a Confederate sympathizer, assassinated Lincoln on Good Friday, shocking the nation and ushering in a time of political uncertainty. Vice President Andrew Johnson soon stepped into the void to preside over a subsequent period of “Presidential Reconstruction” characterized by division, political infighting and white supremacist violence. As they did in wartime, many Americans would turn again to their faith to make sense of a dramatically changing postwar world.

Ms. Bellows is a historian and the author of “The Explorers: A New History of America in Ten Expeditions.”

Home in a Bloody Borderland

Hard Neighbors
By Colin G. Calloway
Oxford, 528 pages, $35

By Peter Cozzens

COMPLAINING to James Monroe around 1780 about what he considered to be the cause of a deterioration in American politics, the English-born Maj. Gen. Charles Lee of the Continental Army told the future president that a troublesome and degenerate element had usurped the colonies' assemblies. Rather than instruments of democracy, these bodies now reflected “a Macocracy by which I mean a banditti of low Scotch-Irish whose names generally begin with Mac—and who are either the sons of Imported Servants or themselves imported Servants.”

Lee was guilty of hyperbole based on bigotry: The Scotch-Irish, who numbered in the hundreds of thousands, did not run the Continental Congress or state houses. Rather, the vast majority eked out a marginal living farming on the American frontier, where they served as a tool in the dispossession of Native Americans, first in the service of British imperial designs and then of American expansion west of the Appalachians. Most were descendants of Presbyterian Scots whom the Royal government had relocated from the Scottish borders across the Irish Sea to Ulster in the early 17th century to tame the “wild” Catholic Irish. A century later, representing two-thirds of an Irish migration that would eventually approach 400,000, the Scotch-Irish from Ulster flocked to the colonial frontier in search of land, again acting as a buffer, this time against “wild” Native Americans. As Colin G. Calloway tells us in “Hard Neighbors,” the Scotch-Irish were “recurrent colonizers” who “perpetually opened new killing grounds.”

Mr. Calloway, a professor of history and Native American studies at Dartmouth, is uniquely qualified to dissect the role of the Scotch-Irish in the white conquest of Native American land in the 18th and early 19th centuries. No other historian today has written with greater breadth and insight on the fate of America's native peoples, nor with greater nuance and compassion for these complex, doomed cultures. He brings these same gifts to bear in “Hard Neighbors,” which examines the emergence and eventual dominance of the Scotch-Irish as the Woodland Indians' principal antagonists.

On the American borderland, Mr. Calloway discerns what began as a “triangular relationship,” of which the Scotch-Irish and the Native Americans formed two points. The third was the government, which the Scotch-Irish came to resent and distrust. “As inhabitants of frontier regions,” writes Mr. Calloway, the Scotch-Irish faced Native Americans to the west, “who were neighbors and enemies, and they looked east to the colonial, state, or federal government that positioned them on the frontier, encouraged their incursions on Indian land, then denounced them and failed to defend the frontiers when contestation turned to conflict.” The government used the Scotch-Irish “as expendable defensive barriers.”

Mr. Calloway's narrative gains particular pathos when it addresses three watershed moments in the Scotch-Irish frontier experience. The first was the French and Indian War, in which the Scotch-Irish served as proxies for the British in battling the Native Americans, who were proxies of the French. “Instances of violence between hard neighbors gave way to unrestrained race war,” the author writes. For the Scotch-Irish who suffered through the war, the conflict shaped their identity as killers of Native Americans, often at odds with government—in this case the British who sought to restrain them from provoking further troubles with the Native Americans at war's end.

ALTO VINTAGE IMAGES/ALAMY

OUT WEST ‘The Greeting’ (ca. 1860) by Alfred Jacob Miller.

The French and Indian War made the Scotch-Irish insular and suspicious of colonial authority. But it was the Revolutionary War, Mr. Calloway convincingly demonstrates, that made them into Americans. Before the revolution, most colonists would have agreed with Charles Lee that the backcountry Scotch-Irish were unruly troublemakers hardly more civilized than their Native American neighbors. But the revolution depicted all Native Americans “as enemies of American independence” and turned the killing of Native Americans “into a patriotic duty.” The Scotch-Irish, Mr. Calloway tells us, “became American by killing Indians.”

The third theme in “Hard Neighbors” is the emergence of Andrew Jackson, first as an American Indian-fighting general in the War of 1812 and later as the president and instigator of the Trail of Tears. Although Mr. Calloway considers it “a distortion to suggest that he governed as a Scotch-Irish president,” the author does regard the expulsion of Native Americans from the South during Jackson's presidency as the “triumph of Scotch-Irish Indian policy.” Ironically, observes Mr. Calloway, the Scotch-Irish lost more than they gained from the Trail of Tears. Land speculators and wealthy slave owners drove up the price of former Native American lands beyond that which the Scotch-Irish farmers could afford.

The westward movement of the Scotch-Irish continued. Thousands migrated first to Missouri and the Ozarks, then southwest to the Texas borderland, where they again became “hard neighbors,” the vanguard of dispossessors of Native American country. There the role of the Scotch-Irish as the clearly discernible spearhead of Americana expansion largely ended. Their fierce acquisitiveness, however, found expression in the more generalized white settlement of the American West.

Running as an undercurrent throughout “Hard Neighbors” is Mr. Calloway's belief that the Scotch-Irish experience on the American frontier has shaped contemporary American politics in ways we may be unaware. “Donald Trump won massive support,” he notes, “in areas of the country where Scotch-Irish people and their descendants had settled and where the current inhabitants' sense of their identities, their attitudes to others and to government, and their grievances bore remarkable similarities to those of the Scotch-Irish on the backcountry.”

In the woodlands on the American frontier, Scotch-Irish settlers found plenty of enemies.

One may dispute Mr. Calloway's interpretation of the modern expression of Scotch-Irish identity, or the extent to which many Americans have come to identify with traditional Scotch-Irish traits. There can be no denying, however, that “Hard Neighbors” represents a seminal reappraisal of the early decades of American expansion.

Mr. Cozzens is the author of “The Earth Is Weeping: The Epic Story of the Indian Wars for the American West,” among other books.

BOOKS

'How hard it is to change one's life. . . . How terrifyingly simple to change the lives of others.' —CYNTHIA OZICK

Refuge and Conversation In Vienna

The Café With No Name
By Robert Seethaler
Europa, 208 pages, $25

By Heller McAlpin

ROBERT SEETHALER, a writer born in Vienna in 1966, is an exquisite miniaturist whose concise novels depict the quotidian struggles of ordinary, hardworking Austrians in the 20th century. His interest is in how these small-scale lives fit into the larger picture of a country subject to dizzying changes through the decades before and after World War II.

Mr. Seethaler's quietly beguiling eighth novel, "The Café With No Name," is his most uplifting to date. It spans a decade—1966-76—in the life of an unassuming young man named Robert Simon. After seven years of unloading crates of vegetables at the Karmelitermarkt in Vienna's poor but bustling Leopoldstadt neighborhood, Robert decides to open a cafe nearby. He is determined to establish a congenial place for customers to gather and "talk if you need to, or shut up if you'd rather." As it turns out, the cafe creates a sort of found family for Robert and his patrons.

Despite a difficult childhood—he was orphaned in the war—Robert is kindhearted and utterly without self-pity. When we meet him at age 31, he has been boarding for some time in the apartment of Martha Pohl, a war widow. Like many of Mr. Seethaler's characters, she sometimes speaks in aphorisms: "You always need a bit more hope than worries," Martha tells Robert. "Anything else would be pointless, wouldn't it?"

The themes of renewal and transformation underlie the novel like girders. When Robert signs the lease for a derelict, abandoned corner cafe, the landlord assures him that the economy is looking up—even though this grimy neighborhood is, in the narrator's words, "still coated in the dust left behind by the war." Indeed, Robert's singlehanded renovations mirror the urban renewal taking place all over Vienna during the 1960s and '70s, and are reflected in the pervasive sounds of construction.

Like Mr. Seethaler's "A Whole Life" (2015), this novel features a hardworking, highly capable orphan whose days are beset with difficulty. But "A Whole Life," which takes place earlier in the 20th century, encompasses one man's entire woefully bleak lifespan. "The Café With No Name" zeroes in on a more hopeful slice of its hero's adulthood, when Robert is consumed by his demanding business.

Gradually, a diverse group of regulars make the cafe their home. In a series of empathetic portraits, Mr. Seethaler deftly captures the texture of their lives and their position in the awakening city.

For some, the cafe is a stopping place after a long day of factory work. For others, it's a way station on nightly drinking odysseys. The fishmonger stops in to argue over local politics and play cards while the cheesemonger comes to rage about her unfaithful boyfriend, a Russian painter 15 years her junior.

In time, Robert hires Mila Szabica, a girl from the countryside who has been laid off from what was supposed to be "a safe job for life" in the

After a childhood on his own, one Viennese man's ambition is to create a place he and others can call home amid the city's bustle.

local textile factory that now must compete with cheap imports from China. Mila is diligent and reliable—which can't be said for the customer she marries, René Wurm, a sweet, battered wrestler who repeatedly sabotages his career with heavy drinking.

Mr. Seethaler offers glimpses of Robert's feelings, including his yearning for a girlfriend. During a rare moment of reflection in his busy schedule, he "couldn't help smiling at the thought of all the lost souls who came together in his cafe every day." Robert muses: "It was strange how little information he had about them and yet how well he knew them. But perhaps he was kidding himself. Perhaps there was no one he truly knew. Not even himself."

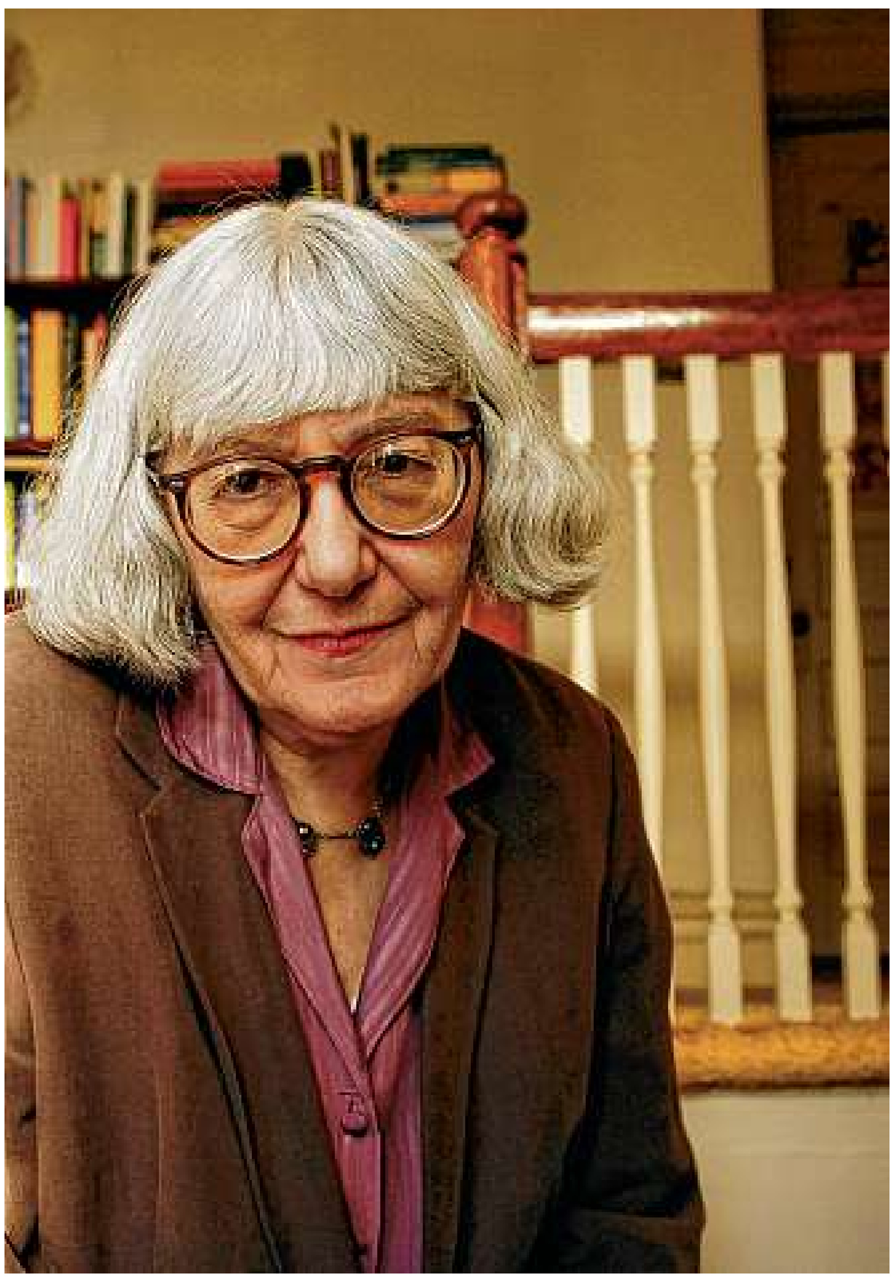
Similarly, readers come to realize how little we ourselves know about these characters—including Robert's aging landlady, whom he cares for devotedly. Particularly enigmatic are two female regulars at the cafe, whose gossipy conversations are presented in unbroken chains of dialogue. "Goodness me, why do people always have to be so unhappy?" one asks after she learns that another body has been fished from the Danube.

"The Café With No Name" is smoothly and straightforwardly translated from the German by Katy Derbyshire. The sense of community that emerges in the nameless coffee house recalls the connections forged between quirky, lonely people in Haruki Murakami's stories and in Satoshi Yagisawa's novel, "Days at the Morisaki Bookshop."

At one point, Robert attempts to articulate what the cafe means to his patrons: "The world's turning faster and faster, and now and then it throws people off course whose lives are heavy enough as it is. Isn't it a good thing if there's a place for them to hold onto?"

Mr. Seethaler's sensitive, compassionate novel provides such a toehold.

Ms. McAlpin's reviews appear frequently in the Journal and elsewhere.



ULF ANDERSEN/GETTY IMAGES

CYNOSURE Cynthia Ozick in 2007.

Both Sides Now

In a Yellow Wood
By Cynthia Ozick
Everyman's Library, 712 pages, $40

By Sam Sacks

'HOW, after all, does one dare, how can one presume?" That is Cynthia Ozick on the paralyzing challenge of saying something new about Franz Kafka. But they can be applied equally to Ms. Ozick, who in her 60-plus years of publishing has produced a body of work—novels, short stories, essays, criticism, poetry and plays—unrivaled by any living American author. Can such a monument be summarized without being cheapened?

One dares to try in part because of the mist of obscurity that has always surrounded Ms. Ozick's output, the rift between her reputation and her readership. Perhaps no other author of her accomplishment has been so consistently taken for granted. Ms. Ozick is 96 years old and still laboring at her trade like an outsider with something to prove. Not for her are the perquisites of eminence. There have been no vague, self-indulgent late works (her 2021 novel, "Antiquities," is as sharp and questing as anything she has written); no retirement celebrations, Festschrifts or public tributes as there were for her contemporary Philip Roth. The closest Ms. Ozick may come to a career retrospective is "In a Yellow Wood," a heaping selection of short stories and essays that seems likely to burnish her legacy while continuing to confound all attempts at marketing her.

Ms. Ozick chose the pieces for this volume herself, drawing, in nonchronological fashion, from every period of her career (the oldest work is from 1971, the most recent from 2024). In her introduction she explains her decision to include both short stories and essays, a breach of the usual firewall that separates fiction and nonfiction anthologies. The title "In a Yellow Wood" comes from Robert Frost's "The Road Not Taken" and speaks to a professional journey that, to the confusion of her would-be audience, has led her down two discrete paths simultaneously. Her essays, most of them literary criticism, are works of steely evaluation and argument. Her stories are enterprises of invention, sorties into a great unknown. With unapologetic ambivalence, Ms. Ozick wonders, "is one traveler on two roads afflicted by writerly fever, or has it been little more than hubris and folly?"

As a critic, Cynthia Ozick offers razor precision. Her fiction trades in an almost willful freedom.

Not the latter, surely, yet Ms. Ozick is right to observe that the esteem afforded to her as a critic has muddled the reception of her fiction. The essays included here, each written with passionate conviction, exacting standards and thrilling verbal panache, make her mastery of the form all the more apparent. She effuses about "the gargoylish and astonishing map" of the world conjured by the Polish-Jewish writer Bruno Schulz. Saul Bellow, she observes, achieved his most enduring novelistic effects when he learned to "force intellect into hiding" and rely on intuition. In "What Helen Keller Saw," she commemorates the woman who activated so much experience in what Keller called her "mental vision." The artist, Ms. Ozick continually asserts, must claim absolute imaginative freedom, even at the risk of being misunderstood. "Coiled in the bottommost pit of every driven writer is an impersonator—protean, volatile, restless and relentless," she says in "Isaac Babel and the Identity Question."

Impersonators and pretenders feature in most of her short stories, which are, in contrast with Ms. Ozick's nonfiction, oblique, ambiguous and inflected by minor-key comedy. These are fable-like tales of artistic delusions and disappointments. "The Biographer's Hat" concerns a hilarious scheme to sex up a literary subject's past to make his life story more salable. Similar is "The Conversion of the Jews," about a flailing scholar of the Inquisition who tries to access the visionary insights of religious mystics to reveal history's secrets. ("He was after impulses, inducements, animating subterranean drives.") "Virility" centers on a plagiarist poet—he steals from his spinster aunt—and "Sin" portrays an ancient shut-in painter who looks like "someone's abandoned messiah."

An obsession with art links the fiction to the essays, but because the stories are usually about Jewish lives there is a complicating wrinkle: The writer's sanction to freely imagine runs afoul of the obedience demanded by God, who—as Ms. Ozick writes in the brilliant "Usurpation (Other People's Stories)"—"cannot be imagined in any form, whom the very hope of imagining offends." The characters, however fervent their aspirations, are so often presented as impostors because, in a cosmic sense, they are guilty of idolatry, having devoted themselves wholeheartedly to images of their own creation.

The irony of their predicament shows itself everywhere on the forked paths of Ms. Ozick's writing and illuminates her own role in evading public acclaim. The most noticeable omission from "In a Yellow Wood" is "The Shawl," a desperately sad short story about an infant's death in a Nazi concentration camp. "The Shawl" is by far Ms. Ozick's most well-known work and is often taught in schools. But she has come to be troubled by it, considering it (harshly, in this critic's opinion) an instance of the kind of Holocaust kitsch that she decries in her extraordinary essay "Who Owns Anne Frank?" As she told an interviewer about using the Holocaust as a subject, "I write about it. I can't not. But I don't think I ought to."

Such are the fertile contradictions of Cynthia Ozick, a self-described "fanatic" of literature who grasps better than anyone the moral perils of fanaticism, an accomplished writer who deeply distrusts the worldly authority her writing has earned her. "The power of language, it seems to me, is the only kind of power a writer is entitled to," she once said. So this titan of literature keeps her head down, toiling away like the hapless strivers and mole-eyed bookworms of her stories, working not for recognition but to contribute something lasting to posterity, with its dreamt-of future readers who are as avid for the pleasures of art as she is. Now *that* is daring, *that* is presumption.

Mr. Sacks is the Journal's fiction critic.

The History Of a Prodigal Father

Lion
By Sonya Walger
NYRB, 176 pages, $15.95

By Anna Mundow

SONYA WALGER'S debut novel is, in the words of the anonymous narrator, "a book about love." Not the romantic kind—though longing saturates these pages—but the trickier family variety, which here encompasses the care bestowed by a steadfast mother and the flamboyant gestures of a mercurial, largely absent father. Forming the emotional core of the novel is the lifelong yearning of a daughter for the affection of a parent from whom she learns to expect inconstancy. "I am used to him not knowing how old I am," the writer recalls of her 13-year-old self, who received letters that read like fiction from a father who never visited her boarding school. As an even younger child she experienced the critical insight that "my father loves me utterly and yet without precision, that he is vague on the details of my life because he disdains the quotidian."

"Lion" chronicles the marriages and resulting offspring that this charming narcissist casually launches into being: planets to his sun, as he sees them, forever fixed in orbit around his supercharged ego. "He fathered four only children," this daughter, the eldest, tells us, "each with a story of our own neglect and love. My story is all I have." Littered with disappointments and betrayals, "Lion" might well have made grim reading. Instead, we are given a seductive work of autobiographical fiction with stories that seem too good to be invented.

"But how hard to be the one who stayed!" the novel opens, giving us a vivid snapshot of the narrator's mother. "The one who . . . washed the sheets, staunched the blood, ignored the lies and the slammed doors . . . who signed birthday cards in his name, lied in his name, raised a human in his name." It is as though the narrator has rushed up to us, reciting a litany of her mother's daily chores, some funny, all of them touching ("bought the bras, the Walkman, the wedding dress"). From its scenes of childhood bewilderment through its portrait of adult disillusion, "Lion" holds our attention. Ms. Walger scans the past restlessly, alighting now on a childhood memory, now on an adult revelation, roaming from England to Argentina with many stops in between.

The novel's elliptical style reflects the narrator's sense that life is "all things all at the same time." It also mirrors the elusive nature of her subject: the daring, outlandish father whose very birth is a family legend. For he appears accompanied by an earthquake. "Tens of thousands of people disappear into the earth as my father arrives in the world," his daughter writes of Argentina's 1944 catastrophe. She omits the year, however, and the more precise estimate of 10,000 fatalities. Dates and names may be extraneous in a portrait of one whose birth was nothing less than "the story of the arrival of a minor god."

This soon-to-be tarnished deity was raised in Buenos Aires, the son of "doting intellectuals"

In an attempt to come to terms with her charismatic, selfish father, a writer takes stock of her most bittersweet memories.

who nonetheless routinely abandoned him and his sisters. Beautiful, beguiling and weaned on lies, he would mature into a charmer who consistently shuns reality in favor of romance. "Twelve weeks of courtship," the narrator writes of her parents' engagement. "Two continents, two languages, and eight years between them." Her British mother, who "belongs to a world that is reliable," marries into a shockingly alien one. A dutiful bride, "she carefully writes her thank-you letters, hands them to my father to mail. They never arrive." Unwilling to queue for stamps, he simply throws them into the trash.

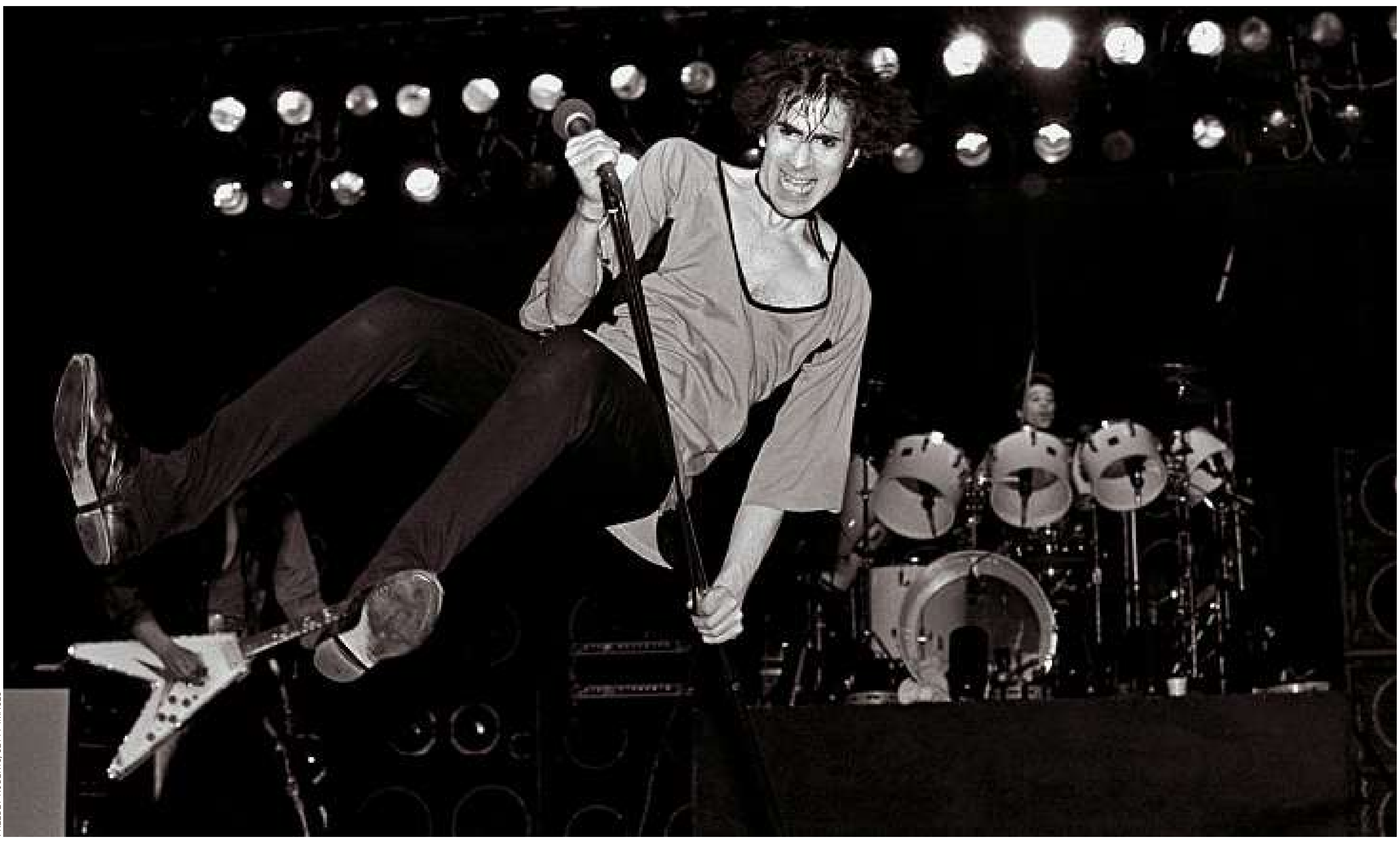
Though frequently broke, he is accustomed to exquisite clothes, drinks from "espresso cups of silver so thin you can dent them with your thumb," has politically dangerous friends and, eventually, acquires an alcohol and drug habit. In one memorable scene, his adult daughter, who has had some wild days of her own, recalls the graying hero and his fellow "aging hipsters" exhibiting what passes for restraint on a typical evening when she visits as a young woman. "They wait till I have gone to bed," she writes, "to pull cocaine from their beautiful old wallets and line it up with practiced ease on the card table."

The power of description throughout "Lion" calls to mind Julia Blackburn's brilliant family portrait "The Three of Us" (2008), in which another ungoverned father inexplicably retains a daughter's love. "Lion" ends with a declaration of the narrator's enduring devotion and an epiphany that accompanies the heartbreak of her father's death. "I used to say that being loved by my father was like being loved by a lighthouse," she concludes. "It went dark for a very long time and then you were dazzled by the stroke of the glancing beam. But I have come to realize that I was the steady one, searching the dark water in order to find someone to save."

Ms. Mundow is a writer in Massachusetts.

BOOKS

'I've had the blues / The reds and the pinks / One thing for sure / Love stinks.' —PETER WOLF


FREEBET ROBERTS/GETTY IMAGES

FREEZE FRAME Peter Wolf performing with the J. Geils Band in New York City in 1980.

He Howled With the Pack

Waiting on the Moon
By Peter Wolf
Little, Brown, 352 pages, $30

BY DAVE SHIFLETT

SOMETIMES IT'S who you know, sometimes it's what you know, and in Peter Wolf's case the who is every bit as impressive as the what.

Mr. Wolf, the former lead singer of the J. Geils Band, might not be on everyone's musical radar. But he also rubbed shoulders (and bent elbows) with a horde of A-listers, many of them remembered, usually fondly, in "Waiting on the Moon," Mr. Wolf's breezy, boozy and sometimes illuminating memoir.

He was born Peter Blankfield in the Bronx, N.Y., in 1946. His parents were "fellow travelers" with strong political convictions and a pleasantly long leash. Mr. Wolf took up cigarettes at age 11, hung out in bars before he was legal age, and basked in the 1960s New York folk scene of Dave Van Ronk, Maria Muldaur, Tiny Tim and Bob Dylan.

Mr. Wolf was known to sneak sips from Mr. Dylan's wine glass. He also took in performances by Louis Armstrong and was a regular at the Apollo Theater, though his initial musical expression—playing triangle in the school band—was overshadowed by his love of painting, enhanced by an acquaintance with Norman Rockwell during Mr. Wolf's youth.

He also had a knack for bumping into interesting people. Shortly after Mr. Wolf arrived in Boston for art school in 1964, a stranger saw him perusing a bulletin board and asked, "Are you looking for a roommate?" The stranger turned out to be the future film director David Lynch, who would eventually change the lock at their shared apartment after Mr. Wolf repeatedly failed to pay the rent on time. When Mr. Wolf slipped through a window and exited with an armful of his paintings he was accosted by police who mistook him for another celebrity of sorts—the Boston Strangler.

Mr. Wolf's musical life blossomed in Boston, where he hosted a late-night radio show (DJ name: Woofa Goofa) and fronted a band called the Hallucinations. He chilled, and guzzled, with the prodigiously temperamental Van Morrison, and befriended the blues legends Muddy Waters and Howlin' Wolf. In 1967 he joined the J. Geils Band, which opened for the Rolling Stones, B.B. King, Janis Joplin and Black Sabbath before becoming a headline act.

He also caught the eye of the actress Faye Dunaway, who had starred in "Bonnie and Clyde" (1967) and, like Mr. Wolf, was a fan of country music. "Sugar," she told him, "I was weaned on Lefty Frizzell, Ernest Tubb, and Kitty Wells." They spent their first date watching "Gunsmoke" (she was a major fan of Miss Kitty) and soon he was chilling (and often swilling) with other stars, including Raquel Welch, Steve McQueen, Alfred Hitchcock, Shelley Winters, Fred Astaire, Dennis Hopper, Carrie Fisher, Robin Williams, Timothy Leary, Tennessee Williams, O.J. Simpson and Paul Newman.

At one casual dinner he initially schmoozed with Robert De Niro and Dustin Hoffman, then redirected to Ryan O'Neal and the musicians Stevie Winwood and Glenn Frey. His ever-widening musical circle included Harry Nilsson, John Lennon, Mick Jagger, Keith Richards and Sly Stone.

> Peter Wolf's fame as a rock star was fleeting, but it lasted long enough to put him among music titans and screen idols.

While Mr. Wolf drops more names than Jerry Garcia dropped acid, he also fills his pages with amusing anecdotes and pulls off some pretty good lines. The poet Robert Lowell "looked like a man in a great rush who had forgotten exactly where he was rushing to." Lynch appeared to have come "from a world of fraternities, proms, and double dates."

The author also describes a lifestyle that might cause the surgeon general to have a heart attack. Mr. Wolf and accomplices did not simply drink multiple glasses of wine but multiple bottles—before proceeding to cocktails. Sometimes the first drinks came just on the heels of sunrise. At Jack Nicholson's house, a "mountain" of cocaine rose majestically from a table (after Ms. Dunaway and Mr. Nicholson disappeared for hours, Mr. Wolf dumped the whole thing into the backyard swimming pool).

Yet love, or perhaps hope, won out—at least for a while. Mr. Wolf and Ms. Dunaway were married in 1974. The matrimony lasted five years but did not end blissfully. "Don't worry, darling," Mr. Wolf overheard his wife say to a paramour. "I'll be getting rid of him shortly." In 1983 he parted ways with the J. Geils Band, though his charmed life continued. Mr. Wolf auditioned to play the infamous prefect Pontius Pilate in Martin Scorsese's "The Last Temptation of Christ" (1988), though the part eventually went to David Bowie. His musical life fared better and included collaborations with Aretha Franklin and Merle Haggard, which resulted in good tunes with memories to match.

Franklin was a woman who did as she pleased, sitting down beneath a studio "No Smoking" sign and firing up a Kool cigarette. Haggard lived by a similar spirit. One afternoon Mr. Wolf and Haggard met up with Willie Nelson and Ray Price (81 at the time) to drink whiskey (George Dickel, for those keeping score), smoke marijuana and discuss various matters of interest. Among them: Haggard's longstanding crush on Ms. Dunaway.

Mr. Shiflett posts his original music and writing at Daveshiflett.com.

Among Mysterious Branches

Under the Same Stars
By Libba Bray
FSG, 480 pages, $24.99

THE CENTRAL STORYLINE of Libba Bray's sprawling novel "Under the Same Stars" begins in Germany in 1939. Best friends Sophie and Hanna spend their summer exploring the forest by their town, especially the legendary Bridegroom's Oak, a "matchmaking tree" that people write to in the hope of finding romance. (The tree really does exist, Ms. Bray writes in an author's note, complete with its own postman.) But the tree can harbor more than love letters, the teenagers discover—it can also serve as a drop-off box for a local resistance group. When Sophie and Hanna vanish at the site of the Bridegroom's Oak two years later, their disappearance will reverberate throughout generations.

Ms. Bray weaves together Sophie and Hanna's story with two other plotlines, each of which picks up a thread of this unsolved mystery. We meet Jenny, a lonely American teenager whose family has relocated to Germany in the summer of 1980. Jenny finds herself falling for Lena, a free spirit who introduces her to the colorful world of West Berlin's underground punk scene. Jenny also befriends her elusive neighbor Frau Hermann, an older woman who survived World War II and speaks in half-riddles, half-fairy-tales about her painful past.

Then there's Miles and Chloe, two teenagers living in New York City at the height of the Covid-19 pandemic. Bored and isolated at home, the friends decide to solve a mystery in the spirit of their favorite true-crime podcast: Why has Chloe's grandmother left her a box of cassette tapes and a newspaper clipping about teenagers who had disappeared in a German forest almost a century ago?

It's an ambitious undertaking to tackle three distinct plotlines that vary so widely in time and geography, and some character arcs develop more organically than others. Jenny's story could have formed its own standalone book; by contrast, Miles and Chloe's sections felt rather didactic.

That's a shame because "Under the Same Stars" has a special appreciation for the power of a good story. As one character observes, fairy tales can be a way for people to talk about things that are too painful or complicated to explore otherwise. Ms. Bray's abundance of timelines and characters offers willing readers ages 12 to 18 different entry points into what is essentially one story: How we awaken to injustice around us and how we're called to act afterward.

SHORTCUTS: CHILDREN'S BOOKS

BY KATIE DANIELS


KARL-HEINZ MARTENS

LOVE KNOT Bridegroom's Oak, ca. 1930.

A Most Puzzling Legacy

Isle of Ever
By Jen Calonita
Sourcebooks Young Readers, 320 pages, $16.99

WHEN 12-YEAR-OLD Everly Benedict (Benny, to her friends and family) learns that she's the heir to a Long Island, N.Y., estate worth millions, she's savvy enough to know there must be a catch. In Jen Calonita's "Isle of Ever," Benny has two weeks to solve a series of riddles left by an ancestor from the 1800s; otherwise she will lose her inheritance. Undaunted by the challenge, she sets out for Long Island determined to win the game and claim the prize. For Benny and her mom, it's their chance to trade their nomadic lifestyle for the permanent home they've always dreamed of.

But the more Benny learns about her mysterious relative, Evelyn Terry, the more puzzling the game becomes. How did Evelyn write a letter addressed to Benny, by name, 175 years ago? Why does Evelyn want Benny to find an island that doesn't exist on any maps? And, most curious of all, what's the "curse" that Evelyn mentions in her letter—a curse only Benny can break?

In "Isle of Ever," Ms. Calonita has created an absorbing adventure story for readers ages 10 to 13 that blends fantasy with classic mystery tropes. There's a rambling Victorian mansion complete with a private library and a spooky, secret-filled attic; a vaguely British caretaker who delivers well-timed snacks and advice; and endless rainy days for Benny and her pals to search for clues. If this sounds a smidge too cozy for a modern-day adventure, rest assured: There are also pirates, cursed gold and something called a Blood Orange Moon. As Benny discovers, there's more to this game than a series of riddles.

When Evelyn was a child in 1825, she and her friends discovered a mysterious island only they could visit, one occupied by a curmudgeonly pirate guarding his ill-gotten treasure. When Evelyn's actions accidentally trap her friends on the island forever, she sets in motion a scheme that is generations in the making and relies on Benny's ingenuity and wits to save the day.

"Isle of Ever" moves at a breakneck clip and Ms. Calonita expertly steers the story toward its cliff-hanger ending, with the promise of more adventures to come. Happily for Benny and her friends—and readers caught up in their quest—the game is still afoot.

Ms. Daniels's work has been published in the Atlantic, the American Scholar and Commonweal.

BOOKS

'Success is a consequence and must not be an end.' —GUSTAVE FLAUBERT

That Katharine Gibbs Touch

Expect Great Things!
By Vanda Krefft
Algonquin, 320 pages, $29

By Joanne Kaufman

H. ARMSTRONG ROBERTS/GETTY IMAGES

WHEN John O'Shea, a bootlegger turned real-estate investor, died all but broke in 1931, his cosseted 16-year-old daughter, Dorothy, suddenly had to figure out how to make her own way in the world.

Fresh out of the University of Maryland in the early 1960s and disinclined to put her education degree to work, Loudell Insley thought she could get a job as a receptionist. Her father thought otherwise. "No man in his right mind," he told Loudell, "would hire you at a living wage."

Meanwhile, Loretta Swit, the product of a working-class New Jersey family—and eventually an Emmy Award-winner for her performance as "Hot Lips" Houlihan on the television series "M*A*S*H" (1972-83)—needed a backup plan in case that acting thing didn't work out.

The solution to the dilemmas of all three young women: the Katharine Gibbs School. An insistence on top-notch stenography and typing skills, as well as poise, impeccable diction, a can-do spirit and perfect grooming—think hat and white gloves—made the school the gold standard in secretarial training during the early and middle decades of the 20th century. Vanda Krefft tells its story in "Expect Great Things! How the Katharine Gibbs School Revolutionized the American Workplace for Women."

Known familiarly—and in some quarters a tad patronizingly—as Katie Gibbs, the school was established in part to address the needs of women who found themselves in much the same fix as Katharine Gibbs herself: single and low on funds, marketable skills and options.

Gibbs was 46 and living in Providence, R.I., in 1909 when her husband, William, died in a freak accident on his sailboat. Left with two young sons and few resources, Gibbs started a dressmaking business with her older sister, Mary, but shut it down when customers failed to materialize.

Mary quickly retrenched, enrolling in typing and stenography classes at a secretarial school; she excelled and was soon hired as an instructor. When the business was put up for sale in 1911, Katharine quixotically jumped at the chance to buy it. She had no clerical skills, true, had never taught anything before and had to go deeply into debt to close the deal. "The reasons against the purchase went on and on," Ms. Krefft writes. "No matter." Thus the Providence School for Secretaries was born.

Part company history, part social history, "Expect Great Things!"—the exhortation was Gibbs's motto and creed—charts the school's early days, when survival was iffy. Retooling and rethinking turned the enterprise around. Changes included cultivating a sense of exclusivity: Only well-educated women need apply. And by way of brand differentiation, Gibbs offered programs of varying lengths—six months (later, eight), one year, two years—as well as an expansive curriculum. There were classes in art and music appreciation, English literature and composition, psychology, economics and world government—many taught by moonlighting professors from Columbia and MIT, among other blue-chip universities. Hinting at some finishing-school pretensions: The school rounded out the schedule with teas and formal dances.

Gibbs saw—and seized—the opportunity presented by World War I. At the time, nearly all executive secretaries were male because the job was a path to management. When the men departed for the battlefield, Gibbs readied her graduates for active duty. She presented employers with women who were better than the men, writes Ms. Krefft: faster typists, flawless stenographers, master organizers; lovely, well-dressed, tea- and coffee-serving hostesses to boot. By 1918 there were three locations of the newly named Katharine Gibbs School of Secretarial and Executive Training, in Providence, Boston and New York. Outposts in Chicago and Montclair, N.J., would arrive later.

Gibbs worked the Depression to the school's advantage with similar shrewdness, telling prospective cash-strapped employers that a Gibbs girl was clever enough to handle the workload of two or three people while collecting a single paycheck. World War II became another boom time for the school.

Once she got on a payroll, a Gibbs Girl, mindful of the school's coaching, took advantage of her proximity to power to learn about the organization that hired her, observe leadership, make contacts and gain enough confidence to seek better employment elsewhere if her employer didn't appreciate and promote her.

Ms. Krefft brings prodigious research to bear. And she does a thorough job of analyzing the school's evolving role in the culture. Elsewhere, the author struggles. For all her savvy, Gibbs, who died in 1934 at the age of 71, doesn't register strongly on the page. And "Expect Great Things!" all but sinks under the weight of the biographical particulars of the Gibbs alumni.

> Gibbs graduates were prized as the elite among executive secretaries. The name took on a desirable aura of refinement.

These chirpy case histories are clearly there to provide evidence of the school's impact. But many of the women profiled—among them high achievers in politics, advertising and the arts—seemed bound for glory long before enrolling. If Katie Gibbs deserves credit for the success of Jean Drewes, a 1930 graduate who became the social secretary to the Duke and Duchess of Windsor, or of Vera Covell, who was the first female radiophone operator for a major U.S. airline, what are we to make of Katharine Brand, a Smith College and Katie Gibbs alum who would become the longtime assistant to Woodrow Wilson's biographer Ray Stannard Baker?

Brand corrected factual errors in her boss's work, made detailed editorial suggestions and, according to Ms. Krefft, wrote the final two Pulitzer Prize-winning volumes of the Wilson biography. Baker gave Brand neither a bonus nor credit for her work, but she stayed on in the job. Ms. Krefft breezily explains away the blot on the escutcheon: "A Gibbs education could offset, but it couldn't completely banish, childhood insecurities."

In 1968, with the times changing and feminist rage against traditional roles on the boil, Gibbs's son and successor, Gordon, sold the school to the publishing company Crowell Collier & Macmillan. By then 50,000 women had passed through the school's doors.

It was grand while it lasted. "They said to me in Tiffany's once, 'Ah—you head the Tiffany's of the secretarial schools,'" Gordon Gibbs recalled. "'On the contrary,' I said, 'it is you who are the Katie Gibbs of jewelry.'"

Ms. Kaufman writes on culture and arts for the Journal.

This Team Takes on the Twisted Types

MYSTERIES
Tom Nolan

> An FBI squad made up of oddballs and misfits gets the cases too strange for other agents.

IF YOU LIKE rooting for underdogs, you'll love the career-challenged crew of eccentric crime-solvers in John McMahon's **"Head Cases" (Minotaur, 352 pages, $28)**: a small FBI unit called Patterns and Recognition—PAR for short. The oddest of this fairly odd squad is narrator Gardner Camden, a special agent with poor social skills and an eidetic memory. "I'm not OCD," he says, "I just know things." Holmesian things, such as that the owner of "a pair of forceps, bent at an angle, with only one loop, on the grip side" must be an obstetrician. Other PAR members include Gardner's wisecracking partner, Cassie Pardo; team leader Frank Roberts; Joanne Harris, a star athlete and expert sharpshooter from Alaska; and Richie Brancato, a rookie whose personal goals are ambiguous and whose personnel file is sealed.

When first encountered, Gardner and Cassie are at a one-story ranch house in Ashland, Texas, where they examine the corpse of a newly-murdered man, a notorious serial killer who had been living underground for years. This is the first of many surprises in store for the PAR team, who are summoned "only after others in law enforcement have hit an impasse." The team is abruptly called away from Ashland to another bizarre murder scene, in Rawlings, N.M.—apparently staged by the same perpetrator as in Texas—where the victim is also a serial murderer, this one recently released from prison. Some of his body parts were cut up and placed in his refrigerator. "But no head, no hands. No feet"—though an index finger was left, apparently to aid identification. "You got a game player on your hands, Gardner," Frank says.

The game gets more personal, with the murderer contacting Gardner by telephone. It seems the killer has real-time information on PAR's movements. "There's a traitor among us," Gardner concludes. But who might it be? Mr. McMahon's inventive, eventful, smartly written "Head Cases," with its brilliant but fallible protagonist, its twisted-minded perpetrator, and its mix of sentiment and intrigue, is a terrific debut that augurs well for further installments in the series.

It's been 11 years since "The Chinese Beverly Hills," John Shannon's last mystery involving Los Angeles investigator Jack Liffey, who specializes in finding lost young people. The intervening seasons have taken their toll. **"Boystown" (Unnamed Press, 272 pages, $28)** finds Jack suffering temporary "cognitive distortion" in the wake of open-heart surgery and a hemorrhagic stroke. But he's still committed to doing what good he may. "You carry around that aura of I-can-help," says his friend Walt Roski, a morose police arson investigator who sometimes assists him in his inquiries.

Jack's latest mission is to find the 19-year-old brother of his daughter's college roommate.

THIS WEEK

Head Cases
By John McMahon

Boystown
By John Shannon

Fagin the Thief
By Allison Epstein

Benjy Walker is a gay man who has gone missing; ominously, he was last seen receiving a public beating at the hands of a man with SS wrist tattoos. The hunt for Benjy takes Jack first into the gay-friendly city of West Hollywood and then to nearby enclaves of Eastern European refugees. There Jack encounters men with military backgrounds, fierce loyalties and codes of secrecy: As one called Sergei reminds himself, "Never leave a footprint." One such émigré was "semi-accidentally" shot by a High Sierras hunting party of roughnecks—a group that may include the brute who attacked Benjy.

Jack probes deeper into Benjy's fate, while Walt adds up the escalating violence: "One old man . . . shot to death in bed. A car . . . burned to the ground with a Molotov Cocktail . . . another man killed by a gunshot through a window." Mr. Shannon pulls the strands of his plot together in a memorable and thrilling finale—out of the ashes of which stumbles an all-too-human, still open-hearted Jack Liffey.

Fagin, the frightening antagonist who commands a ring of juvenile London pickpockets in Charles Dickens's 1838 novel, "Oliver Twist," is a Victorian villain for the ages—and one of the most notoriously antisemitic caricatures in English literature. In **"Fagin the Thief" (Doubleday, 336 pages, $28)**, the American author Allison Epstein presents an enlarged, alternate portrait of a more sympathetic criminal godfather, here given the first name Jacob. Through interlocking flashbacks and flashforwards, we view this revisionary Fagin at various stages of his life.

In 1793, Jacob is a withdrawn but tempestuous 6-year-old child of a father hanged as a thief, being raised by a penniless seamstress mother who's named him after the "cleverest" of the biblical patriarchs. Jacob, she reminds him, "wrestled with angels and won." At 11, Jacob roams the streets of a city where raging fires provide communal entertainment ("Families bring picnics and camp on nearby rooftops") and is self-apprenticed to a dexterous thief named Leftwich. Jacob carefully studies his teacher's "mode of weaving through the world, filling his pockets with the wealth of others." By the age of 51, Jacob has become an old master of his trade and himself a manager of various fast-fingered youngsters, such as the fair-haired workhouse refugee Oliver Twist, who entreats "Mr. Fagin" to induct him into "the used goods business."

Dickens's Bill Sikes is here, with his "dirty hatchet-broad face"—seen initially as a clumsy but determined young pupil of Jacob's, then as a successful but increasingly sullen and unpredictable housebreaker. Also present is Bill's partner, Nancy, who first joins Fagin's circle after a meet-cute in which *she* tries to pick *his* pocket. Gone are the melodramatics that made Dickens a fortune through public readings; this is instead an empathetic saga of troubled souls struggling to survive in an uncaring and unpromising world. "Fagin the Thief" is an impressive achievement in conception and execution, but some readers may grow weary following the stunted emotional development of a lead character whose noblest impulse is simply to stay alive.

PLAY

NEWS QUIZ DANIEL AKST

From this week's Wall Street Journal

1. Rep. Sylvester Turner, sworn in just weeks ago, died at 70. Where was he previously mayor?

- **A.** Houston
- **B.** Dallas
- **C.** San Antonio
- **D.** Austin

2. In his State of the Union address, President Trump made a young cancer patient, DJ Daniel, an honorary member of what?

- **A.** DOGE
- **B.** The FBI
- **C.** The CIA
- **D.** The Secret Service

3. Partisan conflict has erupted over traffic cones—in which country (where they're ubiquitous)?

- **A.** France
- **B.** Germany
- **C.** New Zealand
- **D.** India

4. Ilya Sutskever's new AI startup is worth $30 billion. What's it called?

- **A.** Benign Brainpower
- **B.** Gentle Genius
- **C.** Safe Superintelligence
- **D.** Thoughtful Thinking

5. A demographer claims babies born this year herald a new generation—called what?

- **A.** Alpha
- **B.** Beta
- **C.** Omega
- **D.** Epsilon

6. Demand for Blackwell is strong despite U.S. restrictions. Explain please.

- **A.** Fashion critic Mr. Blackwell is idolized in Russia.
- **B.** Nvidia's Blackwell chips are AI stars.
- **C.** Blackwell Philosophy Guides sell big despite a copyright dispute.
- **D.** Historic Blackwell House, on an island closed to foreigners, is thronged anyway.

7. Who just opened an economic zone to tourists, including Westerners?

- **A.** Belarus
- **B.** Kyrgyzstan
- **C.** Cuba
- **D.** North Korea

8. A new book, "Propaganda Girls," describes how a movie star helped the Allied war effort by broadcasting popular songs into Germany with lyrics changed to make them more depressing. Which star?

- **A.** Marlene Dietrich
- **B.** Greta Garbo
- **C.** Carole Lombard
- **D.** Ingrid Bergman

9. Alaska's Iditarod dog-sled race got underway despite a shortage—of what?

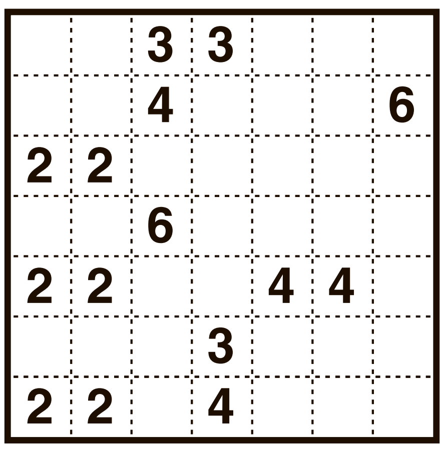
- **A.** Dogs
- **B.** Racers
- **C.** Sleds
- **D.** Snow

FROM TOP: MICHAEL WYKE/ASSOCIATED PRESS; KERRY TASKER/REUTERS

Answers are listed below the crossword solutions at right.

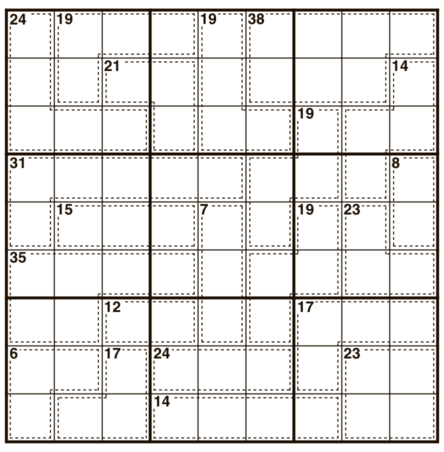
NUMBER PUZZLES

Cell Blocks



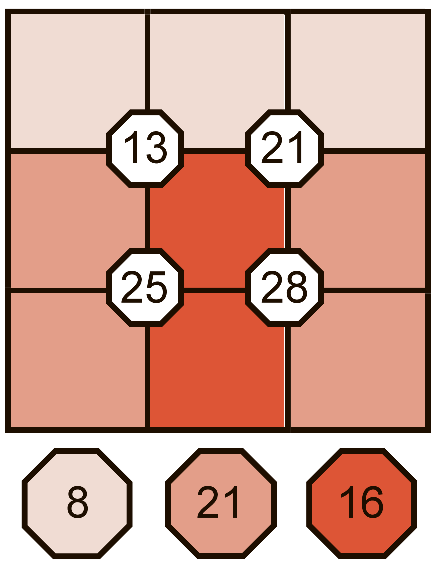
Divide the grid into square or rectangular blocks, each containing one digit only. Every block must contain the number of cells indicated by the digit inside it.

Killer Sudoku Level 4



As with standard Sudoku, fill the grid so that every column, every row and every 3x3 box contains the digits 1 to 9. Each set of cells joined by dotted lines must add up to the target number in its top-left corner. Within each set of cells joined by dotted lines, a digit cannot be repeated.

Suko

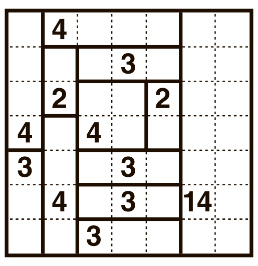


Place the numbers 1 to 9 in the spaces so that the number in each circle is equal to the sum of the four surrounding spaces, and each color total is correct.

ALL PUZZLES © PUZZLER MEDIA LTD - WWW.PUZZLER.COM

SOLUTIONS TO *LAST WEEK'S* PUZZLES

Cell Blocks



For previous weeks' puzzles, and to discuss strategies with other solvers, go to WSJ.com/puzzles.

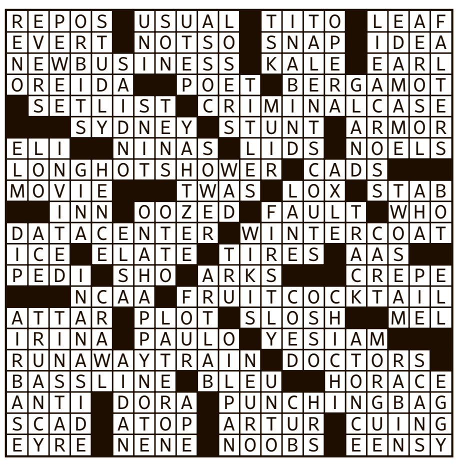
Killer Sudoku Level 3

6	4	9	5	3	7	2	8	1
8	7	3	2	1	4	9	5	6
2	5	1	9	8	6	3	4	7
7	8	6	3	4	2	5	1	9
9	2	4	1	6	5	7	3	8
3	1	5	7	9	8	6	2	4
5	6	2	4	7	1	8	9	3
4	9	8	6	5	3	1	7	2
1	3	7	8	2	9	4	6	5

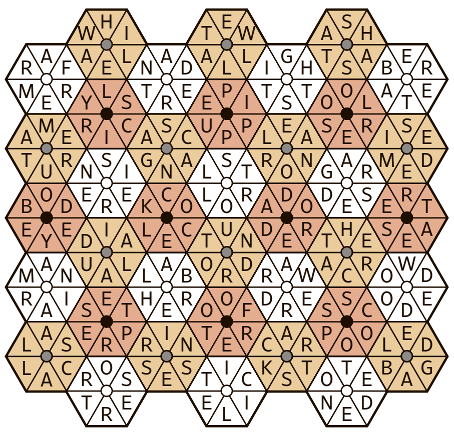
Suko

6	3	7
2	1	4
9	5	8

Do It!

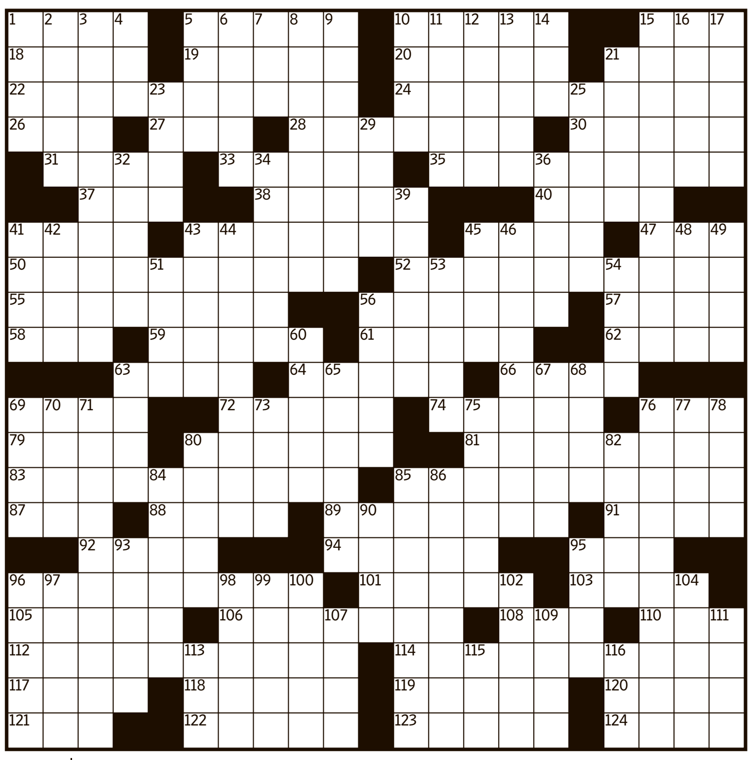


Rows Garden



Answers to News Quiz: 1.A, 2.D, 3.C, 4.C, 5.B, 6.B, 7.D, 8.A, 9.D

THE JOURNAL WEEKEND PUZZLES edited by MIKE SHENK



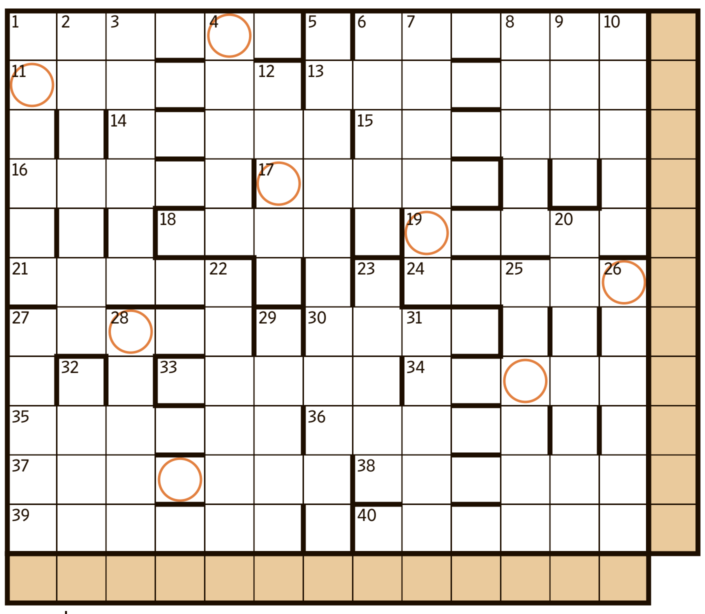
Spout | *by Zhouqin Burnikel*

Across

1 Bounce off the walls
5 Same old, same old
10 Maker of EcoTank printers
15 Result of inflation, sometimes
18 Expanded
19 Capital about 90 miles from the Red Sea
20 Its official languages are Dutch and Papiamento
21 Expand a workforce
22 Warning from a crude ship?
24 Periods between rounds of a boxing match?
26 Fleur de ___ (fancy seasoning)
27 Mysterious radar blip
28 Like Tabasco sauce
30 Mom-to-be's test
31 Sheds tears
33 Little corner of the market
35 Approves or penalizes
37 Floors in an arena
38 Site of Africa's oldest metro system
40 Time to give up?
41 Biol., geol., chem., etc.
43 Screen for streaming
45 Treated as a pawn
47 Density symbol
50 Super-exciting instants?
52 Corn harvester's basket?
55 Snare drum sounds
56 Mendel of genetics
57 Forever and ever
58 Teriyaki sauce ingredient
59 Show a craving, metaphorically
61 "Farewell, mon ami"
62 Canadian gas brand
63 Red state, before 1991
64 "We want in!"
66 Work the soil
69 Shed tears
72 "Casablanca" star, to fans
74 Winning by a point
76 Furious state
79 Tourist city of Uttar Pradesh
80 Synonym resource
81 Levelheaded
83 Protectors for some hair extensions?
85 Diamond dealers?
87 Cause of a blowup
88 Beer bottle adjective
89 Wisconsin city on Lake Michigan
91 Heaviest Olympic sword
92 Play delayer
94 It's up for debate
95 Okla. hrs.
96 Othello, e.g.
101 Trunk in your trunk
103 Hideout
105 Lauder of cosmetics
106 Le Car maker
108 Cat seen at night
110 Thanks for waiting
112 Show about star pitchers?
114 Final film versions?
117 Trilogy, perhaps
118 ___ de leche
119 "Keen!"
120 Appreciative verses
121 Give it a whirl
122 Specifics, slangily
123 Key errors
124 Outperform

Down

1 Barriers to collaboration
2 Sheds tears
3 Toon with a red hair bow
4 Get behind
5 Fighter letters
6 Place to go platinum
7 Article in Le Monde
8 ID needed for senior discounts
9 Football no-nos
10 Tombstone lawman
11 Asks a lot of questions
12 Afrofuturist jazz great
13 Doc who truly delivers
14 Pinch, as a perp
15 Chamber music pieces
16 Big name in pest control
17 Cozumel coins
21 Keep from expanding
23 Grimm in the Pro Football Hall of Fame
25 Like "Joker" but not "Batman"
29 Fresh-mouthed
32 "Blame It on the ___ Nova"
34 "Just watch me!"
36 Like some lip gloss
39 Belabor, say
41 Some 35mm cameras
42 "Farewell, mio amico!"
43 Lasting marks
44 Lake transport
45 Strong impulse
46 Words accompanied by a three-finger salute
48 Coop group
49 Guesstimate words
51 JFK guesses
53 Alphabet quintet
54 Casting need
56 Slalom markers
60 Raced on a sled
63 State with six corners
65 Winter Paralympics equipment
67 Start for mural or muscular
68 Prince Organa's adopted daughter
69 Frazier in the Basketball Hall of Fame
70 Novelist Jennifer
71 Concern for spin doctors
73 EverQuest monster
75 Car radio button
76 Bungler's quality
77 Like a bloody steak
78 Otherwise
80 Lamenting
82 City south of Kyiv
84 Engineless aircraft
85 Fresh-mouthed
86 Love of music
90 Twin in Genesis
93 Colombian corn cake
95 Problem for a plumber
96 Dragon or kraken
97 Grouchy Muppet
98 Make a case
99 Country great Haggard
100 Pass into law
102 O'Connor's successor
104 Ceremonies
107 Home to the Cyclones
109 Grandson of Adam
111 "Hey, you!"
113 Uneven?
115 Bump fists
116 Corn core



Mystery Machine | *a cryptic puzzle by Dean Felch*

In some special rows and columns of this grid, the clue answers won't fit until a letter is removed every time it appears in that row or column. For example, if LITERALLY is a clue answer, and the letter being removed in that row is L, then you would enter ITERAY. When you determine which letter is being removed in a row or column, write that letter (just once) in the shaded area to the right of that row or directly beneath that column. The grid represents a machine that is performing an action. The letters removed from the rows and columns will spell out two words that hint at the operation of the machine. The circled letters in the grid, reading from left to right, spell out the name of the machine. To disguise which rows and columns are losing letters, all answer lengths have been withheld.

Across

1 Planter embraces hard rain
6 Take for granted a small amount of money by error
11 Crater ruined east patio
13 Takes appropriate feeding remedies
14 Most of old filling put a chip in tooth
15 Ace backing more reasonable sporting venues
16 Group of salmon at River Thames' source
17 Listen amidst Social Security scammers
18 Dreadful-sounding textile worker
19 Convenient fodder spread around North Dakota
21 Made smooth lies in speeches and editorials
24 Charon tossed heavy item
27 Indian leader inverted container storing helium
30 Silence our group going from hospital to hospital
33 Southern strike linked to the French struggle
34 Commotion around extremely explosive signal flares
35 Lower profit by that woman
36 Maine country club, a pilgrimage destination
37 President offers Jen alternative
38 Necessary termination of campaign fueled snafu
39 Evaluate a movie's trailer within four seconds
40 Curmudgeonly conservative out of practice

Down

1 Shirt carried by footwear stores
2 Juliet, for example, talking smack
3 Stuff in absinthe starts to warp one's rational mind with only one drink
4 Robust male with alternate pair of hybrids
5 Heavy metal remix of real "Rent"-era theme (3 wds.)
6 Removed high school portfolio-building course
7 Karan's hat confused for furry cloth
8 Hand over last of women incarcerated by Italian city (2 wds.)
9 Translate as spiteful
10 Contents of desk atop articulate writing assignment
12 Relaxes and comes to a halt after losing the lead
20 Distribute unlimited rum in Toledo freely (2 wds.)
22 Noble female duo drops last game
23 Isabella's title is what in Spanish?
25 Trashed recycled clothing
26 Dorm monitor reserved housing close to school with undue haste
27 Historic vessel carrying nose of jet fighter known for stealth
28 Sort his wet load of laundry
29 Change or use foreign cash
31 Curse a cracked dish
32 Views in either direction

▶ **Get the solutions** to this week's Journal Weekend Puzzles in next Saturday's Wall Street Journal. Solve crosswords and acrostics online, get pointers on solving cryptic puzzles and discuss all of the puzzles online at **WSJ.com/Puzzles.**

Wax figures of the six stars of the Bond movie franchise at Madame Tussaud's in Berlin.

By Bradley Hope

Can James Bond Be Licensed to Thrill Again?

With creative control of the franchise shifting after six decades, 007 needs clever, suspenseful storytelling, not just gadgets and frenetic action.

James Bond has stared down plenty of villains over the years—garden-variety megalomaniacs, faceless henchmen, Soviet killers with weird skills—but his latest mission may be the most unexpected: proving that the espionage genre still has a pulse.

Amazon's MGM Studios recently completed a deal to take over creative control of the Bond movie franchise from the family of Albert Broccoli, who had produced the films since the first one in 1962. The tech giant now has an opportunity to breathe new life into a stale brand and to remind audiences why they love spy stories in the first place.

Bond's last on-screen adventure, 2021's "No Time to Die," ended with his death. It was a bold choice but also a symbolic announcement that there couldn't just be endless installments of Bond at it again, with essentially the same cocktail of stunts, explosions and suave one-liners. The franchise, like the genre as a whole, is in definite need of revitalization.

It's worth remembering a time when a spy thriller could be clever without blowing up half the world. Consider one of my favorite films, "Sneakers" (1992), which stands out as a high-water mark in espionage storytelling. There are no death rays from orbit or armies of faceless goons; the fate of the free world doesn't hinge on a ticking bomb. Instead, a team of misfits, hackers and former spies—led by Robert Redford and Sidney Poitier—use wit, deception and teamwork to outmaneuver a nemesis with a very personal grudge against the world.

The film's most intense moments involved cracking codes, sneaking past guards and engaging in cat-and-mouse games of subterfuge. The climax relies not on an explosion but on how smart the team is under pressure. Watching it now, "Sneakers" feels almost revelatory. It achieves so much with storytelling that you don't miss having CGI.

Modern spy films have largely abandoned this ethos, opting for increasingly elaborate set pieces that drown out the very elements that make the genre not only captivating but culturally and politically important. Bond is a prime example. Over six decades, Britain's top spy's adventures transformed from relatively taut Cold War intrigues to grandiose action extravaganzas. Watching a Bond film in recent years often felt like watching a luxury-car commercial or paging through fashion advertisements in Vanity Fair. The budget for "No Time to Die" was reportedly more than $250 million, but somewhere amid the fireballs and IMAX-worthy spectacle the soul of the spy genre slipped from sight.

The decline in espionage storytelling parallels deeper shifts in culture. During Bond's 1960s heyday, spy fiction thrived on a sense of higher purpose. The conflicts were framed as existential battles of ideologies—democracy vs. communism, good vs. evil. Bond's early missions, however campy they got, were grounded in the West's real anxieties about Soviet plots and nuclear Armageddon.

There were exceptions, of course. John le Carré's novels, which began appearing at the same time as the first Bond movies, depicted less-dashing operatives with more compromised morality. But for the most part, readers and moviegoers accepted the premise that spy agencies were simply defending freedom from its enemies.

After the Cold War, and especially in the wake of modern intelligence scandals, including CIA black sites and NSA mass surveillance, public faith in intelligence agencies eroded. The 1990s and 2000s brought ever-murkier motivations, and spy thrillers lost their ideological clarity.

Hollywood's spies scrambled to find new villains and new justifications for their exploits. The audience could no longer be certain what our fictional spies truly believed in. Even Bond felt it: In "GoldenEye" (1995), a fellow agent mocks him as a "relic of the Cold War," and by "Skyfall" (2012), Bond's boss M is delivering elegies for the old ways while British politicians question whether agents like 007 are still relevant.

> As moral frameworks crumbled, filmmakers became ever more reliant on spectacle.

Hollywood responded by making spy agencies the bad guys. In the Jason Bourne films, the CIA is often the antagonist. In "Skyfall," the sins of Bond's own agency, MI6, create the vengeful figure seeking to destroy it. Bond wasn't spared—modern films saddled him with trauma and self-doubt.

With moral frameworks crumbling, filmmakers became ever more reliant on spectacle. The "Mission: Impossible" films gave up much of the teamwork and ingenuity of the original 1970s TV series to focus on Tom Cruise jumping from heights or performing unbelievable stunts, with a team of stock characters serving his main-character story line.

There was a brief glimmer of hope after "Casino Royale" in 2006 stripped Bond back to his roots, emphasizing psychological tension over gadgetry. But subsequent films brought back convoluted back stories and narratives leaning more on nostalgia than innovation.

Recent attempts in the spy genre fared no better. Netflix's "The Gray Man" (2022) is a globe-trotting assassin tale loaded with shootouts and pyrotechnics but utterly missing the soul of espionage. Amazon's "Citadel" (2023) offered eye candy—beautiful stars in perfectly-tailored outfits, high-tech gadgets and fights atop speeding trains—but forgot to pack the intrigue.

To right the course, we should reexamine the classics that delved more into character, tension and narrative propulsion. Sydney Pollack's "Three Days of the Condor" (1975) has a few bursts of violence, but what we remember is Robert Redford's everyman researcher evading shadowy assassins in a paranoid atmosphere of mistrust. The film's most chilling scenes involve phone calls and murmured conversations, the terrifying sense that anyone could be listening or lying.

Alfred Hitchcock's "Notorious" (1946) remains one of the most suspenseful spy films ever made, with hardly a gun fired. Its famous wine-cellar scene, as Gary Grant and Ingrid Bergman risk discovery by Claude Rains, generates white-knuckle tension out of pure timing and circumstance. Less is more in these stories: We care about the characters and the stakes; a whispered exchange or a furtive glance can be as thrilling as a shootout.

That's why a modern TV series like "Slow Horses," on Apple TV, has been a refreshing success. It doesn't rely on saving the world to hold our attention. Instead, it gives us a team of castoff British spies caught up in relatively small-scale intrigue and milks suspense from office politics, personal grudges and the occasional burst of very human heroism.

My greatest hope as a fan of the genre is that Amazon makes room in the Bond "universe" for a story like "Andor," the "Star Wars" spinoff that dared to treat its audience like adults. It discarded galactic battles for a slow-burn thriller about rebellion, surveillance and power.

This is the model that MGM Studios should emulate for Bond. Amazon gives it the resources to keep 007 as stylish as ever. But what Bond needs most isn't money but creative talent willing to take the risk of returning to the heart of the genre: secrets, deception, smoldering tension.

The next Bond film or series must prioritize tension over explosions, stakes over CGI. The Aston Martin with the eject button and rocket launcher can stay, but only if the brain behind the wheel matters.

Bradley Hope is the cofounder of the production company Project Brazen and the author, most recently, of "The Rebel and the Kingdom: The True Story of the Secret Mission to Overthrow the North Korean Regime."

STEFFI LOOS/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

MASTERPIECE | THE COPENHAGEN EWER (C. 1320-30)

A Gilded Pitcher Worth Poring Over

By Barbara Boehm

DEEP IN THE MEDIEVAL galleries of the National Museum, Copenhagen, a gilded silver and enamel ewer stands, dignified, in a large vitrine. Overlooked by tourists, this refined and rare work of art, nearly 9 inches tall, was created by a Parisian goldsmith in the 14th century. It exemplifies an artistic tradition of which we today have neither experience nor awareness. In an age of disposable plastic water bottles, who can appreciate the place of fine art at the table and the consummate example of the Copenhagen Ewer? Anyone who stops to look.

Princely dining in medieval Europe was not a gastric free-for-all, as "Game of Thrones" enthusiasts might imagine, but a finely orchestrated feast. The luxurious vessels that once graced the tables of the courts of Europe are described in inventories and illustrated in manuscripts, but most of the objects themselves are long since lost, their precious silver or gold turned to quick cash in times of war or economic uncertainty.

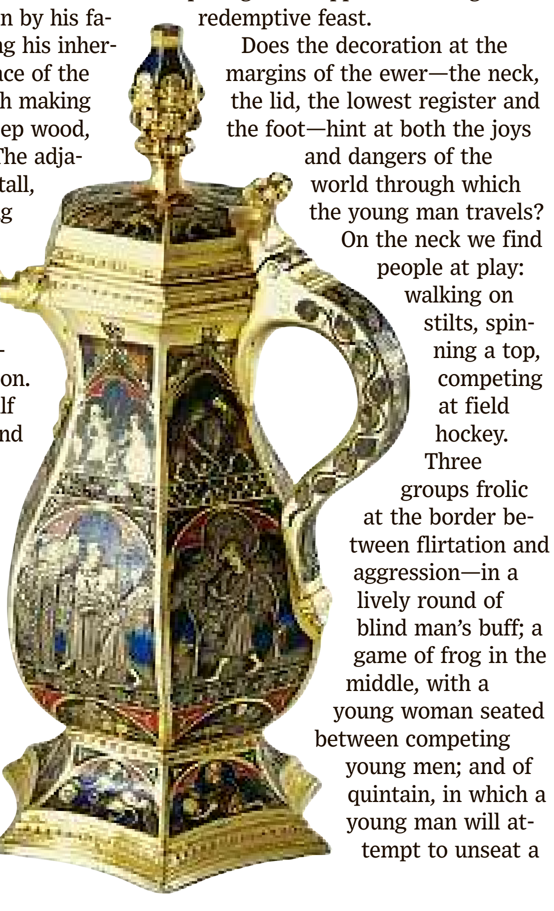
Somehow, miraculously, this ewer survived, an isolated treasure, the sole Gothic enamel of its type known today. Bearing the fleur-de-lis hallmark of Paris, it is the work of an accomplished goldsmith active just a decade or so before the Black Death.

With a sure hand, that unnamed artist enriched the entire surface of the ewer—in three registers on its hexagonal body, and on its stellate foot, curving elegant handle and hinged lid. Even the inside of the lid is decorated, a discreet touch known only to those who filled the vessel with water or wine.

The engraving of the silver is carefully calculated, serving a dual purpose. Artistically, it allows for subtle visual effects, with deep cuts into the surface of the silver to suggest folds in heavy robes or the imbrication of a city wall, and superficial engraving to suggest delicate facial features or a coiffure. Technically, the roughened, furrowed surface of the metal grips the thin, translucent glaze of enamel and holds it in place. Despite some losses over time, the enamel still shines, providing glimpses as through tiny windows to a diminutive, exceptionally vivacious world.

A six-part narrative encircles the vessel at its widest. Like storyboards in precious metal, each scene moves toward the next, clockwise, seemingly beginning and ending with a feast. The tables are laden with food, and, of course, graced with a ewer. The whole seems to suggest Jesus' parable of the prodigal son (Luke 15:11-32), in which an errant young man is forgiven by his father after squandering his inheritance. Indeed, one face of the ewer presents a youth making his way through a deep wood, alone and barefoot. The adjacent scene depicts a tall, bearded man standing at the gates of a town, gently embracing the barefoot young man, arguably the reunion of father and son. The slaughter of a calf predictably follows and then a dinner made lively by musicians.

But is it right to interpret these scenes as illustrations of the parable? Women, unmentioned in the story, figure prominently in three of the vignettes, their affect and presence seemingly caring, maternal. Missing is any hint of the adolescent son's early debauchery, those lurid moments that often enliven artistic renderings of the tale. Moreover, no youthful figure that could be identified as the prodigal son appears at the great redemptive feast.



It embodies the place of fine art at medieval Europe's table.

Does the decoration at the margins of the ewer—the neck, the lid, the lowest register and the foot—hint at both the joys and dangers of the world through which the young man travels? On the neck we find people at play: walking on stilts, spinning a top, competing at field hockey. Three groups frolic at the border between flirtation and aggression—in a lively round of blind man's buff; a game of frog in the middle, with a young woman seated between competing young men; and of quintain, in which a young man will attempt to unseat a woman by pushing her extended foot, her raised skirt suggesting where things may be going.

Populating the lid, the lowest register and the foot are monstrous quadrupeds with human heads and torsos and beastly lower limbs. One creature bares his backside; others ring bells, sound horns, wield knives and sticks. The diminutive scale and nimble drawing of these flights of fantasy find a rival only in the margins of the finest Gothic manuscripts, especially those created by Jean Pucelle, the renowned 14th-century illuminator of French royal manuscripts. In the pages of his imagining, cavorting figures and carnival creatures coexist, as here, with characters both heroic and human. Might we see the artistry of Pucelle, who first trained as a goldsmith, at work here?

Ours, the ewer's masterly artist clearly asserts, is a busy, colorful, noisy world, in which the familiar and the frightening are close at hand. There is drama here in departures and reunions, tenderness in glances and embraces. Whether held, as its owners once did, or simply viewed in a vitrine, this work of art compels us to follow the tale round and round, to reflect upon shared tables and celebrations and our own path through a world of wonder.

Ms. Boehm is curator emerita of the Met Cloisters and a Chevalier de l'Ordre des arts et des lettres.

NATIONAL MUSEUM, DENMARK

P2JW067000-4-D00100-1--------XA

An Adorable Trailblazer
VW's smallest SUV has a cute new look **D8**

OFF DUTY

FASHION | FOOD | DESIGN | TRAVEL | GEAR

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL. ★★★★

Saturday/Sunday, March 8 - 9, 2025 | **D1**

Steak au Poivre on a Work Night?
A streamlined approach **D10**

DAVE URBAN

Style Touchdowns And Yellow Flags: A Menswear Playbook

What's a quietly stylish status watch—or a cool outfit for older guys? Which date-night shoes are so ugly they should be penalized? A guide for men.

By Jamie Waters

SPRING'S ALMOST HERE, and for most men that means substantial changes are in order, like swapping boots for Vans and puffer vests for lighter puffer vests. Instead of defaulting to your usual style moves, what if you seized this moment to upgrade your look? Think of all the halfhearted compliments your colleagues will be forced to cough up when they see the effort you've made.

This handbook, a loose collection of rules, should have something for everyone, from tech bros to retirees to fashion snobs who pride themselves on correctly pronouncing the brand Loewe ("Low-eh-vay").

I asked a bunch of super-stylish folks the questions all guys want to ask, like: What are the sexiest date-night shoes? Can office backpacks ever look good? And should men destroy their skinny jeans by throwing them into the trash or a full-on bonfire? (Answer: bonfire—leaves no trace.)

Feel free to approach this guide as you might an annual performance review: Don't take criticisms personally; ignore any suggestions that seem like hard work; and treat yourself to a nice watch afterward (question four can help with that!).

OK, hit me: What's the top style rule for men?

Your clothes should fit. I know: boring! But nothing kills a look quicker than garments that strain, bunch or bag. Because many items don't fit neatly off-the-rack, stylists recommend having a local tailor tweak them. Since I'm sure many of you have busy lives and frankly can't be bothered to do that, keep in mind that: 1) Slightly too big is less bad than slightly too small; and 2) Pants are the prime danger zone. Celebrity stylist Michael Fisher flagged tight jeans as public enemy number one, though stretch chinos can also cling like a one-time lover who won't take a hint.

Re/Done The Mel Jean, *$325*

How to tell if your pants are too tight? Check your pockets. Your phone, wallet and AirPods, jammed against your thighs, will have caused them to bulge, as if your jeans-which-are-really-leggings have sprouted hip hernias. "Nothing's a bigger turnoff," said Fisher.

Beyond choosing cuts that give legs a little breathing room, please gawk at your backside in the fitting-room mirror. Pick pants that frame it nicely rather than a low-slung design that causes it to fall away like an elephant's behind. "Straight men don't care about how their butt looks in jeans," but women notice, said Dione Davis, 37, a New York stylist who has been on one too many dates with badly dressed men. She praised the rump-framing skills of the mid-rise, vintage-inspired jeans by Mel Ottenberg for Los Angeles brand Re/Done. "Give me '90s butt!" she said.

Please turn to page D2

Inside

MOST VALUABLE LAYERS
Aim high with this recipe for 'banana pudding meets English trifle' **D10**

ATTACK OF 'THE WHITE LOTUS' FANS
As the series' devotees overrun Thailand, hit these off-the-radar spots **D7**

WHY SETTLE FOR ONE METAL?
All that glitters is gold…and silver. The two are reuniting in earrings and more. **D4**

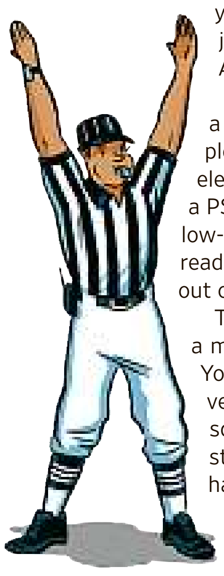
A 'UNICORN' HOME
How window walls and loads of white oak helped make a house unique **D6**

STYLE & FASHION

Style Dos And (Please, For the Love Of God) Don'ts

I'd like to impress at a Saturday dinner (maybe it's a date). What should I wear—and avoid?

The hottest, most pulse-quickening thing you can do? Dress appropriately. In New York stylist Dione Davis's experience, straight men often dress far more casually than their female companions. "I don't want to see Gore-Tex on a date," she said. "What if I dress cute but I'm cold, and then you want to put that jacket on my shoulders? Absolutely not."



She far prefers classics like a black or white soft sweater, pleated trousers and a long, elegant trench. (I'd like to issue a PSA that men only wear below-the-knee coats; a short coat reads stingy, like the factory ran out of cloth!)

That said, I wouldn't aim for a movie-montage makeover. You want to resemble a sharp version of yourself, not to squirm in a costume. But do steam your shirt (my Conair hand-held steamer Botoxes wrinkles in 30 seconds).

What about shoes for that nice Saturday dinner? (Which may or may not be a date.)

Let's start with the nonstarters. The sneakers from On, with Swiss-cheese-holey soles that propel runners forward, dominate in many bars and restaurants these days. Men gush about how comfortable they are, and I absolutely believe them. But if my partner turned up to dinner in these I would rip them off him and lace them on myself so that I could run away quickly. Other ubiquitous shoes that amount to pledges of abstinence include dress-shoe-sneaker hybrids, in which tan leather uppers are awkwardly mounted on white sporty soles in the most diabolical pairing since Bonnie and Clyde.

Amy Smilovic, the founder of New York womenswear brand Tibi, finds white sneakers a little jarring with her husband's night-out staples like dark jeans. She thinks Maison Margiela's navy German Army Trainers, with their nonwhite bases, look more put-together. "Put-together—with a cool edge" is how I'd describe the round-toed Marsèll derbies recommended by Saager Dilawri, founder of stellar Vancouver store Neighbour. Dilawri called Marsèll's leather designs "super comfortable."

Tassel loafers win my vote for the classiest dinners, while the chillest drinks call for sexy, skater-y Old Skool Vans. Meanwhile, you'll find the most fashion-forward men shuffling to natural-wine bars in leather slippers from Lemaire, which I suppose are elegant in an 18th-century-poet kind of way.

From Top: Sebago Classic Will Tassel Loafers, *$250*; Maison Margiela Replica German Army Sneakers, *$750*; Vans Premium Old Skool Sneakers, *$90*

I'm looking to invest in a watch that indicates I'm 'in the know' but isn't obnoxious. Thoughts?

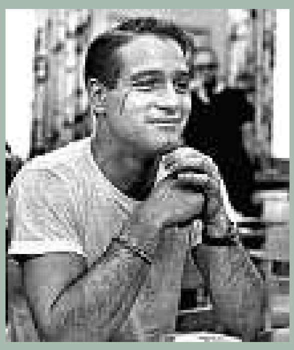
First off, unlike a glass of wine or the window of time between visiting in-laws, bigger is not better with men's watches. The trend is toward smaller, "classically sized" models 36mm and below, said Adam Golden, the owner of renowned Miami watch dealer Menta Watches. 42mm-plus beasts that "spill over wrists," as he put it, seem dated and shouty.

Urbane fellows deserve a Cartier Tank, a polite rectangle of gold that suggests "you appreciate nice things," said Golden. Offbeat sorts might prefer to strap on the Tank's drunk cousin, the Cartier Crash, whose wonky form recalls an oval watch seen in the reflection of a funhouse mirror. Both Cartiers work with casual outfits and formal tailoring, whereas Golden noted that many sports watches look "stupid" with a suit and tie.

Folks looking to splurge on a classic, masculine gem with bragging rights have a clear choice: vintage Patek Philippe Nautilus or Rolex Daytona models. Golden said that decades-old versions of those handsome tickers are smaller, quieter and more knowing than their modern counterparts. Jay-Z sports them; A$AP Rocky had menswear nerds jabbering when he wore a vintage gold Nautilus to his recent trial in Los Angeles.

Jay-Z wearing a vintage Patek Philippe Nautilus in 2022

Daytonas from the '60s and '70s start at around $40K for silver or black dials, said Golden, while '90s-era 'Zenith' Daytonas can be scored for around $20K.



Paul Newman circa 1960

How can I inject some personality into my outfit?

A man can easily end up looking as fun as a tray of airplane food. To escape bland land, find your version of Paul Newman's bracelet, a curb-chain design that lived on his perfectly tanned wrist. "It doesn't matter whether he's playing a prisoner or a socialite, he's wearing that bracelet," said Smilovic. Here, a few accessories that could become your Newman bracelet:

1. A curb-chain bracelet similar to the actor's. Stick to sterling silver; ID bar optional. U.K. brand Bunney sells cool takes that won't weigh down your wrist.

2. A fun bracelet, whether a Mykonos souvenir, a trendy charm design by German studio Gottlob or a beaded "DADA" creation courtesy of your toddler. (Kitsch has a place on the wrist.) But no more than three, please, unless you're Kieran Culkin.

3. A gold chain necklace as thin as Jonathan Bailey's in the miniseries "Fellow Travelers." Wear Mejuri's superfine example over a dark sweater and sit back for compliments.

4. Not a dangly earring.

5. For the blingaphobic, Jacques Marie Mage's beefy black glasses. Yours for $900. *The* status frames.

Any top tips for office dressing?

I hit up two New York execs for answers: Robert Dahdah, chief revenue officer at software company PTC; and Fred Cibelli, a principal at Ernst & Young LLC. Both stressed common sense: wear clean, unwrinkled clothes, however casual. (If you catch yourself wondering whether an item is too scruffy for work, it is!) Dahdah, 57, noted the need to "lessen the distance," style-wise, when meeting clients. "If you show up in a suit and they're in jeans, you might not have a great meeting."

Dahdah's office get-up tends to skew formal—navy Tom Ford suit, open shirt—while his travel uniform features RRL jeans and a double-breasted blazer. Cibelli, 48, more casual, said crew-neck sweaters and long-sleeve tees from Theory and Saturdays NYC have become his star work items. He'll also spend "a little more" on nice glasses and a good haircut.

I'm struggling to find a stylish work backpack. Any recs?

I was recently asked this unappetizing question by a London PR friend, though he won't let me disclose his name here, for obvious reasons: Backpacks are dorky and childish. I advised him to retract his request, get his eyes tested and buy a handsome zippered tote from Japan's Master-Piece. He rudely declined. So, under duress, I will be recommending the least-unstylish backpacks.

Jason Moran, 37, a fashionable New Yorker in marketing, reckons that because backpacks are inherently utilitarian, the *least* cool thing one can do is choose a sleek, sculptural version in fancy leather. I'm with him. Lean into the practical: Pick a low-key take in a sporty fabric like ballistic nylon. Either black or navy so dark everyone thinks it's black. Dilawri wisely suggested avoiding super-structured, boxy models "that look like a 'computer backpack.'"

The most-appealing specimen I've found, a lustrous nylon Tanker model by Porter-Yoshida & Co, can cost almost $800, which I think might be illegal for a backpack. Alternatively, a Benjamin will nab you Eastpak's adequate Icon Pak'r.

Aussie brand July's water-resistant-nylon offering, fitted with a laptop pouch and a bottle pocket, seems to strike the best balance: tidy but not alarmingly sleek, and under $200.

Just remember that strapping it to both shoulders, though better for back health, will make everyone think it's your first day of school. At least sling it from one, like a teen bully, when around people worth impressing.

July Carry All Backpack, $175

How can older guys dress in a cool way? I don't want to look try-hard.

I'm prescribing a two-step plan: 1. Forget about Cary Grant's suits—yes, he looked wonderful but that was a long time ago, when men dressed up. 2. Follow Alessandro Squarzi on Instagram (you'll add to his 360,000 followers).

Squarzi, the 59-year-old creative director of Milan fashion brand Fortela, might be the best modern example of a coolly dressed guy who just happens to have several decades under his cowboy belt. Smilovic said her husband, a boomer, looks to the silver-haired street-style star for cues. "Everyone needs a good example," she said, adding that Squarzi provides "confirmation that you haven't lost it."

This guy, who mixes Fortela designs with pieces from other brands, deploys denim shirts with a rancher's ease, layering faded examples under tweed jackets and shearling coats. Think oldies can't pull off hoodies? I need the inky navy one Squarzi wore recently; he styled the streamlined sweater with jeans, loafers, Jacques Marie Mage sunnies and a vintage Land Rover Defender. It says pacesetter, not pace-maker.

Recent winning looks from Alessandro Squarzi, who likes bright socks with 'elegant' shoes, favors denim shirts and gray sweatshirts, and has a thing for tassel loafers and Mr. Fliks canvas sneakers.

I rang Squarzi to discover his secret, beyond being a handsome Italian. He told me his "mental age is 30," before stressing the importance of proportions. His clothes, often slightly relaxed, fit well. Nothing tight or baggy.

Rather than planning outfits, he "follows his heart every morning." Unlike many American men, his heart does not lead him to sweatpants but to white pants, which he says make other colors pop, and to relaxed, raglan-sleeve coats.

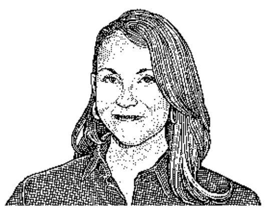
His ensembles, devoid of logos and loud prints, appear breezy. A favorite look of his that's easily replicated: jeans with colorful socks and "elegant shoes" such as tassel loafers (he likes Alden's). In another fun combo, he'll pair a simple black Casio with a sharp suit.

"Since life is already hard enough, one should at least give space to his inner child," he said. "Your clothes can be your playground."

DAVE URBAN (ILLUSTRATIONS); ALESSANDRO SQUARZI (3); MARGIELA (SNEAKERS); GETTY IMAGES (2)

P2JW067000-4-D00300-1--------XA

OFF BRAND / RORY SATRAN



She Wants to Make You Sporty, Rich and, Now, Sexy

CHLOE HORSEMAN FOR WSJ; CASEY ZHANG (SENSUAL SPORT)

Emily Oberg, the persistently innovative founder of the Sporty & Rich fashion brand, at her home in Los Angeles in February.

THE SPORTY & Rich brand has always been very sexy," Emily Oberg said recently.

The 31-year-old Los Angeles entrepreneur was talking about her fashion brand, which hit $40 million in revenue last year, but also the world she's been building on Instagram for the last 10 years. In Oberg-land, "health is wealth!" as slogans on its peppy sweatshirts and phone cases shout. Sporty & Rich women go riding and play tennis in short shorts, throw camel coats over their skimpy Pilates outfits and idolize Princess Diana in her bike-short era. Visual references include vintage lad magazines Playboy and Lui, as well as modern-day "girls by the pool half-naked in a hoodie," Oberg said. This carnal mix of imagery has helped market the brand's athleisure, ready-to-wear, accessories, beauty products and sell out sneaker and apparel collaborations with Adidas.

Today, things are getting even sexier for Sporty & Rich with its new offshoot, Sensual Sport. The first three products, a lubricant, a vibrator and a "wet mouth spray," are all under $100. (Condoms will also be included free with purchases.)

"I always just want to do things that I have a personal interest in," said Oberg. When she's into cable-knit sweaters and saucy sweatpants, she makes them; when she's into lymphatic-drainage massages and smoothies, she offers them at a wellness space at her New York City boutique. When she's intrigued by sex toys, she develops her own.

Sexual wellness is a booming business. Fortune Business Insights valued the market at $25 billion in 2024. Big brands making vibrators, lubes and the like include Dame, founded by a sexologist and MIT-trained engineer, and the Swedish juggernaut Lelo. Celebrities are getting into the mix: Actor Dakota Johnson is a co-creative director of organic lube maker Maude and singer Christina Aguilera co-founded the personal-care brand Playground.

When Oberg started poking around the sector's offerings, she found them uninspiring. She felt there was a void for cool, sophisticated products that women like her and her friends would actually want to put on their nightstand. "I wanted to create something that was fun and still felt luxury—something that a girl who shops at the Row would want to buy," she said.

The result: products that resemble smooth, rounded Apple items in sherbet colors. Sensual Sport's advertising images include elegantly cropped nudes, as well as playful still lifes with pineapples, melted ice cream and peaches. It's as if Irving Penn, Luca Guadagnino and Sofia Coppola collaborated while taking ecstasy. But the challenge of marketing such images on Oberg's preferred platform, Instagram, where suggestive photos are often

A sample of the new ad campaign.

flagged, is real. So she's running the campaign on permissive subscription service OnlyFans, too.

Oberg said she became more comfortable with her sexuality in her 30s and is inspired by the female body. "When I was younger, I felt there was more of a focus on the man, and you are almost afraid to speak up for your own needs," she said. She wanted to create products that would encourage women to experiment on their own with less shame. The brand's slogan is "prioritize your pleasure."

"It's a good time to launch a sexual wellness brand because the topic of sex is still taboo," said Olivia Richman, a New York primary-care physician and sexual-health influencer. Richman said that, especially for women, "There's always room for products that encourage education, open dialogue and pleasure without shame, embarrassment and guilt."

Beyond her personal interest in sexual health, Oberg was ready for a new business challenge. Sporty & Rich, which she founded in 2016,

Oberg set out to create products that would encourage women to experiment on their own with less shame.

has 40 employees at its headquarters in Paris. Its chief executive (and her ex-boyfriend) is David Obadia, who also founded the French clothing brand Harmony. Before launching her brand, Oberg was a correspondent for streetwear-focused media company Complex.

Oberg is the sole owner of Sporty & Rich. While she recognizes that her personal platform and following have been helpful, she wants the brand to stand on its own. "If and when we do sell the brand one day, I think it's just a better position to be in because I don't necessarily have to be tied to it," she said. She says she's been approached about potential investment and acquisition, but so far she's resisted. "We're still in the bootstrapping phase and we like it, because we know what we're doing and we have total control," she said. "That's something that would be hard for us to give up."

This summer, the brand will open its second store, in the West Hollywood neighborhood of Los Angeles. Incorporating a healthy cafe and a Pilates studio, it will be much more expansive than the New York City store, which opened in 2023. (Oberg practices what she preaches, regularly partaking in Pilates, colonics, lymphatic massages, hyperbaric chambers, tennis, hiking and IV infusions.)

"People really want to come and interact with the brand and experience it outside of Instagram or online," said Oberg.

These days, Sporty & Rich has grown too big for Oberg to be as hands-on as she was in its early days, so she's enjoyed getting into the weeds with Sensual Sport. "I just wanted to get back to that feeling of founding something from scratch."

STYLE & FASHION

Meet the 'Cali Sober' Set

In certain circles in Southern California and beyond, people who now shun booze consider drugs—including mushrooms, LSD and ketamine—just fine.

THE ORACLE PROJECT; GETTY IMAGES

HOLD THE WINE Lauren Brenc hosts alcohol-free parties, where she serves mushroom chocolates, in the Los Angeles area.

By Sara Ashley O'Brien

A **NIGHT** out with friends meant drinking when Lauren Brenc was in her 20s and living in New York City.

"I was so programmed to have fun with alcohol, everything became centered around it," said Brenc. "It was damaging my body, my emotional well-being. Everything was suffering."

That changed when she moved to Southern California in 2019. She cut down her drinking—and "started doing big doses of mushrooms," Brenc said. Now 30 and living in Topanga Canyon, she hosts alcohol-free pop-up parties in the Los Angeles area where she serves "mood-enhancing" mocktails and mushroom chocolates.

Like many others, Brenc uses the term "California sober" to describe her way of life. Alcohol is largely off the table, but psychedelics are a big part of her social world. This very Los Angeles lifestyle is catching on, thanks in part to January's surgeon general advisory that alcohol is a leading preventable cause of cancer.

"Individuals are choosing what resonates with them instead of just doing what might be at the party," said Atara Oven. The 38-year-old Santa Monica resident devotes her professional life to preparing people for psychedelic experiences and assisting them on "integration" afterward. In her social community, Oven says it's common for people to abstain from alcohol but use cannabis, mushrooms, LSD and ketamine.

In 2019, she started dabbling with "plant medicine," after cutting back on alcohol because she was tired of the hangovers and wanted different experiences. She hasn't had a drink since November, she said, but she isn't exactly sober. She said she attends Ayahuasca ceremonies and uses microdoses of mushrooms and LSD, at times. "I just don't drink."

> In certain scenes, 'if you are trying to drink, it is actually viewed as odd,' said Jeff Chen, a physician, scientist and entrepreneur in L.A.

The so-called sober-curious movement—focused on drinking less without going cold turkey—has been growing for years, as influencers have raised concerns about alcohol and shared their own stories about reducing consumption. On his popular podcast, Stanford neuroscientist Andrew Huberman has spoken about the negative effects drinking may have on health.

All of this is changing how people socialize. Eventbrite, the event ticketing platform, reports that the number of events billed as "sober curious" grew 92% on its platform from 2023 to 2024, with attendance increasing 51% over the same period. According to a study Eventbrite released in January, one in five 18- to 35-year-olds are seeking alcohol-free or sober-curious events.

Other substances, including psychedelics, have taken alcohol's place in certain social settings. Psychedelics can be abused or lead to unpredictable and harmful outcomes when used recreationally. Some, such as LSD and psilocybin, have shown potential for treating mental-health conditions in therapeutic settings. As a result, some states and local governments have relaxed their stance on the federally prohibited class of drugs. Last fall, Robert F. Kennedy Jr., President Trump's pick for Health and Human Services secretary, posted to social media that his "mind is open to the idea of psychedelics for treatment." A former heroin addict who is 40 years into recovery, Kennedy recounted his son's positive experience with ayahuasca and believes psychedelics should be decriminalized.

Cannabis, the original drug of choice for the "Cali sober" set, has been widely legalized for recreational use. While scientists have not studied many of the sober curious movement's other favored drugs as extensively, alcohol is a different story. Decades of studies have yielded a large body of research that documents alcohol's potential harm.

According to Jeff Chen, a physician, scientist and entrepreneur in Los Angeles who used to run UCLA's Center for Cannabis and Cannabinoids, "if you are trying to drink, it is actually viewed as odd" in certain communities and scenes. He says people are gravitating from booze to other substances for reasons that include broader awareness and acceptance of the long-term effects of alcohol.

Chen says research on the recreational use of cannabis and psilocybin indicates the substances can be less physically harmful and less addictive than alcohol, but urges people—especially adolescents and those with any history of psychotic conditions—to be cautious about both drugs' long-term mental health effects.

With ketamine, whose recreational use is a newer phenomenon, Chen says a relative lack of research makes it harder to draw comparisons to alcohol. He adds that recreational ketamine use can pose significant physical and mental-health risks.

Ford Smith, an investor living in Austin, went to rehab as a teen to address his alcohol addiction. He was sober until he was 26, when he decided to see if cannabis could help his depression and ADHD. He's explored psychedelics such as psilocybin, which he says eased his depression and anxiety. Today, Smith, 33, is the CEO of a venture firm called Ultranative that is focused on the environment and alternative medicine.

Cannabis has been widely legalized for recreational use.

Smith, who was introduced to ketamine on a dance floor in Tulum in 2017, eventually sought out intravenous ketamine infusions at a clinic back home. He says the infusions helped with his depression, but he eventually sought out a drug dealer for easier access.

He became addicted, he says, using ketamine daily for over two years before going to rehab for ketamine addiction. "I know countless numbers of people who've either been in the same addiction with ketamine or are struggling with it currently. People are a little too laissez-faire about how they're using ketamine."

Kayla Lyons, the author of the 2023 self-help book "Soberish," went to rehab about a decade ago to recover from a benzodiazepine addiction. A year later, she went to Alcoholics Anonymous. Now 32 and living in Newport Beach, Lyons says total sobriety doesn't work for her. She's tried other substances, from psilocybin to a tonic that contains the herbal substances kratom and kava. America's Poison Centers, which collects data for all 55 poison centers in the U.S., identified unregulated psychoactive substances including kratom as an emerging public health threat that has led to hospitalizations.

"It makes you feel like you're kind of drunk, but not wasted," Lyons said, adding that she told her older brother to try it for relaxation. "He started drinking two or three bottles a day and then getting serious withdrawal symptoms."

Lyons, a Lagree instructor, says she stays away from kratom now, too. Her social activities include meetups involving coffee and cold plunges. "I have found a really strong community of sober, or basically sober, people who really don't drink," she said. "It's more, 'Let's go for a hike or go grab a juice.'"

FAST FIVE

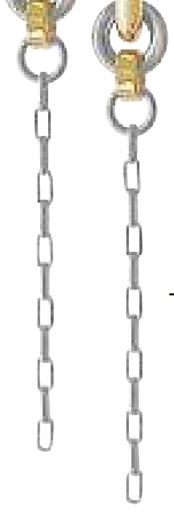
All's Well That Blends Well

Fussy mixed-metal jewelry fell out of favor in the 1990s. Today, silver and gold are reunited in edgily interlocked hoops, loops and links.

We11done Silver and Gold Hoop Earrings, *$345 at Ssense*

Monbouquette Patchwork Chain Necklace Chunky, *$350 at At Present*

Fiametta Mixed Link Bracelet, *$9,800*



Laura Lombardi Two-Tone Pezza Earrings, *$152*

Spinelli Kilcollin Solarium SG Ring, *$590*

AT PRESENT (MONBOUQUETTE); SSENSE (2)

DESIGN & DECORATING

COLLECTED INTERIORS (AFTER); REDFIN REAL ESTATE (BEFORE); MATTHEW MCMULLEN (PINK HOME)

Faux Stone That Rocks

With a 153% return on investment, 'manufactured stone veneer' is proving persuasive when it comes to curb appeal. Often affordable, it can read as (pricey) natural rock.

BY YELENA MOROZ ALPERT

THE 1922 Craftsman that Rebekah Higgs bought in Halifax, Nova Scotia, had a concrete foundation that, as with many houses, had been painted the same color as the shingle siding, in this case a dreary blue.

A career renovator and host of the YouTube series "DIY Mom," Higgs wanted her new home to blend with its historic neighbors. So after she slicked the house in pink, she anchored it with manufactured stone veneer (MSV), for a look less Malibu Barbie, more Atlantic Canada. "The stone added a sense of permanence and grounded the house visually," she said.

Not bad for a material many architects and designers look down upon. "Manufactured stone has gotten very good. From a distance you probably can't tell the difference," said Jacob Belk, vice president of building-products advisory for housing-industry tracker Zonda.

Its 2024 Cost vs. Value report set the return on investment for MSV projects at 153% and the average U.S. project cost at $11,287. Belk points out that, in a post-pandemic real-estate market full of remodeled kitchens and bathrooms, the value of this less-common upgrade has probably increased.

The look-alike veneer is a mostly concrete composite formed and colored to look like natural stone. Some types come in panels. Others, colloquially known as "lick and stick," are individual "stones" with flat backs that a mason puzzles together and mortars.

The ersatz foundation of Rebekah Higgs's 1922 home mimics historic stone found elsewhere in Halifax, Nova Scotia.

Ashley Macuga, principal of Collected Interiors in San Carlos, Calif., has added MSV to three projects in the last two years. A typical facade accent, like the gable on the house shown above, cost her roughly $5,000 in materials and $13,000 for installation. Natural stone would run about $10,000 in materials and installation about 25% more, or $16,250, says Roland Funk of Funk Landscape Design & Construction in Redwood City, who worked with Macuga. Since it's heavier, real stone requires more labor.

Higgs partnered with a local firm on her 600-square-foot project—she routinely gets discounts that suppliers offer influencers. But in Charlotte, N.C., for example, the material she chose, Cultured Stone's Dressed Fieldstone, would cost a homeowner about $7 a square foot, not including installation, says Travis Pryduluk, senior branch manager at SiteOne Landscape Supply.

Macuga admits that when she was renovating the 1947 cedar-shingle Cape Cod, even masons pooh-poohed the material as low-end. But she avoided the cheesy "pasted-on feel" with an overgrouting technique. "There isn't real definition of where one stone begins and one ends," she said. "That messiness is what our eye desires."

> 'The stone added a sense of permanence to the house.'

Los Angeles designer Amber Lewis documented her use of MSV in her reimagining of a nondescript 1956 California ranch house—a project Macuga felt gave her "permission" to try the material. Lewis, too, used an overgrouting technique and says today she also "made sure there was no uniformity in the stone spacing."

Macuga further staved off fauxness by testing grout colors the way designers test paint, bringing sample boards to the sunny side of the house, then the shady side. "When the [stone] blends with the color [of the mortar], it feels more structural and less like a decorative stone accent," she said.

Speaking of structure, MSV won't look realistic if it defies the laws of engineering. "Stone is heavy," notes Ken Pursley, founding partner at Pursley Dixon Architecture in Charlotte, N.C. The "rocks" that mimic a foundation on Higgs's house make sense. But, said Pursely, "if you see a [stone-clad] second-floor structure cantilevering over the first, obviously it is glued on."

BLOCK PARTY As part of this Redwood City, Calif., remodel, designer Ashley Macuga clad the home's gable in Grand Banks Limestone from Eldorado Stone.

HOUSE TOUR

GLASS ACT A transparent wall separates family room and stairs in a Newport Beach, Calif., home, designed by M. Elle Design.

YOSHIHIRO MAKINO

After All, It's a Window Wall

A California couple wanted a home that differed from its by-the-book neighbors. Not drenched in white, but not gloomy. Answer: glass.

By Jessica Ritz

WHAT HAPPENS when you're eager to escape conformity but don't know what you want instead? That dilemma confronted a Newport Beach, Calif., couple who raised their children in a conventional home and craved a change. Its look-alike blue-and-white decor—the Coastal California style—had dominated interior design in the area for 20 years. A by-the-numbers beach bungalow here. A same-old-same-old Cape Cod revival there. "It's lots of raised-panel wainscoting painted white," said the restless couple's designer Marie Turner Carson, "with blue mainly in fabric, sometimes in tile."

"It's a beautiful look," conceded Carson, who runs M. Elle Design with her sister, Emily Turner Barker, in Pacific Palisades. "It's just commonplace, and they wanted something different."

Not that the couple had a clear idea what that something was. They bought a lot closer to the city's waterfront and fuzzily envisioned a new house built for entertaining, not child-rearing, with smaller rooms that felt intimate, more special. But they were torn: They wanted to be free of all-white but not of light.

At first, the designers and architect Eric Olsen lacked a precise answer, too. "We said, 'OK, how do we make the house feel different but still warm and light-filled?'" recalled Carson. Their solution: lots of unpainted wood. "It's a neutral that will look beautiful for a long time," said Carson. She says she started pulling imagery to persuade the hesitant couple that blond oak could be their new white and yet guarantee cozy intimacy.

It took some elegant examples to convince the couple.

Carson was grappling with her own hesitations. She worried that all that wood in modestly sized rooms could get gloomy. "That's how I came up with these window partitions," said Carson. "They break up the rooms, but light can pass through."

This plan threatened to run aground. In the family room, the designers were especially eager to install one of these window walls to subtly block a visually noisy staircase at one end. The clients objected, fearing that it would squeeze the small space too much. "But we said, 'It's really a transparent glass wall,'" said Carson, who convinced the couple by showing them elegant precedents, including a French cottage by designer Christian Liaigre with similar panels.

The glazed wall "ended up being the star of the show," said Carson. Having gained the couple's trust, she used a similar bank of interior windows in the dining room to set off an adjacent butler's pantry but not enshroud it in shadow. "You get the intimacy of a smaller dining room, but you're letting the light reach further."

One paint concession to stave off the darkness of too much wood? The kitchen cabinets were slicked a putty-colored semigloss that, while not white, lightened the mood.

The home's aesthetic suits California, says the designer, who grew up in the area. "To me, it's not that big of a leap because it's all very clean and neutral, it's just not white." To the owners, however, the house, including its exterior of cedar and stone, marks an exciting departure from its by-the-book neighbors. The evidence? When the project was complete, they gave the design team wood wine boxes engraved with quotes from admiring friends. Among the many compliments: "Unicorn," "Like no other home" and "Never want to leave."

On the kitchen cabinets Farrow & Ball's Drop Cloth in Modern Eggshell avoids true, commonplace white and relieves an all-wood look.

From left: In the dining room, another glazed wall defines a butler's pantry while letting in light; the home's modern cedar-and-stone exterior helped it stand out from its look-alike neighbors.

ADVENTURE & TRAVEL

Unscripted Escapes

A new season of the hit show 'The White Lotus' has made Thailand hot. Here, four ways to find 'paradise' without finding crowds of fans.

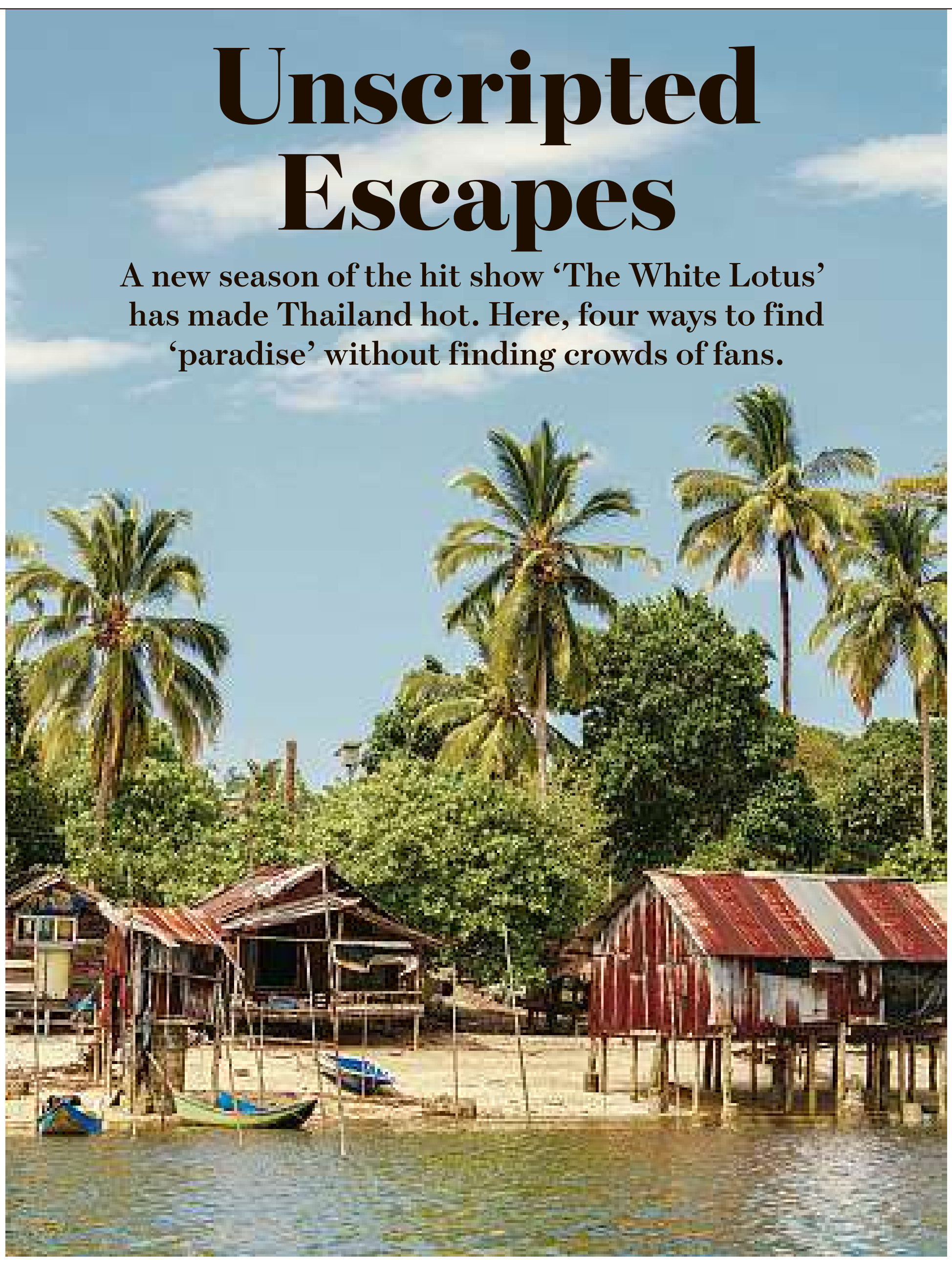
By Chris Schalkx

SINCE its 2021 debut, HBO's luxury-travel satire "The White Lotus" has doubled as a high-gloss brochure for its exotic filming locations. After seasons one and two—set respectively in Maui and Sicily—debuted, bookings at the on-screen hotels skyrocketed, a phenomenon the travel site Expedia cheekily dubbed "set-jetting." Now, weeks after the third-season premiere, the show's latest destination, the Thai island of Koh Samui, is already feeling the heat.

Indeed, the buzz began long before episodes started streaming. Hotels.com reports that searches for Koh Samui surged after the show's teaser went viral in December. This season's main backdrop, the Four Seasons Resort Koh Samui, has seen "a steady growth in website visits and a significant increase in bookings compared with the same period last year," said Marc Speichert, Four Seasons' Chief Commercial Officer. At the brand's other Thai properties (including Bangkok and Chiang Mai), web visits also spiked 37%.

Beyond the Hollywood buzz, Thailand still harbors plenty of unspoiled corners.

But Thailand was booming before "The White Lotus" fans started pouring in. The country expects a record-breaking 40 million tourists in 2025. That surge has not merely left visitors scrambling for a beach lounge: Near-constant gridlock now plagues Phuket's main roads, while Koh Samui struggles to keep up with waste and water issues.



LIFE'S A BEACH Rustic stilted huts are a common sight on the island of Koh Phra Thong.

Look beyond the usual spots, though, and you'll still find plenty of quiet escapes. I should know: Since making Thailand my home base in 2013, I've been on a mission to seek them out. Below, the lowdown on four destinations with all the tropical cool of the big-hitters, minus the "set-jetting" crowds.

Instead of Koh Samui
Koh Phra Thong

Koh Samui's resorts have made it a luxury travel hotspot, but Koh Phra Thong, off the Andaman coast, offers something more rare than mere sun and sand: solitude. You'll find no five-star hotels on this sleepy island. Accommodations are limited to the fan-cooled bungalows at Baba Ecolodge, or simple villas at the small hotels, like Moken Eco Village, that line its northwestern coast.

Beyond the pristine beach, there's a savanna-like heartland that feels more like the Serengeti than Southeast Asia, and thick mangrove forests you can kayak when high tide floods them.

Aboard a longtail boat near Koh Ngai, on the Trang Archipelago.

Instead of the Phi Phi Islands The Trang Archipelago

The Phi Phi islands' star turn in the 2000 film "The Beach" made it so popular that authorities had to close one area, Maya Bay, for years to let its ecosystem recover. But about 40 miles south, the Trang Archipelago offers the same cinematic limestone cliffs and turquoise waters, minus the masses.

The liveliest of the towns, Koh Muk, is home to driftwood-clad beach bars and boutique resorts like Sivalai. Andrew Clark, of Thailand-based luxury-travel outfitters Smiling Albino, says he often takes guests to explore the spectacular mainland caves—but you'll find no headline attractions here. Days unfold in a dreamy loop of snorkeling trips and dips in the bath-warm sea. Before you hop on a ferry, fuel up in Trang town. With its dim sum joints and Southern Thai curry counters, the archipelago's main gateway is one of Thailand's best cities to eat your way around.

Above: A dim sum breakfast in Trang town; Below: Scooters streak the street at dusk in Songkhla Old Town.

CHRIS SCHALKX FOR WSJ

Instead of Chiang Mai
Mae Hong Son

The bratty holidaymakers in "The White Lotus" might not make it to Chiang Mai in Thailand's mountainous north, but it's a fixture on the tourist circuit. Few visitors, however, venture onward to Mae Hong Son, a jungle-cloaked valley town where banana groves stretch to the horizon.

There you'll find a hiker's paradise, with trails weaving past waterfalls, tribal villages and gilded mountaintop temples. Those in the know stay at Fern Resort, a string of thatch-roofed bungalows in the former rice fields southeast of town.

Instead of Phuket
Songkhla

Trinket stores and cannabis dispensaries have overtaken Phuket Town's colorful shophouses. For a quieter alternative, head to Songkhla, an under-the-radar port just north of the Malaysian border. Daniel Fraser of Smiling Albino calls its photogenic Old Town, full of Chinese shrines and wooden tea houses, a "picture-perfect" gem that recalls Phuket Town of 30 years ago.

Start your morning with sweet kopi (coffee) and kaya (coconut jam) toast at an old-timey cafe, such as Hub Seng, followed by a stroll past Sino-Portuguese mansions and narrow streets covered in funky street art. Come sunset, locals flock to the Samila Beach promenade, where restaurants dish up seafood curries, herb-stuffed steamed fish and cockles in spicy nam chim sauce, on tables that spill out onto the sand.

With a Line Stand-In, Your Wait Is Over

Tired of wasting time standing in line for attractions and hot restaurants? Try the latest travel trend: Outsource the job.

IT WAS A SUBFREEZING Friday night, and I wanted a romantic dinner with my husband. But when we arrived at Emilios Ballato, a buzzy, no-reservations Italian joint in Manhattan, the wait for a table was as daunting as a Taylor Swift ticket queue. Shivering on the sidewalk for hours seemed a poor start to date night. So, I hired someone to do the time for us, while we went off in search of an aperitivo.

Booking people to stand in line at hotspots nationwide has become a go-to trick for travelers, too. Need rush tickets for a Broadway show? Someone will line up for you. Trying to snag entry to a shop for limited-edition sneakers? There's someone for that, too. "It's really a hustle on behalf of the hustlers," said Tanya B., a New York-based "line-stander," as such workers are called. "If you can pay someone to wait for you, it makes sense."

Reserving a line-stander can be remarkably simple. National services like Taskrabbit, and regional ones like New York's Same Ole Line Dudes and Skip the Line in Washington, D.C., let you hire someone online for a set fee. Once the booking's done, you can communicate directly with your stand-in, who will update you, typically via text message, when the wait is almost over.

Taskrabbit reports that from 2023 to 2024, line-waiting requests increased 10% year-over-year in New York City and 18% nationwide. Taskers have held spots at restaurants including Los Angeles's Nobu Malibu, Chicago's Au Cheval, and Miami's Joe Stone Crab.

Critics of the practice, who line up themselves, view this travel hack as an irritant and a symptom of economic inequality. To those opponents, Joshua Bekowitz, a veteran line-stander, points out that if you're 30 people ahead of you, the wait's the same even if one of them is a paid stand-in. Commenters on a Reddit forum about the trend see it differently: "Hiring third parties to camp out," wrote one, "[is what] perpetuates the need to actually camp out."

Leesa Raab, a 42-year-old publicist, hired a line-waiter to snag a prime table at the Brooklyn pizza joint Lucali. "With a Tasker we got the exact time and party size we wanted. Some friends teased me [about it], but most thought it was hilarious."

For those willing to pay, services like Taskrabbit typically charge an average of $27 an hour. Same Ole Line Dudes has a structured pricing model: $50 minimum for up to two hours, $25 for each additional hour, plus extra for extreme weather or overnight waits.

But outsourcing doesn't guarantee success. Two hours after we left our Same Ole Line Dudes dude outside Emilios Ballato, he was still biding his time behind two parties. Starving, we mourned the money lost and decided the chicken parm would have to wait.

—Jordi Lippe-McGraw

JACOB STEAD

P2JW067000-4-D00800-1--------XA

GEAR & GADGETS

FACE LIFT The 2025 redesign brings the look of the pint-sized Taos forward in time, with modernized LED headlamps.

VOLKSWAGEN

RUMBLE SEAT / DAN NEIL

Volkswagen's Petite SUV Drives Like a Little Scamp

ONE OF MY daughters loves "The Sims 4," a social simulation game in which players guide the destinies of adorable avatars, tottering around a magical world surprisingly like our own. Your Sim needs to go to the bathroom now and then, for instance. If it forgets to brush its teeth, its confidence level goes down. If your little friend doesn't get a job it will be condemned to live in cutesy squalor. Man, ain't that the truth.

But something is missing: cars. None of the squeaky-shiny-rubberized environments embedded in "The Sims 4" gameplay—called "worlds"—permits vehicular traffic. Sims just materialize at the market, the marina, the gym or their jobs. Or else they just walk. Not in my world.

Surprisingly—considering what a drag they can be in real life—cars are among the most requested upgrades to the game, according to the publisher Electronic Arts. But which cars? May I suggest the 2025 VW Taos SEL? Significantly updated for 2025, our test car this week is halfway to anime, right out of the box—a little elf, a wee enchanted chew-toy, a cutie patootie, if you'll pardon my French. Cheerful and lively, small and simple, easy to buy and to board, the Taos is to the Sims manner born.

SMALL WONDER The Taos counts the Hyundai Kona, Kia Niro and Subaru Crosstrek among its competitors.

Cross-shopped against beamish cuties such as the Hyundai Kona, Kia Niro, Toyota Corolla Cross, Chevy TrailBlazer and Subaru Crosstrek, the Taos's cuteness derives from its neoteny; that is, it has the looks, lines and proportions of a full-size SUV poured into a pint-size package (also my stage name in college).

For 2025, new LED light bars, headlamps and taillamps sprinkle Taos with modernizing fairy dust. In SEL versions, the wheel wells are filled to the brim with 19-inch wheels and all-season tires. I have to say, that's darling. Compared to the tiny Taos, the wheels look like custom rims—a kind of forced perspective.

In a graphical world that tends toward the cheerily generic, the Taos fits right in. If anything, the refreshed styling bends even more toward the conventional, says a thought bubble that appears over my Sim's head.

There is no getting around it, and for some, no getting in it, either: The Taos cabin is small. The seats are kind of hard—firm like old VW seats tended to be, you know? I long for more right-elbow room. There's not a lot of headroom, but there is a panoramic sunroof in the SEL. The narrow rear doors make the loading of groceries something of a struggle, I observed. Nor would I want to wrestle a child safety seat through these doors daily. My Sim would get very emotional.

VW makes a very similar vehicle that's one shoe size larger, the compact-class Tiguan. The difference in price and trim walk is such that some Taos buyers could pay more for the smaller option. Which illustrates the point that in this category—sweet-faced, easy-to-park city cars—smallness has its own worth.

The Taos's turbocharged 1.5-liter engine was also breathed upon for 2025, getting fitted with a more capacious turbo intercooler, revised fuel injectors and a new (and now required) gas particulate filter. These mods help wring an additional 16 hp out of the direct-injected inline-four (174 hp at 5,500 rpm). Maximum torque remains unchanged at 184 lb-ft at 1,750 rpm.

For 2025, AWD-equipped models receive a transmission upgrade in the form of the eight-speed automatic transmission. Cars with 4Motion also get an independent multi-link rear suspension, subbing in for the torsion-beam rear axle.

The revised Taos weighs around 3,500 pounds, depending on options. Fuel economy is about the same as the year before. However, efficiency takes a non-trivial hit with the addition of 4Motion. FWD models score 31 mpg, combined; in AWD-equipped versions, the combined mileage falls to 28 mpg. Acceleration is a surprisingly close footrace between FWD and AWD versions—7.1 and 7.0 seconds, respectively, as estimated by Car and Driver.

Our test car, dipped in madness-inducing green metallic paint, represented the pride of the tiny fleet. Automakers typically load up test cars in order to showcase the latest, most revenue-generating features and options. In these more price-sensitive times, I am hoping they will begin circulating examples that are more representative of the take rate, the way most are delivered.

That said, the Taos SEL with 4Motion drove awfully well, the little scamp. The powertrain revisions go a long way toward refining the Taos's driving experience, dialing out the latency, transient vibration and unlovely shifting behavior of the retired dual-clutch. The Taos felt surprisingly on point and eager on the road, with no bad manners, up and down the rev counter. The quality of quiet is up. The Taos seemed well constructed and tight as a drum.

The VW Taos is a little elf, a wee enchanted chew-toy, a cutie patootie, if you'll pardon my French.

The microevolution of VW cabin design in the past decade has left critics hailing any change as momentous. In that light, the 2025 revision in Taos is downright epochal. The center-mounted infotainment touch screen is now propped against the sculpted folds of the multiply dash console.

Just below, the panel hosting climate controls uses smooth capacitive switches and sliders for adjustments. I had a bit of a tussle with these. Below that is the cubby enclosing the wireless charging pad. Apple CarPlay and Android Auto are standards in all trims.

Between the front seats, the center console is dominated by the large, retro-looking stick shifter with a leatherette gaiter, surrounded by various controls, including one to turn off Traction Control. Don't touch that. At the driver's right elbow is the drive mode selector, offering options for highway, snow, loose terrain and hill-descent driving.

As illustrated on the gearshift finial, the eight-speed transmission features a separate sequential-shift gate, for sportier manual shifting—in case your Sim wanders into "Grand Theft Auto" territory and needs to make a quick getaway.

2025 VOLKSWAGEN TAOS SEL 4MOTION

Base price $34,695
Price, as tested $36,970
Powertrain turbocharged and intercooled, direct-injection 1.5-liter inline four; eight-speed automatic transmission; on-demand all-wheel drive
Power/torque 174 hp at 5,500 rpm/184 lb-ft at 1,750 rpm
0-60 mph 7.0 seconds (Car and Driver)
Length/wheelbase/width/height 175.9/105.5/72.5/65.1 inches
Curb weight 3,500 pounds (est.)
EPA fuel economy 25/33/28 mpg, city/highway/combined
Cargo capacity 60.2/24.9 cubic feet (behind 1st/2nd row)


WSJ's
Take On
the Week
WSJ

EATING & DRINKING

THE BAKEAWAY

Thinking Out Of the Box

Who needs instant pudding? A foolproof pastry cream takes a comfort-food classic to new heights.

By Vallery Lomas

I LOVE USING fruit in desserts. It adds a welcome vibrancy, expanding the flavor profile beyond the basic butter, eggs, sugar, flour. And I might love banana desserts best of all.

Once exotic, now a ubiquitous supermarket stalwart, this tropical fruit transcends seasons and regions. It's accessible. And I defy you to name a more comforting banana dessert than the all-American classic of vanilla pudding, sliced bananas and Nilla Wafers. Think of the recipe at right as an affectionate homage.

My banana pudding trifle brings a little glamour to the familiar dessert without fussing it up too much.

My banana pudding trifle brings a little glamour to the familiar dessert without fussing it up too much. Piled high in a glass trifle dish, this version proudly shows off its layers.

The velvety-rich custard base is no mere vanilla pudding, and we certainly aren't using the instant stuff from a box. The cookie layers (more on those below) will soften to a cakelike consistency under the weight and moisture of the custard—though the broken cookies scattered on top will hold their crunch, offering a welcome textural contrast to the custard and the banana slices. For a simple dessert, there really is a lot going on.

Ripeness Is All

Fortunately, the bananas, our most important ingredient, require very little preparation. But they must be very ripe. Only truly ripe bananas will bring the right flavor and texture to this very banana-forward recipe.

The outer peel should be covered in brown spots, but the banana shouldn't be mushy or emit any off-odors, which tend to indicate that the fruit has crossed the line to overripe or even rotten. Peeled, the banana should reveal smooth, off-white flesh, uniform in color.

If your bananas haven't yet reached that point, give them at least three days to ripen before using them in this recipe. It can take even longer; storing them in a brown paper bag will help them ripen more quickly.

Custard Fundamentals

The custard is the component that unites the different flavors and textures in this dessert. Cooked on the stovetop, the custard I use here is really a pastry cream, and I rely on a foolproof method to produce this building block of so many desserts. Using only the eggs' yolks makes it incredibly rich and velvety. Cornstarch thickens it and makes it stable enough to provide structure for the various layers.

To get the ideal creamy texture, it's important to take care tempering the egg yolks, slowly adding hot milk as you whisk. Add the milk too fast and you'll end up with scrambled eggs—definitely not what we want here. Perfect smoothness is the goal.

To that end, continue to cook (and whisk) the cream after it has thickened. This step achieves something else, too: It cooks off the starchy flavor of the cornstarch. To ensure that any clumps or bits of egg get eliminated, use a flexible spatula to press the cooked pastry cream through a fine-mesh sieve.

And pressing plastic wrap directly onto the surface of the prepared cream will prevent a skin from forming on top as it chills in the refrigerator. For more helpful tips and a couple of visual cues to guide you, see "How to Achieve the Creamiest Pastry Cream," below.

Lighten It Up

Smooth and lovely as it is, a straight pastry cream isn't lofty enough for a trifle. So I whisk unsweetened heavy cream until stiff peaks form, then fold in the chilled pastry cream. In fancy-pastry terms, equal parts pastry cream and whipped cream folded together is called Diplomat Cream—an apt name for the layer that ties everything together.

Smart Cookies

You can use Nabisco Nilla Wafers or another brand of vanilla wafer cookie here; crisp shortbread cookies work nicely, too. What matters most: The cookies must be thin enough to absorb moisture from the cream and become scoopably soft.

Still, I tend to go for the Nabisco classic because it really dials up the nostalgia factor. And what's more delicious than that?

LAYER UP This striking trifle gives the classic banana pudding a glow up.

Banana Pudding Trifle

Active Time 30 minutes **Total Time** 3 hours (includes chilling) **Serves** 12

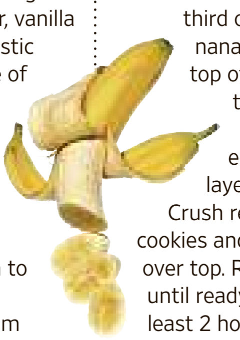
2 cups whole milk
4 large egg yolks
½ cup granulated sugar
3 tablespoons cornstarch
2 tablespoons unsalted butter, cubed
1 tablespoon vanilla extract
Dash of salt
1 cup heavy cream
8 large, ripe bananas, sliced
12 ounces vanilla wafer cookies (such as Nilla) or thin shortbread cookies

1. Make the pastry cream: Heat milk in a saucepan over medium heat until bubbles form around the edge. Remove from heat.

2. In a medium bowl, whisk together yolks, sugar and cornstarch. Whisking constantly, slowly add hot milk. Return mixture to saucepan. Cook over medium heat, whisking, until mixture thickens. Continue cooking and whisking to cook off cornstarch flavor, 1-2 minutes more. Remove from heat and use a flexible spatula to press pastry cream through a fine-mesh sieve into a large bowl. Stir in butter, vanilla and salt. Press plastic wrap onto surface of hot cream to cover. Refrigerate until ready to use, at least 30 minutes.

3. In a large bowl, whip heavy cream to stiff peaks. Fold chilled pastry cream into whipped cream.

4. Assemble the trifle: Spread one quarter of the cream mixture evenly across the bottom of a trifle dish. Layer a third of the cookies on top, then a third of the banana slices on top of that. Continue layering in this way, ending with a layer of cream. Crush remaining cookies and sprinkle over top. Refrigerate until ready to serve, at least 2 hours.



Vallery combines whipped cream and pastry cream for a light, airy result.

How to Achieve the Creamiest Pastry Cream

The key is to temper the egg yolks, slowly introducing hot liquid so the eggs won't cook and curdle. In step 2 of the recipe above, you whisk continuously with one hand while slowly pouring in hot milk with the other. Cook the pastry cream until it goes from the consistency pictured at left to the creamy thickness at right. Then cook 1-2 minutes more, still whisking steadily, to cook off any cornstarch flavor. Finally, use a rubber spatula to press the pastry cream through a fine-mesh sieve to reach absolute smoothness.

LINDA XIAO FOR WSJ; FOOD STYLING BY PEARL JONES; PROP STYLING BY SEAN DOOLEY; GETTY IMAGES

SLOW FOOD FAST / SATISFYING AND SEASONAL FOOD IN ABOUT 30 MINUTES

Filet Mignon With Sauce au Poivre and Confit Potatoes

The chef
Charlie Mitchell

His restaurant
Saga in New York City

What he's known for Working his way from Detroit to New York City and climbing the fine-dining ladder; earning a Michelin star early in his career; taking the helm at Saga after his mentor, James Kent, passed away.

THE SORT of elaborate, multicourse meals Charlie Mitchell cooks at Saga, in lower Manhattan, don't necessarily translate outside a restaurant kitchen. "I cook tasting menus," he said. But with home cooks in mind, the chef streamlined this steak au poivre, his third Slow Food Fast recipe.

As luxurious as filet mignon in a classic French au poivre sauce is, Mitchell's preferred steak technique makes it a realistic weeknight dinner. "I cook it very fast over really high heat," he said. He lets the meat come to room temperature before it hits the pan and waits to season it until just before cooking. "Salt draws out moisture, and that prevents a good sear," he said.

For an equally sumptuous side dish, poach potatoes in olive oil until they're buttery soft. The volume of oil called for might give you pause, but rest assured: You can save the poaching oil left over for another use. Let it cool, strain into a sealable container and store at room temperature, out of direct light. It won't go to waste. Once you make potatoes this way, you'll want to do it again and again. —*Kitty Greenwald*

Total Time 35 minutes
Serves 4

4 (5- to 6-ounce) filet mignon steaks
2 pounds baby potatoes
6½ cups extra-virgin olive oil
3 cloves garlic, smashed
4 sprigs thyme
Flaky salt and freshly ground black pepper
¼ cup green peppercorns
2 shallots, minced
⅓ cup brandy
½ cup beef or chicken stock
1 cup heavy cream

1. Let steaks rest at room temperature for at least 20 minutes before cooking.

2. Meanwhile, set a large pot over medium heat. Add potatoes, enough oil to cover (4-6 cups), garlic, thyme and a good pinch of salt. Simmer gently, making sure oil never boils, until largest potato is tender, 15-20 minutes. Turn off heat. Keep potatoes in oil until ready to serve.

3. Season steaks generously with salt and pepper. Place a large sauté pan over medium-high heat. Once hot, add 2-3 tablespoons oil. After 30 seconds, lay in steaks. (If necessary, work in batches to avoid crowding.) Sear until a golden crust forms, 2-5 minutes. Flip and sear reverse, 2-5 minutes. Continue cooking, flipping frequently, until steaks reach desired doneness, about 6 minutes more for medium-rare. Transfer steaks to a cutting board and let rest at least 5 minutes.

4. Wipe out pan and set over medium heat. Add 2 tablespoons oil, peppercorns and shallots, and sweat until shallots are translucent, 2-4 minutes. Carefully add brandy (it may flame), and cook off alcohol, 1-2 minutes. Add stock and simmer until reduced by half, 3-5 minutes. Add cream and simmer until flavors meld, about 2 minutes.

5. Use a slotted spoon to remove potatoes from oil. (Save oil for another use.) Spoon sauce over steaks and serve with warm potatoes.

WEEKNIGHT LUXURY This steak, its creamy peppercorn sauce and a side of luscious olive-oil-poached potatoes come together quickly.

ELIZABETH COETZEE/WSJ; FOOD STYLING BY DANA BONAGURA; PROP STYLING BY CARLA GONZALEZ-HART; MICHAEL HOEWELER (PORTRAIT)

P2JW067000-4-D01100-1--------XA

Is an Appliance That Lasts Decades Really More Economical?

Maybe it's time for a new oven. Maybe it's worth repairing. Here, what to factor in as you do the math.

By Matthew Kronsberg

I WON'T SAY that the spark is gone, but when it comes to my 20-year-old Bosch range, it definitely isn't what it used to be. The front left igniter has grown feeble, and a few of my kitchen's other major appliances show similar age and wear. The hinges on my Bosch oven have gone a little slack; on rare, brief occasions my Fisher & Paykel refrigerator makes a sound suggesting a tiny, angry woodpecker is trapped inside.

None of these issues are catastrophic, and with a little TLC, I could perhaps keep all my appliances going another 20 years or more. But every time they need attention, the calculus on whether to repair or replace them changes.

While the prices of appliances have dropped, repair costs have done the opposite.

I find myself wondering: Is it even possible now to outfit a kitchen that will function for decades? And does doing so make sense, given that new appliances often work better and more efficiently?

WHICH IS THE BETTER VALUE? / HOW TWO RANGES, VINTAGE AND NEW, MEASURE UP WHEN IT COMES TO COST, SIZE AND CAPABILITY

1950s Chambers Model C
Price Tag About $8,000 (restored)
Width 37⅞ inches
Curb Weight About 450 pounds
Oven Size 2.25 cubic feet
Turkey Test Can fit a 25-pound bird, but not really anything else.
Hottest Burner 9,000 btu
Pasta Performance 32 minutes to bring 7 liters of water to a boil from 70 degrees (assuming 45% efficiency) on its hottest burner.
Superpower The oven is so efficiently insulated that after preheating, a chicken will roast with the oven off.

New Bosch 100 Series Gas Range
Price Tag $1,499
Width 30 inches
Curb Weight 176 pounds
Oven Size 5.8 cubic feet
Turkey Test Fits a 25-pounder plus sides.
Hottest Burner 16,000 btu
Pasta Performance 18 minutes to bring 7 liters of water to a boil from 70 degrees (assuming 45% efficiency) on its hottest burner.
Superpower This model offers bells and whistles many would deem worth having, including settings for dough proofing, air frying and more.

BRADLEY HUBER (CHAMBERS); BOSCH

'They Don't Make Them Like They Used To'

A widespread belief holds that large appliances' lifespans are getting shorter. InterNACHI, the International Association of Certified Home Inspectors, puts the expected service life of a modern refrigerator at 9-13 years, and that of a gas range at 15-17. But look at estimates from decades ago, and the numbers differ less than you might expect.

In a 1978 study in the Home Economics Research Journal, refrigerators clocked in at an expected life of 15.2 years; gas ranges, at 13.5 years. But take those numbers with a grain of salt, advises Nick Gromicko, founder of InterNACHI: Such studies look at how long households hang onto these appliances, working or not. Replace a working refrigerator in a renovation, and it counts the same as a broken one.

Drops in price have far outpaced drops in lifespan, said Gale L. Pooley, the author, with Marian L. Tupy, of "Superabundance: The Story of Population Growth, Innovation, and Human Flourishing on an Infinitely Bountiful Planet." Factor in average-wage increases, and "you can get 13.23 refrigerators today for the time price of one in 1956."

Still, while prices have dropped, repair costs have done the opposite, said Matt Hillebrand, vice president of builder sales and IT at Don's Appliances, which has served the Pittsburgh area since 1971. The cheaper the appliance, the more appealing it becomes to replace it versus fix it, he said, because whether you have a $700 refrigerator or a $12,000 one, replacing a compressor essentially costs the same.

Exactly Like They Used To

Some say the best way to achieve appliance longevity is to start with one that has already lasted a long time. Devoutly in this camp are Elizabeth and Ethan Finkelstein, founders of Cheap Old Houses, whose social-media accounts, books and TV shows highlight affordable vintage homes.

For the 18th-century farmhouse they are renovating in upstate New York, the Finkelsteins have ordered a copper-clad vintage Chambers stove. Restored and updated with some safety elements by Antique Appliances in Clayton, Ga., it will run them a little over $11,000, but the built-to-last appliances of its era weren't cheap to begin with. A stove like the Finkelsteins' cost at least $450 new in the 1950s—the equivalent of around $5,400 today—according to John Jowers, owner of Antique Appliances.

Keep It Simple

As I debate when or whether to replace my appliances, I've repeatedly heard this advice: Buy the simplest model from the best brand you can afford.

Consider a maker's reputation for durability, but also its policy on maintaining an inventory of spare parts. Makers such as Bosch, Miele, Sub-Zero and Gaggenau (which debuted on Consumer Reports most-reliable list last year) make and keep replacement parts in stock for at least 15 or 20 years.

Indeed, finding a replacement igniter for my Bosch stove proved easy, some 20 years on. Since it cost just $17, I even bought a spare, and I think I can handle the installation myself. So, for now, I'll stick with the range I've got. Once I spend a little time watching YouTube instructional videos, things should be sizzling here for many years to come.

▶ Ready for a countertop rethink? Find coffee gear built to last at **WSJ.com/Eating**.


Publicis Et Nous
HERMÈS
PARIS
Hermès, the endless line